The Last Stand

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F

Fandom:
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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta & Hordak (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Fluff, Healing, Romance, Action/Adventure, Redemption, Enemies to Friends, Enemies to Lovers, Abandonment, Second Chances, Forgiveness, Post-Season/Series 04, Fan made season 5, Slow Burn, Eventual Smut, But with love

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The Last Stand

by TellerOfLightAndDark

Summary

As Adora and Bow work together on a plan to save Glimmer from Horde Prime's ship, the young queen finds herself stuck in a cell with her worst enemy. However, as the two of them start talking, Glimmer realizes that Catra isn't the monster she always believed she was. Meanwhile, the Rebellion begins to organize its last stand against Horde Prime for Etheria's freedom. Will Adora and Bow be able to rescue Glimmer? Will Catra make amends for her past mistakes? Will the princesses gain a new, powerful ally? Will the Rebellion prevail? Or is Etheria going to become the next jewel in Horde Prime's collection?

(Or, Season 5 fanfiction!)

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Stuck Together

"Let us out of here!" Glimmer yelled furiously at the top of her lungs.

The young queen had been punching and kicking at the door of the chamber she and Catra had been confined in for quite some time. When the two girls were taken to the room for the first time by two of Horde Prime's clones, the first thing they noticed was…

The cleanliness…

The room wasn't really well furnished, but it was exceptionally clean, incredibly tidy, with white walls and a large, thick looking window that gave them a nice view on Etheria's surface. Still, it didn't give Glimmer and Catra any sense of comfort. It wasn't the kind of clean you'd find in Birght Moon castle's rooms… no… it felt…

Cold…

Sterile…

There even were two beds and a small desk in between of them. No one would have ever described it as a prison cell, but that was exactly how the two girls saw it as soon as they were brought inside. The door had been shut behind them and it didn't take them long to realize that it could only be opened from the outside.

'Of course…' Catra thought bitterly.

Despite Horde Prime's manners, it was now obvious he considered both Glimmer and her as nothing more than valuable assets to the expansion of his empire… nothing more than tools… tools that didn't get to be trusted or free, for the matter.

‘Are you surprised? It’s not like you haven’t been used before.’ The thought made Catra cringe, she shook her head, trying to get rid of the thought.

Since she and Glimmer had been escorted to their “personal chamber” as Horde Prime described it, Catra had tried to just lay down on one of the two beds and get some rest, but there were just too many thoughts that kept nagging at her, thoughts that were both confusing and enraging.

It didn’t help that for a solid ten minutes, Glimmer had been trying to break down the very obviously- impossible to break down using just punches and kicks-door of their room, using nothing but punches and kicks, grunting and yelling more and more furiously as the door remained intact but more importantly… closed.

“Hey Sparkles, would you mind stopping that? I’m trying to get some shut eye here.” Catra said, not bothering to look at the young queen as she spoke to her.

“My… name… is… Glimmer!” The girl yelled, delivering another punch to the door.

“Whatever Glitter, just stop doing that, it’s not going to work.” Catra scoffed.

“Oh, and please tell me, what should I do instead? Nothing? Just like you?” Glimmer chuckled mockingly as she turned towards the Force Captain.

This got Catra’s attention. She stood up growling, quickly covering the distance between her and the young queen.

“And what should I be doing huh? There’s nowhere we can go. If your pretty teleportation trick worked then we could get out of here in an instant but wait! I almost forgot, you completely drained yourself of any magical energy you had trying to wipe us all from existence!” Catra snarled, inches away from Glimmer’s face.

“I didn’t know the Heart of Etheria would work that way! I wanted to stop you, Hordak and the Horde once and for all!” Glimmer yelled back.

“Yeah, good job so far.”

“Hey! I made a mistake! At least I’m admitting it, while everything you did was-”

“Saving you.” Catra interrupted the girl before she could finish. “So the least you can do in return is to stop making all this noise and let me rest.”

Glimmer shut her mouth, there wasn’t much she could say to rebut, Catra did save her life.

Catra saved her life…

It was in that moment, when that single thought crossed her mind, that Glimmer’s eyes widened, and a single question came to her… and before Catra could turn around, she spoke again.

“Why?” Glimmer’s voice was barely more audible than a whisper.

“What?”

“Why did you save me?” The young queen repeated, this time making sure Catra would hear her.

It was then that Glimmer noticed a glint of something appearing in Catra’s eyes, something she had seen only once before, when she met the Force Captain in the Fright Zone, defeated and ready to die at the hands of the rebel queen. It wasn’t like Catra not to fight back, and it was right then and there that Glimmer understood that she wasn’t looking at a monster… just at a girl who lost everyone, a girl full of regrets who wished for everything to end because how could she fix things now? After everything she’d done?

However, that glint soon disappeared as Catra shook her head. She grinned maliciously, stepping towards Glimmer, trying her best to look intimidating.

“Why, Sparkles? Don’t you get it? Saving you the only way to save myself. Without you the Heart of Etheria is useless right? And without the Heart of Etheria, this little planet alongside everyone who inhabit it including me, are useless. This way, I get to see another day, hell, maybe Horde Prime will even make me his new right hand and then-”

“Stop it.”

Catra remained speechless. Her smirk vanished, replaced by a puzzled expression. Glimmer had interrupted her, but what was bothering her the most was that she didn’t look hurt, she didn’t look angry. Her eyes were filled with nothing more than… compassion.

“You can stop now Catra, I get it now.” Glimmer said, putting her hand on Catra’s shoulder and giving her a light squeeze.

“W-what is it that you think you’re getting, huh? Little queen?” Catra harshly brushed away the touch, as she tried not to linger on the comfort it brought her.

“You don’t… you don’t truly care about those things, do you?”

Glimmer’s words hit her like a full speeding skiff.

“W-what are you talking about?” Catra’s voice trembled for a moment.

“You really had me fooled you know?” Glimmer spoke kindly. “I really thought all that mattered to you was power, but I was wrong. I understood that the second I found you today and looked into your eyes.”

“You don’t know anything… anything about me!” Catra took a step back, her breathing getting more erratic as Double Trouble’s

words echoed in her mind. ‘We both know this was never what you wanted.’

“I think I do. I think we’re more alike than we’d like to admit. Tell me Catra… does winning battles feel anywhere near as good as having your friends around you? And… losing them… you’d prefer to lose one thousand battles instead, wouldn’t you?” Glimmer asked, a small, hopeful smile on her face.

Catra’s lip trembled for a moment.

“You care about your friends.”

An insane laugh bubbled up Catra’s throat.

“M-my friends? I don’t have any friends! I-”

“Do you want to know what Scorpia told me before I managed to find you?” Glimmer took a step towards Catra as she took another one backwards.

“Do not even say that-” The Force Captain growled, how dare she even mention that traitor’s name, but Glimmer didn’t listen to her and kept speaking.

“She told me not to hurt you, even though you’ve done a lot of bad things.”

Catra felt tears starting to well up in her eyes.

“And even after everything you’ve done… whenever someone speak your name, I can see it in Adora’s eyes, that she still loves-”

No, it was too much. It was too much to bear for Catra. She had worked so hard to achieve her goal, to prove her worth, to show everyone that she could win too, the she wasn’t second to anyone. She had worked so hard that it made her drive away all of her friends, so hard that it made her try to kill the one person who gave her hope, the only one person in all of her hellish life who ever made her feel loved.

Catra knew she couldn't go back now. It was too late. She could never get those people back, she knew that they hated her now, that it was too late to fix things. That's why she would never let Glimmer give her any hope to do so, she couldn't trust her only to be hurt again, she couldn't suffer anymore than she already did.

"Shut up! Adora and Scorpia were nothing but filthy traitors, they left and-"

"They only did the right thing by leaving!" Glimmer interrupted her, trying to defend her friends.

Silence followed. A deep pain flashed in Catra's eyes before a mischievous grin formed on her face.

"The right thing huh?"

"You know that's not what I meant." Glimmer tried to explain, her tone latched with worry.

"And what about you Sparkles? Didn't everyone leave you too? Adora, Bow, your mom…"

In a last attempt to shield herself from the truth, from the agonizingly painful truth, Catra made one last move to prevent her façade from crumbling.

A really bad move.

She didn't see Glimmer's punch coming, but it hit her square in the stomach, and it hit her hard. She stumbled backwards and before she could regain balance, another punch hit her left cheek. This time, Catra fell to the ground. She felt Glimmer kneeling on top of her. The young queen grabbed her by the collar of her uniform and raised her fist, ready to strike Catra again. The kindness in her eyes had disappeared, leaving nothing but a scorching rage.

"Come on, do it, it's not like Horde Prime really needs me. You could explain everything about the Heart of Etheria to him

yourself, so what are you waiting for?”

Glimmer’s fist started to tremble.

“I’m the one who opened the portal! I’m the one who took your mother away! Go on! Finish me! Kill me!” The Force Captain screamed as her voice started to break.

It was in that moment that Glimmer’s anger vanished. The monster had once again tried to fool her, but it couldn’t, not anymore. Now she could see right through it, now she could see the desperate, wounded soldier that stood behind it, and as Glimmer looked at the sobbing girl, she slowly lowered her fist.

“Just… just kill me… if you can’t do it… at least hate me…” Catra whispered, tears streaming down her face.

“I think you’re already doing it enough for the both of us.”

Glimmer stood up and reached the farthest bed from the room’s window, she sat down and released a long, exhausted sigh. She didn’t turn around when she felt Catra stand up from the floor and reach for her own bed. They didn’t say anything else for the rest of the night.

Old Shadows

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As soon as Adora and Bow left Bright Moon to stop the Heart of Etheria, Micah was kindly escorted to Angella's old bedroom by two sentinels.

An immense wave of nostalgia hit his heart as soon as he entered it, noticing how it was exactly as he remembered it… their old bedroom… Angella hadn't removed any furniture, she hadn't changed the bed… she hadn't changed anything… his beautiful, beautiful queen.

A small, tired smile grew on the old king's face

As he leaned against the edge of the balcony, he took a moment to set his gaze upon the countless stars that now adorned the sky.

He had never seen anything like it before. He had only read about the stars when he was younger, but as the years went by, he began to think they were never even real. However, there they were. It was like a luminous mantle had covered a once dark sky.

And yet…

It was nothing compared to the smile of his little Glimmer. He had fought so hard to preserve that precious memory during his time on Beast Island. It had been one of the few things that managed to keep him sane.

The memories he had of his wonderful, little princess and his kind, beautiful queen kept him going during all those lonely years. But

now that Angella was gone…

Glimmer was all what he had left…

“Please… let her be okay…” Micah whispered, heaving a long sigh.

“She’s a strong girl. You shouldn’t worry about her.”

Micah quickly turned around, startled by the familiar voice. Shock appeared on his face then, anger.

“Where are the guards?” Micah demanded.

“I already told you before you stormed off… I’m a guest here at Bright Moon.” Shadow Weaver replied calmly.

“And you really expect me to believe that?”

“I’m not your enemy, Micah.” Shadow Weaver’s voice was oddly kind, but the old king knew it was only a façade.

He quickly reached for his staff but before he could cast a spell, a sharp pain erupted from his side, making him kneel to the ground.

“You’re wounded, you need to rest.”

“Don’t pretend to care.” Micah hissed through gritted teeth as he shakily raised himself off the floor.

“I did…” Shadow Weaver’s reply was barely more audible than a whisper.

“No, you needed me, you used me and then… you abandoned me.”

Twelve years before:

“My king! The village is lost! We have to retreat now!” A soldier cried as he reached Micah’s side.

The day before, the Rebellion’s spies reported that a small group of Horde soldiers had assaulted a little village near the mountains, not far from the Whispering Woods. Angella thought it would have been easy to defeat them and ordered an attack. However, as soon as Micah and his men were going to prevail, they realized that the Horde’s troops that had occupied the small settlement, were just a distraction.

While they were busy fighting, they didn’t notice a large force approaching and when they did, it was far too late to order a retreat.

But not everything was lost.

“Not until all the citizens are safe! Go help the others evacuate the ones who are left!” Micah ordered, his gaze set upon the approaching Horde’s troops. “I’ll hold them off.”

“B-but… my king, they’re too many!”

“That is an order soldier! Now go!”

The man nodded curtly, taking one step back, hesitation clear in his eyes, before turning around and running towards the remaining Rebellion troops.

Micah watched his troops retreat alongside the village’s people. They were going to be safe. He would make sure of that. When he turned around, he found himself face to face with an entire Horde’s battalion. One of its soldiers took a step towards the king, pointing his stung gun at him.

“Give it up old man! You can’t stop-” The Horde’s soldier didn’t get to finish his sentence, as a powerful blast of magic hit him square in the chest, knocking him out.

The other troops didn't hesitate for a second and attacked Micah all at once, but against the magic of the king of Bright Moon, they didn't stand a chance. His spells took down most of the soldiers and even when the tanks arrived, Micah didn't run. He kept fighting until both his men and the village's citizens were gone, far beyond the horizon, far beyond the Horde's grasp. That is when the king let his staff clatter to the ground and fell to his knees. His hearing was muffled, his vision blurry, and only when a hand cradled his cheek, he realized he wasn't alone anymore.

"Oh Micah… why did it have to end like this?"

The king immediately recognized the voice, and as he raised his gaze from the ground, he found himself face to face with his old mentor.

Shadow Weaver.

"L-Light Spinner…" Micah stuttered.

"You know very well that that is not my name anymore… that woman is long gone."

"N-no, I don't believe that. You could have killed me back in Mystacor… you knew I would have grown up to fight the Horde… but you still spared me. Why?" Micah asked,

"I… I…" Shadow Weaver hesitated.

"I think I know why. You didn't kill me because back then, inside of all that darkness, there was also a light, and I believe it's still there." Micah muttered as he placed his hand on hers.

The old king's vision began to darken. He smiled weakly as he gave one last squeeze to Shadow Weaver's hand, then, he fell to the ground. Even when the Horde's soldiers who were still standing surrounded him and everything went black, he held onto that hope, that Light Spinner was still somewhere inside the red witch.

But that small, fragile hope didn't last long…

When the king opened his eyes, the sound of waves reached his ears. He stood up groggily and the first thing he noticed, was the sea. As he slowly turned around, a horrified gasp escaped his lips. He had seen this island many times, depicted inside many of the books he had read.

Beast Island…

And as Micah fell to his knees, his eyes wide and welled up with tears, he realized…

He was never going back home.

The present day:

"You let Hordak send me there to die, you let him rip me away from my family, but I came back, back to where I belong. I'll see my daughter again and then, you'll pay for everything you've done. Now get out of here." Micah declared, taking a step towards the old witch.

Shadow Weaver remained still, looking straight into Micah's eyes. However, as the king turned around, she broke her silence.

"You think Hordak's plan was to send you to Beast Island?"

Micah stopped in his tracks, a confused expression on his face as he turned towards his old mentor.

"What are you talking about?"

"Hordak wanted to lead his army to Bright Moon, taking you with him. He wanted to execute you in front of your precious queen and your little Glimmer, breaking them, breaking the Rebellion. Do

you know who stopped him?" Shadow Weaver asked, her tone oddly pleased.

No…

It couldn't be…

It had to be a trick…

"You're lying." Micah whispered in bewilderment.

"I used Hordak's hatred for you, for the king who never gave up, to convince him that the best way to punish you, was to make suffer a faith worse than death. I convinced him to send you to Beast Island." Shadow Weaver said as she slowly began make her way towards the king.

"Why would you do that?" The king asked, his eyes wide in shock, his gaze set on the floor.

He quickly raised his face as he felt a hand cradling his cheek.

"Because that way you would have had a chance to survive." Shadow Weaver said, her voice kind, soothing.

Micah's eyes widened in pure disbelief. He wanted to tell the red witch she had indeed chosen a faith for him that was worse than death itself. He wanted to tell her that there hadn't been a day on that forsaken island he hadn't felt despair. That he had long given up hope to come back home, to see his family again. But if she was telling the truth then…

Shadow Weaver gave him a chance…

"Why are you telling me this?" Micah asked.

"Because I need you to trust me, I need you to help me. Your daughter is such a powerful sorceress. Even before I started to train her, I could sense in her the same extraordinary power I had

once seen in you. Just think of what the three of us could do if only we worked toge-”

Micah suddenly grabbed Shadow Weaver’s hand, forcing it away from his cheek, his other hand grasping the old witch tunic’s hem. His eyes, once filled with confusion and regret, were now burning with such a scorching rage, that even Shadow Weaver couldn’t help herself but to release a slight whimper.

“You dared to taint my daughter with your magic?! I’ve seen what it made you do, the people it made you kill, the monster it turned you into. I won’t let you corrupt Glimmer with something so despicable! I won’t let you turn her into a monster!” Micah snarled ferociously.

“I trained her, gave her advice when her friends abandoned her, I made her achieve her true potential! Something Angella had failed to do for a long time!” Shadow Weaver rebutted indignantly.

However, as the red witch spoke those words, she realized she had made a grave mistake. Micah shoved her away, his staff raised towards her, glowing dangerously.

“Do not dare to speak her name!” Micah seethed in rage.

“Micah…”

“Who did it…” Micah’s voice started to break. “Was it you? Did you take her away from me?!”

“I was there with Glimmer when it happened, we tried to prevent it, but we couldn’t…” Shadow Weaver explained.

“Who then?” Micah demanded, a single tear streaming down his cheek.

Shadow Weaver remained in silence, her gaze shifting to the ground.

“Who?!” Micah screamed.

The old witch raised her head, and finally spoke.

“Hordak’s second in command… Catra…”

Chapter End Notes

Whoooo! Here we are with the second chapter! I know, I know, you’re all screaming at the top of your lungs “Micah and Shadow Weaver?! We want more Glimmer and Catra! We want to see that juicy, juicy Catradora happen!”… don’t worry, I’m already in the middle of writing the third chapter. It’ll bring you more intense moments between our two favorite stubborn babies, Sparky and Kitty, and it will finally bring you some action, with Adora, Bow and the princesses… nah, I’m not going to spoil it for you. I wanted to make this chapter about a short encounter between Micah and Shadow Weaver, about Adora and Bow returning to Bright Moon and only at the end I would have introduced the beginning of a new scene with Glimmer and Catra but… I don’t know, I think Micah and Shadow Weaver would have had a lot to talk about, so I kept writing and I realized that I had enough material for an entire chapter. So there you go! Enjoy. Thank you for your appreciation guys, it means a lot to me. I’m currently going through a rough time, so it brings me joy to see that you’re enjoying this story. I hope you’ll like it just as much as I like writing it. To the next chapter!

P.S. You've noticed that Catra & Scorpia tag? Yeah, yeah you've noticed... because they're going to meet again... and it will be... tear jerking... I like to give people something to look forward to :3 Oh, same with Entrapta and Hordak...

Reunion

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Who did it…" Micah's voice started to break. "Was it you? Did you take her away from me?!"

"I was there with Glimmer when it happened, we tried to prevent it, but we couldn't…" Shadow Weaver explained.

"Who then?" Micah demanded, a single tear streaming down his cheek.

Shadow Weaver remained in silence, her gaze shifting to the ground.

"Who?!" Micah screamed.

The old witch raised her head, and finally spoke.

"Hordak's second in command… Catra…"

Suddenly, the bedroom's door swung open.

"My king! Adora and Bow have returned! They're waiting for you in the war room!" The sentinel who had just barged in exclaimed.

"What about my daughter?!" Micah asked.

The sentinel shifted her gaze to the ground, a grimace appearing on her face. She hesitated for a moment before speaking again.

"They're alone my king… no one else have returned."

“No…” Micah whispered, his eyes widening in terror.

The old king rushed outside the bedroom, leaving both Shadow Weaver and the guard behind him. He ignored the pain erupting from his side as he quickly made his way towards the war room. As soon as he reached it, he slammed open the doors. It was just as the sentinel had said, only Adora and Bow had returned and the looks on their faces… they didn’t look reassuring in the slightest.

“Adora… Bow…” Micah called them.

“King Micah!” Adora exclaimed, standing up from her chair.

“Where is Glimmer?” The old king asked, his voice trembling.

Adora and Bow stared at each other for a few moments. Neither of them seemed to be willing to reveal Glimmer’s fate. How could they? How could they tell Micah that his daughter was now at the mercy of the true Horde? How could they tell him after promising they’d save Glimmer, that they would bring her back…

After a long silence, Bow stepped forward, sighing heavily.

“They took her… I was right there… I could have reached her but… I wasn’t fast enough.” Bow said, his head hanging low.

“Wh-what?” The old king whispered, confused.

“It was Hordak’s plan… to open a portal and bring through the rest of the Horde’s armies. We stopped him… but I still couldn’t prevent Light Hope from teleporting Etheria out of Despondos… now the true Horde has found us and… they took Glimmer.”

“S-so… where is she now?!” Micah asked in a panicked voice.

“In space!”

Everyone turned around as they were interrupted by a booming, shrilling voice.

“Entrapta!” Bow yelled, rushing towards the pigtailed princess, enveloping her in a tight hug.

“Hehe, I’m glad you’re okay too.” Entrapta laughed awkwardly.

“And Swift Wind!” The winged steed exclaimed, before entering the war room, limping slightly.

“Swifty! Are you okay? You’re limping…” Adora’s voice filled with worry.

“It’s nothing, really.” Swift Wind chuckled, gently pressing his snout against Adora’s hand.

Suddenly, the group heard another voice coming from the corridor outside the chamber.

“Guys!”

As Adora and Bow turned around, they both gasped in surprise as they saw Scorpia, Perfuma and Frosta walking towards them. Behind them, Sea Hawk was carrying a very annoyed Mermista bridal style. They all seemed tired, but other than that, they looked fine.

It didn’t take long for the princesses to notice a third person shifting awkwardly as she tried to hide behind Bow. The first one to notice was Scorpia and as soon as the scorpion princess’ eyes landed on the figure, they widened in surprise. She began to move faster, reaching Bow in a moment.

“Entrapta…” Scorpia whispered.

Bow slowly stood aside. The two princesses were now standing right in front of one another. Entrapta’s expression was conflicted, both fearful and hopeful. Scorpia’s… Scorpia’s was simply black. A few, tense, endless moments passed as the two simply stared at each other… then… the scorpion princess’ eyes filled with tears, her stoic composure breaking apart as she stepped forward and enveloped Entrapta in a bone crushing hug.

“I’m so sorry!” Scorpia sobbed.

“Sorry? About what?” Entrapta seemed confused, although, her fearful expression had disappeared, leaving behind nothing but a warm, contented smile.

“When Catra sent you to Beast Island… I was so afraid of losing her too that… that I didn’t do anything. I let that happen… I let that happen to my friend. I’m so sorry, Entrapta.”

“Oh… well… I have never been good at friendship so I’m in no place to judge.” Entrapta replied cheerfully, although her smile grew smaller as she felt Scorpia tighten her grip, another sob escaping her lips. The pigtailed princess sighed as she hugged her back, then, she spoke again. “Listen, if there’s one thing I understood about friendship is that no one gets it right the first time. It’s like an experiment! Every little mistake we make helps us do better the next time and… well… you won’t ever have to do better on your own again, and that goes for me too! I have friends now! You have friends… Adora, Bow, the princesses and… me…”

“A-are you serious? W-we’re still friends?” Scorpia asked astonished, wiping away her tears.

“Of course! Friendship is hard, you’ve got to work at it, it takes everything you have…” Entrapta trailed off, looking at Bow with a smile on her face, “But I’m starting to think that it’s totally worth it.”

“We were so worried about you Entrapta! When we discovered that you had been sent to Beast Island I… I…” Perfuma stopped speaking, deciding her actions would speak louder than her words. She threw her arms around the pigtailed princess and held her tight.

“I’m so happy to have you back!” Frosta shouted happily, joining the hug.

"Well… you could have definitely avoided all that 'making Hordak's bots super strong' thing, but yeah, same here." Mermista murmured, trying to mask her glee with her usual indifference, although it was clear that she was truly happy about the scientist princess' return.

When they parted, Adora stepped forward.

"Are you all okay?" She asked.

The princesses all looked at each other, regret clear in their eyes.

"We followed Glimmer's plan, we surprised the Horde's troops and wiped them away. We were super charged but then… something happened and we…" Frosta trailed off.

"The Heart of Etheria channeled that power into me."

"Wait, what?" Scorpia's confusion was clear in her voice.

"We learned how the Heart of Etheria worked on Beast Island. The Heart gets his energy from the magic of all the princesses. When it's charged, it releases all that power, making it flow through all of you and then… into me. She-Ra is the only being capable of withstanding all of that raw, magical energy… the First Ones… they discovered it and created the sword to… to control her… to force her to use their weapon. And I almost did…" Adora explained, a pained expression adorning her face.

"Adora…" Bow spoke in a kind tone of voice, laying a hand on the blonde's shoulder, trying to comfort her.

"Hey, don't you dare blaming yourself for any of this!" Scorpia did her best to cheer her up, Adora hadn't done anything wrong… she was the one who… "If there's anyone to blame… that's me."

"Scorpia-" Adora began to talk but the scorpion princess cut her off.

"I created a connection with the Black Garnet! Glimmer said it would give us the power we needed to defeat the Horde but… if it wasn't for me we'd still be in Despondos, away from the rest of the Horde! The Heart hurt you all and it was going to destroy everything and…" Scorpia stopped, a sob escaping her lips. "I didn't want to hurt any more friends…" She closed her eyes, her head hanging low in shame.

Suddenly, Adora's expression changed from one of regret, to one of pure determination.

"Scorpia! None of this is your fault!"

Scorpia raised her head, shocked by the power Adora's voice held. Her eyes went wide as the blonde took her pincers into her hands.

"Listen to me. Everything that has happened… it's not your fault and… it's not Glimmer's fault either. You both wanted to save Etheria, to protect the ones you love. And you are right, I can't keep blaming myself for everything that goes wrong. The First Ones made the Heart. They're the ones to blame for all that happened and right now we're the only ones who can stop the Horde. We need to stop blaming each other and stand together, united!"

Ah, suddenly it all made sense, why Adora was Catra's best friend, why Catra had never truly been able to move past her. Scorpia had hated her for a long time, for leaving Catra, for hurting her. Only now she was starting to realize that Adora wasn't a bad person, she was actually the strongest person she had ever met. Even in the most hopeless of situations, there was this… this fire in her eyes… a fire that refused to die down. It was so… so… inspiring, and suddenly Scorpia found herself thinking. It was true, the princesses made a mistake, but right now, they couldn't waste any more time blaming each other, not if they wanted to save everyone, not if they wanted to save Etheria.

"Standing together is the only we can defeat the Horde, it's the only way we rescue Glimmer."

Everyone turned towards Adora.

“What happened to her?” Scorpia asked, her voice laced with worry.

“She was right next to the Black Garnet, Hordak was there too… I tried to reach her but a beam of green light came down from the sky and then… they were gone.” Bow explained.

“So… d-do you have any idea of where she is now?” Perfuma’s voice trembled.

Suddenly, the group’s attention was drawn to the war room’s table, as someone loudly cleared their voice. All of the princesses’ mouths hung open as they noticed who was sitting at it.

“That’s what I was asking before…” Micah said, his tone grave

“King Micah…” Frosta whispered, before bowing alongside the other princesses.

“How are you here?!” Perfuma’s shock was clear in her voice.

“There is no time for that, right now we have to save my daughter.” The old king replied curtly before turning towards Entrapta. “Entrapta, what were you saying before?”

“That Glimmer is in space!” Entrapta answered, a little too enthusiastically. When the king narrowed his eyes, she chuckled nervously “Sorry… ehm… it was just a guess, but now I’m pretty sure about it! When I arrived, I overheard you talking about the Horde capturing Glimmer, and Bow, you said she and Hordak disappeared into a beam of green light, right?” Entrapta asked, turning towards the archer.

“Uhm, yes?” Bow answered, clearly confused, not getting what Entrapta was trying to say.

“Then we have to act quickly, come on! To the ship!” The pigtailed princess shouted as she rushed outside the chamber.

Everyone inside the war room exchanged confused looks.

“Uhh… what ship?” Scorpia asked, scratching her head.

“It’s a long story, come on!” Adora said, gesturing the others to follow her as she rushed behind Entrapta.

They had no idea what the scientist princess was talking about, but if she had even the slightest clue on where Glimmer was held prisoner and how to save her, then there was no time to lose.

Chapter End Notes

Hi guys! I'm back with another chapter! This time, I wanted to give you one of the many things I’m looking forward to see in season 5, the reunion between Scorpia and Entrapta! Of course, there are many, many things I’m planning to write about that you’ll probably enjoy more, but still, I hope you liked my take on their reunion. Thank you guys, really, thank you for all your appreciation, your kind comments are what keep me going. Thank you for all the kudos, the bookmarks, they are really showing me that you're enjoying this story, so don't worry, I'll keep bringing you more! See you next time!

Together

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Bow, you said that Glimmer and Hordak disappeared into a beam of green light, right?" Entrapta asked, turning towards the archer.

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Glimmer…

Just thinking about the young queen brought a storm of confusing emotions into Adora's heart. The blonde couldn't even remember how many nights of sleep she had lost trying to figure out what in Etheria had gone wrong between the two of them. So many things had happened… Angella's death… Glimmer's coronation… Shadow Weaver becoming her mentor…

Shadow Weaver…

To Adora, the fact that Glimmer would still be willing to accept not only the witch's advices, but also her teachings after everything

she had done to them, was unconceivable. She knew Shadow Weaver, she knew how her kind words, how her praises could get to someone's head, making them feel special, important. Someone might have even called it love, but Adora knew that it had nothing to do with what true love was.

She came to understand what a real mother was when she left the Horde, when she met Angella and heard how much the queen's voice softened and filled with pure, unconditioned love as she spoke about her daughter. Even after everything that happened between the two of them, even in Angella's final moments, that love had remained as strong as it had always been.

Only then Adora understood what she had missed for all her life…

But Shadow Weaver…

The moment someone would stop doing what the witch told them to do, her kind, sweet words would become sour, hateful, more harmful than any bot, spell or monster Adora had ever faced. Shadow Weaver never loved her, not truly, she only loved the little soldier who always did as she was told, the one who obeyed… the one she could control.

Adora swore to herself that she would never let Shadow Weaver hurt Glimmer… she couldn't let her harm another person she loved… not after she had already failed to protect…

Not after she had already failed to protect Catra…

But the red witch had been sly. She knew that with Angella being gone, Glimmer would have begun to feel the weight of Etheria's destiny on her shoulders. She needed someone to guide her, to give her advice, and Shadow Weaver gladly took that position.

However, despite how close they had grown, Adora never felt jealous of Glimmer. She had only wanted to protect her, to protect her best friend. Only in the last few days she had realized that by

doing that, she must have made Glimmer feel like she wasn't enough, like she couldn't do anything on her own…

She must have made her feel like she could never be as strong as her mom…

She must have made her feel like she didn't trust her…

But that was in the past. The only thing that mattered now was to find Glimmer, to save her and then… then Adora would tell her how much of a stubborn, strong, incredible person she was, and that no matter what, she would never stop believing in her.

"Here we are!" Entrapta yelled enthusiastically as the small group stopped in front of Mara's ship.

"Uhm… Entrapta? So, how's the ship going to help us save Glimmer?" Bow asked, scratching the back of his head.

"Come on inside! I'll show you!"

The small group quickly followed Entrapta inside the spaceship, coming to a stop as they reached the bridge. The pigtailed princess pressed a panel of the command console and suddenly, a bright, flashing red screen materialized in front of them.

"Uh… that is very… very red… that's not a good sign, is it?" Scorpia asked.

"Not at all!" Entrapta answered, her cheerful demeanor remaining intact.

"What is that? And… what are those small triangles?" Perfuma asked, pointing to the screen and to the small, moving shapes it displayed.

"That's a radar! But let's start from the beginning! So, before I came back, I decided to make a quick stop to inspect the ship and collect a few more data to-" Entrapta began to explain, only to be interrupted by Bow.

“Entrapta! We were worried about you! Couldn’t the ship wait?!” The archer shouted indignantly.

“I told her it was a bad idea.” Swift Wind whispered to Adora, who couldn’t help but snicker slightly… ‘Classic Entrapta.’ she thought.

“I know… but I just couldn’t resist! And when I got on board, I noticed a red screen that kept flashing. When I inspected it, I knew it had to be a radar! I could see all of the Horde’s ships that are now roaming the planet… that’s what those little triangles are!”

“Well, that’s not very reassuring.” Mermista deadpanned.

“There are so many…” Adora whispered in disbelief.

“What does this have to do with Glimmer?” Micah’s patience was running thin, his voice made it very clear.

“One ship in particular has remained outside Etheria’s atmosphere. Let me show you!” Entrapta said as she began to tap on the command console. The radar’s screen zoomed out, displaying a reproduction of the whole planet and right beside it… an enormous, immobile ship. “It’s the biggest one… ooooh, imagine all the advanced tech it must contain…” Entrapta began to trail off.

“Entrapta! Focus!” Adora yelled.

“Right, that must be Horde Prime’s ship!”

“Horde Prime?”

“Yes! He’s the true leader of the Horde… oh! And also the emperor of the known universe according to Hordak!

“What?!” Bow yelled, his eyes widening in fear.

“Horde Prime cloned himself and built an army. Hordak is one of his clones. He got… discarded… because he was considered to be

a defect…" Entrapta's enthusiasm suddenly died down, much to the group's surprise. "That's why he built his empire here on Etheria and called Horde Prime through his portal, to show him that he isn't a mistake, that he can still be useful to him."

"Wow… I didn't know Hordak had… you know, feelings." Bow muttered, a grimace on his face.

"That doesn't excuse everything he did." Adora stated, her tone hard.

"I know but, still… it's weird."

"I… guess…" The blonde's voice softened as she crossed her arms.

"If Horde Prime came for Hordak and he was right beside my daughter when they disappeared then…" Micah's eyes widened in realization "Entrapta… are you saying that-"

"Glimmer was mistakenly taken by Horde Prime alongside Hordak and now…" Entrapta turned towards the red, flashing radar and pointed straight at the massive ship right next to Etheria. "She must be held prisoner on his ship!"

A loud gasp rose from the small group.

"So… uhhh… let me get this straight. Glimmer is being held prisoner on an intergalactic tyrant's ship, which is in space and probably like… 'everythingproof'… and even if somehow we'd manage to get inside, there would be an entire army of Hordaks waiting for us. We're all tired, wounded and- Adora? Where's your sword?" Mermista asked.

Adora hesitated, her gaze shifting to the ground for a moment before answering.

"I had to destroy it. It was the only way to stop the Heart."

Color drained from everyone's faces.

If the sword was gone than…

“Does that mean that She-Ra is gone?” Perfuma broke the deafening silence, her voice quivering.

For a single instant, Adora’s eyes were filled with fear, doubt and insecurity. What could they do against Horde Prime if they didn’t have She-Ra on their side? What could they do against an army made of thousands of his clones if even with She-Ra they had struggled for so long against just one of them? How could they save Glimmer without the most powerful of all the princesses?

But those doubts didn’t last…

There was no time to waste doubting herself…

“She-Ra may be gone… but Adora? Never.”

The fire in Adora’s eyes was suddenly rekindled, burning brighter than ever before. Everyone looked at her in pure amazement. Her sword was gone, her powers were gone, the true Horde had arrived and had captured Glimmer, but Adora still refused to give up. Even without She-Ra she would have fought until the end to protect her friends, to protect Etheria. And just like that, hope began to unfurl in the princesses’ hearts once again. Scorpia raised her chin, a determined look on her face. She stepped towards Adora and put a pincer on her shoulder.

“I haven’t known you guys for a long time, but you made me feel more at home than the Horde ever did, and Glimmer… she helped me understand that standing together is the only way to save the people we love, and she gave me the courage to do it. Now it’s my turn to help you, to help her. It’s true, She-Ra… She-Ra did puck quite a punch… but no matter, if we all stand together against Horde Prime than I know that we can win! With or without her, we can defeat him! We can save Glimmer! We can save everyone! Together!” Scorpia spoke with such passion, such burning determination, that the princesses couldn’t help themselves but to cheer for her.

The scorpion princess held out her pincer and one by one, Adora, Bow, Micah, Sea Hawk and the princesses all put their hands on it.

"Yeah! Together!" Frosta cheered gleefully.

"We can do this!" Perfuma chimed in.

"Having She-Ra would have like… totally made things easier, but I guess Adora will have to do." Mermista smirked mockingly, although with no malice.

"Hey!" Adora tried to look offended but couldn't help to grin.

The group shared a brief laugh.

They could do it.

Together.

Meanwhile…

Screams of pure agony came from the room at the end of the corridor, and yet, even though those terrifying sounds would have driven away even the bravest of warriors, the two clones kept walking until they reached the chamber's entrance. They diligently waited for their master to finish the task at hand, not bothered by their brother's cries of pain.

Hordak laid now unconscious on a white, rectangular table, his wrists and ankles secured to it. Horde Prime removed his hands from his hollow cheeks, drawing a ragged breath.

"Your mind has become stronger during these last few years, little brother. Somehow… it keeps coming back even if I wipe it away myself… but no matter… you'll cave eventually." Horde Prime

whispered into Hordak's ear. "And maybe it isn't such a disaster that your mind has survived the first reconditioning process… after all, it let me get a closer look to everything that happened to you while we were apart…"

The tyrant turned around, noticing the two clones' presence.

"Ah, H-567, H-568, you're here. Good… bring me the queen's companion… I believe we've much to talk about…"

Chapter End Notes

I'm back guys! Here with another fresh chapter that I hope you'll enjoy! I'm already in the middle of writing the next one and I'm like, halfway done so it won't take long for chapter five to come out. I hope that you're enjoying the story so far and that you're looking forward to the next chapters, they'll be worth the wait, trust me. "And what will happen next?", you may ask. I won't tell you, but I guess I can give you a little hint on what is going to happen in the next chapter… a plan will be made… someone will have a really bad time… two prisoners will have another heart to heart moment… that's it. Also, thank you for all the kind comments, for all the kudos and the bookmarks. It feels like I'm doing something right and it's amazing, truly, thank you all for this.

No One is Coming

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

‘Come oooon! Sleep for the First Ones’ sake!’ Glimmer yelled internally as she tossed around the bed.

She had to get at least a couple hours of sleep, maybe that way she would have been strong enough to be able to teleport again. However, as the young queen shut her eyes and tried to relax, she quickly found out that she couldn’t get her head out of the storm of thoughts that was raging inside her mind. She had to get out of Horde Prime’s ship, she had to go back to Bright Moon, she had to make sure the other princesses were alright… making sure Bow was alright… making sure Adora was alright.

Adora…

The name brought an immense sense guilt in Glimmer’s heart. There were so many things she had to apologize for, so many harsh words spoken in the heat of the moment. If only she could go back and stop herself from telling Adora that… that… Glimmer couldn’t even bring herself to recall the accusation, it hurt too much. She was angry, angry at the Horde, at herself and at Adora, for not trusting her.

When Shadow Weaver began to teach her magic, she finally felt like she could be strong enough to protect Etheria, to protect her home and friends. The truth was that, deep down Glimmer knew that a big chunk of that strength consisted in having her friends at her side, helping her, being there for her, trusting her.

As she began to lose those things, as she began to feel like Adora didn’t trust her anymore, didn’t believe in her anymore, she became scared… scared that she would have never been as

strong as her mother… scared that she would have never been able to protect Etheria and its people… because how could she do it alone?

Only now the young queen understood that Adora never stopped believing in her, and neither did Bow, they were just trying to protect her, just like they always did. And now Glimmer found herself wondering if she would even get the chance to see her best friends again...

“Okay, I’m done with this!” Glimmer shouted, standing up from the bed.

Her shout made Catra jump three feet in the air. The former commander growled as she landed ungracefully on the ground. However, her snarl quickly morphed into a confused expression as her eyes landed on the young queen. Her fists were clenched, she was shaking and a faint, pinkish aura was surrounding her.

“What are you doing?!” Catra half shouted as she stood up from the room’s floor.

“I’m gonna get us out of here!” Glimmer responded through gritted teeth.

“How’s lighting up our cell going to help us escape from it?” The former commander crossed her arms, cockily raising an eyebrow.

However, Catra’s smugness quickly faded as Glimmer didn’t seem bothered by her comment. She had her eyes closed shut, she was shaking more and more violently and her expression, from one of focus was starting to turn into one of pain.

“Listen, I think you should-”

But Glimmer didn’t let Catra finish, she held out her hand and spoke again.

“Take my hand! Quickly!”

Catra took a step towards her but stopped as soon as the young queen let out a scream of pure agony and fell to her knees. Magic had never brought anything more than pain into Catra's life, and what Glimmer was going through… it definitely looked painful… she didn't want anything to do with it. But what if it was the only way to escape? She couldn't let the opportunity slip.

But something was wrong…

Something was definitely wrong…

Glimmer's breathing was getting more and more labored, her forehead was slick with sweat and even though the pink glow surrounding her was becoming brighter and brighter, it looked like the pain she felt was starting to become unbearable.

"Why do you even care? Even if it kills her, at least we'll be free."

Ah…

There it was…

The voice…

Catra stared at the young queen blankly as she heard the it speak. It was much like her own, but deeper, darker. She had begun to hear it when Adora left her…

"Don't trust anyone…"

"You'll only get hurt…"

"Destroy anyone who stands in your way… anyone who stands between you and the only thing that matters in this life… power…"

Many other times she had heard it, followed it, believing it would guide her towards what she truly wanted, believing it would bring her the power she had always desired… but now… as she looked at Glimmer's face, contorted with pain… even though the voice

was the same as always, telling her never to trust, telling her never to feel remorse…

It didn't feel right.

Catra quickly reached Glimmer and knelt down in front of her.

"Listen to me Sparkles, you gotta-"

"No! I'm going to take us out of here!" Glimmer cried, shaking her head.

"It's killing you!" Catra yelled back.

"I don't care! I gotta at least try!" The young queen hissed in pain.

"Stop!"

"No!"

"Glimmer!"

The young queen's eyes shot open at the mention of her name. Catra had called her by her name… not some stupid nickname like Sparkles or Glitter… she had called her by her true name. The cat girl cupped her cheeks, raised her face, and when Glimmer met her gaze, she gulped. In those mismatched eyes she saw not only concern… but compassion too.

"Stop, now."

Glimmer stared at Catra for a few, endless moments before turning away, a shameful look on her face. The bright, pink light surrounding her began to fade and soon, the two were left in a dark room.

"What the hell was that?!" Catra yelled, both angry and incredulous.

“I was trying to get us out…” Glimmer answered, her voice barely above a whisper.

“By killing yourself?!”

“It wouldn’t have killed me! Probably…” The young queen tried to justify herself.

“Probably?! Why would you do something that stupid?!”

Glimmer remained silent, her gaze still focused on the floor, unable to meet Catra’s.

“Why?!” The former commander demanded harshly, gripping Glimmer’s shoulders.

“Because no one is coming for us!”

Silence fell over the room.

Catra slowly let go of the young queen as her brow furrowed in confusion. What did she mean by that? Surely someone would have come for them… and if not for them… at least for Glimmer…

“What are you talking about? Of course someone will come! Your… your princesses fanclub, the guy with the arrows and… ugh… Adora… they will all come to rescue you!”

“No, they won’t… especially not Adora…” Glimmer’s voice began to break.

Catra stared at her, puzzled. Were they talking of the same Adora? The same blonde idiot who risked her mind getting wiped by Shadow Weaver to save her friends? Why wouldn’t she come for Glimmer now?

“Why wouldn’t she?”

“I was horrible to her… I… I told her that since she came to us, the Rebellion had never been in a worse position. I told her that

she wasn't good enough… and that…" Glimmer hesitated, wiping away the tears that had begun to stream down her cheeks. "I told her that if she had been… my mom would still be here."

Pain suddenly flashed in Catra's eyes.

"Good for nothing…"

"Useless…"

"Worthless…"

She knew all too well how much those words could hurt a person… how much they could haunt someone. After all, they made her the monster she was now… someone who'd do anything to prove to the people who had been throwing those same words at her all her life that she was actually worth something… even if it meant doing the most horrifying things… even if it meant driving away all those she cared about.

But Adora…

Even if Catra would have never admitted it, Adora wasn't like that. She would have never abandoned Glimmer because of what she told her. It didn't matter how much the young queen had hurt her, she would have never hated her, let alone hurt her.

"Did you mean it?" Catra broke the silence.

"No!" Glimmer answered hastily, "Everything was falling apart! The Horde was winning, and I felt like she didn't trust me, like she didn't believe in me… she was only trying to protect me and I… I took it out on her…" She muttered, hugging her knees as she sat against the edge of her bed.

"Well… we all look for someone to blame, apparently… turns out it's us…" Catra grimaced, moving to rest beside the young queen.

A long pause followed. Catra was right. Glimmer had found herself with the weight of Etheria on her shoulders far too soon and when

everything started to crumble around her, she snapped, blaming everything on Adora. She should have never done that, Adora had always been enough. But now… after everything that happened… would Glimmer even get the chance to tell her?

"Are we really that bad?" Glimmer asked timidly.

"Totally, we're like… the worst people on all Etheria." Catra let out a low chuckle, although, there was no malice in it.

"Hey!" The young queen slightly punched her shoulder.

The two shared a brief laugh. They wouldn't admit, especially Catra, but they really needed it.

"But you know what? Even when you're the worst, there are still people dumb enough to want to stick around you."

Glimmer's eyes widened in surprise at the former commander's words.

"Thanks…" The young queen whispered as a small smile grew on her face.

"Just… just don't be the worst for too long or… they'll…" Catra couldn't finish, she groaned, shutting her eyes and pinching the bridge of her nose.

Glimmer stayed silent for a few moments, seemingly lost in thought before putting her hand on Catra's shoulder in a reassuring way.

"They haven't given up on you, you know? Not Scorpia and… and neither Adora."

Catra's ears flattened.

"Glimmer… I-" The former commander began to speak but was suddenly interrupted by a mechanical sound.

The room’s door had opened…

Both Glimmer and Catra shot up from the floor as two Horde Prime’s clones entered the chamber. They stood motionless for a few instants before turning towards the cat girl.

“The Emperor requires your presence.” One of the clones stated, emotionless.

Catra took a step towards them, she couldn’t show any fear, it would have been her downfall. But before she could reach the two clones, she felt a hand grasping her elbow. She turned around, shocked to see Glimmer holding her, a terrified expression on her face.

“Why? Why do you care?” Catra wanted desperately to ask, but there was no time for that. The former commander quickly grasped Glimmer’s hand, squeezing it gently, giving her a small, reassuring smile before turning around and following the two clones outside the room.

And as they lead her through a maze of endless corridors, Catra found herself thinking…

“Why did I do that?”

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! I’m back with another chapter! I hope you enjoyed this one and I’m glad to tell you that chapter VI “The Plan” is already done, so I’ll post it in a few days. Why not tomorrow? So that the hype may grow. Yes I know, I’m awful. In addition, chapter VII "The Escape" is half way done, so don't worry, soon you'll see our dearest girls reuniting. I hope you’re enjoying this little story as much as I am enjoying writing it. Thank you all for your kind comments, kudos and bookmarks, they really keep me going. To the next chapter!

The Plan

Chapter Notes

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"Why did I do that?"

Meanwhile:

"I haven't known you guys for a long time, but you made me feel more at home than the Horde ever did, and Glimmer… she helped me understand that standing together is the only way to save the people we love, and she gave me the courage to do it. Now it's my turn to help you, to help her. It's true, She-Ra… She-Ra did puck quite a punch… but no matter, if we all stand together against Horde Prime than I know that we can win! With or without her, we can defeat him! We can save Glimmer! We can save everyone! Together!" Scorpia spoke with such passion, such burning determination, that the princesses couldn't help themselves but to cheer for her.

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"Hey!" Adora tried to look offended but couldn't help to grin.

The group shared a brief laugh.

They could do it.

Together.

After a few moments, Adora cleared her throat and spoke again. "Okay, to save Glimmer we'll need to come up with a plan. Bow? Any ideas?"

"Well, for starters, Horde Prime's ship is in space, but I think that with Mara's we'll be able to… get there too? Maybe?" Bow turned towards Entrapta, looking for a confirm.

"Of course! This ship was designed for interplanetary travels after all!"

"But won't Horde Prime's ship be like… impenetrable?" Mermista asked.

The princess had a point. Even if they managed to get close to Horde Prime's ship, how could they get inside it? And how could they do it without being blown up?

"Not at all!"

Everyone turned towards Entrapta, looking at the pigtailed princess both in confusion and amazement. How could she know that? How could she know anything about an intergalactic tyrant's spaceship?

"While it's not possible for us to know exactly where Glimmer is held on Horde Prime's ship, or at least not until we'll get access to one of its computers to study the internal planimetry, I was able to use Mara ship's magnifying lenses to study its exterior!" Entrapta shouted gleefully, raising her hands in the air.

"Can the ship do that?" Adora wondered, scratching her head.

"It can! And it has many, many more functions! Before I met with you in the castle, I was able to study some of them and I believe there's a chance we can get inside Horde Prime's ship without being completely obliterated! Well, maybe, we have like… approximately a thirty percent chance of success but that's a lot!"

“Is it a lot? It doesn’t seem like it’s a lot.” Scorpia whispered to Perfuma, who tried her best not let her smile falter.

“And how exactly are we going to do it?” Bow asked, his tone doubtful.

“Thanks to this!” Entrapta said as she tapped another panel, bringing up a screen which displayed an enlarged image of Horde Prime’s ship.

Even though the resolution of the image wasn’t perfect, as the scientist princess magnified its lower portion, everyone noticed a small, opened hatch. It was nothing compared to the tyrant ship’s size, but for Mara’s…

“What is that?” Micah questioned.

“That, King Micah, is how I believe Horde Prime gets rid of his garbage!”

Everyone inside the ship stared blankly at Entrapta.

“So, uh, does his ship have a garbage dump inside of it? And the garbage gets shot into space through that opened hatch? How is that going to-” Bow’s eyes went wide as he realized Entrapta’s plan. “Wait… are you seriously suggesting that we should-”

“Reach Horde Prime’s ship, wait for the hatch to open and then get inside? Yes, that’s exactly how we’re going to do it!” Entrapta explained, raising her fists in the air in excitement.

The others however… didn’t seem to share her glee.

“Uh, Entrapta? Are we sure that’s actually an entrance to the ship’s garbage dumb? What if it leads to an engine’s cooling channel?” Bow asked, his voice laced with worry.

“Oh…” A thoughtful expression appeared on Entrapta’s face, although it didn’t last as her cheerfulness came back in a matter of seconds, “Well, it could be either that or a hatch for garbage

disposal! Or, I guess, a few other things… but what are the odds that it won't be our way in and instead a way to get toasted?! Pretty low according to my calculations."

"I don't wanna get toasted!" Frosta cried.

"Hey, hey, don't worry. It's totally going to be the garbage thing, trust me." Scorpia tried to comfort the small princess as she lightly patted her hair with her pincer.

"But even if the hatch turns out to be our way in, that space villainous fiend will see us coming from miles away!" Sea Hawk intervened dramatically.

"Wow, a thoughtful consideration for once." Mermista rolled her eyes.

"He's right though…" King Micah muttered, not noticing how the pirate's eyes shined with pride as he spoke those words, "How are we going to even get close to that ship without being spotted?"

"And that's where the most incredible function of this ship comes in handy! Try to get a look from the outside!" Entrapta said as she pointed to the exit, hopping up and down in excitement.

The group followed the pigtailed princess' instructions, quickly getting off the ship. They began to stare at it, not noticing any change.

"Uhh… is something going to happen or-" Mermista began to speak but found herself unable to continue.

Everyone's mouths fell open as Mara's ship disappeared into thin air.

"What… where…" Adora muttered in puzzlement.

"A camouflage…" Bow whispered in awe.

Suddenly, the ship came back into view. Entrapta descended its small ramp, quickly reuniting with the group.

“Wasn’t that amazing? And that’s not even the best part!”

“There’s even more?” Scopria laughed in disbelief.

“Yes! That isn’t a simple camouflage, it makes the ship invisible to both eyes and radars! We’ll be completely undetectable!” Entrapta stated, laughing maniacally.

“Woah… Mara’s ship could do all that?” Adora couldn’t believe her own ears, it was… too good to be true.

“Well, I mean… it was She-Ra’s ship after all.” Bow reasoned.

“That means we can get in without being spotted. What are we waiting for?” Micah said, putting a hand on Adora’s shoulder.

However, the blonde’s hopeful smile quickly vanished as the old king spoke. She turned around, a look of worry on her face.

“King Micah, can we have a word in private? It’ll take just a minute.” Adora asked.

Micah seemed to hesitate, but after a few moments, he nodded curtly. The two made their way back to the castle. Once they had reached the throne room, Adora sighed heavily before she started to speak.

“I know I’m no position to ask this, my king, but…” Adora hesitated, biting her lip nervously.

“What is it Adora?” Micah urged her to speak, not unkindly though.

“Please, stay in the castle until our return.”

It took all of Adora’s courage to speak those words and in part… she regretted them. How could she ask something like that to

Micah? How could she ask him to stay behind while they risked their lives trying to rescue his daughter? How could she ask a father not to try and save his little girl, the only light he had left in his life?

“What?!” Micah’s eyes widened in surprise.

“Please…” Adora stepped forwards, gently taking the old king’s hands into her own. “If you come… with your injuries…”

“I… I can’t leave her… I can’t stay put while my little girl is up there… who knows what they’re doing to her.” Micah seethed in anger, but his gaze softened as Adora spoke once more.

“If we find Glimmer… if she discovers you’re still alive… only to lose you moments after… her heart will shatter.”

“But... how can I…” Micah set his gaze on the floor.

“I promise you.” Adora stated firmly, squeezing the king’s hands, making him raise his eyes, “I promise you, we’ll save Glimmer, we’ll bring her back and… you’ll finally be able to hold her in your arms again.”

Micah smiled weakly. He had met Adora just a few hours before, but he could already tell how much of a strong, perseverant, and determined young woman she was. His daughter was lucky to have friends like her, friends who would have never abandoned her, who would have done anything to save her and bring her back…

“Alright… I trust you Adora…”

They would have brought her back, he was sure of it.

“Thank you.” Adora said, giving Micah’s hands another comforting squeeze before letting go.

As she was going to leave the throne room, she turned around one last time, a brave smile on her face.

“Keep the eyes glued on the sky, we’ll be back soon.”

“I’m counting on it.” Micah answered.

Chapter End Notes

I’m back, as promised, with chapter 6! I hope you enjoyed it. So, the team finally has a plan to save Glimmer, but what will happen when they’ll find out that there are others who’ll need saving? And you may be wondering, why “others” as in more than one other than Glimmer? There are only Glimmer AND Catra who need to be rescued… no one else… hehe… just wait. However, I won’t tell you anything else, just be prepared for some action, some tears and some joy. Capter 7 is almost done, so you won’t have to wait much longer. To the next chapter and beyond!

Loyalty

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra remained silent as the two clones guided her through a long hallway. She could see the massive door at the end of it becoming closer and closer. That was likely her destination. She felt her heart pounding in her ears, but her gaze remained set onwards.

Her eyes didn't show any sign of fear, she couldn't let Horde Prime get suspicious. She had to give him the impression that she actually knew how the Heart worked. She still had to be vague though. No one could assure Catra that the tyrant wouldn't have just gotten rid of her once he knew what he wanted to know.

When the door opened, she finally saw him. Horde Prime stood at the other side of the chamber, his arms folded behind his back, his gaze set upon the endless void beyond the glass of the room's large, panoramic window. When he turned around, his amused grin sent a chill down Catra's spine.

"Ah! Our dear queen's companion has arrived. Please, come and join me, child." Horde Prime called her.

Catra didn't hesitate. She immediately began to make her way towards the imposing ruler, her eyes not leaving his. The two clones didn't follow her, they remained by the door, motionless.

"Amazing, isn't it?" Horde Prime spoke as he turned towards the large window.

"I've never seen the stars… not once in my whole life." Catra answered, her eyes setting upon the countless, white, shining dots scattered in the infinite darkness of space.

"Quite a sight, isn't it?" The tyrant said, strangely amused.

“It is…” Catra whispered, she had never seen something this beautiful before.

“But what is the most stunning thing of all? What is truly amazing about all this?”

Horde Prime’s question took Catra by surprise. The beauty of it? The feline was quite sure he couldn’t care less about beauty. She couldn’t blame him, after all, she didn’t either. The Horde hadn’t taught her to value such frivolous things. The Horde taught her to value power, commitment, discipline, and order.

Order…

Catra’s eyes went wide as Horde Prime’s words came back to her mind.

“I desire only peace and order…”

“It‘s orderly… everything seems to be in its place.” Catra finally spoke, knowing she had given the right answer as Horde Prime’s grin seemed to widen slightly.

“Yes… yes! Such an incredible, immaculate infinity!” Horde Prime exclaimed, however, after a few moments, his smile fell. “And yet… there are still impurities that defile the beauty of such a marvel… abnormalities which threaten its balance… its order. I have met many of them and wiped them all away. They all rose up against me, against a life of peace and order… can you believe it?”

“They rose up against a life of imprisonment… it’s what I should have done long ago…” Catra had to refrain herself from scowling and saying those exact words out aloud. Instead, she chose to further please the tyrant.

“Savages who got what they deserved.”

Horde Prime’s amused expression was suddenly replaced by a surprised one.

“My, my… and here I thought I was the only one with this peculiar vision in the entirety of the vast universe… the only one capable to convince it as a perfect machine… stainless. Of course, in order for the universe to be orderly, someone has to have to control over it… it is my duty, and my burden.” The tyrant stated.

“Of course, and I bet it makes you feel miserable, doesn’t it?” Catra thought sarcastically.

“But where are my manners? I believe I have dismissed you and the queen far too soon when we first met. You must pardon me but there was a little… unresolved issue… I had to settle with my little brother.”

Horde Prime’s malicious grin made Catra’s stomach flip.

“Now that we are here, introductions are in order. You already know enough about me.” Horde Prime proudly gestured at himself, “But I know nothing about you. Tell me… what is the relationship between you and the queen?”

“The queen is the leader of the rebellion. I am… I was Hordak’s second in command, before you… settled things with him.” Catra didn’t hesitate to answer.

“A commander of the Horde? I had misjudged you, child. I initially thought of you as small… and fragile.”

Catra’s eyes went wide. This time, she couldn’t help but scowl and speak her mind.

“I assure you… my lord…” Catra hissed the title between gritted teeth, “I may be a lot of things, but fragile? It’s not amongst them.”

Had she just doomed herself? She expected that Horde Prime would be the kind of leader who’d kill for much, much less. However, Catra became surprised as her words didn’t seem to have angered the tyrant… no… they seemed to have impressed him.

“Such fire! I see that unlike my little brother, his soldiers are not complete disappointments.” Horde Prime laughed.

Catra breathed an inward sigh of relief. She could do this. She only had to keep pleasing him, to say the right words, to come up with some intricate lies about how the Heart of Etheria worked and everything would be fine. Horde Prime would be satisfied, he’d let her go back to queen sparkle head and then they’d figure out how to escape. It seemed easy…

However…

Catra’s relief was short lived…

“It’s a pity though…”

The cat girl became completely still as Horde Prime pronounced those words. Suddenly, a mechanical sound caught her attention. In the middle of the room, a small hatch had opened. Slowly, a white, rectangular table began to emerge from the floor. When Catra turned towards the tyrant to ask for an explanation, it was already too late.

Horde Prime’s clawed hand was already around her neck. He lifted her off the ground, his smile turning into a displeased scowl.

“You do not seem to understand the concept of loyalty…”

The tyrant threw her towards the table, sending Catra crushing into it. The feline tried to stand up, to take a stance, but the two clones who had been guarding the door were already beside her, lifting her off the floor and securing both her wrists and ankles to the white table.

“And that is the thing I value the most… Catra.”

The cat girl stopped struggling for a moment. She had never told Horde Prime her name. How could he have known about who she was? How could he possibly have known about what she had done?

"I see know… you have given yourself a name… you tried to create an empire of your own… there was even a time you wished I would not come for you… is that so?"

The former commander's eyes widened in realization as the tyrant's words came back to her. He had read Hordak's mind… but why hadn't he said something back then?

"Why can I not see your thoughts?"

Because he didn't know. Horde Prime hadn't been able to read Hordak's mind, at least not immediately, and when he did, he failed to see the whole picture. He hadn't seen Hordak discovering the truth about what happened to Entrapta and he hadn't seen Catra betraying him, defeating him.

He must have come to know the truth after she and Glimmer had been sent to their cell… and that meant there was a limit to his power. She just had to be strong enough to resist him… otherwise Horde Prime would have found out that she truly didn't know anything about the Heart, and that would have meant Catra's end.

"Now, foolish child, you'll tell me what I want to know… you'll tell me how your weapon works and then… I'll wipe your mind and make you the perfect soldier…. obedient… loyal…" Horde Prime smiled wickedly as he cradled Catra's cheek. "And once I'm done with you, I'll do the same with all of my little brother's subjects. After all, I cannot risk any of them trying to do what you did to him, am I right?"

Catra turned her head towards him and bit his thumb… hard.

"You foul, disgusting beast!" The tyrant howled in pain as he retracted his hand, holding it tightly as droplets of green blood dripped on the floor.

Catra spat, a devilish grin on her face.

"Gosh, you even taste disgusting." Catra cackled.

The slap that came next stung badly, but the feline's smirk only grew wider. Horde Prime was starting to lose his temper.

"Not so high and mighty now, are you?" Catra thought.

"I'm going to enjoy tearing your mind apart." The tyrant hissed between gritted teeth.

"Good luck with that, you couldn't even do that properly to your little, defective brother." The feline countered mockingly.

When Horde Prime roughly grasped her head between his hands and pressed his thumbs against her cheekbones, Catra felt as if a constant shock was being sent through her body. It was the worse pain she had ever felt in her whole life… even worse than Shadow Weaver's magic…

And it went on for hours…

She didn't know what made her resist. Was it her desire to live? To escape? To see another day? No, it wasn't that simple. Maybe it was like Glimmer said, maybe she had changed… maybe everything she always thought mattered to her wasn't truly what she wanted. Maybe all she wanted was a chance to go back… to fix things… see where this change would have led her… discover for herself what was truly important to her.

Yes… that was what kept her going for a while…

But it became too much. In the end, even that small, fragile hope for a better future wasn't enough. Horde Prime had proven to be more powerful than she had imagined. More powerful than her. Catra's eyes began to close and everything started to go black.

But…

In the exact moment in which she felt herself letting go… giving up… someone appeared in the dark. She couldn't see the figure very well, everything was blurry, but there were certain particulars… so clear… so bright…

Golden hair…

Sky blue eyes…

"Don't… give… up…" They spoke.

That glowing figure… the one that came when Catra needed them the most… she couldn't see who they were, but as soon as she heard them speak those words, the darkness vanished. Catra felt her strength coming back, alongside a power she couldn't quite explain. It was like… after walking alone in a deep, dark tunnel for such a long time… she had finally found a light. It was a light she had almost forgotten… a light in which she had never dared to hope again… but that truthfully had never abandoned her.

"You won't break me!" Catra roared, staring straight into Horde Prime's eyes, showing no fear.

"Damn you!" The tyrant shouted back, releasing Catra as he stumbled backwards and fell to his knees.

Horde Prime's breathing had become heavy, erratic. He closed his eyes for a moment, straightening his tunic as he stood up, but his trembling legs didn't go unnoticed, and neither did his expression. It was a mixture of pain, astonishment, embarrassment, and pure, utter anger.

"Take this… this animal… back to her cage! I'll deal with her later…" Horde Prime muttered, waving a hand in the air before turning around.

The two clones quickly reached for the bindings which kept Catra tied to the white, rectangular table, releasing her. She felt her legs give out, but her pride remained intact, because as they dragged her outside the chamber, she kept her eyes fixed on Horde Prime… and a tired, yet smug grin appeared on her face when she saw the tyrant not doing the same.

When the clones brought her back to her cell, they found Glimmer pacing back and forth, a hand covering her mouth. The young

queen gasped in shock as they let Catra fall to the ground and turned away, the door closing behind them.

“Catra!” Glimmer quickly reached her side, kneeling down and taking the feline’s head in her lap.

“Wow, what a welcome… does the queen like me now?” Catra chuckled weakly.

“Oh my stars! Even in these conditions you still manage to be a jerk!” The young queen yelled, although she couldn’t help but smirk a little.

“Surprised?”

“Not really…”

A few moments passed as the two remained in silence.

“Catra…” Glimmer spoke again, her smile wavering as she focused on Catra’s eyes. Heavy bags had formed under them and they were starting to close. “Are you… are you feeling okay?”

“I’m… I’m so tired…” Catra answered.

“It’s okay, I don’t think they’ll be back soon, you can sleep. I’ll be here.”

“You shouldn’t be so kind… I don’t understand it. I… I took away so much from you.” The feline whispered.

Glimmer sighed heavily.

“You didn’t know… you didn’t know the portal would…” The young queen stopped as she felt her throat go dry, a tear streaming down her cheek. “And even after everything you’ve done… I believe you’re not a monster… I know it, I saw it… you deserve a second chance… we both do.”

“Glimmer… I’m so-” Catra began to talk but was suddenly interrupted.

The door had opened again…

Glimmer raised her gaze, her eyes filled with hatred as she shouted.

“You’ve just taken her back! Leave her alone!”

But the queen’s eyes suddenly went wide, the hate in them gone, replaced by surprise.

It wasn’t a clone who had opened their cell’s door.

“Glimmer…”

“Oh my gosh Glimmer, you’re okay!”

“Guys! We have company! Should I use my uhm… red, magical, lighting… would that be too much?”

“Just use it! I almost out of seeds and I can’t grow anything else to slow them down!”

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! I’m back! I finally completed this chapter. I thought it would turn out to be the chapter about our precious, most beloved pair of prisoners’ escape, but guess what? As I wrote the scene of Catra’s interrogation, I found myself enjoying it immensely. I kept writing and writing and would you look at that? 2300 words. They’re more than any other chapter I’ve ever written, so here you go! But, as you can see, we’re finally there. The next chapter will be called “The Escape”, and you can probably guess what it will be about! I hope that even if this chapter didn’t turn out to be about Glimmer and Catra’s escape, you still enjoyed it, as I enjoyed writing it. So hold on and let’s move towards the next chapter! Oh! Right, guys? I have a little doubt, if you could answer it in the

comments it would be great, of course, tell me also what you think about this chapter, but if you could also answer this question, it would be great. So, as you can see in the story summary there’s a sentence that goes like this “However, as the two of them start talking, Glimmer realizes that Catra isn't the monster she always believed she was.” Do you think there’s a better wording for that concept? You know, I think my English writing and speaking is pretty good, but I’m originally an Italian, so maybe there’s a way to express that concept that would sound better. Just let me know if you think that sentence is okay or if you’d write it differently.

The Escape - Part I

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The clone watched in boredom as the purging chamber's massive slid shut in front of him. He moved to a nearby computer and began typing in a few commands, muttering to himself in annoyance. Of course, clones weren't allowed to have thoughts, emotions, let alone to manifest them, but how much did he hate the purging duty.

There was nothing or no one to fight. There weren't cities to conquer, revolts to suffocate, nothing to actually please Horde Prime. But… it was still a task that needed to be done, even if nothing exciting would have ever happened during this kind of labor.

He waited a for a few minutes as the ship's external hatch opened towards the dark, freezing emptiness of space, before typing in another command, making the chamber's internal door open. The large cubes of waste inside the room immediately got expelled through the purging channel. He waited for another minute as both the ship's external hatch and the chamber's internal door began to close, then, the clone began to walk away.

"The waste cargo is still in the purging chamber… why hasn't it been ejected yet? That is a task you should have already completed ten minutes ago."

The voice of another clone interrupted him. As his eyes widened slightly in puzzlement, he slowly turned around.

"I already emptied it." He answered.

The second clone narrowed his eyes at the statement, a displeased scowl forming on his face.

“Then why is the cargo’s platform detecting a weight of…” The clone interrupted himself as he stared at the data the computer was providing, “…seventy-eight thousand pounds?”

The two clones stared at each other for a few instants before the second spoke again.

“Open the purging chamber.”

The first one obeyed…

However…

As the massive door began to slide open, a burst of ice froze him in place. The second clone remained stunned for a moment, his eyes lingering on the already defeated companion. He quickly turned around, trying to spot the origin of the attack, but the only thing he managed to see was a large, red stinger. It went through his armor as if it had been made of butter and a second later, he fell to the ground, paralyzed, as a loud thud echoed through the nearby corridors.

“Ouch… sorry buddy.” Scorpia said sheepishly.

“Ugh, they’re the bad guys! Stop apologizing!” Mermista groaned.

“Hey! Do you know how painful this bad boy can be?” The scorpion princess shot back.

“Guys! Stop arguing and especially, stop doing it so loudly!” Bow hissed through gritted teeth.

“Let them come! I have enough ice for each and everyone of them!” Frosta exclaimed, raising her fists in the air.

Unfortunately, the little princess found herself kneeling to the ground as everything around her began to spin. Scorpia

immediately reached her side, gently helping her up.

“You okay little buddy?”

“Yeah… i-it’s nothing.” Frosta said, averting the concerned looks of the other princesses.

“It’s not nothing, the Heart took a lot out of all of us.” Adora put a hand on the ice princess’ shoulder, giving her an encouraging smile as she kept speaking, “But it doesn’t matter, we’re on Horde Prime’s ship now.”

“I still have to figure out how we didn’t die in that tunnel.” Bow said, aghast.

“Well… you could have not let Entrapta fly the ship if you were so worried.” Adora slightly bumped him with her elbow, a teasing smile on her face.

“Oh, come on! I thought that after ditching us for learning more about the ship she would have at least learned how to fly it straight!”

“In my defense the garbage expulsion’s tunnel was veeery dark!” Entrapta chimed in, not bothered by Bow’s accusations.

“You could have… I don’t know… turned on the ship’s lights?” Perfuma suggested shily.

“It has headlights?” The scientist princess asked.

“How do you not know if Mara’s ship has lights or not, but you know about its radars and magnifying lenses?!” Bow asked in a shrill voice, hands in his hair.

“Meh, priorities.” Entrapta answered casually.

“Guys, guys! Remember why we’re here. Entrapta? Do you think you could…” Adora pointed at the computer near the purging chamber’s entrance.

“Oh! Of course!”

The pigtailed princess quickly made her way towards the console, firmly holding a small tablet in her hands. She raised it and began tapping on it, as the group that stood behind her began to huddle closer. Everyone held their breath as Entrapta stopped sweeping her fingers along the tablet’s screen and began to stare intensely at it.

A few, endless instants went by… and then…

“Device successfully hacked.”

A large grin appeared on everyone’s faces, Entrapta had done it. She had managed to hack into one of Horde Prime ship’s computers.

“Entrapta… you’re a genius!” Adora exclaimed, holding the scientist princess’ shoulders in excitement.

“Thank you! I mean, the data always confirmed that but… it’s nice hearing it from… my friends.” Entrapta spoke as a joyful smile grew on her lips.

It wasn’t the usual excited, over stretched smile she used to show whenever she managed to discover something new. It was… smaller… quieter… but truthfully, so much bigger, just like the pigtailed princess felt as she heard Adora speak those words. Her experiments had always been the priority for her, but she was starting to feel like there could be space for something else in a one’s life…

Something, dare she say, maybe of equal importance?

“And here it is!”

Entrapta tapped the tablet once and suddenly, a large, detailed map of the tyrant’s gargantuan space station was displayed on its screen for everyone to see. The ship seemed to be divided vertically into thirty sections. Right now, the small group was at

the lowest floor. A small rectangle appeared on the screen, with an arrow pointing at their position, identifying it as 'purging duties'. The scientist princess began to scroll downwards, and finally, when she reached the twenty fifth floor, the tablet showed what they were searching for…

'Prisoner accommodations'

And right at that moment, when Entrapta magnified the image of the floor, only one room seemed to be occupied.

"That must be where they're holding Glimmer prisoner!" Bow exclaimed.

"Just let me do a quick check…" The scientist princess said as she began typing in a few more commands.

Suddenly, the inside of the cell was displayed on the screen and…

There she was…

Glimmer looked deeply concerned as she kept pacing back and forth in the small yet strangely comfortable looking cell, but other than that, she seemed unharmed.

"Glimmer…" Adora whispered.

"What are we waiting for? There's a queen to save!" Sea Hawk raised his saber in the air.

Sadly, his enthusiasm was short lived. Adora took a step forwards and put a hand on his shoulder.

"Not all of us can go. We're not that many but still, if we go all together, they'll surely notice us. We have better chances to save Glimmer and get out if we split into two groups." Adora explained.

"Well… Adora does have a point, I mean, imagine walking this ship's corridor with such a majestic steed by your side." Swift Wind chuckled, waving his mane.

“Well I’m not staying behind!” Frosta crossed her arms, pouting.

“Frosta…” Bow muttered, clearly conflicted, the small princess was in no shape to fight.

“No! We came here to save Glimmer and that’s what-” Frosta stopped speaking for a moment, closing her eyes, and leaning into Scorpia’s side. “That’s what we’ll do.”

“Hey.” Scorpia whispered in a kind tone of voice as she kneeled down and put a pincer on her shoulder, “Just because you’re tired after all that happened, that doesn’t make you weak, okay?”

“Exactly, plus, we’ll need a group to stay behind and protect the ship while we’re gone.” Adora intervened.

Frosta seemed conflicted, but after a few moments, she sighed heavily, nodding her head.

“Good. Now, Perfuma, Scorpia, how are you feeling?”

“Good enough.” The scorpion princess spoke determinately.

“Same here, I also have some seeds, they should be enough to slow the guards down if they find us.” Perfuma answered.

“Okay, then me, Bow, Perfuma and Scorpia will go free Glimmer while Mermista, Sea Hawk and Swifty will stay here with Frosta and Entrapta.” Adora explained.

“Hey! Why do I have to stay here?!” Mermista complained loudly.

The blonde simply stared at her before gesturing at the group who would have had to stay behind and guard the ship.

“Oh! Just think about what I could discover if we just made a little stop at the ‘robotic engineering’ floor!”

“Come child! I’ll tell you about my greatest endeavors while we wait for our comrades to come back!”

“I’m not a child! I’m twelve!”

“On this awful, big bad spaceship…”

“Ooookay… I guess you do have a point, I’ll try to keep them out of trouble.” Mermista grumbled.

“Good.” Adora put a hand on Mermista’s shoulder, giving her an encouraging smile before turning around, “Entrapta?”

“Oh yes! So, I just sent a copy of the space station’s map to Bow’s tracker pad. As you’ll see, all the ship’s floors are accessible through a lift you’ll find just down this corridor,” Entrapta explained as she pointed to a corridor that led to the purging chamber’s entrance, “Then, all you’ll have to do is reach the twenty fifth floor, take Glimmer and come back!”

“Seems easy enough, right?” Bow asked tentatively.

“Weeell, we do not know the exact pattern the clones follow while they’re on guarding duty. When you reach the twenty fifth floor you could find it filled with guards or half empty. I could analyze the clones’ moving pattern through the cameras scattered around the ship, but it would take a while and we don’t know when they’re gonna notice the absence of this two.” The scientist princess pointed at the frozen clone and at his paralyzed comrade.

“We can’t lose any more time. We’ll just have to do this the best friends squad’s way.” Adora spoke with determination, a brave smile on her face.

“Oh boy…” Bow chuckled nervously.

“I don’t know what that means but, let’s do it!” Scorpia said enthusiastically.

As the two groups separated, Entrapta began to follow Mermista, Sea Hawk, Forsta and Swift Wind as they boarded Mara’s ship. However, the scientist princess stopped dead in her tracks as she seemed to have found something on the station’s map she hadn’t

noticed before. A floor labelled as ‘Reconditioning’. Curious eyes widened in horror as she accessed its cameras.

“It’s you…” Entrapta whispered.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for the wait guys, also, happy new year! It’s currently 3 am here in the fabulous Lasagna Land. Yes, that is a stereotype joke, I did it because I’m tired, drunk aaaand… an Italian. Still, I wanted to give you a little gift and to tell you (did I already say this?) how much your appreciation always brightens my days, truly, I can’t thank you enough… and yes, your eyes don’t deceive you, this is only part one of “The Escape”. I’ll publish the second part in… two days! (it's already written, currently, I'm working on chapter 10) Just so a little hype can be built. Yes, I know I’m despicable, you don’t need to tell me. I hope you’ve enjoyed this chapter and stay tuned for the second part, which will conclude our heroes’ escape and begin a new arch. I really hope you’ll like what I have in store for our favorite team. To the next chapter and beyond!

The Escape - Part II

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I just sent a copy of the space station's map to Bow's tracker pad. As you'll see, all the ship's floors are accessible through a lift you'll find just down this corridor," Entrapta explained as she pointed to a corridor that led to the purging chamber's entrance, "Then, all you'll have to do is reach the twenty fifth floor, take Glimmer and come back!"

"Seems easy enough, right?" Bow asked tentatively.

"Weeell, we do not know the exact pattern the clones follow while they're on guarding duty. When you reach the twenty fifth floor you could find it filled with guards or half empty. I could analyze the clones' moving pattern through the cameras scattered around the ship, but it would take a while and we don't know when they're gonna notice the absence of this two." The scientist princess pointed at the frozen clone and at his paralyzed comrade.

"We can't lose any more time. We'll just have to do this the best friends squad's way." Adora spoke with determination, a brave smile on her face.

"Oh boy…" Bow chuckled nervously.

"I don't know what that means but, let's do it!" Scorpia said enthusiastically.

As the two groups separated, Entrapta began to follow Mermista, Sea Hawk, Forsta and Swift Wind as they boarded Mara's ship. However, the scientist princess stopped dead in her tracks as she

seemed to have found something on the station's map she hadn't noticed before. A floor labelled as 'Reconditioning'. Curious eyes widened in horror as she accessed its cameras.

"It's you…" Entrapta whispered.

Meanwhile:

When Horde Prime's clones brought Catra back to her cell, they found Glimmer pacing back and forth, a hand covering her mouth. The young queen gasped in shock as they let the feline fall to the ground and turned away, the door closing behind them.

"Catra!" Glimmer quickly reached her side, kneeling down and taking the feline's head in her lap.

"Wow, what a welcome… does the queen like me now?" Catra chuckled weakly.

"Oh my stars! Even in these conditions you still manage to be a jerk!" The young queen yelled, although she couldn't help but smirk a little.

"Surprised?"

"Not really…"

A few moments passed as the two remained in silence.

"Catra…" Glimmer spoke again, her smile wavering as she focused on Catra's eyes. Heavy bags had formed under them and they were starting to close. "Are you… are you feeling okay?"

"I'm… I'm so tired…" Catra answered.

"It's okay, I don't think they'll be back soon, you can sleep. I'll be here."

“You shouldn’t be so kind… I don’t understand it. I… I took away so much from you.” The feline whispered.

Glimmer sighed heavily.

“You didn’t know… you didn’t know the portal would…” The young queen stopped as she felt her throat go dry, a tear streaming down her cheek. “And even after everything you’ve done… I believe you’re not a monster… I know it, I saw it… you deserve a second chance… we both do.”

“Glimmer… I’m so-” Catra began to talk but was suddenly interrupted.

The door had opened again…

Glimmer raised her gaze, her eyes filled with hatred as she shouted.

“You’ve just taken her back! Leave her alone!”

But the queen’s eyes suddenly went wide, the hate in them gone, replaced by surprise.

It wasn’t a clone who had opened their cell’s door…

No…

Glimmer’s gaze fell on the two guards who had brought Catra back just a few minutes before. They were laying on the floor, one covered in roots, the other in red sparks.

“Glimmer…”

The soft voice made her head turn so quick it hurt and the young queen found herself unable to utter a single word as she finally saw her savior.

She really was there.

She really came.

Adora…

“Oh my gosh Glimmer, you’re okay!” Bow shouted happily, his eyes teary.

“T-told you they’d come for you…” Catra muttered weakly.

“Catra…” Adora’s tone suddenly hardened as she noticed the former Horde commander’s presence.

Why would Catra be in a cell with Glimmer? But most importantly… why was the young queen holding her? Unless… but it couldn’t be…

“Nice to see you too, princess.” The feline countered, her voice dripping with sarcasm.

“Glimmer, what-” The blonde began to ask for an explanation, but Glimmer immediately stopped her.

“Adora, i-it’s fine! She… she saved me…”

“What?” Adora whispered, as her gaze softened.

But before Glimmer could answer, Scorpia leaned inside the room, a worried look on her face.

“Guys! We have company! Should I use my uhm… red, magical, lighting… would that be too much?”

“Just use it! I’m almost out of seeds! I won’t be able to slow them down much longer!” Perfuma shrilled from outside the cell.

“S-Scorpia?” Catra stuttered, as she felt her eyelids becoming more and more heavy.

The scorpion princess found herself shoving Adora aside. She had to make a mental note to apologize to her once this whole rescue was over, but as soon as she heard that voice, she acted on impulse. She hadn’t noticed that Catra was inside the cell at first,

but now, there she was. The feline was laying on the ground, her head in Glimmer's lap. She looked… terrible, if Scorpia had to be sincere. But she was alive.

Still, she couldn't think about anything to say. The two of them simply stared at each other for what seemed to be an eternity.

"Catra… I…" Scorpia began to speak but a hand clamping down on her shoulder suddenly reminded her of the situation at hand.

"Scorpia!" Perfuma yelled as she pointed towards five more clones rushing towards them.

"Halt! In the name of the great emperor of the known universe!"

"Oh shoot!" Scorpia exclaimed before pointing her pincers towards the guards, red lightning erupting from them an instant later.

Catra's eyes widened in pure disbelief. What was all that about? What kind of power was that? It looked like… it looked like Shadow Weaver's magic… What happened to Scorpia while she was gone? What did the other princesses do to her? And… and why was the only thought of someone doing something bad to the scorpion princess making her feel such a deep, scorching anger? As if… as if she still…

"Catra?! W-what's wrong with her?!"

"Horde Prime did something to her… I think… I think he tortured her."

Catra heard Glimmer and Scorpia's voices becoming muffled, as her vision grew darker and darker. Her eye lids felt so, so much heavier now. She couldn't hold them opened any longer. Grimacing in pain, she raised her head and looked at the small group, using the little strength she had left to utter a few words.

"J-just get out of here… leave me… I'd slow you down…"

"No!"

Everyone turned towards Adora. The blonde had spoken that single word so quickly and with such a strength, that even Catra became speechless.

"She tried to kill you!"

"She kidnapped your friends!"

"She's the reason Angella is gone!"

Those thoughts… Adora couldn't deny their truthfulness as they began to swirl inside her mind. But even if in that moment she found herself reliving all the bad things that Catra had done… even if a part of her still wanted her ex best friend to pay for what she did… even if the darkest corner of her mind told her to leave her there… a thought still arose in Adora's mind, silencing all the others.

"I won't leave her again."

Everything remained still for a few instants. No one moved… no one spoke… until…

"Glimmer… can you walk?" Adora asked, breaking the deafening silence, her voice strong, determined.

"Yeah, yeah I think so… b-but wait… Adora I… I just wanted to-" Glimmer began to talk but fell silent as Adora kneeled down and put a hand on her shoulder, giving her a light squeeze alongside a comforting smile.

"I know, we'll have plenty of time to talk once we're back in Brightmoon."

Stars, how much did Glimmer miss her friend's confidence. Before being kidnapped by Horde Prime, she had begun to despise that blind courage, that annoyingly unwavering determination. She thought it was what made Adora a better leader than her, therefore, she hated it. But as she remained alone in her cell after the clones took Catra away, she found herself thinking about what

had happened between her and the blonde and found out that… none of it mattered anymore. Adora's courage, her confidence, even her stubbornness, those were the things that made her who she was, and Glimmer had missed that so, so very much.

"Okay…" Glimmer replied, a tired smile on her face.

"Scorpia? Think you can still clear our way?" Adora turned towards the scorpion princess as she heard more heavy footsteps coming down the corridor towards them.

"Y-yes! Of course, b-but what about-" Scorpia's eyes went wide, her mouth clamping shut as saw the blonde bending down and raising Catra from the ground, holding her in her arms.

"Let's go."

The small group rushed outside the cell. Scorpia turned around briefly, red bolts erupting from her pincers. They flew through the air before hitting another squadron of clones. Perfuma threw her last seed as far as she could down the corridor before using her powers to make it grow into a root barrier. Horde Prime's soldiers wouldn't have taken long to destroy it, but it would have still slowed them down.

"Y-you're an idiot… you'll get them killed." Catra whispered.

"I'm not going to let it happen, and I'm not going to leave anyone behind…" Adora answered, her blue eyes shining with determination.

"You've already broken that promise, don't you remember, princess?" A tired yet dark chuckle escaped the feline's lips.

Adora didn't answer, her expression morphed into one of pain and Catra waited for that sweet sense of satisfaction she had always felt whenever she had succeeded in hurting the blonde…

But it didn't come.

Why?

Why didn’t it come?

That single, frightening thought was the last thing that crossed Catra’s mind before she finally closed her eyes. Between the clones’ angered shouts and the sound of lighting, everything went black. Seeing her going limp in Adora’s arms, Scorpia quickly reached her side.

“I-is she alright?!” The scorpion princess asked, voice laced with worry.

“She passed out, but she’ll be fine.” The blonde answered, although, the confidence in her voice wavered slightly.

As the princesses rushed through the floor’s long, white corridors, the lift finally came into view. The clones’ steps were becoming closer again. They must had broken through Perfuma’s barrier, but luckily, the root wall had managed to slow them down enough for the small group to make their escape. They called the elevator…

But the door didn’t open.

“What’s wrong with the elevator?!” Bow shrieked, clearly panicking.

“Someone must have called it before us!” Adora turned around, only to see a few clones appearing at the end of the long corridor that lead the princesses to the lift.

“What are we going to do?” Perfuma’s voice quivered.

“We fight…” Glimmer stepped forwards.

The young queen raised her fists, a grimace of pain appearing on her face as a purplish light engulfed them. Her powers were starting to come back, but it still hurt. She turned towards Adora, expecting her to tell her to stop, that she would only hurt herself that way. Instead, the blonde nodded, an encouraging smile on

her face. Glimmer's eyes widened in surprise before she nodded back.

"Those tin cans don't stand a chance against us! Come on!" The young queen shouted.

"Yeah! We can hold them as long as we need to!" Scorpia raised her pincers. They were trembling slightly, but she would have never given up, not on her new friends, nor on Catra.

"The lift will be here shortly! Use everything you've got!" Bow said, nocking an arrow.

The group let out a powerful war cry as the clones got nearer and nearer. Glimmer, Scorpia and Bow were ready to attack but suddenly…

Ting!

The elevator's doors opened behind them.

"Oh… ehm… hi guys!"

It was Entrapta's voice…

The small group turned around, but as they did, their jaws fell to the floor as they noticed who the scientist princess was supporting with both her arms and her pigtails.

"Is that… Hordak?!"

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! Soooo… funny story: as I re-read the second part of "The Escape", I found myself adding a few things, and those few things became… many things. In the end, I found myself with this chapter and another one with a similar word length. So I thought, why not divide them and create two chapters? One now, the other in two days! This way, you'll have another chapter pretty soon! The next one, "The Escape – Part III"

will be the last chapter of “The Escape” arc. I hope you’re enjoying this story so far and… oh? Don’t tell me you expected Glimmer and Adora to have their long awaited talk and make up in this chapter? Really guys? During an escape? And maybe you also expected Adora and Catra to talk things out? Or Catra and Scorpia? Hehehehe… sorry, for that you’ll have to wait. But not that much, that I can tell you. To the next chapter and beyond! Remember, in two days!

The Escape - Part III

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Once she had gotten in, the ventilation system turned out to be much simpler than she had anticipated. After all, Entrapta already had a fair amount of experience with crawling through air ducts. That, and the map on her tablet, made reaching the reconditioning chamber practically a piece of cake.

The scientist princess had managed to sneak past all the clones who patrolled the floor, finding herself in front of a small, square grate. Her eyes widened as she caught a glimpse of a rectangular, white table on the other side… and the person tied to it.

Entrapta felt a small pang of guilt as she carefully pushed the grate open. She had left Mermista, Sea Hawk, Frosta and Swift Wind alone on Mara's ship. She should have followed Adora's instructions, and she would have! Even though Horde Prime's space station must have been a technological paradise, she found herself being able to refrain from wandering off. She was going to follow her group, to wait for Adora and the others to come back… but when she saw him… when she saw Hordak…

Mermista had her hands full trying to calm Frosta down, while Sea Hawk was too lost in retelling his own adventures to notice the pigtailed princess slowly backing away from the ship. The same went for Swift Wind. Apparently, having to wait for Adora and not being able to take part in the action had made him… slightly anxious… or at least that is how Entrapta interpreted his little jingle about all of them being trapped on a terrifying, giant space station.

As she took the lift to the 'Reconditioning' floor, the scientist princess began to wonder if she was actually doing the right thing. After all, leaving the group she had been assigned to could have completely jeopardized the rescue mission.

"It won't take long… I just need to free him and bring him back." Entrapta whispered to herself, quietly pushing the small grate open.

She could already hear the other princesses yelling at her. She could see their eyes wide, filled with both shock and anger. But how could she have abandoned him? How could she have abandoned a friend? Friends would never do that. Friends support each other, through thick and thin. If she had stayed on Mara's ship, she would have done the completely opposite thing of what friends should do.

At least, that is what Entrapta had understood about friendship. She walked up to Hordak, nervously fiddling with her fingers. His eyes were closed, his breathing almost imperceptible… but he was still alive. The scientist princess couldn't refrain herself from smiling at the realization, a sigh of relief escaping her lips. She stepped forward and began to open the locks that kept him tied to the table.

Once she had opened the last lock, Hordak's body collapsed on top of hers, making both the former Horde's leader and the pigtailed princess fall to the ground. She began to gently push him away, when suddenly, she heard a low grunt coming from him.

"Hordak?" She called him, her voice uncertain.

As he raised his head, Entrapta felt a chill running down her spine. His eyes looked… different… and the snarl that quickly replaced his neutral expression… he had never looked at her like that…

"Hordak? What's-" The scientist princess began to speak, but her voice died in her throat.

Hordak's hands had circled her neck…

“Intruder… must… eliminate… for… Horde Prime…” Hordak muttered.

Did he not recognize her? Had he forgotten about her? No… it couldn’t be… how could he? But then, why was he trying to…? Suddenly, the realization hit her. Horde Prime must had done something to him. Something to make him forget. But if that was the case then… could she make him remember? And how?

Entrapta couldn’t breathe, and slowly, her vision began to blur. She felt her strength abandoning her and in a last attempt to save both Hordak and herself, she raised a shaking hand to his pale cheek.

“Y-you don’t need to be perfect… y-you don’t need him… r-remember what I s-said? Imperfection is beautiful… at least… to me…”

Everything became dark for a moment.

Her hand dropped to the floor.

Then…

Air suddenly filled her lungs.

He had let her go.

Entrapta felt him dragging himself away from her. She slowly rose up from the floor, still feeling dizzy. Hordak had both his hands tangled in his short, dark blue hair. His eyes were screwed shut and his face was contorted with pain. The pigtailed princess moved towards him. She tried to cup his face with her hands but Hordak slapped them away.

“Don’t… I’m not myself… I’ll hurt you.” Hordak muttered through gritted teeth.

“I don’t think you will.” Entrapta said, raising her hands, much more slowly than before.

This time, as the scientist princess cupped his face, the former Horde leader only tensed for a few moments.

“Say my name.” The scientist princess whispered.

“E-Entrapta…” Hordak stuttered.

He remembered.

He didn’t forget about her.

“See? Even after everything that had happened… you’re still you.”

“H-how are you here? I thought that… that you…” Hordak found himself incapable of saying those words.

“Adora and Bow saved me from Beast Island… we came for Glimmer… but then I saw you. What did Horde Prime do to you?” Entrapta’s tone softened.

“It doesn’t matter.” The former Horder leader averted her gaze, shame flashing in his eyes.

“It does, I’m here to rescue you!”

“I won’t hand myself to the rebellion.” Hordak spat with disgust.

“But if you stay here… Horde Prime will kill you.”

Entrapta gently raised his face and stared into his eyes. They were filled with anger, hate, shame and confliction but surprisingly… all those things vanished when she opened her mouth and spoke again.

“Please… he doesn’t deserve you… come with me… I don’t think I can bear to lose a friend just after learning what having one means.”

“You thought you could be equal to me?!”

“You have become an abomination!”

"You must be reborn!"

Horde Prime's words rang into Hordak's head. He'd never be equal to Horde Prime… but Entrapta didn't seem to care. He was indeed an abomination. He was a flawed creation… but while his own creator and brothers always gave him looks of disgust, he had never seen Entrapta looking at him with anything more than curiosity, admiration and… affection. He should have been reborn. Hordak himself couldn't understand how he was still there, how he could still be… himself. Horde Prime had never failed to recondition a clone before. But something… something in his mind kept pulling him back from oblivion, something that kept resisting his own creator's power. Something even stronger than Horde Prime.

And when the reconditioning chamber's door opened and Entrapta came out running, Hordak followed her, a fresh, new purpose in his mind. To understand what that 'something' was.

A few minutes after:

"The lift will be here shortly! Use everything you've got!" Bow said, nocking an arrow.

The group let out a powerful war cry as the clones got nearer and nearer. Glimmer, Scorpia and Bow were ready to attack but suddenly…

Ting!

The elevator's doors opened behind them.

"Oh… ehm… hi guys!"

It was Entrapta's voice…

The small group turned around, but as they did, their jaws fell to the floor as they noticed who the scientist princess was supporting with both her arms and her pigtails.

"Is that… Hordak?!"

"Ahh… clones!" Entrapta yelled, pointing at the guards rushing towards them.

Everyone looked conflicted, as their gazes kept shifting between the incoming Horde Prime's clones and the former Horde leader.

"There's no time! Get inside!" Adora shouted.

The small group reluctantly moved inside the lift, its doors quickly closing just a second before Horde Prime's clones could catch them. The elevator began its descent towards the 'purging duties' floor. It should have been a quick travel, but each and every person inside the small, moving, metal cage, felt like the lift would have taken forever to reach their destination.

The first one to move was Hordak. Despite the fact that he was too weak to stand on his own, as his gaze focused on who Adora was carrying, he took a step forwards, an angry snarl escaping his lips. However, the former Horde leader quickly realized his mistake as the blonde stepped back, her arms tightening around Catra, while Scorpia came between them. The scorpion princess took a defensive stance, her stinger ready to hit.

"You won't hurt her again." Scorpia murmured, her voice puzzling the small group, as it came out as a mix of anger, hate and resentment. No one had ever heard her talking like that.

A few, silent moments went by, then…

Glimmer's shock from finding herself face to face with the one person she hated the most faded away, replaced by a fiery anger.

"Glimmer! Wait!" Entrapta pleaded.

“What is he doing here?!” The young queen screamed in rage as her fists began to glow.

“I-I-” Entrapta began to speak but was harshly cut off.

“Entrapta?! Have you seriously left Mara’s ship to… to…” Bow quickly nodded an arrow.

“I couldn’t leave him here! Horde Prime was torturing him!” Entrapta put herself in front of Hordak, shielding him.

“And you think I care?! He was going to split my head in half with a chunk of metal! Why would you do something like this?!” Glimmer shouted, the glow surrounding her hands growing in intensity.

“Because he’s my friend!” The pigtailed princess shouted back.

For a single instant, the young queen’s expression softened. However, as her eyes met Hordak’s, she shook her head.

“It doesn’t matter, I’m going to-” Glimmer began to raise her fists towards Hordak, but before she could blast him, she felt a hand lightly grasping her shoulder.

“Glimmer…” Adora spoke, her voice soft, pleading her to calm down.

“Adora, not you too! You know what he did! He brought the Horde to Etheria! He destroyed countless cities! Ruined lives! He almost killed me!”

“I know.”

Adora’s answer took Glimmer by surprise. The young queen stared at her friend, mouth slightly agape in shock as she slightly lowered her fists.

“And he will pay for what he has done to Etheria… to us… but if you start a fight here, we could get hurt, all of us. Now, the most

important thing for us is to escape. We'll deal with Hordak later."

Glimmer wanted so badly to tell Adora that she was wrong, that Hordak needed to pay right there, in that exact moment, for everything he did. But the blonde was right, fighting him now could have put them in danger. Entrapta seemed completely determined to defend him and Glimmer didn't want to actually hurt her, or Bow, or Adora, or anyone else who had risked their lives to save her.

"Alright…" Glimmer grunted.

Everyone seemed to draw a sigh of relief as the purplish light around the young queen's hands finally dissipated. There would have been a time for Hordak to pay for his crimes. Right now, it was the time to escape. The lift stopped, its doors sliding open. The small group quickly strolled through a long corridor, and as they turned around its corner, they were met with a comforting sight.

"There they are!" Mermista shouted.

The mermaid princess, Frosta, Sea Hawk and Swift Wind were all standing by the purging chamber's entrance. They seemed tired, but other than that they looked fine. Sadly, although their expressions were initially relieved, that soon changed as their gazes fell upon Entrapta and Hordak.

"What is that Horde scum doing here?!" Sea Hawk gasped.

"I-it's okay! I brought him here!" Entrapta tried to explain.

"Uhh… what?! You left us because of him?!" Mermista fumed.

"Do you know how worried we were when we couldn't find you?!" Frosta chimed in, furious.

"Guys! We don't have time for this! We need to-" Adora began to speak, but she was abruptly cut off.

Ting!

The lift had just opened. The sound of heavy footsteps came next.

"They're here! Run!" Bow yelled.

Everyone turned towards the purging chamber, quickly getting in.

"We need to shut the door from the inside! Otherwise they'll get us before Mara's ship is ready to fly!" Bow said, before turning towards Entrapta, "Entrapta? Think you can do it?" Despite everything that had happened, the archer still managed to give the scientist princess an encouraging smile.

"I'm on it." Entrapta answered.

"Everyone, get on board, quick!" Adora shouted.

The blonde stayed behind until everyone got on board. She was going to follow them immediately but suddenly… she found herself unable to move as a voice she had never heard before spoke, sending chills down her spine.

"Where do you think you're going with my guests?"

As Adora slowly turned around, she saw a dozen of clones appearing at the end of the corridor that lead to the purging chamber. They weren't alone though. A hulking figure towered over them. He was very similar to them, but from the first instant Adora had laid eyes on him, she knew… he was no ordinary clone.

"It's Horde Prime!" Glimmer yelled from behind her.

Horde Prime…

The true leader of the Horde…

The emperor of the known universe…

And when Adora's gaze met his, she realized, she had been a fool to fear Hordak when she was younger, because the former

Etherian Horde leader was nothing compared to his creator.

“I’m almost done with the door! It should close any second now!” Entrapta said, furiously swiping her fingers along her tablet’s screen.

“Adora! Get on board!” Bow yelled from inside the ship.

And that was the moment when Horde Prime’s demeanor changed completely. As he heard the young archer voice that name, his wicked grin disappeared, replaced by a puzzled expression before his eyes began to darken.

“So… you are still alive. I should have known… I'd recognize those eyes anywhere. Your family wasn’t a bother enough, wasn’t it? You had to come back too!” Horde Prime roared.

“W-what?” Adora whispered.

The girl was suddenly lost. She couldn’t breathe, she couldn’t move. Did that monster know… about her past? About who she was before Light Hope pulled her through the portal? Did he know about… her family? As a thousand questions began to form in Adora’s mind, the girl didn’t notice Horde Prime raising his right arm. A couple of clones stepped forward, carrying a giant crossbow and securing it to the tyrant's arm.

“You’ve disrupted my plans for the last time, descendant of Grayskull.” Horde Prime declared as a bright beam erupted from his weapon.

“Adora!” Frosta cried.

Suddenly, a wall of ice rose in front of Adora just a second before she could get hit. The barrier shattered the moment the beam touched it, sending both the blonde and Catra to the ground. Luckily, before Horde Prime could shoot again, the purging chamber’s door closed in front of him and his clones.

“My lord… it’ll take just a few moments to open the door.” A clone spoke as Horde Prime lowered his weapon.

“Don’t bother.” The Horde leader muttered.

He walked to a nearby window, crossing his arms behind his back. His eyes followed Mara’s ship as it began to fly away. He waited until it was long gone, before turning towards his troops.

“What is the status of the second fleet?”

“It has reached the objective, my lord.” A clone answered, reaching the tyrant’s side.

“Good… my little brother’s right hand has proven to be much stronger than I thought… but she still let a small detail slip.”

The clone handed Horde Prime a tablet. On its screen, five small triangles could be seen moving towards a flashing red dot. It displayed a name.

Bright Moon…

Chapter End Notes

> Aaaaaaand, it’s over! The “The Escape” arc is finally finished! Now we can work on some characters patching up things or… making it worse… hehehe. So, I hope you’ve liked this chapter and the story so far. It will be a while before I can post the next chapter, I have two exams, but I’ll work extra hard so you won’t have to wait too much. Thank you guys for all the appreciation you’re showing for my story, it’s really important for me, it keeps me going, really, it does. Tell me what you think of this chapter in the comments, also if you liked the escape in general and… I’ll see you… in the next chapter! Bye bye!
>
> P.S. have you ever seen an old Horde Prime's toy? Well, give it a look and see for yourselves where I got the idea for his weapon XD

Father and Daughter

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The small vessel traveled silently through the endless void of space. Only the First Ones could tell how Entrapta had managed to fly Mara's ship through the purging tunnel without crashing it into its walls, let alone escape Horde Prime's space station before the hatch at the end of the tunnel could close. But she still managed to do it, despite everyone's screams of panic.

As everyone began to quiet down, Entrapta immediately activated the ship's radar, looking for anything that could have been following them. Surprisingly, Horde Prime didn't seem to have deployed any ship to chase them. They were alone. Etheria was becoming closer and closer and in a few minutes, the ship would have reached its surface.

The rescue hadn't gone exactly as planned. Sure, they had managed to save Glimmer, but no one had expected to find Catra with her. Still, Scorpia had been more than happy to finally reunite with her, even if for a moment before the cat girl passed out. Of course, what upset them the most was Entrapta risking to jeopardize the whole mission by rescuing their sworn enemy.

Adora became furious as she first laid eyes on the former Horde leader, but as Entrapta explained why she did what she did, that anger began to quiet down. Hordak had done the most awful things to Etheria, but clearly, not to Entrapta. It was ridiculous, but Adora found herself being grateful to him for that.

As she quietly made her way to a corner of the ship, sliding down against a wall, finally giving her legs a well deserved rest, her eyes landed on the former Horde Leader. He looked… tired… weak… and fearful. But even though Adora knew the princesses

could have destroyed him right there, in that exact moment, she also knew that they would have never done it and… she would have never done it either. They weren't the Horde.

Mara's ship began its descent towards Etheria, a synthetic voice warning the group that soon they'd be entering the planet's atmosphere. Adora wasn't listening though, her mind had gone back to the few words Horde Prime told her before they managed to make their escape.

"So… you are still alive. I should have known… I could recognize those eyes anywhere. Your family wasn't a bother enough, wasn't it? You had to come back too!"

"You've disrupted my plans for the last time, descendant of Grayskull."

Her family wasn't a bother enough… descendant of Grayskull… those words began to whirl inside Adora's mind like a storm. If what Horde Prime told her was true then… she was a descendant of Grayskull… whoever they might have been… but most importantly… it meant that maybe, just maybe… her family might have still been alive, out there, somewhere, waiting for her.

Finally, Adora had an actual chance of discovering who she truly was, where she came from… of reuniting with her family. She knew it was such a small chance, and she knew that she shouldn't have felt so hopeful, but she couldn't help it. She would have done everything she could to stop Horde Prime and then, she would have found them… even if it meant to search the whole galaxy for them.

"What if you can't find them? What if they're already…" Adora asked herself.

The blonde raised her head, looking at the princesses, looking at Glimmer, at Bow, Swift Wind and Sea Hawk. If she wouldn't have found her family, Adora realized that she already had one right in front of her. They would have always been there for her, like they

had already done in the past. If that wasn’t a family, then Adora wouldn’t have known what else it could have been.

The blonde’s gaze began to lower, until her eyes fell upon Catra. She hadn’t realized she was still holding her tight, and began to relax her arms, still keeping them wrapped around the feline but much more gently.

Catra…

Adora... well… the blonde had mixed feelings about the feline. She had been shocked to find her with Glimmer. She thought that if the two of them would have ever met again they would have killed each other. That is why she couldn't believe her own eyes when she entered their cell on Horde Prime's ship.

Glimmer was holding her, reassuring her even. Adora didn't understand until the young queen had intervened, telling her that Catra had saved her. That single statement made Adora even more confused. Why would Catra do something like that?

Did Catra save Glimmer only to ensure her own safety? Adora found herself shaking her head at the thought. Despite everything that Catra had done, she knew the cat girl couldn't have saved Glimmer just because of that. She just knew it.

Catra decided to side with Horde when Adora left. She almost destroyed Bright Moon. She helped Hordak raze Selineas. She activated the portal that almost destroyed the entire universe... and even if she failed in doing that… it still costed Angella’s life.

And Adora? She wanted nothing more than to hate Catra for what she had done. For how much she had hurt Glimmer, for how much she had hurt her. She wanted to hate her because of what she had never thought her ex best friend would be able to do. And she had managed to do that… for a while… or at least, that is what Adora kept telling herself.

But Adora couldn’t lie to herself any longer. She had always known that she would have never been able to hate Catra, not fully, not

after everything they've been through together. There had always been a speck of hope in Adora's heart for Catra, hope to see her chose a better path, hope to understand what had gone wrong between the two of them, hope for a chance to reconcile with her… hope to reunite with the only person who had ever loved her before she left the Horde…

And when Glimmer told her what Catra had done for her? That tiny speck began to burn brighter than ever before. Catra, the Horde Commander was gone in an instant and in her place, Adora could see someone else. She could finally see Catra, the girl whom she spent her whole life with, who stole her socks, who was afraid of mice, who slept at the feet of her bed making Adora feel that deep, soothing, comforting warmth she had missed during every night she spent in Bright Moon.

Without even knowing, Adora looked at Catra and gave her a tired, sad smile. When she raised her gaze, her eyes met Scorpia's. She expected the scorpion princess to be mad, after all, Adora had no right to be in that position with Catra. They were supposed to be enemies, and the chances of them patching things up were basically nonexistent, while Scorpia still had a possibility. Surprisingly, the scorpion princess simply smiled before turning towards the other princesses.

"Landing in three minutes."

It was time to move. Adora stood up, looking out and seeing Bright Moon castle becoming closer closer. They had done it, they really had done it. She had kept the promise she made to Micah.

Micah…

She still couldn't believe they had found him on Beast Island, still alive after all those years. Although, that shouldn't have surprised her so much. He had a daughter to return to.

Adora made her way towards Glimmer, reaching the young queen's side.

“Hey…” Adora said quietly.

“Hi…” Glimmer spoke, a cautious smile on her face.

“Happy to be back?”

“You don’t even know.” The young queen muttered, her eyes turning curious as she noticed Adora’s grin widening as Mara’s ship began to land near Bright Moon castle. “What are you smiling about?”

“Other than about the fact that you’re here?” Adora gave her a sly look, chuckling at Glimmer’s reaction. The young queen’s eyes had gone wide with surprise before she looked away.

“Adora… listen… I-” Glimmer began to talk, her gaze low, a shameful look on her face, but suddenly, she was interrupted.

“We’re landing.” Entrapta announced, her usual cheerful voice replaced by a trembling murmur.

Adora looked at the scientist princess, confused. She couldn’t understand what could have been scaring her. After all, she had just successfully escaped a space station using a First Ones’ ship… she should have been ecstatic! But as she focused on the pigtailed princess’ gaze, she began to understand. Entrapta’s eyes were set upon Hordak.

Entrapta was scared…

Scared for her friend…

And although Adora couldn’t quite figure out how Entrapta could have grown to like or even consider someone as despicable as Hordak as a friend… she felt bad for her. She knew that if she would have ever found herself in Entrapta’s position, she would have done everything to protect her friend… actually, Adora realized that it could happen sooner than she expected… given who she was carrying between her arms.

The blonde's train of thought was abruptly interrupted by the ship finally landing on the castle grounds. She turned towards Glimmer, a soft smile on her face.

"I promise you we'll have time to talk Glimmer… but first… there's a surprise for you…" Adora spoke, barely hiding her excitement, her voice shaking slightly.

"W-what is it?" Glimmer said, puzzled.

"I think you should see for yourself."

The small group began to descend the ship's ladder. They had done it, they had really done it. Sea Hawk fell to his knees and began to kiss the ground.

"Sweet, sweet land!" He cried dramatically.

"I thought you'd like to sail through space." Mermista mocked him.

"Bah! That black void has nothing in common with the incomparable beauty of the sea! Or… its inhabitants…" Sea Hawk winked at the princess, smoothing his mustache, while Mermista groaned loudly.

"I can't believe we've actually done it! We… we should celebrate! I, uh, what do you guys do for celebration?" Scorpia scratched the top of her head.

"We could have a pajama party! B-but not because I'm tired or anything!" Frosta said, trying to stifle a yawn.

"Yeah! Let's do that!" The scorpion princess spoke loudly, putting a pincer around the small princess' shoulders.

"And I could make herbal teas for everyone… I know I need one right now." Perfuma said heaving a long sigh.

"Why don't we ask the folks of Elberon to throw us another party? They make the best ones!" Swift Wind pawed the ground

enthusiastically.

And as the princesses laughed together, a figure began to approach the group. Adora was the first one to notice and quickly gathered everyone's attention.

"They're all great ideas guys, but… I think that right now, the best thing we can do is stand aside."

The small group turned around and finally noticed who was standing right in front of them. Everyone began to step aside and Glimmer, who had remained hidden behind the group for the whole time, suddenly found herself face to face with the figure who had silently approached them, unable to utter even the smallest word.

He had been waiting for the princesses to return…

He kept looking at the sky until he finally saw Mara's ship descend towards the castle…

He couldn't breathe as he slowly approached the group, fear gripping his heart as his little girl was nowhere to be seen…

But now, as the princesses stepped aside… now that he could finally see her… now that he finally knew she was alright…

Tears began to stream down the old king's cheeks.

"Glimmer…"

The young queen became speechless. She couldn't believe her own eyes. It had to be a trick, a cruel joke and nothing more, so when Micah took a step towards her, she found herself taking one backwards. Adora watched in disbelief, she would have expected the young queen to cry with joy, to hug her father with such a strength that she would have squeezed the air out of his lungs… she couldn't understand why Glimmer was acting the way she was… but when she turned towards her and Bow, Adora understood. The young queen's eyes were filled with desperation,

as if she was silently begging her best friends to tell her if what she was seeing was true, or if it was nothing more than a cruel joke the universe had decided to play on her. But when the young queen saw both Adora and Bow smile at her, tears in their eyes as they happily nodded…

She knew it was true…

Somehow… she couldn't explain how… but it was true….

She turned towards Micah…

And decided not to waste another second…

Glimmer launched herself at Micah, locking him in a tight hug, embracing him with all the strength she had left. She prayed whoever was looking at her from above to let it be true, she prayed for her father not to disappear between her arms…

He didn't.

Micah hugged her back as fiercely as his daughter did, burying his face into her hair as they both cried. They cried for all the time the world had taken them, for all the stories Micah hadn't been able to tell Glimmer as she grew up and… they cried… because even after all that had happened to the both of them… the universe had decided to let them find each other again, and have this moment.

"You're here… you're here…" Glimmer kept muttering between sobs.

"I'm here baby girl… I'm here…" Micah answered, laughing joyfully as he cradled his daughter's cheeks.

"Please, tell me this isn't a trick…" The young queen pleaded, grasping his father's hands.

"No Glimmer… I'm truly back."

“Dad…”

“My sweet princess…” The old king embraced her again, this time more gently.

“I thought I lost you.” Glimmer muttered.

“And I thought I’d never see you again but… thanks to them… I could finally come back to you.” Micah turned towards Adora and Bow, a sea of gratitude in his eyes.

“A-Adora? Bow?” The young queen said, puzzled.

“We found your dad on Beast Island…” Adora explained.

“The Horde had exiled him there, but when we-”

But Bow wasn’t given any more time to explain as Glimmer quickly marched up to him and Adora and hugged them both.

“Thank you… thank you so much…”

A few moments of silence went by. Glimmer knew that the fight against Horde Prime was far from over, that the Rebellion could have still lost, that Etheria could have still become nothing more than a weapon in the hands of the intergalactic tyrant. But right then, she wasn’t going to let anything ruin that moment. The moment in which she found her father again, the moment in which she realized her friends had never abandoned her.

Sadly… even that moment had to pass.

When Glimmer let go of Adora and Bow and turned towards her father, his eyes had widened in shock. His joyful expression quickly turned into one of pure hatred as his gaze fell upon an old enemy. He raised his staff, a blinding light engulfing its top before a purplish beam erupted from it, quickly traveling through the air until it met its target.

And when the smoke cleared, and everyone could see again… they all noticed…

Hordak had fallen to the ground.

Chapter End Notes

I'm back guys! It's been a while, hasn't it? I had another exam and right now I'm studying for the final one of this semester, so I'll have more time to write after the eleventh of February. Meanwhile, let me know what you think of this chapter in the comments! And also, thank you for all the appreciation you're showing me, as always, that is what keeps me going, truly. So, I want to thank you all for reading this chapter, and I wanted to tell you that in the next one, our favorite cat girl will finally have a long deserved talk with a certain character… who is it you may ask, well, I won't tell, you'll have to find out yourself in the next chapter! Bye bye!

P.S. A week ago I watched Klaus on Netflix for the first time, I don't know why I waited so long to watch it, it's one of the best animated movies I've ever seen! I loved it so much! So probably, in the future, when this fic will be done, I may write something about Klaus, just to let you know.

Author's note: The story is alive! (Secondly, me too)

Hi guys! Sorry for the long wait, in this session I gave seven, SEVEN exams and I managed to pass them all. It has been tiring, and I didn't have time to write. A week ago, when I finished my exams, I began writing again and before I knew it, I had a 8000 words file right in front of me. It's going to be separated into four chapters, "Katrina", "Battle For Bright Moon pt.1", "Battle For Bright Moon pt.2" and "Forgive and Condemn". You'll see a little bit of Etheria's past, of fighting and a little bit of some of our favorite characters fixing things… and in other cases… making them worse… so stay tuned! Chapter 12 is coming out tomorrow, chapter 13 will be published on 22 February, chapter 14 will come out on 25 February and chapter 15 on the 28th. Be ready! The Last Stand's bomb is coming!

Katrina

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hordak!" Entrapta screamed as she saw her old lab partner falling to the ground.

King Micah's spell had hit him square in the chest, but as the scientist princess quickly knelt down next to him and put her ear against it, she managed to hear a faint beating. He was still alive.

"Get away from that monster Entrapta, I'm going to finish him…" Micah spoke gravely.

But as the old king grew near, he was stunned to see the pigtailed princess standing up and shielding the former Horde leader.

"I won't let you hurt him." Entrapta declared with a trembling voice.

"Do you have any idea who you are protecting?" Micah asked after a few seconds.

"A friend…" The princess answered.

The old king became speechless. How could anyone consider that monster a friend? After everything he had done to Etheria and its people…

"Micah…" Suddenly, Adora spoke up.

"Adora? Don't tell me you're with-" Micah began to speak but as the blonde cut him off.

"We shouldn't kill him."

"Why shouldn't we? He's the one that brought war and destruction all over Etheria! He is the one who banished me!

Glimmer…” The old king turned towards his daughter, only for his eyes to widen in puzzlement as he saw her lowering her gaze in shame.

“He shouldn’t die… he could reveal vital information about Horde Prime… maybe even a way we could defeat him…” Glimmer muttered, clearly conflicted.

“Yes! Exactly! H-he can be helpful! I-I can convince him! I promise!” Entrapta blabbered loudly, a hopeful look on her face.

Micah’s hand tightened around his staff for a few moments, his knuckles turning white as everyone held their breath… then… the old king released his grip, giving a low grunt.

“Then… for our sake… we’ll keep him prisoner… for now.”

“You’ll see Micah… he’ll be more useful to us alive than he could ever be if he was dead.” Adora gave him and encouraging smile, which grew only brighter as the king reciprocated.

“I hope so Adora and… thank you… for saving my daughter.”

Micah’s smile lingered for a few moments on his face, before being replaced by a look of surprise. His eyes weren’t focused on Adora anymore, but on the figure she was carrying.

“A magicat?”

“Uhm… a what?” Bow asked, confused by the king’s words.

“But… it’s impossible… the Horde slaughtered them all…” Micah muttered in disbelief as he brought a hand to his forehead.

“W-what?” Adora’s eyes widened in horror.

“Dad? What are you talking about?” Glimmer stepped forwards, gently putting a hand on her father’s shoulder.

A shadow crossed Micah's eyes. Memories he wished never to recall were coming back to his mind. The old king closed his eyes, releasing a long sigh as a saddened expression replaced his surprised one.

"Not here, come inside the castle, we'll talk in the war room."

A couple of guards reached the king's side, visibly tense as their eyes shifted towards the individual Entrapta was holding.

"Take that…" Micah paused for a moment, his eyes meeting Entrapta's, before starting to speak again, "Take the former Horde Leader to one of the sparad rooms, I'll create a barrier so he won't be able to escape." The king turned towards the small group, his eyes lingering on Adora and the magicat she was holding. "Then… we'll talk."

~

Adora gently placed Catra on top of her bed. She stayed by her side for a few moments, looking at the feline's chest rising and falling. Suddenly, the blonde felt as if her heart was being held in a tight grip. Was she glad that Catra was okay? Yes… even after everything she had done… Adora was still happy to see that she wasn't hurt. Truth to be told, she had tried many times to hate Catra. But every time she thought she had finally managed to free herself from her past with her, every time she thought she could finally face her head on, both of them having made their choices without regrets, she found out that… she couldn't.

"What am I supposed to think of you now?" Adora mumbled as she lightly put a hand on Catra's head.

She almost immediately retracted it.

"You know it's wrong. You know what she did." Adora thought.

And that is what she would have wanted to actually feel.

To feel as if what she was doing was wrong.

But then…

Why didn't it feel wrong?

Why did she feel… warm…

Why did that simple gesture make her feel such a powerful longing?

The truth was, even though once or twice in her past Adora thought she had finally severed her bond with Catra, she had never actually done it. Something that had been growing between them since they were little, for so many years, something that gave them both the only true love they had ever experienced during their time in the Horde… it couldn't be easily broken.

Knock knock!

The sound startled the blonde out of thought. She looked at her room's door, she had left it open, but still, Scorpia knocked before entering. The image made Adora smile.

"Hey…" Scorpia spoke with a slight uncertainty in her voice.

"Hey." Adora answered, a tired yet sincere smile on her face.

"Mind if I… uhm…" The scorpion princess had a light blush on her face.

"Check on her? Sure… you… you actually have more right to so than me…"

“I don’t know about that…” Scorpia answered, a sudden look of shame appearing on her face.

The scorpion princess slowly walked up to Adora’s bed before kneeling down next to it. She brought a pincer to Catra’s cheek, before resting it on the cat girl’s hand.

“You know… that’s a good question…”

“What?” Adora asked, not understanding what Scorpia was referring to.

“What you said before. Sorry… I wasn’t trying to eavesdrop on you, I was going to knock but then I heard you speaking… ‘what should I think of you now?’, that’s… that’s a good question.”

Adora smiled sadly before shifting her gaze to Catra.

“I thought I figured her out you know? I thought… I thought she didn’t care about people… and those few ones she cared for… she did only because they were following her… but then…”

“She saved Glimmer… wow… I mean… I didn’t see that coming.” Scorpia laughed awkwardly before looking at Adora. “You know… I began to think that too… when I left. I thought she only… cared about winning you know? Only about… being someone in the eyes of the people who treated her the worst… who made her feel like she was the worst. But… when I saw Shadow Weaver here at Bright Moon, I understood what made Catra so mad… and I wasn’t so sure about who she truly is any more… and now? Now I’m sure she’s not a bad person…”

“Just a stubborn cat that makes the worst choices.” Adora laughed briefly.

Scorpia’s eyes widened in surprised before doing the same.

“Yeah…”

As Adora's laugh died down, her smile was slowly replaced by a frown.

"Something wrong?"

"I'm scared Scorpia…" The blonde answered, looking straight into the scorpion princess' eyes.

"Is this… it this about what King Micah wants to tell us?"

"N-no… I… I actually want to know… and I want Catra to know too."

"Yeah, me too." Scorpia answered, briefly looking at the feline before shifting her gaze towards Adora.

"You know what she did, right? When she opened the portal?"

"I… I don't remember all that well, it was all so messed up and-" Scorpia began to talk but Adora quickly cut her off.

"Glimmer's mom died…"

A dreadful silence fell over the room.

"I… I didn't know…" Scorpia's eyes became wide with horror as she began to remove her hand from Catra's.

But before she could do so, Adora placed her own hand on top of her pincer, stopping her.

"She didn't know… she only wanted to win Scorpia… she didn't know that to escape the portal… someone would have had to stay behind."

Scorpia began to calm down, then, she raised her gaze, a worried look on her face.

"Does everyone know?"

"Not everyone… Micah…" Adora began to speak but found out that she couldn't.

"T-the king doesn't know?!" Scorpia shrilled.

"No… and I… I don't think we should let him know… not now… he was already incredibly kind to let Hordak live… I don't think it would be the same for Catra."

"T-then what do we do?" The scorpion princess muttered.

"We'll listen to what Micah wants to tell us and… we'll wait… we'll wait to tell him. We'll do it after everything's over."

"Alright…" Scorpia seemed to have calmed down.

Both the girls nodded before standing up.

There was a story they had to listen to.

A forgotten truth that they had to know.

It was time to learn about the so called magicats.

It was time to learn who Catra really was.

~

"Hey Angella…"

"Katrina! You almost gave me a heart attack! What are you doing in my room?!"

"Uh… your guards are patrolling the castle's entrance, and I'm pretty sure they wouldn't have let me in if I wanted to use the

main door."

"So you climbed the castle and used my room's window instead?!"

"Yeah, that's exactly what I did. I mean, it's not like there was another way to talk to you."

"You can only blame yourself for that!"

"Oh yeah?"

"Yes! You accused a harmless visitor of having been secretly planning our demise and punched my advisor when he called you foolish!"

"Yeah, and then my guards knocked out yours before they could do something about it, that's politics you know?"

"Katrina…"

"They had it coming, they wouldn't see the truth-"

"What truth, for the First Ones' sake! What truth?!"

"That Hordak is planning to take over Etheria!"

"How would you even know that?!"

"My spies saw-"

"Your spies?! When did we agree to send spies to watch over Hordak?!"

"You wouldn't have agreed Angella, what was I supposed to do?"

"Oh my… you… I… ugh!"

"Take your time."

"This is not the time for joking Katrina! Our Alliance was formed so that all Etheria's kingdoms would stand united against threats,

and not so that we could act behind each other's back!"

"Whatever mom."

"This is serious!"

"Yeah! It is! Because guess what? If I told you about my plan, you would have acted against it, maybe you would have even warned Hordak! And… my spies would have never found out what he's been hiding from us."

"An army… of robots…"

"Don't say it with that tone! You make it sound ridiculous!"

"Because it is ridiculous!"

"So you're saying you don't trust me…"

"That's not what I'm saying… what I'm saying is that this is a serious accusation Katrina, we'll need a little more proof to what you're saying than your spies' words."

"And mine? It doesn't matter to you?"

"Of course it does! But…"

"Oh… I get it… we wouldn't want the space visitor who brought us such marvelous inventions to resent us… is that right?"

"N-no! That's not it! I-"

"Forget it…"

"Please Katrina! Don't go… I'm sorry…"

"Whatever… I just hope that none of us will get hurt before you see the truth Angella…"

Chapter End Notes

A dark, forgotten memory has finally been recalled. And here we are with chapter twelve! I hope you've all enjoyed it! In two days just as I explained in the author's note, I'll publish chapter thirteen, "Battle for Bright Moon - Part I", get ready!

Battle For Bright Moon - Part I

Chapter Notes

> Start listening to this when the "SLAM!" occurs and keep reading in the meantime!
>
> https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fOjLAA_dbK0&list=PLwJCsF_uNWYnEJ1Ph9_kYxSi4mfT79X2d&index=24&t=0s

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The princesses listened closely as Micah recalled the old memory. It had been fifteen years since that night, and not one day had passed without the old king wishing he and Angella had listened to what Katrina warned them about.

"When I joined Angella in our bedroom, I found her distraught. She told me about her 'meeting' with Katrina, the magicat's queen, and that she didn't know what to do… I didn't know either… I guess that everyone hoped Hordak would truly turn out to be what he claimed he was… nothing more than a visitor, with marvelous things to show us. But deep down I knew there was something wrong with him, and just like Katrina, I began to hope that nobody would get hurt before we'd find out the truth… but someone… did get hurt…" Micah's gaze shifted downwards.

"Dad?" Glimmer stepped closer to the old king, putting a hand on his shoulder.

"A year later you were born, my beautiful baby girl…" Micah smiled sadly as he softly cradled his daughter's cheek. "That was the happiest day of my life, and for a single moment, I believed that everything would have turned out just fine."

A silence fell over the room as Micah stopped talking. Glimmer slightly gasped as she saw a tear streaming down his cheek.

“Dad… what happened?”

“The day after you were born we received the news that… Katrina’s village had been burned down to the ground by the Horde…”

“Oh no…” Scorpia covered her mouth as her eyes widened in horror.

“Some of them must have escaped right? They can’t be all… all…” Adora muttered in disbelief.

“When we went to the village to search for survivors… we only found a mountain of burnt corpses… not even a single magicat was ever seen again after that night.”

“Why didn’t our parents tell us about them before?” Perfuma asked timidly.

“Katrina had warned us… but we didn’t listen… that night Hordak waged war against Etheria and managed to destroy one of our most powerful allies… if we had been there… if only we had listened to her… but we didn’t. She died because of our blindness.”

“Uhh… let me get this straight… you never told any of us about this because you were ashamed of yourselves?!” Mermista yelled in disbelief.

“We never wanted to look back… we all promised to fight together against the Horde and never commit the same mistake again… I know it was selfish of us…” Micah’s head hung low in shame.

“It can’t be…” Adora whispered, her eyes widening in horror.

She had served them. She had admired them. She had loved them. She would have given her life for the Horde in the past. She would have given her life for the people who were actually destroying Etheria. That thought had kept her awake for countless nights. But now? Now she knew that she would have given her life

for the ones who killed Catra's people, who destroyed her best friend's home, who took away her future.

"Adora? Are you alright?" Bow asked, a worried expression adorning his face.

"I helped them… I wanted nothing more than to impress them… the same people that destroyed Catra's life. I-if I knew I would have never… a-and if she knew m-maybe she wouldn't have stayed… I… I…" Adora blabbered, clearly panicking.

"Adora! It's alright! You couldn't have known!" Bow exclaimed, grasping the blonde's shoulders, trying to calm her down.

"But I… I…"

"Adora." Glimmer suddenly spoke up, marching up to Adora in a shy yet still determined way.

The young queen let her gaze linger on the floor for a few moments before stepping forwards. She gently grabbed Adora's hand and finally raised her gaze. Determined eyes met desperate ones.

"Stop blaming yourself for things you didn't do. It's not your fault that the Horde killed Catra's family, they chose to do so, and it's not your fault that she decided to side with them, she chose to do so, not you. Please…"

Adora looked at their conjoined hands with bewilderment before giving the young queen a shaky smile.

"Thanks guys…"

The princesses were there, Bow was there, and even after everything that happened between them, Glimmer was there too. They were there for Adora, and when Micah called her name, she expected him to tell her the same things, to reassure her, to support her. To be there for her too...

But he didn't…

"Adora… what did you say the magicat's name was?" Suddenly, Micah's voice had grown grave, deep and menacing.

"Micah… I-" Adora began to talk but was suddenly cut off.

"Catra."

The voice came from the entrance of the war room and as everyone inside turned around, the red figure slowly made its way towards the old king. Adora's gaze fell upon Micah's face. Sadness and regret were gone, instead, the blonde could only see puzzlement, anger and… such an incredibly profound hatred in Micah's eyes. She had never seen it in her entire life.

"I must say, I'm surprised she's here. When I saw you carrying her-" Shadow Weaver began to talk but trailed off as Adora stepped in front of her, teeth bared.

"What did you tell King Micah?!" The blonde barked.

"Only the truth…" The red witch answered after an instant of hesitation, Adora's outburst had indeed caught her off guard.

"What truth?" Glimmer asked, her tone slightly shaking.

"She's the one that killed your mother princess, don't you think your father deserved to know it?"

"O-oh… oh no…" Scorpia muttered as she covered her mouth.

Adora's face became completely pale. Micah wasn't supposed to find out. Not that soon. Not with everything that was already happening. The blonde quickly turned around only to find the old king standing right in front of her.

"Did you know Adora? Did you know it was her even when you brought her inside my home? Inside Angella's home?" Micah asked, his voice a mixture of disappointment and disbelief.

Adora could only stare at the old king without uttering a single word.

“So you knew…”

“Micah… I-” Adora began to speak, hopelessly trying to justify herself.

“I don’t want to listen to your excuses… where… is… she?” Micah demanded, his eyes darkening.

The blonde hesitated for a few seconds, her gaze shifting downwards, uncertainty written all over her face… then… she raised her eyes to meet Micah’s. Every doubt she could have had was gone, instead, the old king could only see determination in Adora’s eyes.

She wasn’t going to tell him, and even though he would have found Catra anyway, she would have never let him hurt her.

“Why? Why would you defend her?” Micah asked, his voice starting to break.

Glimmer suddenly stepped forwards, catching his father’s hand.

“Dad, you don’t understand! She sav-”

SLAM!

The young queen began to speak, but the sound of the war room’s door slamming open interrupted her.

“My Queen!” A guard shouted, quickly reaching the group.

“What is it?”

“Five ships are approaching Bright Moon!”

Not now…

There were already too many things going on…

“Adora… do you think…” Glimmer turned towards the blonde with a worried expression.

“It’s Prime.” Adora stated coldly.

“Wha-? He’s already here?!” Scorpia exclaimed.

“Uhh… how are we supposed to fight him? I can barely use my powers, scorpion princess here used everything she had on the ship and so did Perfuma, Frosta can barely keep her eyes open,” Mermista groaned before turning towards Glimmer, “and I doubt that you’re up to do any magic either, are you?”

“I… I don’t think I’ll be able to fight so soon.” The young queen mumbled with a defeated tone.

“Then… how are we going to…” Perfuma wondered out loud after a few moments of silence.

The princesses were tired, confused, and Horde Prime’s troops had taken them by surprise. They didn’t have time to prepare, to recharge their powers or come up with a plan.

“Together.”

“What?” The group turned towards the voice’s source.

“Saving Glimmer seemed impossible right? But we did it anyway… why?” Adora asked.

Everyone remained silent for a few instants.

“Because we did it together.” Entrapta spoke with such marvel in her voice that it took everyone by surprise. “It makes zero sense really, the odds were against us, the chances of us actually succeeding were so low, but we did it anyway. It’s… it’s not the

first time that this happens. It seems that…" The scientist princess stopped and let out a brief, puzzled laugh, "It seems that when we're together we can even challenge the rules of probability."

"Entrapta is right! Whenever we fought together, we always managed to succeed!" Perfuma chimed in.

"We may not have our powers but that doesn't mean that we can't kick some clones' butts!" Frosta raised her fists in the air.

"Come on! The Horde never managed to defeat us! And when the dust settles, there will be songs about our great victory! Obviously, I'll be the one singing them." Sea Hawk yelled enthusiastically.

"Uhh, no thanks, no songs… but yeah, I guess that together we always managed to win, one way or the other." Mermista spoke casually.

"We can do this." Adora looked at everyone in the room, her gaze lingering on Glimmer, "Together…"

"Together." The young queen smiled weakly.

The group turned towards King Micah. He had remained silent the whole time.

Then… after a long sigh…

Micah spoke.

"We… we'll deal with this attack… then… I'll do what I have to." Micah muttered. Casting aside Catra's fate, if only for the moment, seemed to have taken all of his will power.

Scorpia gave Adora a terrified look, but the blonde simply shook her head. She wasn't going to let it happen. But why? Why would she even risk crossing Micah to defend someone who hurt her and everyone she cared for so much? Was it because finally, Adora had managed to catch a glimpse of the old Catra? Was it because

by saving Glimmer, the cat girl had showed that there wasn't only darkness, and hatred inside her heart? Of course, that is what Adora would have liked to believe, but the truth was different.

Even if Catra hadn't risked her life saving Glimmer, even if she would have ended up by accident at Bright Moon… Adora could have never let her die. Some would have called her 'weak' because of it. Sparing an enemy because of a past long gone. But Adora wasn't sure she would have agreed, she didn't know if hers was actually weakness… or strength… and the past she shared with Catra? That may have been gone… but not forgotten… never.

The group quickly followed the guards outside the castle. The sight they were met with was actually terrifying. Five gargantuan ships were slowly approaching Bright Moon. They were obviously smaller than Horde Prime's station, but still, they were bigger than anything the princesses had ever seen. Mara's ship was the size of an ant in comparison.

The five, large, black ships came to a halt as they towered above the castle. A loud screeching noise resonated through the air as their gigantic cannons began to shift, their target clear. Bright Moon castle would have never stood a chance against that kind of fire power.

"You need to get to your ship and disable those cannons… I'll… I'll summon a shield to protect the castle." Micah explained as he began to trace lines in the air.

"You know you can't create a shield strong enough to protect the whole palace, even if I helped you." Shadow Weaver said as she reached the old king's side. "Even if we wanted to defend only ourselves, one of our shields wouldn't last a minute against those cannons."

"Then what are we supposed to do?!" Glimmer questioned the red witch.

"We have to escape, run away and re organize ourselves."

Everyone turned towards Shadow Weaver in astonishment.

“B-but we can’t leave! They’ll destroy everything! Maybe even the Moon stone!” Bow protested.

“Horde Prime won’t risk that.” Glimmer murmured in a disgusted tone of voice.

“What?” Adora asked.

“Catra told him about the Heart of Etheria… he doesn’t know much about it, but I doubt he’ll risk destroying one of its pieces.”

“Then… why are his ships targeting Bright Moon?” Perfuma wondered, clearly confused by the tyrant’s doing.

“I think he wants to give us a taste of his power, he wants us to know he could completely erase us and our home in an instant. He wants us to surrender, to give him what he wants.” Glimmer theorized.

“Whatever is the case, we can’t stay here, it’s too dangerous to take the risk, we need to flee-” Shadow Weaver chimed in, trying to make her point, but suddenly, a voice spoke from above them.

“That won’t be necessary.”

“Aunt Casta!” Glimmer exclaimed as the sorceress glided towards the small group.

“And I’m not alone!” Castaspella shouted excitedly.

Everyone gasped as the clouds above them cleared and countless other wizards and sorceresses appeared from above the castle, descending gracefully towards them like hundreds of falling stars.

The cavalry had arrived.

Chapter End Notes

CASTA COMING IN LIKE "IM MARY POPPINS Y'ALL!"

Battle For Bright Moon - Part II

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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“I thought I’d bring back up, seems we’ll need it. Alright everyone! Let’s show the Horde what Mystacor is capable of!”

As Castaspella spoke, all of the mages began to trace lines in the air with their fingers, and as they kept moving their hands, a large barrier began to rise from the ground. It grew and grew until it completely covered Bright Moon castle.

“Good job everyone!” Castaspella praised as she clapped her hands.

“Casta…”

The mages’ queen whipped her head around so quickly and so harshly that her neck hurt. That voice… she knew that voice… it was the same voice that always told her she could do anything, that she could overcome any obstacle life would present to her. It was a voice she expected never to hear again, that she grew not to miss anymore, not to remember anymore. And yet… there it was… and there he was…

“Micah…” Casta muttered in a hushed tone of voice, her voice cracking, tears flooding her eyes.

“I…” The old king tried to find some words, but when he felt his sister wrapping her arms around him, he knew he didn’t need to.

“I thought you were gone.” Castaspella whispered, bewildered.

“I’m here Casta, I’m sorry it took me so long to come back.” Micah said, holding her tighter.

The two held each other for a few more instants before letting go, their hands still conjoined, warm smiles upon their face.

However, the moment was soon spoiled .

“Uh, not to interrupt the happy reunion or anything, but I think we’ve got company.” Mermista spoke up, pointing a finger towards an area outside the magical barrier that had been completely enveloped in a greenish light.

Soon, hundreds of clones began to appear from inside the beam of light, stepping forwards, marching towards the barrier until they came to halt a few inches away from the light blue wall of magic. Their expressionless sent chills running down the princesses spines. The clones were armed with long, white, odd looking rifles and as one of them took a step forwards, the others raised their weapons towards the shield.

“Surrender, the great Prime demands it.” The clone spoke in an emotionless tone of voice.

“Why don’t you surrender?! I really want to see what your pea shooters can do against this barrier! Hah!” Swift Wind shouted, scraping the ground with his hoof.

“As you wish.”

That was all the warning that was given to the princesses before the clones started shooting. Greenish spheres of energy flew through the air at an incredible speed before colliding with the wall of magic surrounding the castle. The black ships’ cannons, which had remained silent the whole time, finally began to shoot. Their powerful blasts hit the barrier’s surface before dissipating into thin air. All of Bright Moon’s guards reached the palace’s grounds, joining both the princesses and the mages. As agonizingly slow minutes began to pass, small cracks began to

form on the wall's surface as both Horde Prime's clones and ships kept shooting.

"The wall won't last much longer! Gather in groups and use the blasting spells! Aim for those cursed ships!" Castaspella yelled at her mages.

"Prepare yourself! When the barrier is broken, we'll have to fight with everything we've got!" Micah shouted to his soldiers.

"Whatever happens… we stay together." Adora stated, looking at Bow, then turning towards Glimmer.

Soon, the barrier would have fallen. But despite that, the princesses exchanged determined looks, the fear in their hearts long gone. Their powers were still weak, but they still had each other. They managed to rescue Glimmer and now they had their queen back. Micah was there too, and so was Castaspella and all of her mages. Horde Prime's clones may have had larger numbers, but they had nothing to fight for if not the fear of their master.

The cracks in the barrier grew more numerous, larger and deeper until chunks of the wall began to fall down, disappearing in the air before touching the ground. All of the wizards and sorceresses gathered in small circles, moving their hands through the air and summoning what looked like large cones of light. They emerged from the ground and grew taller and taller until from the tip of each one of them, beams of pure magical energy erupted and flew towards the five black ships.

Horde Prime's clones realized what the wizards and sorceresses were trying to do, but despite the fact that the barrier was starting to crumble, it was still preventing them from reaching the castle's grounds. Suddenly, loud explosions could be heard above Bright Moon as the ships were repeatedly hit with countless magical rays. Their light was blinding . When the cones of light summoned by the mages finally grew silent and vanished into nothingness, black smoke could be seen rising from all of Horde

Prime’s ships. They remained motionless for a few instant, before starting to move.

“Look up! The ships are retreating!” Castaspella warned everyone as the five ships began to move, shifting away from above the castle and disappearing into the night sky.

The clones, however, didn’t cease their attack and soon, the magic wall summoned by Mystacor’s mages fell apart. It was then, as the last thing that separated Etheria’s armies from Horde Prime’s, that Glimmer turned towards the other princesses.

“Ready?” The young queen asked, offering the princesses a small, yet courageous smile.

“For our home!” Bow shouted.

“For our friends!” Scorpia joined the choir of voices that was growing louder and louder.

“For Etheria!” Adora exclaimed as the magic wall fell.

But before the two armies could clash against each other the sound of a war horn resonated through the air. Suddenly, the clones began to turn around.

“We’re being attacked from behind!” One of them cried.

“Who’s attacking them?!” Frosta asked.

“I don’t know! But we have to take advantage of this! Come on! We can do this!” Adora shouted as she knocked down to the ground a clone a grabbed his rifle.

“They don’t have their ships anymore, come on!” Bow spoke between ragged breaths, clearly exhausted.

That is when a clone appeared behind him and raised a blade above his head.

“Bow!” Both Adora and Glimmer cried.

They began to rush towards the young archer, but it was too late. As Bow turned around the saber came down. He shut his eyes but…

The blow never came…

Instead, the archer heard a loud thump. When he opened his eyes, he saw the clone laying on the ground in front of him and when he raised his gaze, he was met with a smug grin.

“What would you do without me?”

“Huntara!” The princesses cried in unison.

And as more clones fell, both the princesses and Bright Moon’s and Castaspella’s armies realized who had been helping them. Huntara and her people had come to the rescue right on time.

“I thought you were trying to free the Crimson Wastes from the Horde… what are you doing here?” Glimmer asked, both surprised and relieved.

“I did, and when me and my people saw those black ships appearing out of nowhere I thought about paying you a visit, turns out I came at the right moment.” Huntara answered, grinning triumphantly.

Attacked both from the front and from behind by Bright Moon’s, Mystacor’s and Huntara’s armies, the numbers of Horde Prime’s clones grew thinner and thinner in a matter of minutes. The remaining ones called a retreat and ran away from the castle’s grounds. Their ships had flown away, leaving them stranded. In a last attempt to save themselves, they ran away until they reached the edge of the Whispering Woods and as they disappeared into the trees, Adora knew…

Etheria wouldn’t have forgiven them…

The clones were never seen again…

Etheria had won the first battle against the Emperor of the known universe.

"We did it!" Bow exclaimed, bringing Adora into a tight hug.

Glimmer smiled sadly, taking a step backwards, but before she could move further away, the young archer caught her and brought her into the embrace too. The young queen's eyes widened in surprise before shutting tight, a trembling smile growing on her face as a few tears rolled down her cheeks.

The moment however, was short lived.

"Adora!" Scorpia suddenly called the blonde.

Adora turned towards the scorpion princess, noticing her terrified expression. She followed her gaze and noticed that Micah was leaving the castle's grounds. She knew where he was headed and without a moment of hesitation, she began to move. Before the old king could enter the palace, Adora caught up to him and blocked the entrance.

"Adora… move aside." Micah spoke in a firm tone of voice, but its slight trembling betrayed the fury he was trying to hide.

"No, I know what your going to do… I'm sorry but I can't let you do it." Adora shook her head.

"I'm not going to ask you again, I'm going to do what has to be done." The old king took a step forwards, now mere inches away from the blonde.

"You don't know what happened." Adora kept her eyes glued on Micah's, not showing any sign of fear.

"I don't know what… of course I know! I know what she did!"

“Oh, are you sure?! Did you know that Catra opened a portal not knowing that it could have destroyed our universe?! Did you know… did you know that she didn’t have the slightest clue about what had to be done to save us? To close the portal? Did you know that Angella chose willingly to do that?” Adora stopped for a moment, wiping away a few tears that had welled up in her eyes. “Did you know that the only reason Catra did what she did is because she wanted me to suffer? And that happened because I broke a promise I made to her while we grew up in the Horde…”

“You… you grew up in the Horde?” Suddenly, Micah’s voice began to soften.

“And so did Catra. I promised her that we’d always be together, because as long as we had each other nothing bad would have ever happened… and then… then… the sword came. I got to see what the Horde was doing and decided to put an end to it, but in doing that I… broke my promise… I left her alone with the one who always treated her the worst.” Adora turned towards Shadow Weaver, a disgusted scowl forming on her face. “And to think that some people would call you our mother, you’ve never been one, especially to her.”

“I did what I had to… to make her stronger.” Shadow Weaver responded spitefully.

“Lie all you want, you were always a bitter, sad old woman who took it out on a child.”

“And yet you didn’t protect her, did you?” The red witch mocked.

A flash of regret passed on the blonde’s face but it was gone in a moment.

“No… but I’m going to do that now.” Adora spoke determinately.

As the blonde’s gaze returned to Micah, she could see that his expression had turned uncertain. Now he knew, he knew that Catra never killed Angella, it was the Queen who made her choice. She stopped the portal, sacrificing herself to save all of Etheria.

Now he knew what kind of life Catra had as she grew up, who she had as a mother.

The old king hesitated for a few moments, and that was when Shadow Weaver stepped forwards.

"Your king gave you an order, step aside Adora."

"And her Queen is giving her another order!" Suddenly, Glimmer spoke up. "Adora, don't move an inch."

The blonde's gaze shifted on Glimmer, her determined look turning into one of gratitude.

"Glimmer?" Micah spoke in confused tone of voice as he turned towards his daughter.

"Dad…" The young queen reached for her father's hands, gently grasping them, a pleading look in her eyes. "Catra saved my life."

"What?!" Micah's eyes widened in puzzlement.

"Uh, are we talking of the same Catra who brought the Horde to the Crimson Wastes? The same who helped Hordak take over Selineas and countless other bad thin- ouch!" Huntara began to talk but Perfuma quickly interrupted her by elbowing her in the stomach.

"Yes, that Catra. She saved me dad. If she hadn't intervened, Horde Prime would have killed me."

Micah grunted, lowering his eyes, but Glimmer let go of his hands, cupped his face and raised it so that her eyes could meet his.

"Please dad, I know who she was in the past, I know what she did to Etheria, but I know there's something more to her than that. Give her a chance to redeem herself, at least if not for me, for her family…"

The old king remained silent for a few instants. Shadow Weaver had told him only a partial truth about what had happened to Angella. He only knew that a woman named Catra had killed her… but he didn't know… he didn't know she was the last one of her people… people who were brutally massacred by the Horde. He didn't know she had to grow up in the Horde and neither did he know that the one who raised was none other than the traitor who slaughtered all of the previous masters of Mystacor. He couldn't even imagine what horrors Catra had to experience as she grew up with a… no, not a mother… with a guardian like her. He didn't know that Catra didn't kill Angella directly, that it was never her intention do so. He didn't know… but now he did.

"She'll be taken to one of the spare rooms and imprisoned… if she'll prove that she really had changed… than I'll give a chance at redemption." Micah declared.

Shadow Weaver's eyes grew thin, but other than that, she remained silent and retreated into the castle.

Night finally came, and the princesses left the castle's grounds to reach their chambers.

It was time for a well-deserved rest.

~

"My Lord…" The clone spoke, failing to hide the fear in his voice.

"Tell me X99… how did the assault go? Did my armies bring back the little queen and her companion?" Horde Prime spoke calmly.

"The assault… the assault failed my Lord… we lost an entire battalion and five of our ships are in dire need of repara-"

The clone didn’t get to finish. In a flash, Horde Prime stood from his throne. His hand clasped around the clone’s throat. The tyrant raised him from the ground effortlessly, watching lazily as the soldier started to gasp for air.

A few moments passed and then…

Silence…

Horde Prime let go and the clone's lifeless body hit the ground with a loud thud.

Another one stepped forwards.

“My Lord…”

“I hope this time some good news will be brought to my attention.”

“While the attack was taking place, some of our scavengers managed to retrieve something that may have a connection with the Etherian queen’s weapon…”

“Let’s see it then…”

Two other clones walked up to the tyrant, holding up a glass case. Horde Prime’s eyes roamed its content, a curious look appearing on his face.

“Fragments?”

“Of an Eternian weapon, my Lord. Both the energy readings and the radiation signature are identical to the ones we detected when we analyzed the planet’s core.” The clones explained.

“For these fragments to be still energized even after the weapon broke… an incredible amount of energy must have been contained in it…”

“My Lord?”

“I believe we just found a very important piece of my new toy…”

Horde Prime cackled darkly, his eyes never leaving the golden hilt inside the glass case.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! So here we are with a new chapter! I hope you liked it, and that you’re enjoying the story so far! Thank you all for all your kind comments, your support keeps me going so keep enjoying this story and keep letting me know it in the comments! The next chapter “Forgive and Condemn” will be published on February the 28th, so keep an eye out for it… it’s going to contain three of our favorite characters FINALLY talking…

Forgive and Condemn

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Despite knowing that they had managed to push back Horde Prime's armies, Adora couldn't sleep. A storm of thoughts, doubts, hopes and fears kept swirling inside her mind. What would have been Prime's next move? How would they be able to stop him? And… what would it have taken to do so? How many lives…

"Stop… thinking!" Adora screamed into her pillow.

Tock Tock!

The sound made the blonde yelp in surprise and almost fall out of bed. She quickly scrambled out of her tangled sheets and reached her room's door. When she opened it, her eyes widened in surprise.

"Glimmer…" Adora whispered.

"Hey. Were you… were you sleeping?" Glimmer asked, crossing the blonde's gaze and immediately lowering her own to the floor.

"Not really… I was… thinking. Thinking a little too much if I have to be sincere." Adora chuckled, scratching the back of her head.

"I couldn't sleep either…" Glimmer muttered, shifting awkwardly on her feet.

"Do you… maybe… want to come in?"

Glimmer's eyes seemed to sparkle as Adora asked her to enter. A small smile grew on the young queen's face as she nodded. Both girls reached the blonde's thin mattress and sat down. A few moments of silence went by, then, just as Glimmer opened her mouth to start talking, Adora cut her off.

“I’m sorry…”

“W-what?”

“I’m sorry Glimmer.”

“What are you even apologizing for?” The young queen yelled in disbelief as she suddenly stood up, her arms outstretched.

“When your mom… when your mom left us, I wanted to be there for you, to protect you. Turns out, what you really needed was someone to believe in you and… I always did but… not in a way that would make you feel like you could do things on your own, like you were strong enough to be queen. I wanted to protect you but I only pushed you away. I’m so-”

“Are you crazy?!”

“G-Glimmer I-” Adora’s eyes widened in surprise at Glimmer’s outburst.

“I’m the one who should be apologizing! I’m the one that told you that you weren’t enough… you are!”

“Glimmer, listen-”

“No! You listen! I… I blamed you for my mom’s death…” Glimmer sat next to Adora and took the blonde’s hands in her own, tears now pouring down her eyes. “I blamed you… my best friend… and I broke your heart, don’t tell me I didn’t because the look you gave me that day… the second you looked at me I realized what a horrible mistake I made.”

“If I was stronger… maybe I could have stayed. Now you’d have your mom and-” Adora averted her gaze as tears started well up in her eyes.

“My mom made a choice!” Glimmer suddenly shouted.

“Glimmer…”

“I have to face the truth. I can’t find any excuses, let alone blame it on someone I love. My mom left us… left me… she did it to save us all but that doesn’t change the fact that she chose to leave me. You didn’t kill her, Catra didn’t kill her. She made her choice and… even if it hurts so much… I should have never blamed it on you Adora. You’re the one good thing that happened to me in a long time.”

“Oh, Glimmer… I…”

“I know. I know I broke your heart, and I know that even if I want to, with all my heart, I will never be able to erase those words… I’d… I’d understand if you wanted to never speak to me again just… please, know that I was angry a-and I was trying to avoid to see the truth so that it would hurt less and I-” Glimmer started rambling, but she stopped as Adora squeezed her hands and called her name.

“Glimmer.”

“W-what is it?”

“I have already forgiven you.” Adora sniffed, giving the young queen a small yet warm smile.

“W-what?!”

“When the Heart activated… a small part of me believed it was the end… for me, for everyone I cared for, for Etheria… but… I couldn’t accept it. I couldn’t accept that everything would end like that, with me being apart from my friends, with the Horde still trying to take over Etheria… with Catra still being so keen on taking her revenge against me. I wanted to fix it all, but… most of all I… I wanted to see you again and fix… and fix us.”

Glimmer suddenly broke into a fit of teary laughter.

“W-what are you laughing about?” Adora asked as her own smile began to stretch wider.

“N-nothing, nothing, sorry but… when the Heart activated, that’s exactly what I was thinking about too.”

Adora remained silent for a few instants, before a giggle left her lips, then another, until she too broke into a fit of laughter. She moved close to the Young Queen and brought her into a tight embrace. Glimmer gasped in surprise, and when she felt the blonde starting to let go, being afraid of the hug being too much after such a long time spent apart… she immediately wrapped her arms around Adora, holding her just as tightly.

The two remained locked in their embrace for a while before letting go, both letting themselves fall backwards on Adora’s mattress.

“It was you wasn’t it? Who stopped it…” Glimmer murmured.

“You mean… the Heart?”

“Yeah…”

“Yes, it was me… I… I had to break the sword but… I did it.” Adora confessed, her smile growing sadder, she knew she had done the right thing, but she also knew that when she broke the sword, a part of her died with it.

“Adora I-”

“Glimmer… it’s fine.”

“F-fine?! But what about She-Ra and-” Glimmer stuttered in a worried tone of voice, but as Adora cupped her face, she stopped.

“Glimmer… you’re here. Bow’s here, your dad’s here, everyone is safe. That’s enough for me.”

“I’m sorry… I’m sorry you lost She-Ra because of me…”

“Hey.” Adora’s voice suddenly became stern.

“W-what?” Glimmer asked, a little taken aback by the blonde’s tone.

“I chose to lose She-Ra, so that we alongside countless worlds and stars could be saved. It was my decision Glimmer, just like your mom chose to close the portal to save us. I… I won’t blame myself for what happened to her… but you must promise me you won’t blame yourself for the loss of She-Ra… deal?” Adora smiled encouragingly.

“Deal.” Glimmer answered, smiling and wiping away a tear.

A few moments passed before Glimmer spoke again.

“You… you want to try and fix things with her too, don’t you?”

“I… I don’t think I can bring myself not to try.” A sad chuckle left Adora’s lips.

“She doesn’t hate you.” Glimmer said, her voice kind and encouraging as she squeezed the blonde’s hand.

“I think I’d disagree.”

“No really, I know she’d never admit it, I think she’d rather jump down my room’s balcony… but… something tells me she never truly forgot about you. I don’t think she has ever managed to leave behind her past with you.”

“Do you know where your dad has taken her?” Adora asked, not trying to hide the hope in her voice.

“Yeah, one of the spare rooms, come on, I’ll take you there.”

“Glimmer…”

“Yeah?”

“Thank you, and… I’m glad we talked…”

"I'm glad too…" Glimmer smiled warmly before taking Adora's hand.

Both girls vanished from the room in a puff of pink, glittering smoke.

~

"Is she asleep?"

"Yes…"

"Katrina, I know that look… what's wrong?"

"Mathias… I have a bad feeling…"

"About what?"

"Things have been too calm lately…"

"Is this about the Horde?"

"Yes…"

"Angella will listen to you if we talk to her together. I know what they've been doing all these years. I was one of them, remember?"

"Even when you were there, you've never been a Horde soldier. I know it. You've never done what they did."

"They did what they did because they were afraid… afraid of Hordak, afraid of losing their loved ones. I was just lucky enough not to be asked to do what others were forced to."

"I refuse to believe it. You would have died instead of following his orders."

"Katrina… I…"

"But it doesn't matter, you're here now. You're here, I'm here and… she's here."

"Let me speak with Angella, she'll trust me."

"No, she won't hear reason, she didn't listen to her best friend, she won't listen to you. We're alone in this."

"Then, if the Horde comes, we'll fight them even if we have to do it alone. For us, for our family, for your people."

"For you, my little bundle of joy…"

"Our little Catra…"

Catra's eyes fluttered open. She sat up quickly, groaning as felt her head throb painfully. That dream… it was like if she knew those voices. But it was impossible, how could she remember something that never happened? But it felt… it felt so real…

Why hadn't she ever dreamt of those voices before?

"It was just a dream, nothing more…" Catra whispered to herself.

She looked around, checking her surroundings as she tried to understand where she ended up. The mattress underneath her was far too soft to be the one she slept on in the Horde. As her eyes adjusted to the darkness of the room, she found out that it was far larger than her and Sparkle's cell on Horde Prime's ship. Its walls weren't painted in the same cold, tasteless white, but in a nice light ocher. It gave Catra a strange sense of warmth.

However, despite the comforts of the room she had woken up in, as the feline jumped off the bed and took a step towards the room's door, she yelped in pain as her hand made contact with a barrier made of light. She turned around only to notice that the wall circled her bed, and as she looked up, Catra realized that it was as tall as the room's ceiling. She could have never gotten out

of there. Then, as her eyes landed on the pink curtains of the chamber's balcony she realized. A large, comfortable room, with a nice bed and pink curtains used as a cell?

Yep, she had to be in Bright Moon.

"Of course." Catra groaned.

Then, it all came back to her. Horde Prime trying to take by force the information he needed, her resisting until the tyrant couldn't almost stand on his own anymore, the clones taking her back to Sparkles… Adora, Scorpia and the princesses saving them… Adora and Scorpia…

"Why didn't they leave me there?" Catra mumbled to herself as she stared blankly at nothing.

And as Catra kept wondering why the princesses, why Adora had taken her to Bright Moon, she didn't notice that she wasn't alone anymore, that someone had just entered the room and heard her. The figure emerged from the darkness as the cat girl's gaze was still lost into nothingness.

"Do you really think I would have left you there?"

Catra yelped in surprise as she quickly raised her gaze. Her eyes focused on the person who had just managed to sneak up on her. Tall, blonde hair, a nervous, small smile on her face.

Adora…

"Considering you've already done it in the past, it wouldn't have surprised me."

"I never left you to die, I'd never do it… even… even if you hadn't done what you did for Glimmer."

"And what did I do for Sparkles exactly?" Catra chuckled darkly.

"You saved her life." Adora stated.

“I saved myself.” The feline said, a smug smirk appearing on her face.

“Damn it Catra!” The blonde suddenly yelled in frustration.

Catra’s smirk actually vanished, a puzzled expression replacing it.

“I hate it when you do that!”

“Uh… what?! When I do what?!” Catra shouted back, both in anger and confusion.

“Lying! You always did! Even back when I was in the Horde, whenever something bad happened to you you’d never tell me the truth.”

“Oh, of course now, always the black sheep’s fault isn’t it?” The feline said mockingly.

“W-what are you talking about?! I’m not blaming you for anything! I just want to know-”

“What?! What do you want me to say Adora, huh?!”

“I want you to tell me why you saved her.” Adora demanded in a stern tone of voice.

Catra scoffed at that, turning her head to the side, averting her gaze from Adora.

“You can’t run this time, you can’t escape, and I won’t go away until you tell me.” Adora took a step forwards and pointed at her.

“Why do have to be so annoying?!” Catra grunted in frustration, pulling her hair.

“Because I thought I had lost you!”

Silence fell over the room. After a few, tense, endless instants, Catra spoke.

“What are you talking about?”

“After everything that happened, after the portal… I thought that the Catra I knew was gone forever. But when Glimmer told me you saved her… I finally understood that the girl I grew up with is still alive.”

“That girl is long gone Adora.” Catra shook her head.

“No, she’s not.”

“Oh, and who are you to say who I am now, huh?! You left and now you think you know me better than myself?!”

“Apparently, yes!” Adora yelled, waving her arms in the air.

Catra stared blankly at the blonde, her mouth slightly agape.

“If this freaking wall wasn’t here I’d… I’d-”

“What?! What would you do?! I’m listening…”

“I… I… gah! I hate you so much!” Catra cried as she punched her pillow.

“I don’t care, you’re still going to tell me.”

“I already told you why I did it.”

“You lied.” Adora crossed her arms.

“Then enlighten me miss smart ass, why would I ever save the queen of the Rebellion?” Catra snarled.

“You saved her because even if you act as the bad guy, I don’t think that’s who you are. Remember when I fell into your trap? When I told you that I would have never let you hurt anyone else, not after what happened with the portal, I remember the look you gave me.” Adora’s expression turned from stern to understanding, compassionate.

Catra hated that.

“Y-you’re just imagining things.” Catra shot back, although she couldn’t prevent her voice from wavering.

“No, I didn’t imagine that look. I saw all the guilt, the regret, the pain you were feeling. You are good at many things but lying and hiding your emotions? You’ve never been convincing. You did what you did because you wanted to redeem yourself.”

Catra remained silent, she let out a shaky breath and shut her eyes tightly.

“That’s what happened, isn’t it?”

“And what if that’s what happened?! What could possibly change?!” Catra suddenly jumped off her bed, now mere inches from the magical barrier.

“Then I’d know you’re still my Catra… that we could-”

Catra broke into a long, dark laughter.

“What? Fix things? As if that was possible.”

Adora shifted awkwardly on her feet, a flash of pain appearing on her face.

“Wouldn’t you like to go back?” The blonde offered weakly.

Catra felt her blood boiling. How dare Adora say that to her? How dare she offer such a thing? How dare she even thing about going back after she was the one who ruined everything?!

“We wouldn’t need to go back if you had stayed!”

The blonde looked away and Catra noticed how her eyes clearly reflected what she was feeling…

Guilt…

“I’m sorry… I’m sorry I broke our promise.” Adora’s voice was barely more audible than a whisper.

“Oh no, you don’t get to destroy the only thing I clung to as we grew up and then simply say that you’re sorry! You can’t fix what you did!” Catra pointed at the blonde accusingly.

“What should I have done?! After seeing what the Horde was doing I couldn’t stay! I had to go away! I had to fight them! And what about you?! If being with me was so important then why didn’t you come with me?!”

“Wasn’t I enough to make you stay?!” Catra screamed at the top of her lungs, a single tear streaming down her cheek.

Silence.

Adora’s eyes widened, her anger immediately dying down. Is that… it that why Catra had stayed behind? Is that how Catra felt when she left her? As if she wasn’t enough for her?

“Catra… I…” Adora whispered as she took a step towards her.

“Please… please just… just leave me alone…” Catra climbed on top of her bed and hugged her knees, turning her back on Adora.

“Catra…”

“Please…” Catra whispered, but even if her voice was barely audible, Adora managed to hear it breaking.

“Alright… I’ll… I’ll just go…”

Adora walked up to the room’s door, hesitating for a moment before opening it.

“Goodnight Catra.” The blonde said without turning around, before walking out the room.

Chapter End Notes

So here we are! THEY… FINALLY… TALKED! With… uhmm… slightly bad results but wait for it! You know things will get better… or will they? At least they got better with Glimmer! Shut up! I didn't tear up while writing their dialogue! Oh! Wait wait wait! Before I go, I need to tell you something! Do you know who's gonna talk in the next chapter? Catra and-

Author's note: Boooomb incoming!

Hi guys! It’s me, the Teller of Light and Dark. What do you say? “We thought you were dead and the story had died with you.”?! How… how dare you! I wouldn’t even dream to die without having finished this story first! Even though… I’m Italian and… right now with the Corona Virus here in Italy things are a little bit complicated… and I’ve had fever, cough and cold for a week now… haha! But I’m totally feeling better now! So don’t you worry. Aaaaand, since I’ve been feeling better and the situation is starting to get better (and because of the virus my university is closed and there are no lessons and because of the quarantine I can only stay at home and do stuff at home), I began to write again and would you look at that? An 8000 words file?! Does that mean-?! Yeah, another four chapters comiiiiiiing! Chapter XVI: Old Friends, Chapter XVII: A New Purpose, Chapter XVIII: Mistakes, and Chapter XIX: True Strength are coming respectively on March 21, 23, 25 and 27! So stay tuned for four new chapters of The Last Stand! See you tomorrow!

Old Friends

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hordak?"

A voice… that's the first thing the former Horde leader heard as he slowly opened his eyes.

"E-Entrapta?" Hordak croaked in a low voice as he noticed the pigtailed princess standing a few feet away from him.

"Oh, thank the First Ones, you're awake! I was starting to get worried."

"W-where are we?" The former Horde leader asked as he sat up, holding his head.

"We're currently in Bright Moon's castle." Entrapta explained.

Hordak's eyes widened in shock before an angered scowl appeared on his face. He quickly stood up from the floor on which the guards had left him and tried to reach for the pigtailed princess. However, as the former Horde leader extended his arm towards Entrapta, his hand came in contact with the magical barrier that had been created around him. He hadn't noticed it, but as soon as he touched it, the light wall lit up, brightening the room's darkness. Hordak recoiled backwards, holding his own wrist tightly, his face contorted into a grimace of pain.

"What is the meaning of this?!" He roared.

“King Micah wanted to kill you. Me, Glimmer and Adora managed to stop him but… you still acted antagonistically against them… against the Rebellion. The best we could achieve was for you to become a prisoner.” Entrapta answered.

The moment she stopped speaking, the scientist princess flinched back as Hordak slammed his hands against the magical barrier which surrounded him, not caring the slightest about the pain it caused.

“So that I can help you?! So that I can betray my own creator and master for you?!”

“Yes.”

Hordak couldn’t stop himself from letting out a strangled noise of surprise.

“I won’t give you anything. Now, release me!”

“I won’t.” Entrapta spoke determinately.

The former Horde leader’s expression changed from one of anger to one of puzzlement.

“It’s useless to keep me here! I won’t tell you anything about the great Prime!” Hordak roared.

“I don’t care about that!” Entrapta shouted back, twice as strong, effectively stunning him. “If I free you now… you’d just go back to him…”

“It is my duty, what I was made for… to serve my master and obey his-” Hordak began to speak but the scientist princess cut him off.

“Then I won’t do it.”

“W-what?!” Hordak stuttered, bewildered.

"If you go back to him… he'll wipe your memories away… he… he will wipe *you* away…" Entrapta whispered, pain flashing in her eyes.

"Even if that was the case, I have to go back to Horde Prime anyway! He's my creator!"

"And I'm your friend!"

Silence fell upon the room. Hordak's eyes became wide with surprise. He had fought his entire life to climb the ranks of Prime's armies, he had become his right hand and when his master had casted him away… he did everything he could to go back to him… to show Horde Prime he was still worthy to be at his side. However… the emperor of the known universe… his creator… would have erased him if it wasn't for Entrapta…

Entrapta…

The weird scientist princess had appeared in Hordak's life out of nowhere. He didn't trust her… he felt disgusted during the first days of their collaboration… a princess roaming his laboratory… unthinkable! But… as time went by… Hordak stopped thinking about Entrapta as a princess, as one of his enemies and began to notice all the small things that made her and her company… so enjoyable. Such an intelligence, such a curiosity and…

Something warm…

Something Hordak had never felt before in his life…

Entrapta had been the only one to ever made him feel that strange yet soothing warmth in his chest…

"Even if… even if you are… you can't choose for me…"

"I don't care if I can't… I'm going to do it anyway… I won't let you die." The scientist princess countered in a hushed tone of voice, her gaze low as she spoke.

“Entrapta…”

The way Hordak pronounced her name… so softly… made the pigtailed princess raise her eyes, a slight glimmer of hope visible in them.

“Let me out… please…”

“Will you help us?”

“Horde Prime… Horde Prime is…” Hordak hesitated, conflict clear on his face before he let out a long exhale. “Horde Prime cannot be defeated. Surrender to him and he might think about your collaboration as something valuable. You’d be saved.”

“And you’d be gone… just like all my friends…” Entrapta’s small, hopeful smile had vanished. “I guess you don’t have anything else to say… is that right?”

Hordak gritted his teeth and shut his eyes tight. Once again, his expression betrayed his interior conflict but sadly… Entrapta’s hopes were once again dashed.

“That is right princess… leave me…”

Entrapta let out a small whimper.

She turned around and rushed outside the room.

She didn’t even notice Hordak’s hand outstretched towards her.

~

“My Queen!”

“What is it?!”

“The Horde… they’ve breached our defenses!”

"How many are there?!"

"At least eight hundred soldiers, the same number of bots and a two dozen of tanks!"

"We can't defeat them…"

"We can! Use your power against them my Queen!"

"No, even with my power… I can't risk my crown falling in their hands… take it."

"W-what? M-my Queen, I can't!"

"You can, take it to our true home…"

"I… I… I am at your command My Lady…"

"Go… take our people to safety and… wait for the Queen to come back… only then we'll have the power to fight back."

"Goodbye… my Queen."

…

…

…

"Mathias… where are you?"

When Catra woke up, she found herself breathing heavily, her forehead slick with sweat. She grabbed her hair and pulled, grunting loudly. What was happening to her? What was the meaning of her dreams? She had one before Adora came into her room, and when finally, she managed to relax enough to fall asleep again… the dreams came back.

The voice speaking… the one the second voice referred to as 'Queen', she had heard it in the first dream… it was… oddly soothing, warm… it made Catra shake her head violently. She

didn’t know those voices, she had never heard them before and yet… whenever she heard them… they felt so real… as if memories were trying to resurface after being pulled into a dark corner of her mind.

“J-Just dreams… they’re just-” Catra murmured, but suddenly, she became silent as a voice cut through the darkness of her room.

“Wildcat?”

No…

Not now…

She couldn’t face anyone else right now…

Scorpia stepped into the light glow of the magical barrier surrounding Catra’s bed, her pincers conjoined behind her back, a nervous, small yet genuine smile on her face. The feline did her best to conceal her fear, a weak, trembling, mocking grin growing on her face.

“So, princess Scorpia steps away from her new, glittering friends to come and see lil’ old me?”

“What’s wrong Catra?”

The cat girl’s eyes widened in shock, her mouth slightly agape as her grin shattered. It was as if Scorpia didn’t even hear her talking… as if she had immediately been able to see past her façade. She took a step forwards and that’s when an incredulous, slightly hysterical laugh bubble up Catra’s throat.

“You think you can talk to me like that? After you left me?!”

“I know I hurt you, I’m not asking you to forgive me… but I needed to save Entrapta.” Scorpia tried to explain.

Of course she would play the ‘I need to save my true friends’ card, of course she had to remind Catra of her mistakes.

“Is she…” Catra’s voice was barely more audible than a whisper, she interrupted herself before finishing, but Scorpia heard her anyway.

Catra hated how the scorpion princess’ smile grew more hopeful.

She… she hated it…

“Entrapta is fine.” Scorpia said in a warm tone of voice.

But what Catra hated the most, was the relief she felt as she heard those words.

“If you’re so happy she’s fine, why did you send her away in the first place?” A mocking voice spoke inside Catra’s mind.

“Shut up…” Catra muttered under her breath, holding her head.

“Catra…” Scorpia whispered, as she slowly raised her pincer towards the feline.

“You’ve got what you wanted right?! So why are you still here?!” The cat girl hissed angrily.

“What are you talking about?” The scorpion princess raised an eyebrow in confusion.

“I saw you… on the ship… now you even got the powers of a princess… and you’ve got brand new friends so you can drop the act and leave already!”

“I never wanted those powers Catra, I never wanted to become a princess.” Scorpia smiled weakly, slightly shaking her head.

“What?” Catra asked incredulously.

“I wanted to be your friend. I cared about you so much… I still do…”

As she heard those words, Catra turned away, her gaze set on the room’s floor. She didn’t want to believe it… she couldn’t believe

it… because the truth was that despite how strong Catra wanted to look, she was at her limit. Another betrayal? Another person leaving her? Someone she cared for coming back only to stab her back? It would have broken her. But despite that, despite the feline's fear, despite her best attempts at driving her away, Scorpia didn't give up and instead, she chose to press on.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

The scorpion princess' sudden question silenced the cat girl, who now wore a confused expression. What was she talking about?

"What do you mean?"

"Why didn't you tell me about Shadow Weaver?" Scorpia asked as she took a step towards the magic barrier surrounding Catra.

"I… I don't know what you're talking about…" Catra stuttered as she wrapped her arms around herself and turned away.

"That's what Adora told you in the Crimson Waste, isn't it?" Scorpia pressed on, taking another step towards the cat girl, and despite her pained expression, she kept speaking. "She told you that Shadow Weaver had come to Bright Moon…"

"Shut up…"

"She… she tricked you…"

"Shut up!" Catra yelled ferociously.

However, Scorpia didn't seem to be scared. It was now or never, the scorpion princess thought. She couldn't let Catra hold in whatever what was eating her from the inside, she had to make her talk, she had to make the cat girl trust her again… she had to help her best friend.

"Tell me if that's what happened!"

Catra growled, pinching the bridge of her nose in frustration.

“Yeah! That’s what happened! Are you happy now?!” The cat girl finally admitted.

Scorpia’s expression changed. All the sadness, the anger, it was all gone, replaced by a weak yet hopeful smile.

“I knew it.”

“W-what?” Catra’s eyebrows scrunched up in confusion.

“I knew that wasn’t you… I knew that the girl who told me all those terrible things wasn’t you Catra… I just… I just wish you had told me sooner.”

“And that would have changed everything right?” The feline chuckled mockingly.

“Yes… I would have known that everything you were doing… you were doing it because you were hurt.” Scorpia’s tone was so kind, so compassionate.

“You don’t need help, those who ask for it are nothing but weaklings!” Catra could hear a familiar voice screaming inside her head.

“I wasn’t hurt!”

“You were! Stop denying it!” Scorpia shouted, with such force that she surprised both Catra and herself, “Why is it so difficult for you to just say it! Shadow Weaver… she must have given you a tiny speck of what she had always given to Adora… some kind of love… some kind of recognition… isn’t that right?”

How…

How could Scorpia have seen right through her?

Was she that transparent?

“You don’t know what you’re talking about…” Catra countered weakly.

“And when you discovered she had tricked you… that broke you.” The scorpion princess took another step towards the barrier.

“Stop!”

“Admitting that she hurt you doesn’t make you weak!” Scorpia cried desperately.

“That’s exactly what weakness is!”

“And who taught that?! Let me guess… was it her?!”

Catra’s mouth hanged open in shock. There was no witty comeback, no snarky comment, nothing that she could have used against those words… because they stated the truth. Shadow Weaver had always taught both her and Adora that one has to count only on themselves, such was the cruelty of the world they lived on. To ask for help was an unforgivable display of weakness.

“I… I…” Catra tried to answer, but she couldn’t. When did Scorpia become so good at reading her? At understanding what she’s been through?!

Maybe…

Maybe the scorpion princess had always been good at that, it’s just that…

Catra never actually listened to her…

“But you don’t need her Catra… you don’t need to prove anything to anyone… you’re an amazing person, you’re strong, determined and so fun to hang out with. You were… you still are my first true friend.”

Catra bit her lower lip, shutting her eyes tight and shaking her head. It’s in that moment that she heard the sound of footsteps

coming closer and closer. She opened her eyes only to see that Scorpia was standing right in front of her. The scorpion princess outstretched a pincer towards her and pressed it against the magic wall.

"W-what are you doing?!"

"G-Glimmer explained this kind of m-magic to me. N-nothing can get out, but something or someone with enough magical power c-can… get… in! B-but… oh boy, I didn't expect it to be t-this painful!" Scorpia stuttered as she slowly pushed through the barrier.

Catra wanted to yell at the scorpion princess to go back, that she wasn't worth risking to get hurt. But before she could speak even one single word, Scorpia had already passed through the magical wall and now… she stood right in front of her.

"S-Stay back…" Catra warned, her voice starting to break.

"I'm not going to leave you Catra." Scorpia spoke determinately, although not unkindly.

"Stay back!"

The feline closed her eyes and pulled out her claws. She couldn't let Scorpia come any closer, she couldn't let her… even if the scorpion princess still cared about her, Catra was sure that sooner or later she'd find a way to drive her away… just like she did in the past.

"She'll leave you… leave you all alone… don't let her! Hit her!"

Catra did.

Her claws came down and hit something hard.

When the cat girl opened her eyes, she saw that Scorpia had defended herself by raising a pincer, but now… five, thin lines could be seen along its surface. Catra took a step back as she

realized what she had just done. Her mouth was slightly agape, her lower lip was trembling, and her pupils had shrunken down to the size of a needle's tip.

"S-Scorpia I-"

Catra didn't have time to finish.

A pair of strong arms embraced her and held her tightly.

"I'm sorry…" Catra whispered as tears started to stream down her cheeks.

"It's okay, I won't leave you again."

The two held each other until they fell asleep…

And when Shadow Weaver silently strolled into the chamber…

Her eyes grew thin at the sight of the two girls…

"Weak… as always…" The witch whispered.

She swiftly moved her hands through the air and when Catra opened her eyes a few hours later…

The magic barrier was gone…

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! Here we are with a fresh new chapter! I hope you've all enjoyed it and remember, this is just the first of the new four chapters that I've written. Next one will come out on March 23 so stay tuned for more! Bye!

A New Purpose

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Catra's eyes fluttered open she couldn't actually believe what she was seeing. The barrier, the magical wall that Sparkle's aunt had erected around her had vanished. She slowly outstretched a hand through the air, tentatively at first, as if she was expecting to get shock again. However, nothing happened. She was free! Free to … free to … do what?

As the question came to her mind, Catra began to wonder what could have been off her life from that moment on. Suddenly, her train of thoughts was interrupted by something big, warm and quite heavy shifting beside her. Catra looked over her shoulder and her eyes fell upon Scorpia's sleeping face. She seemed so… content…

Idiot… only Scorpia could do something as stupid as trying and actually succeeding in pushing through a freaking magic wall just to comfort her. Not that would have ever admitted that the Scorpion princess had actually given her any comfort…

But nightmares hadn't come back this time.

"What should I do?" Catra whispered to herself.

"You should run away" a voice inside her head suggested.

And indeed, for an instant Catra thought about leaving everything behind. She knew Prime was too strong for Sparkles, Adora and the others. They would have never been able to defeat him. But Catra wasn't one to run or hide.

"Join him then…"

Catra remembered Double Trouble's words, that the best way to survive was to always choose the winning side. If she gave Horde Prime what he wanted… without resisting him… maybe he would have taken her as one of his soldiers! Maybe even as his right hand and then-

"I'll wipe your mind and make you the perfect soldier…. obedient… loyal. And once I'm done with you, I'll do the same with all of my little brother's subjects. After all, I cannot risk any of them trying to do what you did to him, am I right?"

The feline shook her head violently as the tyrant's words came back to her mind. Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, everyone in the Horde… Prime would have made them his new puppets. They would have obeyed his every order, the would have followed him and even died in the name of his endless conquest… devoid of conscience… without a choice.

But Catra?

Catra had a choice…

To run or to fight for who only now she understood were her people…

What else was there to try?

Winning for herself?

She tried to do it, it didn't feel good as she expected it would. The sad thing was, Catra had spent her whole life trying to win for herself, eighteen long years thrown away, hating, pushing everyone away. But it still taught her a valuable lesson…

She wasn't that kind of a person.

Sure, now that she had done what she had done, almost all of Etheria must have thought about her as some kind of heartless

monster. It was okay though, Catra knew she deserved it, she came to accept it slowly, but she did.

But now?

Now it was time to turn the page, time for another Catra to steal the spotlight… maybe it wasn't even a completely new person, just one the girl had buried deep down in her quest for something that in that moment, as she took one last look at Scorpia before leaving… she realized wasn't worth anything.

That night… Catra choose to finally fight back.

The feline quietly stood up from her bed, making sure not to wake the scorpion princess. What she was about to do may have costed her her own life, but now it was too late to turn back, and if she actually died? She wasn't going to let anyone she cared for die alongside her.

Catra silently opened her room's door and shut it behind her. She stopped dead in her tracks as she noticed a guard a mere foot away from her, just outside the chamber, but as a few seconds went by she realized the soldier had fallen asleep. Catra tsked quietly as she began to tip toe down the castle's corridors. If anything like that happened in the Horde while she was still second in command? She would have taken the culprit and…

And…

Catra shook her head, groaning. That wasn't who she truly was… not anymore.

After a few minutes of exploring, she finally managed to find the palace's exit. Good. As she took the first step outside, Catra took a long, deep breath and let the fresh night air fill her lungs. It felt heavenly. First she had been stuck on Horde Prime's ship, then in queen Sparkle's castle. It was the first time in a while she felt so alive and…

Free…

And ready.

A part of her kept screaming at her that what she was about to do was the most stupid thing she had ever even thought about doing, that she should have taken the easy way instead. But Catra quickly silenced that small part of her. She had been picking the easy way for way too long now, and it never truly ended well for her. No… there was truly no turning back now… she was going to do it.

She was going to save the Horde.

She was going to give them a chance to do better…

To be better…

A chance to understand what they truly wanted to do with their lives without having anyone doing their choices for them…

And Catra wasn't going to let anyone stand in her w-

"So, where are we going?"

Catra yelped so loudly that it would have had to be a miracle if none of Bright Moon guards had heard her. She spun around, her claws shining under the moon light, ready to strike. She scoffed in both disbelief and annoyance as her eyes focused on who had managed to sneak up on her. Catra pulled her claws back in and crossed her arms.

"What are you doing here Scorpia?" The feline pinched the bridge of her nose in frustration, trying to avoid the scorpion princess' glance…

And her stupid, goofy, determined smile.

"Uh, well, when I woke up and didn't see you, I thought you had slipped outside the room quietly to not wake me up. Oh, by the way, that was very considerate of you so, yeah, thanks wildca-" Scorpia kept rambling on until the cat girl interrupted her.

“Scorpia…” Catra sighed heavily.

“W-what is it?” Scorpia asked, chuckling nervously.

“I didn’t wake you up because I didn’t want you to follow me.”

The two stared at each other silently for a few moments.

“Did… did I do something wrong? I thought… I thought… I mean, when we hugged and stuff that-”

“No! It’s not that…” Catra groaned loudly, stupid sentimental Scorpia, “I can’t let you come because I don’t want you to get hurt.”

A warm smile grew on the scorpion princess. However, it only lasted a few moments before a concerned look took its place.

“Then… what you’re going to do is… is gonna be dangerous for you?”

Catra hesitated, she didn’t have time for this. Horde Prime might have already reached the Fright Zone for what she knew.

“Yes, it will.”

“Well, then I have to come with you.” Scorpia declared taking a step forward.

“Scorpia… I might come face to face with Prime… I know I don’t stand a chance against him but I have to do this. And I have to do this al-”

“Horde Prime?! B-but… that means… wait… Glimmer said Bright Moon’s spies have spotted a couple of ships heading towards the Fright Zone… are you going there?” Scorpia asked in a bewildered tone of voice.

Catra shrugged and averted her gaze.

“Why would you do that?”

“Prime will brainwash all of them… there’ll be nothing left of who they were before and… gah! I don’t even know why I’m doing this…” Catra threw her arms in the air, a light blush on her cheeks.

“Oh… oh, Catra. I think you do.” Scorpia said, smiling warmly and putting her pincer on the cat girl’s shoulder. “But still, you don’t have to do this alone. I know what you’re thinking… that… that maybe this is the first good thing you think you’re doing in a long time and… it’s yours… it really is Catra. But I can’t simply let my best friend go there without back up. And I know you care about me but… this is my choice.”

“Ugh… why must you be so stubborn?” Catra groaned, however, a slight smile tugged on her lips.

“Hey, you know me, that’s one of my best qualities!” Scorpia joked, earning a chuckle from the feline. “Oh! That and the fact that when I left the Fright Zone, I snatched a skiff…”

Ohoho… Scorpia committing a crime against the Horde?

“Well well well, you’re not such a goodie two shoes, are you?” Catra grinned mockingly.

The two of them started to walk, leaving the palace’s grounds behind them. The Whispering Woods become nearer and nearer until both the princess and the former commander found themselves at its gates. Scorpia took a step forwards and pulled the skiff out from a bush where she had hidden it the first time she came to Bright Moon.

“How did you get here? The forest seems to have re grown after I froze it… didn’t you get lost?” Catra asked.

“Oh, I wish I knew… I just… I kept thinking about saving Entrapta and… I just got here. Lucky shot, huh?” Scorpia snickered as she readied the skiff.

“I… guess…” Catra wasn’t completely satisfied with the explanation, but there wasn’t time to think about it.

It was time to go.

And if someone hadn’t called her name just before she jumped on the skiff alongside Scorpia, she would have disappeared into the woods that instant.

“Catra!”

Chapter End Notes

> We've reached 10000 hits! Wooooooo! I'm so happy right now guys, thank you, really, thank you for your appreciation. It kept me going and it still keeps me going to this day! I hope you've enjoyed this chapter and be prepared because you know that the next one will come out really soon! See you in two days!

Mistakes

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The feline became frozen. She slowly turned around only to find herself face to face with a familiar blonde.

“What do you want?” Catra asked in a dark tone of voice, she wished a snarky comment would come to her, but strangely… she didn’t feel like it.

“Catra… w-where are you going?” Adora asked.

The slight panic in her voice… Catra expectred it to be music to her ears, like it had always been, but for some unknown reason, this time… it only made her stomach clench in an unpleasant way. The feline hated it. There was no reason for her to feel this way. In front of her stood someone who betrayed her… who took her heart and stomped on it, crushing it into a million pieces.

“It’s none of your business.” Catra replied coldly.

“It is if you’re going to get hurt.”

“Excuse me?! Since when do you even care Adora?!”

Adora’s eyes widened before she casted her gaze downwards, pain and guilt written all over her face.

“Always…”

And she did. Adora always cared for Catra, she had always feared for her and even though she believed she had grown to not feel

anything anymore, to only feel anger towards her ex best friend… Adora knew that deep down… it wasn't true.

The blonde's voice was barely more audible than a whisper, but when it reached Catra's ears, the feline became red with anger. She took a step forward and before Adora could do something, she clasped her hand around her throat, claws halfway out.

"You wanna say that again? Huh?!" Catra shouted angrily.

How dare she…

How dare Adora say that…

"Catra, maybe you shouldn't-" Scorpia began to talk but as soon as Catra whipped her head around, she closed her mouth.

The look she gave her…

It sent chills down the scorpion princess' spine.

"I… I said… a-always… that I always c-" Adora tried to speak, both of her hands gripping Catra's wrist.

"Shut up! I don't want to hear your lies anymore! Everything you ever told me was a lie… everything I clung to in that dark pit I called life, every hug or 'you're my best friend' or 'I love you'… nothing but dirty lies!"

"N-no… I never lied when I said those things, never." The blonde stuttered.

"I swear, if you don't shut up… I'm gonna… I'm gonna-" Catra growled, but she fell silent as Adora had raised a hand to her cheek.

She run her thumb under her eye, softly, wiping a tear Catra didn't know she had cried. The feline gasped in shock and let Adora go. The blonde fell to her knees, her own cheeks stained with tears.

“Please… let me come.”

Those words stunned Catra even more than that single, unwanted tear. Adora… wanted to come with her? Adora wanted to be at her side? To fight alongside her? Adora didn’t want… she didn’t want to leave her behind? Adora… Adora wanted to protect her?

Adora wanted to be the hero, once again…

Adora wanted to take everything from her…

Adora wanted to keep her safe… beside her… on a leash… as always…

“So that you can save the day once more?” Catra chuckled darkly.

“W-what? N-no! I… I know where you’re going Catra. Glimmer told us about those ships… but you’re not going there to try and join Prime, are you?”

“No!” Catra answered maybe a little too quickly, and the smile she received from Adora only made it worse.

“Horde Prime will be there… Catra, you can’t beat him!” Adora cried desperately.

“I won’t let you tell me what I can or can’t do! I’m done being your pet!”

“M-my… Catra that’s not-” The blonde stuttered but became silent as Catra bent down and grabbed her by the hems of her jacket.

“Oh but I was… wasn’t I?! Always trying to stand up for poor, little ol’ me… but only in ways that wouldn’t make Shadow Weaver look at you as if you weren’t her golden, perfect child any longer… that way you kept her love and felt like the valiant hero…” Catra spat viciously.

“I’m s-sorry… I wanted to protect you…” The blonde countered weakly.

“No, you never wanted to protect me, you only wanted to feel like a hero. That’s why you left…”

“C-Catra… no! That’s-”

“Follow me, and I won’t hesitate…” Catra raised a clawed hand over the blonde’s face, “I’m warning you, Adora.”

The feline let go of Adora’s jacket and let the girl fall back on the ground.

“Catra, please! I just want to protect you!”

Catra halted in her steps as Adora called out to her. She gritted her teeth and clenched her fists to her sides.

“It’s too late for that.” Catra muttered without turning back.

The feline jumped on the skiff. She gave a swift nod to Scorpia, signaling her to start the engine. Scorpia did so, casting one last glance at Adora. The blonde looked crushed. The scorpion princess gave her one apologetic look before grasping the skiff’s helm and starting to drive it away, into the woods. The last thing Catra heard coming from behind her as both her and Scorpia grew further away from Bright Moon was the sound of loud, desperate sobs.

She hated how that sound made her heart ache.

~

To the young queen, the whole situation felt surreal. It really did. Not only her friends had managed to save her from Horde Prime, but together, they also managed to drive his armies away from Bright Moon. Etheria never had to face such an opponent, but united, the princesses had succeeded in a task that many would

have thought impossible. It was true, the war was far from over, but right now, Glimmer felt at ease.

Bright Moon was saved, she had finally been able to patch things up with Adora and despite everything that happened between her and Catra, she felt like the feline could become one of their greatest allies in their fight against Horde Prime. Glimmer's mind went back to the last moments before Adora entered Catra's chamber, a few hours before. The blonde had turned around one last time, a kind smile on her face, one of those the young queen had missed so much, and told her that Angella would have been proud of the queen she had become.

Adora didn't notice the tears that started streaming down Glimmer's cheeks. Not tears of sadness… but happiness.

"Angella would have been proud of the queen you had become."

Proud. Glimmer hadn't felt proud of herself in a long time. But right now? She felt more proud than ever. Because Adora thought so, because wherever she was, her mom thought the same and… and so did her father. King Micah… having her dad back was… strange. It wasn't that Glimmer didn't like the situation. After all, when Adora, Bow and the others had brought her home, and she finally got to see her dad again, she couldn't believe her own eyes. When she felt his arms tighten around her and understood that he was really there, that it wasn't a dream… Glimmer had never felt so happy in her entire life.

However, the truth was that they had been apart for so long that now it felt strange to be around each other, but neither the young queen nor the old king would have ever wanted to change that. With time, things would have gone back to normal, Glimmer was sure of it.

"My Queen?"

The strangely soothing voice made the young queen turn away from her room's balcony.

“Shadow Weaver…” Glimmer muttered.

The irritation in her voice didn’t go unnoticed.

“I know you don’t approve of the way I acted on the battlefield, but everything I did I did it for-” The witch stared to explain herself but was suddenly interrupted.

“Me?” Glimmer spat indignantly.

“Of course…” Shadow Weaver answered, cradling the queen’s cheek.

Her hand was quickly swatted away.

“How could you? How could you take my father’s side when he was going to… to…”

“To?”

“She’s your daughter!” Glimmer hissed through gritted teeth.

“Hordak ordered me to raise her, to make her a Horde’s soldier… she’s never been nothing more and now, she’s not even that any longer.” Shadow Weaver replied casually.

The young queen’s eyes widened.

“You’re a monster, you… you disgust me.”

“I’m being honest, something you should learn to be too, my Queen.”

“What are you talking about?” Glimmer asked, taking a step back as the witch came closer.

“After everything she had done to you, you still want to give her a second chance? Are you doing it because you believe she can change or because you don’t want to look appear as a merciless queen in the eyes of those around you?” Shadow Weaver questioned.

“She can change! She already did!” Glimmer shouted back in anger.

“Catra will never change, she’ll always try to get what she wasn’t born to have… power… and she won’t care about who gets hurt in the process… she didn’t care about the fact that in order to win, she had killed your mother.”

Glimmer was fuming. She marched up to Shadow Weaver, the two only inches apart.

“You don’t know what she told me on Prime’s ship, I get the feeling you don’t know her at all.”

Shadow Weaver remained silent for a moment, she began to circle around Glimmer, noticing how the young queen’s eyes never left her. When she got behind her, she gently put her hands on her shoulders and quietly whispered in her ear.

“I know her well enough to tell you that keeping her here was a grave mistake. As soon as she’ll get the chance, she’ll run away to join Prime. Don’t think she has ever helped you because of something that’s not in her interests.”

“I… I don’t believe you.” Glimmer muttered, the resolve in her voice slightly wavering.

SLAM!

Suddenly, the bedroom’s door swung open.

“Glimmer!” Bow breathlessly called her as he barged into the room.

“Bow?! W-what’s happening?!” Glimmer stuttered.

“It’s Catra! She’s gone!”

The young queen’s face paled.

Her mind immediately went to one and only one person.

Adora…

"Where's Adora? Is she okay?" Glimmer spoke slowly, as if she was afraid to know the answer.

Had it been a good idea to leave Adora alone with Catra?

Could Catra have… hurt her?

"We found her on the edge of the Whispering Woods… she's not hurt but… she's not okay."

Glimmer didn't know whether to feel relieved or not. But there was no time for indecision, she had to be there for Adora, whatever had happened.

"Let's go."

Bow nodded and turned to leave. Glimmer did the same, she began to follow the archer but stopped as she felt Shadow Weaver's eyes on her.

"This doesn't mean anything, we don't know what happened."

"Keep my words in mind, my Queen."

Glimmer didn't answer, she simply turned around and followed Bow down the castle's corridors. A storm of thoughts and worries began to swirl inside her mind. How could she have left Adora alone with Catra? After all that had happened between them she should have expected something like this to happen… but nothing had happened right? Catra couldn't have hurt Adora, she was fine! The cat girl had changed! Glimmer was sure of it… but then again… why would she have left if she had truly changed?

Each and every one of those doubts vanished as the young queen's eyes fell on a figure near the Whispering Woods' edge. It was a blonde girl, kneeled to the ground, her arms locked around

herself as her shoulders slightly shook. As Glimmer grew near, she began to hear the sound of quiet sobs.

“A-Adora?”

Chapter End Notes

> And here we are at the end of chapter 18, hope you've all enjoyed it! And obviously, that you've enjoyed the story so far. Remember, chapter 19 will come out on 27 March!

True Strenght

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Where's Adora? Is she okay?" Glimmer spoke slowly, as if she was afraid to know the answer.

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"A-Adora?"

"Glimmer! I'm s-sorry I should-" Adora stuttered, quickly standing up from the ground and frantically wiping away the tears that had been staining her cheeks.

"Adora? What happened?" Glimmer asked, and as soon as the blonde heard her voice, she began to calm down.

Adora expected Glimmer to be furious, after all, Catra was still a prisoner at Bright Moon and right under everyone's noses, she had managed to escape. But the only thing she heard as the young queen spoke, was the concern she felt for her friend.

"It's… her…" Adora whispered.

"Did Catra do something?! She might have saved me but if she hurt you I'm gonna-" Glimmer muttered through gritted teeth, her fists clenching at her sides.

"She went to the Fright Zone." The blonde quickly informed.

"What?!" Bow yelled in shock without one second of hesitation.

"Yeah…"

"You don't think she went there to… to join-" Glimmer's tone suddenly became quiet, unsure.

"No! No… I said that and she gave a strange look, she didn't want to tell me because she didn't want to say I was right… but she's

not going there to join Prime…"

"Then… why?" Bow asked, clearly confused by the former second in command's actions.

"I don't know but… I just wanted to go there together, to face whatever she's going to do together… but… she thought I didn't believe in her enough to let her do this alone… she told me she won't be my pet anymore but I swear don't think of her that way!" Adora explained, grasping Glimmer's and Bow's hands, her eyes filled with fear.

Unbeknown to both the young queen and the archer, in that exact moment, they thoughts were the same. Does… does Adora think we could truly believe that? Does she really think we would ever think of her as a monster? Is that why she's so scared?

"Adora…" Bow gripped the blonde's hand with his own, his tone stern yet… not unkind.

"W-what?" Adora raised her gaze, that fear still present in her eyes.

"We know you don't think of her that way." The archer's stern expression slowly morphed into a friendlier, warmer one, a smile growing on his face.

"And we know you just want to help her… I think Catra is feeling a little bit like me…" Glimmer said, her voice hushed, rubbing her arm as she suddenly felt a little self-conscious.

"What? H-how?" Suddenly, the fear in Adora's eyes was gone, surprise showing in its place.

Glimmer chuckled as she slightly shook her head. Sometimes Adora could be the most naïve dork on the whole planet.

"Adora… when… when I became queen… I wanted to prove myself that I was worth something, that I could do things on my own and be strong like… like my mom. But the truth is that

sometimes everyone needs some help… we're just too stubborn and too afraid to look weak to admit it."

"So you think…" The blonde began to guess.

"I think that Catra needs you… more than she'd like to admit. You didn't give up on me, did you?" Glimmer put a hand on Adora's shoulder, a small, encouraging smile on her lips.

"No, I would never!" Adora quickly answered.

"Would you give up on Catra?"

A long silence passed. Would she ever give up on Catra? Adora thought that eventually, she would have had to. After everything that happened between them, after how much harm they've done to each other, the blonde thought that what they shared was long gone. But after what Catra had done for Glimmer on Horde Prime's station? A glimpse of what Adora thought was gone, glimmered in the darkness and suddenly, she found out that…

"No, I don't think I could do that."

"And what are you going to do?" Bow asked in an encouraging tone of voice, a wide smile starting to spread on his face.

"Uhm…" Adora seemed taken aback by the young archer's enthusiasm.

"And what are you going to do?!" The archer asked, his voice booming.

"I'm going to help her." The blonde answered, fear and uncertainty completely gone, while the fire that had guided her through the most difficult times of her life ignited in her heart and shined in her eyes.

"And you won't do it alone." Glimmer said.

They truly were the best friend in the whole universe.

“Indeed!”

The joyful cry made the small group turn around.

Sea Hawk, Mermista, Frosta, Perfuma, Entrapta and Swift Wind quickly made their way towards the trio.

“You thought you could go on an adventure without us?” Sea Hawk held a hand to his chest, gasping dramatically.

“Guys… I can’t ask you to do this for me.” Adora shook her head.

“We’re not gonna do this for you, we’re gonna do this with you!” Frosta chimed in, raising both of her fists in the air enthusiastically.

“That’s what friends do! Right? Tell me I said that right, it might mean that I’m truly learning something about friendship!” Entrapta pleaded comically.

“Yes Entrapta, you said that right, we won’t leave you alone on this.” Perfuma said as she patted the pigtailed princess’ head.

“That cat did destroy my kingdom buuuut… I guess that if you care so much about her… plus she did save Glimmer didn’t she? That must mean that there’s something good in her, right?” Mermista huffed, crossing her arms, although she couldn’t prevent a small smile from forming on her face.

“Come on Adora, if you saved me, Bow and Micah on Beast Island, saving Catra in the Fright Zone will be a piece of cake!” Swift Wind neighed joyfully.

“All right.”

Adora looked at each and every one of her friends. The battle would have been hard, there was no telling what was waiting for them in the Fright Zone, but whatever it was, they would have faced it together.

"Let's go."

~

"Catra…"

"I don't want to talk right now, okay Scorpia?"

"Catra… it's not okay. You should talk to me, we're friends, right? That's what friends do… I think…"

"Yeah…"

Catra hated the hesitation in her own voice, and she hated how hard it had been for her to say that single word, as if she was still scared to actually acknowledge the fact… as if… if she said it out loud it would all vanish in an instant.

"You're not made for this… you're not made to be around people."

The voice inside her head cackled darkly, and Catra found herself gripping her hair tightly. It was only when she felt Scorpia's pincer touch her hand that she realized what she was doing. She immediately let go and turned towards the scorpion princess. Her brow was furrowed in a mixture of concern and confusion.

"I… I don't think I can talk right now…" Catra murmured, avoiding Scorpia's gaze.

"I just wanted… I just wanted to say… I just wanted to let you know that she even stood up to Shadow Weaver for you…" The scorpion princess talked in a hushed tone, almost as if she was afraid to see the feline's reaction to her words.

It was like the blast from one of the Horde's tanks had hit her square in the chest. Catra's eyes widened in shock and strangely

enough, the cat girl found out that she couldn’t breathe.

“W-what?” Catra whispered in disbelief.

“A-ah! S-sorry, I didn’t want to upset you! It’s just that-” Scorpia rambled frantically before being interrupted by the cat girl’s hand grasping her pincer.

“Scorpia… what did you mean by that?”

“King Micah… he… Shadow Weaver told him about the portal… about what happened to Glimmer’s mom…”

Catra’s ears immediately dropped in shame.

“I guess… I guess he didn’t take it well did he?”

“He wanted to kill you Catra… when the battle against Horde Prime’s troops ended… he wanted to do it in front of us… he didn’t care we were there… he just wanted-”

“Revenge…” Catra concluded, her head hanging low.

“And then… Adora stood between you and him… I-I was terrified… I couldn’t even move a muscle but as soon as the king set his gaze upon you… she just… had this fire in her eyes!” Scorpia couldn’t refrain from smiling. “That was when Shadow Weaver told her to move aside… to let the king…”

Catra despised herself from almost letting a whimper escape her lips.

“What? Surprised she’d let you die? You were really gonna cry over it?”

That voice needed to shut up…

“But Adora didn’t move an inch! She said, and I quote, ‘you were just an old, bitter, sad, old woman taking it out on a child’. Gosh, it was awesome! I've never seen anyone but you stand up to her..."

Scorpia enthusiastic grin faded as she saw Catra's conflicted expression. "Listen, I know what you think of Adora, but... I don't think she sees you as your pet... or that she wants to protect you so that she can be the hero."

"Doesn't matter... I need to do this alone." Catra muttered, she didn't sound convinced by the slightest.

"All I'm saying is... let people who love you help you Wildcat... that's true strenght..."

Catra didn't answer, she just kept her gaze fixed on the horizon. It was strange, the Whispering Woods seemed more… open… as if a path towards their destination had been created by someone who was secretly aiding them. And soon enough, both the scorpion princess and the former second in command began to notice an opening. As the trees grew scattered, the Fright Zone grew nearer and nearer. The Woods had let them through. Catra would have never believed that it happened because of some "purity of one's intentions" nonsense... they must have simply taken the right way... yeah... that was it.

"Catra…" Scorpia's worried tone interrupted her train of thoughts.

"Scorpia? What's wrong?"

But the scorpion princess didn't answer, she simply pointed a pincer towards the sky, right above their heads. Catra raised her gaze and found herself unable to breathe. The three ships were massive. Gargantuan black shapes obscuring the sky, their forms emerging from above the woods and almost reaching the Fright Zone without being completely in sight.

Catra thought they would have had more time.

Seems even time wouldn't have been on their side.

"Screw time… I can do this… throw at me everything you've got… it won't matter." Catra thought, her eyes never the leaving the ships, but not showing an ounce of fear.

Chapter End Notes

Sadly… here we are… at the end of the bomb… but still! I hope this chapter was worth the wait! Let me know in the comments and as always, I'll see you in the next one! Pssst… heartbreaking moment incoming...

Author's note: Finally, some new chapters!

Hi guys! Yes, I'm alive! Everything is going alright and soon enough I'll be able to move freely not only through my town, but possibly even between towns! The infections have gone down a lot, and things are finally starting to look brighter! I couldn't be happier about it, and I also couldn't be happier to tell you that five new chapters are coming! Chapter XX: Going Back will come out tomorrow, Chapter XXI: The Message on April the 28th, Chapter XXII: Someone To Fight For on April the 30th, Chapter XXIII: A Real Hero on May the 2nd and Chapter XXIV: One More Promise on May the 4th (be with you, hehe). So I hope you're ready, I apologize for the wait and I hope that what I've written will be worth it! See you tomorrow!

Going Back

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Fright Zone had certainly seen better days. After Catra and Hordak's fight, multiple sectors had been reduced to nothing more than flaming debris. Hordak's weapon had proven worthless against the feline's agility, but for what concerned the Fright Zone, it had done more damage than the cat girl could have ever imagined. As soon as the former Horde commander and the scorpion princess entered the zone's borders, small, scattered group of soldiers came into view. Some of them were laying on the ground with other tending at their wounds.

Some of them were crying…

Some of them weren't moving…

Scorpia stopped the skiff in front of the nearest building, jumping off alongside Catra. The feline looked… absent…

"Catra?" Scorpia's voice caught her attention.

The scorpion princess gave her a concerned look. Catra didn't look angry, just like the many times she felt disappointed in her subordinates' doing. She didn't look indifferent… she looked… scared.

"It's nothing." Catra answered curtly.

"It's not your fault…" Scorpia tried to reassure her.

Catra sighed heavily and after a few moments… she gave the scorpion princess a weak smile.

"Yeah, it is. I thought I was above the consequences, above them," Catra nodded towards the soldiers around them, "But the truth is… the truth is that I'm not that kind of person. I thought it would mean that I was truly strong… but instead it made me just as bad as Shadow Weaver."

"You're nothing like her!" Scorpia yelled, placing her pincers on the cat girl's shoulders.

"I chose to banish Entrapta, I chose to lie to Hordak, I chose to fight him and cause this destruction… I chose to drive you away and… and I… I chose to stay when Adora…" Catra closed her eyes and pinched the bridge of her nose, a silent 'damn it' leaving her lips.

"Catra… I…" The scorpion princess began to speak but decided to stay silent as Catra's expression began to chance.

She remained in silence as the fear she saw on Catra's face slowly left place to calm, and something that gave Scorpia the impression that the cat girl had finally managed to find some kind of peace.

"But I'm going to do what I can to fix this… all of this…"

"Oh… Wildcat…" Scorpia's voice cracked, as tears started to pool in her eyes. She took a step forwards and enveloped Catra in a tight hug. "I'm going to be with you every step of the way."

"Scorpia! Personal space!" Catra tried to sound angry but couldn't refrain herself from letting a small smile appear on her face.

The two began to make their way towards the entrance to nearest sector. A few soldiers who had noticed them approaching, immediately stood up straight and saluted Catra. The feline however didn't answer with her usual condescending smile. That seemed to shock the guards.

“How’s the situation?” Catra questioned one of them.

“A-ah! Sector X and W have suffered the worst damage. The survivors have been transported to the infirmaries. The ones who didn’t make it…” The first soldier stopped talking, a lump forming in his throat.

The second one placed his hand on his comrade’s shoulder and began to speak.

“Some of them are still under the debris, the ones with fatal wounds who were still alive when we got to them… they asked us to bring them here… outside… to see the sky. They didn’t want to die looking at a metal ceiling.” The guard spat the last words viciously.

A third one looked extremely concerned as his gaze quickly shifted between his comrade and Catra. He had known of guards who had been punished for far less.

“W-we know it’s not permitted b-but-” He began to speak, but fell silent as Catra shook her head.

“It’s okay… don’t worry about it.”

The three soldiers looked completely puzzled.

“Most of the sectors’ communications screens are still working, right?” Catra continued.

“Y-Yes commander!” The first soldier answered swiftly.

“Spread the word that an emergency communication is about to be transmitted.”

“B-but what about the sectors that need reparations? L-Lord Hordak won’t allow-” The third soldier meekly protested.

“Hordak isn’t a problem anymore.”

That single statement made all of the guards gasp.

“W-what?” The first soldier muttered, giving voice to his other comrades’ disbelief.

“There is no time to explain, just spread the news, now go!” Catra raised her voice and the three soldiers nodded before leaving.

Only the second one began to slow down and turned around.

“Commander? What’s coming?”

“If we’re not fast enough? Our end.” Catra answered.

When all of the soldiers had disappeared, each of them running towards a different sector, ready to communicate Catra’s warning, the feline and the scorpion princess reached for the nearest entrance that could lead them to Hordak’s sanctum. The two navigated swiftly through the maze of corridors until they finally found themselves in front of the now crumbling throne room. The door still worked though, allowing them to enter the chamber. The throne was still intact. Good. That’s all Catra needed for her plan.

“You sure about this?” Scorpia asked, but not with an insecure tone, only with an encouraging smile.

“Yeah… they need to know. Then… they’ll be able to choose for themselves.”

She needed to be quick…

She needed to save them…

She needed to-

“Catra!”

Suddenly, a voice called her name just before she could start to climb the stairs leading to the throne. As she turned around, she came face to face with a familiar dark skinned girl.

“Lonnie…” Catra whispered, both puzzled and relieved.

The way Catra said her name, took the girl by surprise. The feline had never used that tone with her.

“What happened here?!” Kyle asked in panic, emerging from behind Lonnie, Rohelio on his side.

They were alive, all three of them…

They were alive.

But Catra knew that the happiness she felt in that moment would have been short lived. She knew it the moment she heard Kyle’s question. Her ears flattened on her head and her gaze shifted downwards.

“It’s my fault.”

Lonnie’s eyes went wide, her expression turned from a surprised one, to a devasted one and finally… to an enraged one. Kyle stepped forwards and tried to place a hand on the dark skinned girl’s shoulder, however, he stopped, letting his hand hover in the air a few inches away from her as he noticed Lonnie tightening her fists. Nobody was expecting what came next. Well, Catra did, but she still chose not to react and remained still as Lonnie’s fist hit her jaw… hard… sending her to the ground.

“Catra!” Scorpia cried, before raising her pincers menacingly.

“Stay out of it Scorpia!” Catra groaned as she brought a hand to her aching jaw.

Lonnie watched in disbelief as Scopia unwillingly stepped aside. Catra didn’t move an inch, she didn’t get up, she didn’t try to fight back, she didn’t… do anything. Lonnie had expected the feline to put up a fight, to deny her responsibilities, to claim she was above the consequences of her actions… but she didn’t. Catra was simply waiting for what would have come next.

For a moment, Lonnie was stunned. She remained silent, staring at the cat girl in the eyes. Her hesitation, however, was short lived. Soon enough, her confusion vanished leaving space to a deep, burning anger. Lonnie scowled as she kneeled down and grabbed Catra by the hem of her uniform, roughly lifting her up as she balled her other hand into a fist.

"People are dead Catra! Dead! Do you understand that?! Or do you simply not care?!"

"Lonnie… maybe we should-" Kyle stuttered as she stepped forwards but immediately shut up as Lonnie turned halfway towards him and snarled.

"No! I'm sick of her treating everyone like dirt! We're-"

"I'm sorry."

The statement alone brought such a silence upon the small group, as if no one, expect of course for Scorpia, couldn't believe that those words had just been spoken by Catra. It made Lonnie's rageful scowl disappear, and as she looked straight into the feline's eyes, it was as if she was looking at a completely different person. But as soon as their gazes crossed, Lonnie knew… Catra was sincere.

Slowly, the soldier slowly lowered her fist…

"Sorry is not going to fix this…"

"I know, that's why I'm here." Catra muttered, her tone slightly shaking.

Lonnie and the cat girl stared at each other for a few moments before the soldier let go of the hem of her uniform and stood up. Then… Lonnie extended her hand towards Catra. The feline hesitated for an instant before reaching out and grabbing it. Lonnie raised her from the ground but didn't let go of her hand, not before she gave her a meaningful look.

Catra knew exactly what it meant.

'You better do everything you can to fix this.'

"So, what's your plan?" Lonnie asked.

"You saw the ships, didn't you?"

"Y-yes! We were in the woods and-" Kyle began to explain before being interrupted.

"In the woods?" Scorpia raised a brow in confusion.

"U-Uhm… you see…" Kyle fidgeted with his fingers, giving Catra a nervous glance.

"We left." Lonnie stated without an ounce of fear.

The statement didn't anger Catra, it was just another slap to her face, waking her up, making her realized even more what kind of person she had been in the past.

…

"They left because of you…" The voice inside Catra's head spoke again, although this time… it seemed quieter.

And it only got even more quiet as she shook her head. She was going to fix this.

"I don't blame you." The feline muttered, her voice laced with shame.

Surprise flashed in Lonnie's eyes. It only lasted a few instants before her stern expression came back, but Catra had still managed to notice it and… strangely… it made her feel better.

It made her feel proud…

Proud of herself…

When was the last time she felt like that? Was there… was there even a time when she truly felt proud of herself?

"When we saw the ships, we knew something was wrong… Catra? What's happening?" Lonnie asked.

"Just know that it's bad… for all of the Horde. If we don't get everyone out of here as soon as possible… well… you can consider all of them as already dead."

"W-what?!" Kyle stuttered in fear, followed by a surprised growl from Rogelio.

"There's no time, I gotta warn all of the Horde about Prime's arrival!" Catra explained swiftly.

Lonnie nodded curtly. She didn't understand what was happening, she didn't know who this 'Prime' was, but from what Catra had just told them, whoever or whatever was coming… wasn't going to do any good to the Horde. The three former Horde soldiers and the scorpion princess quickly followed the feline up the stairs that lead to Hordak's old throne. Step after step, the iron chair became nearer and nearer and when Catra found herself right in front of it… she didn't attempt to sit down… she remained silent… still.

"I wanted it." Catra thought. *"This should have all been mine. Hordak was weak, he should have never had ruled over the Horde! I would have made the Horde the greatest force on all of Etheria! They would have all respected me! They would… they would have all feared me…"*

They would have all feared me…

In front of what Catra had always thought she desired, she hesitated. She had wanted this, but now? That throne was simply who she was before.

Never again.

She quickly sat down, unlocking a small hatch on the throne’s armrest. She had seen Hordak do that before, it was easy, the only problem was… was the device still working? Catra held her breath and pressed the small button hidden underneath the hatch. A few seconds passed and then…

A larger hatch opened on the ceiling above the small group and a screen descended towards them, stopping right in front of Catra. It flashed red, displaying only a few words…

Vocal recognition required.

Damn it.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! So, here I am with the first of the new five chapters! I hope you've liked this one and the story so far. Remember, the next one will come out on the 28th! Let me know what you think about this chapter in the comments and I'll see you… in two days! Bye!

The Message

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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Vocal recognition required.

Damn it.

“Catra?” Scorpia muttered, a hint of worry in her voice.

“Let me think…” Catra whispered.

There had to be a way to-

Suddenly, a small creature jumped on Scorpia’s shoulder, making the princess release a small yelp.

“Is that…” Lonnie wondered, taking a step closer.

“Hordak’s little monster, yeah.” Catra groaned loudly .

She didn’t have time to deal with the little imp. She needed to find a way to access Hordak’s communication device! But to do that she would have needed his voice! But how could she do that?! Hordak had been imprisoned in Bright Moon and there was no time to go and get him…

“Think… come on, think!” Catra muttered under her breath before a loud screech caught her attention. “Would you make that thing shut up?!”

“Uhm… I kiiiinda don’t want to upset the little devil who’s currently standing on my shoulder, if that’s okay with you.” Scorpia answered nervously, a bead of sweat rolling down her forehead.

“I don’t care! We have to find a way to-” The cat girl growled before stopping abruptly.

Who said they needed Hordak?

They only needed his voice…

A voice that could be imitated…

“Come closer Scorpia.” Catra beckoned the scorpion princess.

"O-Okay, moving veeery slowly…"

"Hey, little guy, say something with Hordak's voice, come on!" Catra tried to communicate with the small imp.

The only answer Catra got was a sound that seemed to resemble a snort… the creature crossed its arms and looked away. Did that little imp just act as if… as if it was offended?! She had no time for that!

"Listen you-" Catra abruptly stood up, making the imp shriek in fear.

The creature made itself look smaller on the scorpion princess' shoulder, curling into a shivering ball. Catra stopped in her tracks and closed her eyes. It was true, she had no time for all of this, but she knew that if she kept acting like that she wouldn't have solved anything.

"Rethink your approach. Come on. Think of something stupid… something kind… something Scorpia would do… something Adora would do…" Catra thought before staring right at the creature.

"Listen, I know that you're Hordak's p… Hordak's friend and you're angry because of our fight… but right now all of the Horde is in danger. They could all die, okay? This could be the end for a lot of people who don't deserve it, and the only way to warn them all in time is this, and it won't work without Hordak's voice. So… please… can you speak? Then we'll go away, I'll bring you to Hordak if you want."

The small creature titled its head as if it was suddenly very interested.

"And, Entrapta will be there too, if that's even something you care ab-"

Catra didn't have time to finish her sentence. The small imp jumped off Scorpia's shoulder and flew above the small group, chanting the scientist princess' name loudly.

“Entrapta! Entrapta! Entrapta!”

The screen flashed green.

Voice confirmed, welcome back Lord Hordak.

The small imp flew down and perched on Scorpia’s shoulder and finally… the screen lit up, displaying Catra’s face. She was going to go live in a few seconds. She was going to speak to the entire Horde in a few seconds. She was going to tell all of them the truth of what happened in a few seconds. Catra felt herself starting to sweat, but as soon as that terrible feeling of dread caught hold of her, it immediately dissipated as Scorpia laid a pincer on her shoulder, giving her an encouraging smile. Rogelio, Kyle and believe or not, even Lonnie, did the same.

She could do this…

She was ready…

Communication beginning in three…

Two…

One…

The communication started. Thousands of soldiers, frightened and confused had gathered around the Fright Zone’s still functioning communication screens… and waited. They waited for Catra to speak. They waited for someone to give them directions, to explain what was happening… maybe even to give them a few words of comfort.

Catra gulped and gave the small group beyond the screen one last look.

She could do this.

They were there for her.

“Soldiers of-” Catra stopped as soon as she began, those were not the ones she wanted to talk to. She took a deep breath and started again.

“People… people of the Horde… I’m sorry, but I’m going to say is not going to give you much comfort. I wish I had better words, to lift up your spirits but… the truth is that I can only tell you the truth. What happened to the Fright Zone… happened because of me.”

She was going to tell them, she was finally going to tell the truth, and there was no turning back now.

“Months ago, princess Entrapta found out that activating a portal could have destroyed us all, but I didn’t listen to her. I banished her on Beast Island before Hordak could learn about her discovery and lied to him about it. I told him Entrapta had betrayed him… had betrayed us… but the truth is that I’m the one who betrayed all of you. Hordak found out the truth and in his attempt to kill me… he caused the mayhem you now see around yourselves.” Catra paused for a few moments.

There it was, the truth had finally been revealed. It was the time to give them a choice, a choice that only now the people of the Horde could truly make.

“I know you have no reason to trust me… but believe me… all that is coming towards us right now… those black ships… they carry nothing but more death and suffering. Horde Prime has found out about Etheria, he is the supreme leader of the Horde, and he won’t stop until Etheria and all of the universe is under his control. But… do not think he’ll be a kind leader. I saw him erase Hordak’s mind because of his ambition… and I heard him planning to do the same with every man… woman or child that he’ll find here. I know many of you won’t believe me, but trust me… with Horde Prime there is no future… for any of us. It may seem hopeless, to fight someone like him, but it’s either that or living the rest of our lives as his puppets. I choose to fight… if you do

the same… then meet me at the Whispering Woods' borders." Catra took a deep breath.

She could have ended the transmission right then and there, but there was something else she wanted to tell to the people who were listening. She took a deep, almost shaky breath and spoke once more.

"I once chose the road that I believed would give me power, I chose the road the Horde had shown us… and trust me, it's the loneliest you'll ever walk. Don't make my same mistake."

Catra pressed the button on the throne's armrest, and the screen faded to black.

It was then that another powerful explosion shook the chamber.

"We must go!" Lonnie shouted.

The small group quickly descended the staircase that lead to Hordak's throne and rushed outside the chamber. They rushed through the maze of corridors, trying to reach the nearest exit. Hordak's weapon had done more damage than what they had first thought. Flames had began to spread everywhere… but… no one seemed to be around anymore. Could it be that… but Catra didn't have time to think about that.

The feline had barely the time to dodge backwards as a pile of rubble came crashing down from the ceiling. She fell to the ground, grunting in pain as her back his the metallic floor. She opened her eyes, shaking her head to clear the dizziness and stood up.

"Catra! Catra, are you alright?!" Scorpia called her.

Good… she was fine…

Scorpia was fine…

The only problem was that… the debris had separated Catra from the rest of the group.

"I'm fine!" The cat girl answered.

"Stand aside! I'll clear a passage!" Scorpia spoke frantically.

"No!" Catra screamed, effectively stopping the scorpion princess. "If you use your powers, everything could come crashing down on our heads! Just go! I'll find another exit!"

"B-but Catra-"

"You heard her! She'll find another exit, but we have to go!" Lonnie shouted.

Catra heard the small group run away. At least they would be safe. She turned around and started to rush through the nearly collapsed sector's corridors, her eyes darting everywhere to find even the slightest chance of escaping… and then… when Catra begin to think that the Fright Zone might have truly become her tomb… a few metallic panels shattered and fell from the ceiling, revealing a darkened sky.

It wouldn't have been hard to reach the hole, not for her… and Catra would have done it in an instant… if it only wasn't for a voice that caught her attention a moment before she could make her escape.

"L-let me go! Let me go!"

It was a child's voice.

"Just go! Save yourself! Go!" The voice inside Catra's head screamed.

Catra didn't listen. She ran away from what could have possibly been her last chance to escape and quickly searched for the source of the voice. Her eyes darted everywhere as the screams

got louder and louder. Where was this child?! And why was she even risking her life for someone she didn't even know?!

A part of Catra didn't really understand the meaning of her actions, but still, she kept moving. She ran and ran until she found herself in front of the broken gates of a training room. She slipped inside, careful not to be noticed… and Catra finally saw her.

At the center of the training chamber stood a girl… probably nine or ten years old… with caramel brown skin and curly, black hair that reached her shoulders. The feline's eyes however, did not widen because of the girl, but because of the two figures standing near to her.

Prime clones…

They were already in the Fright Zone…

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! I hope you've enjoyed this chapter as much as I enjoyed writing it. I really wanted to show how Catra is actually changing not only in her ways of acting, but also in her ways of thinking. Remember, the next chapter will come out on April 30, and our favorite feline will have to face the most hard, brutal fight of her entire life… and soon after… a heart breaking moment will follow. Be prepared...

Someone To Fight For

Chapter Notes

DON'T TOUCH THE CHILD!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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Prime clones…

They were already in the Fright Zone…

Of course they were, how could she have outran those freaking spaceships?

"Let me go!" The child screamed in rage.

One of the clones was holding her arm, a blank expression on her face. The other one began to reach out in order to grab the other… but the child seemed to have no intention to let that happen. She placed her foot on the leg armor of the clone which was holding her, jumped upwards and kicked the other one in the head. The clone crashed to the ground, unmoving. The other clone's eyes widened a bit.

"Serves you right…" Catra snickered quietly.

The young girl turned towards the other Prime guard and tried to kick him in the stomach. Unfortunately, as she raised her leg, the clone caught it with his free hand and raised the child above his head before slamming her to the ground.

The kid cried in pain.

"That will teach you how to behave properly." The clone snarled.

That will teach you how to behave properly…

Catra remembered those words… she had heard them countless times when Shadow Weaver had tried to 'teach her some manners'. She remembered the old hag hissing those words as she threw her against walls, as she used her magic to make her unable to breathe… unable to see…

Catra saw red. She rushed towards the clone, jumped on his shoulders and propelled herself into the air, before coming down and hitting the Prime guard's head with her heel as hard as she could. The feline heard a cracking sound, and the clone reached his companion on the ground. Catra stared at the two unmoving bodies for a few moments before she kneeled next to the kid. She had her eyes closed.

“Please… just let her be okay…” Catra found herself thinking.

The feline gently raised her head and released a sigh of relief she hadn’t noticed she was holding as the kid groaned and opened her eyes.

“C-Commander?” The kid croaked before grunting and sitting up.

She held her head for a second, shutting her eyes tight before opening them again. When she realized who was crouched beside her, her eyes widened, and she shot up.

“Commander Catra! I-” The kid quickly raised her arm, trying to salute Catra, but just a second after she doubled over in pain, clutching her side.

Catra put her hands on the kid’s shoulders, shaking her head.

“Hey, there’s no need for that, okay? What’s your name?” The feline asked.

“Ivy… my name’s Ivy…” The young girl said before quickly adding, “C-Commander!”

“Well, mine’s Catra, so just call me that, okay?”

“Uhm… okay…” Ivy replied somewhat timidly.

“Did you hear my message on the communication screens?” Catra asked.

“N-no… I was in the barracks with the other cadets a-and suddenly a lot of people were running everywhere! I-I thought it was just an exercitation, so I just followed my regular t-training program… and when I got here… I started to see the fires a-and t-those monsters a-and I-” Ivy started to ramble, her breathing getting quicker.

“Hey, hey, kid… look at me.” Catra cupped her cheek and raised the child’s face.

The kid was shaking… and Catra was the only person who could be there for her in that moment. "What can I do… what can I do to make it better?!" The feline screamed internally. She wasn't good at this, the whole comforting people thing… she had terrorized them her all life. But making it better for a terrorized kid? Making her feel better? How could she even-

"Catra?"

"Go away…"

"Are you okay?"

"Go away!"

…

…

…

"Can I sit with you?"

…

"Whatever…"

"Catra… please, tell me what happened…"

"She hurt me okay?! Like she always does!"

"W-why?"

"Because a few kids were laughing at my ears! So I shut them up, and when they ran crying to Shadow Weaver, she… she hit me…"

"Catra…"

"J-just go, it'll pass."

"I'm proud of you."

"W-what?"

"You stood up to those bullies, it took courage… you're very brave… I'm proud of you Catra."

…

"… thanks…"

"Where does it hurt?"

"Here…"

"Let me take a look."

The whole memory flashed before Catra's eyes in an instant. The truth was that… she did have a person who had been there for her. A really dumb one, who did not understand how Catra truly needed her to be there for her… but she tried, and sometimes she did make things better.

"They're gone, okay? Those monsters are gone… you took one out as if it was nothing! That took guts. I've never seen a cadet fight like you. You're…" Catra hesitated for a moment, staring into Ivy's eyes, noticing the way she was looking at her, both curious and amazed.

"You really wanna give her what you never got? Why should she deserve it? Why her and not you? Why should you give it to her?!" The voice inside Catra's head spoke venomously.

…

"Because I'm not Shadow Weaver."

…

"You're strong Ivy… I'm… I'm proud of you." Catra spoke kindly, the warmth of her voice surprising not only Ivy, but the feline herself.

“T-thank you Comm… thank you Catra.” Ivy replied, her voice barely above a whisper.

“Now, let’s get out of here, okay? More of those monsters are coming… we need to run.” Catra helped Ivy up.

“N-No! I can fight! We can fight them together!” Ivy raised her fists.

Catra smirked, she liked the fire in the kid… she reminded the feline a little bit of herself. When Catra was still a kid, many other cadets were scared to fight, even in a simulation. They were scared of getting hurt… but not Catra. She wanted to fight, she wanted to prove herself.

“As much as I’d like that, I only came here to save the Horde, not put it in danger. They’re too many, and we can’t beat them… but once we’ve escaped… I know someone who could help us.” Catra explained.

“W-who?”

“I’ll tell you later, right now we have to-”

BOOM!

Suddenly, the wall of the training room shattered. Catra threw herself to the ground, pushing Ivy down as well. Miraculously, none of the debris hit them. When the two stood up, Catra’s breath hitched.

“Well, well, well. If it isn’t my little brother’s most trusted commander…”

The somewhat elegant voice sent chills down the feline’s spine.

Horde Prime…

She didn’t think he would actually come to the Fright Zone. But there he was, standing right in front of Catra, a malicious grin

plastered on his face. A dozen of clones quickly reached his side, surrounding the tyrant and raising their rifles towards the former Horde commander.

"Ivy, listen to me… you have to run, okay?" Catra muttered, her eyes never leaving Prime's ones.

"N-no! I can help you! I-"

"This isn't training kid, these guys are not going to stop if you fall to the ground, and I'm not planning on making you die here. Go."

"B-but I-" Ivy protested.

Freaking, stubborn kid!

"I'm not asking you, cadet! Reach the woods' edge and wait for me there! That's an order!" Catra didn't really want to play the 'commander' card, she found out that she couldn't care less now, but if it was the only way to save the kid… well…

Ivy took a small step back, frowning slightly. She looked at Catra one last time before turning on her heels and rushing towards the training room's exit. The feline put herself in the line of fire, but the clones didn't seem to care about the small girl. Their rifles remained pointed on Catra.

"You're going to make them shoot me?" Catra spoke mockingly, a condescending grin growing on her lips.

Horde Prime didn't seem to like the insinuation, his smile wavered for a second before he recomposed himself. The tyrant chuckled darkly.

"No, I was thinking of having my soldiers put up a little bit of a show for me. Most of the people I encountered on my way in immediately kneeled, the others… well…" Horde Prime's grin grew more sinister.

He was going to pay…

“This place hasn’t offered anything but boredom to me… so no, I won’t make my sentinels shoot you.” Prime gaze shifted from Catra to his clones. “Drop your rifles, do this barehanded. I want to see nothing more than a bloody pulp smeared on the floor when you’re done.”

The clones immediately dropped their rifles and rushed towards Catra. Not one second to think, not one second to prepare herself, to study her surroundings. Twelve against one.

It was going to be fun.

Chapter End Notes

> Mmmmmmmm… we've finally come to the fight, in a couple of days I'll publish the next chapter, and Catra will have to face not one but twelve Hordarks… who knows how it will all end… well, it won't be the whole fanfiction's end, because after this bomb I've planned another one of five or maybe six chapters that will bring this story to its conclusion, but still! It will be awesome… or maybe heartbreaking… who knows...

A Real Hero

Chapter Notes

> Hey guys, quick warning. The fight will be a little bit gruesome, not "Doom Guy's glory kills" gruesome, but let's say "Brienne vs The Hound" gruesome. You've been warned!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The clones didn't hesitate. The first threw a punch to the feline's face. Easy, predictable. Catra dodged his blow and hit him with all of her strength under the jaw. The uppercut made the clone stumble backwards, bumping into two others. Catra ran, jumped, planted her right foot on the first Prime guard's chest plate and propelled herself into the air. She kicked both of the clones he had bumped into in the head, before coming down, her elbow colliding with the top of his head. The trio fell to the ground.

Nine more…

That's when the first punch hit her, right in her left cheek. When Catra was younger, the other cadet's blows never truly hurt, not that much. Shadow Weaver's… punishments… those hurt in a different way. Adora's hits? Now that Catra thought about it, she always felt like she had never truly put all of her strength in those… not when the blonde faced her… but the clone's punch? It hurt… it truly hurt…

The iron gauntlet collided with her cheek and sent her stumbling back. The clone didn't relent, he just closed the distance that separated him from his objective and threw another punch. Catra dodged it, lowered herself, swiped at his legs and made him fall to the ground before jumping on his chest and hitting him a few, quick placed punches to his head.

She screamed in pain as the point of another clone's boot hit her straight in the stomach. The clone she had just punched however… didn't stand up. But three more were towering over her as she opened her eyes. The first stomped his foot down, trying to crash her chest underneath it, but failed miserably as the feline rolled to the side. The second one tried to grab her. Catra planted her claws in his gauntlet, pulled herself up, kicked the first clone right in the face before slashing the third one right across his eyes.

The first Prime guard fell on the floor, the third one screamed before collapsing to his knees, while the second one, with Catra's claws still inside his arm, tried to punch her. The feline grabbed his fist, kneed him in his stomach, making him double over in pain, before hitting the side of his head with her elbow, as hard as she could.

Five more clones… just five more…

The first punched her in the sternum, and Catra felt herself lose her breath. The second one kicked the back of her knee, making her fall to the ground. She tried to stand up, and the third one kicked her right in her back, sanding her crushing down to the floor. The remaining two kneeled down and held her by her arms. Catra screamed in rage, pulling with all of her might, but they didn't let go. The three clones who towered above her began to kick her. Again, again and again.

"Do something! They are going to kill you! They're going to kill you and then they'll kill everyone else! Do something!"

Catra raised her left leg and threw a blind hit. Her knee collided with the chest of one of the two clones who were holding her. Her left arm was suddenly free. She rolled to the side and slashed the remaining clone who was holding her down across his face. He let go and fell to the ground. Finally… she was free to stand up again. The clone she had just hit in the chest tried to raise himself from the floor but Catra moved quicker and kicked him in the head.

Three more. Just hold on.

The first clone threw a kick at her. Catra grabbed his leg and roared in anger as she pulled him down to the floor. The second one grabbed her from behind and the third didn't hesitate for one second. He hit Catra across the face. The feline's vision was getting blurry, and she was tasting copper in her mouth. But she wasn't going to let a bunch of "Hordaks" take her down. She pushed back against the clone who was holding her, raised her feet from the floor and kicked the third clone in the chest.

Catra saw the one she had pulled down by his leg starting to get up. She had to act quickly. She bit down on the arm of the clone who was holding as hard as she could. The Prime guard yelled in pain and let go. Catra turned around, grabbed the sides of his head and headbutted him. Not really one of the quickest or more 'energy saving' moves she had ever come up with, but she was truly starting to get pissed off.

The clone Catra had pulled to the floor tried to grab her from behind, but the feline saw him coming. She grabbed his arms and sent him to ground. Both of the clones who had just attacked her laid in front of her, unmoving.

One mo-

The kick in her lower back sent her to the floor. Tears prickled in her eyes. That really hurt… and Catra felt like she wouldn't have been able to stand up even if she tried with every little bit of strength she had left. She rolled onto her back only to see the clone kneel on top of her. He grabbed her neck with one hand, while he balled the other into a fist.

"Don't let him win! Shadow Weaver always tried to make you behave like a human being… be a beast! Destroy them!"

Catra screamed in pure rage before she pushed down her chin, managing to put it between the clone's hand and her neck. She bit his thumb and ripped it off. The Prime guard held his bleeding

hand as he cried in pain. But Catra wasn't done with him. She was seeing red, so the feline grabbed the sides of the clone's head, pulled herself up and sank her teeth into his neck before ripping out a piece of white flesh.

Catra spat it to the ground, pushing the clone aside. The Prime guard fell beside her, holding his neck for a few moments before going lump. She wanted to stand up but fell to her knees the moment she tried. She wasn't seeing well, everything was blurry, and her body hurt… it hurt everywhere. But as Catra looked around, she saw what she had just accomplished.

Twelve Prime's clones…

She had defeated them all…

And even if for a moment… even Horde Prime seemed impressed.

"Is this… everything you've got?" Catra breathed heavily, a crooked, trembling yet smug grin growing on her face.

Horde Prime's disbelief soon faded as he began to lowly cackle. He walked up to the former Horde Commander, his arms crossed behind his back.

"Your arrogance has brought you far in life, that I can say… but it won't bring you farther." Horde Prime spoke as he slowly reached for Catra's neck, circling it with one hand and raising the feline from the ground into the air.

"The great Horde Prime is finally ready to get his own hands dirty? Are you sure you don't want another dozen of your clones to beat me up some more before you try that? Might just make things even easier for you." Catra laughed.

She wasn't scared…

She wasn't begging for her life…

She was still disrespecting him…

Prime didn't like it one bit. His smirk faded, replaced by an angered scowl. He balled his free hand into a fist and hit Catra in the stomach, making her fly five meters in the air before she crushed down to the ground. She heard Prime's steps becoming distant for a moment, before he came back with something in his hands. As he towered over her, Catra's gaze fell upon his weapon. It looked like a crossbow, a big, white, metallic crossbow that the tyrant secured to his right arm before pointing it towards her face. The feline thought he would have fired it, but Prime hesitated, humming thoughtfully.

"I might just start with something else… after all… if I'd hit you in the head, everything would end in an instant. Let's say… I'll shoot you a dozen times before I give you my permission to die, Commander. That seems only fair counting the number of soldiers you took from me, am I not right?" Prime asked, hoping that the threat would at least make a spark of fear appear in the feline's eyes.

In response, Catra spat at him.

Horde Prime's eyes widened as the mixture of red and green blood dripped from his forehead.

"I'm going to use my crossbow to blow off your legs, then it'll be the turn of your arms. I'll make you suffer so much that you're going to pray me for your death!" Horde Prime screamed in rage, pointing his crossbow at Catra's left knee.

They were safe. Scorpia, Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Ivy… the people of the Horde whom she hoped had listened to her message… she wouldn't have seen them again… but they would have been alright. Catra closed her eyes and let her mind drift elsewhere.

"I don't want to go…"

"They won't say anything about your ears… or your tail… or anything else that makes you special."

"Ugh… special… it's starting to sound as if it's something bad."

"Not to me… never to me."

"Stop being cheesy."

"Nope, I know you love it."

"Yeah, yeah, I love it sooooo much."

…

"So… are you ready?"

Underneath her eyelids, she noticed the darkness getting brighter. She knew it would have hurt… more than anything else, but somehow… it didn't bother her… because everything she truly cared about was safe. It was a strange sensation, really. One that Catra didn't fully understand and yet choose to feel. She always thought she would have only cared about herself, about her objective, and that nothing would have ever mattered more than that.

She was wrong.

Now she knew.

Catra smiled.

"Yeah, I'm ready princess."

The darkness became brighter and then…

Steps…

They resonated through the training chamber, loud and quick. She had expected Horde Prime to fire his weapon at any second now, but when Catra heard those steps, she opened her eyes, and saw her… a flash of blonde and suddenly… Horde Prime grunted in pain as he stumbled back and fell to the ground. He hadn't been quick enough, and the figure had caught in by surprise, hitting him in the back.

“Catra?”

She knew that voice…

Catra blinked a few times, trying to shake away the blurriness. Blonde hair… blue eyes.

“A-Adora?” Catra muttered.

“Yes, yes! I’m here Catra, I-”

“W-why did you come?! I-I told you to stay away!” Catra tried to yell, but her voice came out as barely more audible than a whisper.

“And how could I?! I couldn’t leave you, not again…” Adora’s voice began to crack as her eyes roamed her ex best friend’s injuries.

“Adora…”

“Don’t trust her! She’s here only to be the hero again!” The voice inside Catra’s head screamed.

And yet… somehow… Catra knew… it wasn’t true. She could see it in Adora’s eyes.

“Y-you need to run away, Prime… he’s-” Catra tried to warn her.

“So, the Grayskull’s descendant interrupts us once again… but this time… she’s alone…” Horde Prime chuckled darkly as he stood up.

Catra’s eyes widened, she lifted her head, noticing how behind Adora… there was no one to be seen. Did the idiot come alone?!

“A-Adora?! W-where are the others?!” She asked in a panicked tone of voice.

“W-we got separated in the corridors!”

“No… no, no, no! G-get out of here!”

“I won’t leave you!” Adora declared, standing up and putting herself between the wounded feline and the tyrant.

She didn’t have her sword… just one made for Bright Moon’s soldiers, and a round shield. Adora didn’t have She-ra with her this time, but it didn’t matter. She would have never left Catra again.

“Please… Adora… this doesn’t have to end like this.” Horde Prime lowered his crossbow, extending his free hand towards the blonde. “Don’t you want to go back to your family?”

Adora trembled slightly.

“You’re trying to trick me.” Adora hissed between gritted teeth.

“On the contrary. When my brother stole you from your family… it broke them. Your father, King Randor, and your mother, Queen Marlena… oh, they did everything in their power to find you. They sent scouts to the farthest places of the universe… even your brother Adam looked for you for years… but how could they find you? You’ve been isolated in Despondos for so long, unable to reach them, unable to reunite with your true family. But you still can. Come with me, leave your past behind… leave this beast to die and I’ll grant you your most intimate desire… to finally find out who you truly are.”

And for a moment, just for a single instant… Adora thought of how everything would have turned out if she had left everything behind. She would have finally been able to embrace her family again. And what would have happened if she stayed? She could have died, and she would have never found out who she truly was…

Who she truly was…

Adora’s gaze fell upon Catra. Their eyes locked. The feline looked confused and… scared. She must have noticed Adora’s hesitation, how the blonde had held her breath as Horde Prime spoke to her about a family that Catra didn’t know anything about.

"See? She has a true family she can get back to… do you really think she'd turn that down… for you?" The voice inside Catra's head cackled darkly.

"Who I truly am…" Adora muttered.

"Yes… don't you want to know?" Prime pressed on, a sickening grin plastered on his face.

Adora looked down upon Catra…

And smiled…

"I know who I am." Adora raised her gaze, her blue eyes locking with Prime's green ones, now filled with disbelief. "I am Adora, a girl who has been stolen from a family that one day I'll meet again, but not today. I am a soldier who fought for the wrong side, but who's finally doing the right thing… and I'm a friend… who won't leave behind those who she loves."

"And so… you've chosen the path of pain. A shame, really. But don't worry, I'll bring your head to your family once we're done, so you can be finally reunited."

Prime raised his crossbow. Adora took her stand. She knew she could have easily dodged the blast. She remembered when the tyrant used his weapon on his space station. It would have taken a few seconds to charge. She would have been faster. But then… the tyrant's smile grew more sinister. He shifted his aim… pointing his crossbow right at Catra…

She would have never been able to avoid the hit…

"Catra!"

Adora crouched down in front of Catra and raised her shield.

"Adora! No!"

Horde Prime fired his weapon.

The incandescent, white ball of pure energy traveled across the air and met its target.

Catra felt Adora's body collide with her own, and the two got thrown a few meters backwards.

"Ugh…" Catra groaned, slightly pushing Adora, as to give the blonde a hint to move.

But Adora didn't move an inch…

When the feline raised her head… her face lost every trace of color and her eyes widened in horror. Adora's shield laid shattered in pieces on the ground. Horde Prime's shot had pierced it… but the broken shield wasn't what Catra had been staring at.

…

The shot had pierced Adora's chest.

Chapter End Notes

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One More Promise

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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"A-Adora? No… no, no, no! Adora!" Catra cried, groaning in pain as she shifted to hold the blonde's head in her lap.

There was a time when the feline believed that the horrifying sight she was staring at would have brought her an immense satisfaction… that it would have finally filled the void the blonde had left in her heart when she went away. To think that Adora would one day pay for what she did to her, it made Catra's pain

turn into bitterness, then anger and in the end… hatred… hatred for the one she once loved the most.

But now…

The only things she felt as she held Adora between her arms were an unrelenting desperation, and a terror she had never felt in her entire life.

"C-Catra?" Adora replied weakly.

Her face was pale, her lips slightly stained with blood and her eyes… her eyes were almost closed.

"And so… another one of my enemies falls. Oh, pardon me… two of my enemies." Prime shifted his aim and pointed his crossbow at Catra.

The feline held Adora tightly, hiding her face in the blonde's hair. Once again, every hope seemed to be lost. But how could Catra feel any differently? She had never let herself have faith in others… but that day, faith would have proven her wrong. It would have proven to her that other people, the one who cared about her and Adora… would have never left them alone.

An arrow flew through the air, planting itself in Prime's armor and exploding a second after. The tyrant grunted in pain as he took a step backwards. Then, a purple sphere of light flashed in the darkness of the corridor that lead to the training room, colliding with his face. What came next was a mixture of ice, roots and water, followed by a series of red bolts. Everything hit Horde Prime square in the chest at full force, making him fall to the ground. His crossbow fired a shot towards the ceiling above him…

"Damn you!" The tyrant screamed as a pile of rubble collapsed on top of him.

Bow, Glimmer, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta and Scorpia quickly entered the training chamber.

“I bet that won’t hold him for long, come on guys! We gotta-” The scorpion princess spoke in a cheerful tone of voice, but immediately fell silent as her eyes fell upon Catra and Adora.

The feline turned towards the group, a terrorized expression on her face.

“A-Adora?” Glimmer muttered.

“Oh no…” Bow covered his mouth.

“It… it can’t be…” Perfuma muttered, her breathing uneven.

Glimmer crouched down and took Adora’s hand into her own.

“Glimmer…” The blonde muttered weakly.

“A-Adora… what did you do…” The young queen said, her voice cracking.

“Is… everyone… safe?”

“They are… they’re all okay, and you’ll be too.” Glimmer declared, wiping her tears and standing up, the fear on her face replaced by a blank expression.

“Glimmer? What are we going to do?” Frosta asked, tugging at her tunic.

“I’ll teleport everyone away. Once we reach Bright Moon, my aunt will know what to do.” The young queen explained swiftly.

“Will she be able to-” Bow began to speak but was cut off.

“Yes… yes, she will.” Glimmer said.

Everyone began to gather around the young queen, but before she could conjure her spell, Adora grabbed Catra’s wrist.

“Catra…”

“Shh, don’t waste your energies… w-we’re going to Bright Moon, okay? A-and there, Sparkle’s aunt will cure you, okay?” Catra explained, hating how her voice must have sounded so weak, but she couldn’t do anything about it.

“No… you need… to stay…”

“W-what?”

“I saw… your message. Your people needs… a guide… you need to give them… hope.”

“I… I can’t leave you now.”

“They need you… bring them to Bright Moon… I promise I’ll… be waiting for you… I promise.”

Adora smiled. Another promise made to the person she cared the most in the entire universe. One she was sure she would keep. Catra looked at her for a few, endless moments, before standing up.

“I’ll… I’ll go… I’ll bring the survivors to Bright Moon and… and you better be there to welcome me.” Catra tried her best to sound smug.

It made Adora chuckle slightly, but it soon turned into a fit of cough.

“I’ll go with you.” Scorpia took a step towards Catra, but the feline raised a hand.

“If Prime gets out of those scraps and decides to attack Bright Moon, Sparkle’s gonna need every princess on Etheria to stop him. You gotta go with them… and… do me a favor Scorpia…”

“Of course!” The scorpion princess replied quickly.

“Watch over her until I arrive… okay?”

Scorpia nodded swiftly. Catra turned towards the group of princesses, giving them a look that was both apologetic and pleading.

"All of you… please… watch over her…"

Glimmer looked at the feline for a few, long moments before nodding. Every princess did the same and as Catra turned away from the small group and began to travel through the Fright Zone's corridors to find another exit… she prayed Adora would keep her promise this time. She ran as fast as she could, dodging falling debris and looking everywhere for an exit.

And after what seemed an eternity, the feline managed to find one. The commands to open it had been engulfed by flames, and the sliding door had opened halfway. Catra jumped, passing through the crack between the door and the wall, finally finding herself in the open. She looked above and saw the sky. The smoke had caused it to turn gray, but as Catra began to make her way towards the Whispering Wood's border and took a long, deep breath… she realized… she had done it.

And as the realization hit her… that she had actually managed to survive… that despite the bruises and the pain that coursed through her whole body, she had won a battle seemingly impossible to win… she didn't notice what was waiting for her under the shadows projected by the forest's first trees.

Catra didn't think many of the Horde's people would have followed her. After all, she did admit that what happened to the Fright Zone, happened because of her. She believed that many would have risked staying and becoming Prime's new puppets rather than following the one who had betrayed them.

"No one will show up. The Horde will hate you for what you revealed to them." The voice inside Catra's head chuckled darkly.

But once again, the voice would have been proven wrong…

Because as Catra reached the first trees, her eyes widened at the sight of what had been waiting for her. Hundreds of people had gathered around the Whispering Wood's entrance, alongside a few dozens of transport vehicles and tanks.

"Catra!" A voice called her name.

Ivy made her way through the large crowd, rushing towards the feline and catching everyone's attention. The little girl stopped in front of Catra, a sigh of relief escaping her lips as she realized that the feline was fine. Internally, the cat girl did the same as she saw that the child was fine.

"Y-you won!" Ivy exclaimed excitedly, raising in the air her fists.

"Did you have any doubts?" Catra chuckled.

"Uhm… are you hurt?" The little girl asked shily.

Catra looked and felt as she had been definitely hurt. Her left cheek was swollen, she had a bleeding cut over her right eyebrow and a lot of other bruises she would have discovered the next time she'd shower. But now it wasn't the time to think about herself. She needed to reach Bright Moon… as fast as she could.

"Don't worry about me kid, I'm tough you know?" The feline flexed her bicep.

"See? I told you she'd come back!" Ivy turned towards some other Horde kids, who immediately turned red and avoided the cat girl's amused stare.

"Catra…" Another voice called her.

"Lonnie." Catra answered as she raised her gaze and noticed the dark skinned girl approaching her. "What happened to-" She began to ask, but decided to remain silent as she noticed both Kyle and Rogelio emerging from the crow and reaching her side.

“We ran into Adora and the other princesses… we told them we were headed towards the woods, just like you told us to do, and Scorpia decided to stick with them. Stubborn as always.” Lonnie paused for a moment before giving the feline a good look. Catra looked terrible. “So… you made it out alive.”

“Yeah…”

“Ivy told me what happened when we reached the woods…”

“And?” The feline asked in a cautious tone of voice.

“And it makes me think that you’ve… that you’ve really changed… or at least you’re trying.” Finally, Lonnie let her blank expression vanish and gave Catra a small, yet genuine smile.

“What are you talking about?! She’s amazing!” Ivy spoke with stars in her eyes.

Catra noticed that all the people who had been waiting near the Whispering Wood’s edge had begun to gather around her, listening to what the child was saying.

“She took down one of the monsters who was holding me! And when their boss came out, she fought twelve of them on her own to save me! And she won! She’s the strongest person in the world! No, in the entire universe!”

Catra felt her cheeks burn. This freaking brat… no one had ever made her blush like this… and now, this little girl with her simple words had managed to do it. It wasn’t that the feline didn’t like what she said, it simply made her feel something that she hadn’t felt in long time. And even if Catra didn’t immediately understand what that was, when she looked into Ivy’s eyes… she knew. She was proud of herself. The people around them were chattering, some of them had confused expressions on their faces, many were smiling, a few chuckling at the girl’s words, but not maliciously.

“Commander?” A soldier stepped forwards.

“That’s not my title anymore.” Catra answered, shaking her head.

“Uhm… I…” The man stuttered.

“She’s right.” Lonnie’s voice caught everyone’s attention. “She’s not Hordak’s second in command anymore. Every person who would have wanted to follow that Catra… they should know now that that person doesn’t exist anymore. But this one?”

The dark skinned girl put a hand on Catra’s shoulder.

“This person is the one I’ll call my leader from now on…”

Catra’s eyes grew wide at Lonnie’s statement, and her disbelief grew even more when she felt the people around her starting to chant her name, raising their fists in the air.

“Catra! Our new leader!”

“Hordak wasn’t there to save us, Catra did!”

“She saved us all! Long live our new leader!”

The Horde's new leader...

Finally a good one… in the end...

Chapter End Notes

> Hi guys! Here we are with the last chapter of this bomb! I hope you liked it, I hope you liked the story so far and I know… I know… "ARE YOU SERIOUSLY LEAVING US WITHOUT LETTING US KNOW ABOUT ADORA'S FATE?". Well, yeah. Hehehe… I'm evil, I know. However, the next time you'll here from me, you'll have the last chapters of this story! Yes, exactly, I'm planning on writing six or maybe seven more chapters that will wrap up the story and bring it to its conclusion, so stay tuned! Oh, I almost forgot… the trailer for season 5 looks amazing! I can't wait to see it and discover how it will all end! Well, the note is getting far too long, as

always I wanna thank you for all the kind comments, your appreciation is what keeps me writing, so keep that up! See you soon!

Author's note: Some new chapters!

Hi guys! Yes, the story is still alive! I'm sorry for not being active during this last month, but a lot happened. Exams, the new season… exams… but now I'm back, back with three more chapters! I know I said the next time you would have heard of me it would have been when I actually had all the remaining chapters, but I just can't wait to share what I have written with you guys! So, tomorrow chapter 25 will be published. Chapter 26 will be published in two days and 26 in four! I hope you'll like them! Oh and by the way, I absolutely loved Season 5 and the ending of the show, there are so many great moments in the season that I cannot chose one and speak about it! Best season of all and by far one of the most beautiful cartoon shows I have ever seen… mmmh, better than Steven Universe? That's a tough one, what do you say?

Drifting Away

The Horde's new leader…

Catra had always wanted it, she couldn't lie… but then, as she started to chance, Catra realized what it would have meant to become the Horde's leader… what it would have costed her… what it would have made her do. She thought the only way she could have become the leader was to be as ruthless as Hordak… she would have needed to become a monster. But now? Now, as those people chanted her name, she knew… she could be both their leader, and the person she was trying to become.

"Where will we go now?" Ivy asked, speaking for practically every other person around.

"We march on Bright Moon."

"W-what?" A few soldiers murmured.

"W-we can't defeat the Rebellion in this state!"

"The princesses are too strong!"

"They've got She-Ra, we've got only a few tanks!"

"Hey! Shut up! If we have Catra, we're gonna defeat them all!" Ivy turned around and shouted towards the crowd.

However, the small girl quickly turned around as she felt Catra's hand on her shoulder.

"We're not going there to fight them."

"W-what?" Ivy asked in confusion.

That was when a tall, burly soldier emerged from the crowd and stood right in front of Catra.

“Are you suggesting what I’m thinking… kitten?”

Catra heard a few people gasp, and to be honest, if this guy was about to begin a fight, she wasn’t really sure she would have been able to take him, not in her current state. Despite that, the feline didn’t move an inch, her bored, unimpressed expression never leaving her face.

“Siding with the Rebellion against Prime? Yeah, that’s exactly what I’m suggesting right now.”

A dreadful silence fell upon the large group surrounding Catra.

“You’re… you’re a fool!” The large soldier yelled at her face.

The feline didn’t back down, in fact, she took a step forwards, an enraged expression taking the place of her previous, bored one. Catra took satisfaction in noticing the hint of fear on the man’s face as she stepped closer.

“Tell me then, what would you do?” The cat girl asked the soldier in a mocking tone of voice.

“W-we… we can take this Prime! If we fight him together, we’ll-”

Catra didn’t let him finish.

“We’ll die… that’s what will happen.”

“You can’t know that!” The soldier shouted but decided shut his mouth as Catra grabbed the collar of his uniform.

“Oh yeah?! Then let me tell you what I know. Have you seen Prime’s army? Do you know what it’s composed of? It’s made of his clones, exact copies of Hordak. Now imagine yourself fighting against him. Do you think you could win?”

"I… I…"

"No, you wouldn't. Now imagine these people fighting against a thousand of those clones, a thousand of Hordaks… and those are the numbers a single one of those black ships can carry. When Prime imprisoned me on his station, I could see dozens of those descending towards Etheria. Now answer me, big guy, do you think we can take them?" Catra asked her final question slowly.

…

…

…

"No…" The soldier answered, his voice barely more audible than a whisper.

"Very well then. And to all of you, I don't expect you to be happy about this, but the Rebellion wants Etheria to survive, they want their people to survive… we want the same, so either we collaborate… or we all die. Make your choice." Catra declared, letting go of the tall soldier and starting to make her way towards the Whispering Woods.

After a few moments, she heard engines starting, and the sound of quick steps following her. Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio and even Ivy quickly reached her side. Lonnie was giving her a small, smug smile, as if she was actually happy that even though Catra had changed, that fire inside her never died, and it never would have.

A few soldiers began to mutter about the fact that they would have all gone lost inside the Whispering Woods, that the strange forest would have never let them go. However, soon enough, the whispers died down. To the few ones who had actually seen the Whispering Woods before, the forest looked completely different now. The woods seemed different, almost as if a clear path had been opened in front of them.

None of the Horde's people got lost during their journey towards Bright Moon.

Not with Catra leading them.

~

"What do you mean 'I can't do anything else for her'?!" Glimmer screamed in rage.

"Glimmer… please… I-I've done everything I could and-" Castaspella replied weakly.

"Dad." The young queen turned towards her father. "You must know some kind of magic to heal her, please!"

But the old king simply shook his head, lowering his gaze in both shame and sadness.

"N-no… no, no, no! P-please, anyone! T-tell me that… tell me that…" Glimmer's eyes frantically searched for someone who could help.

Everyone's gazes were set on the floor… and so was Shadow Weaver's.

"Can't… can't you do something?" Glimmer asked, her voice smaller than it had ever been.

The red witch simply shook her head.

Glimmer felt tears starting to stream down her cheeks. Adora… her best friend… was about to die. She couldn't accept it. There had to be someone or something that could have helped her! She had already lost her mother… she couldn't lose anyone else.

The young queen let out a ragged breath before she quietly opened the door to Adora's bedroom. She quickly reached the bed and knelt down beside it. Her tears grew only heavier as her gaze set upon Adora's face. It was so pale…

Glimmer gently took the blonde's hand into hers before giving it a light squeeze. Adora slightly shifted her head towards her.

"Glimmer…" She murmured.

Her voice sounded so small… so frail… but despite everything, Adora was still smiling.

"Adora… I… I don't know how to help…" Glimmer tried to hold back her sobs but couldn't prevent them from escaping her lips in the end.

"Please… don't cry." The blonde pleaded.

"And what am I supposed to do?! You're… you're…"

"I know… I knew it the moment I saved her…" Adora chuckled quietly.

"W-why… why did you have to do it?" Glimmer asked as she rubbed her thumb on the girl's hand.

"Because… I couldn't leave her a second time…"

Glimmer pressed her forehead against Adora's hand, letting herself cry as the blonde lightly passed her fingers through the young queen's pink hair. Quietly, the room filled with familiar faces. Bow, Perfuma, Frosta, Mermista, Sea Hawk, Scorpia, King Micah, Huntara, Swift Wind, Netossa and Spinnerella… and… and even Shadow Weaver. They all came around the small bed.

"Bow…" Adora smiled at the sight of the young archer.

"Adora… I… tell me what I can do, I'll do anything… please… just…" Bow rubbed his forehead as he tried to speak coherently.

“Promise me just one thing…”

“Yeah, anything!” The archer replied immediately.

“Watch over Glimmer… be there for her… just like you’ve always done.” Adora asked.

Bow could only nod in response, his hand above his mouth as if to hold back a sob. The blonde slowly moved her head and looked over the princesses. Frosta was clinging to Perfuma’s vest, while Mermista’s hand was closed around Sea Hawk’s in an iron grip. Netossa and Spinnerella were locked in a tight embrace.

“Promise me… you’ll all fight… until Etheria will be safe…”

“I promise… I swear I’ll fight until the end.” Mermista replied, her tone dead serious.

“When we’ll win, I’ll forever sing of your bravery, Adora.” Sea Hawk quietly muttered.

“Don’t leave us… please…” Frosta murmured into Perfuma’s dress.

“We’ll fight… we’ll do it together and for Prime it’ll be the end.” Netossa hissed between her teeth.

“He will pay for this.” Huntara growled, tightening her fists.

“A-Adora… how can we do it without you?” Perfuma asked between sobs.

“I know… you’ll do great… because I know that what you’re doing… is the right thing…” Adora spoke, sounding more and more breathless.

“Don’t strain yourself…” King Micah lightly put his hand on the blonde’s shoulder.

“Micah… be there for Glimmer… she has already… lost you once… don’t ever let her go again…”

“I’ll be there for her… always…” The old king gave the pale girl a weak smile.

Adora nodded, before shifting her gaze towards Scorpia. The scorpion princess seemed surprised, Adora had talked to almost everyone in the room, but she didn’t expect her to speak to her too.

“Scorpia?”

“Y-yes?” Scopria came closer.

“You’ve always been there for Catra. When I left her… when I hurt her… you were there. Please… keep being there for her… she deserves to be loved.”

“Oh… oh geez… I… I promise I’ll never leave her alone!” Scorpia promised, her voice audibly cracking, tears starting to pool in her eyes.

“Swifty…” Adora raised her hand towards the steed, beckoning him.

Swift Wind came closer, pressing his snout into her hand.

“I would have loved… to see your ‘horses’ revolution’… take place…” The blonde quietly cackled.

“Oh… Adora…” Swift Wind closed his eyes.

Adora rubbed his snout a couple times before noticing Shadow Weaver coming closer. Swift Wind moved aside, and the red witch found herself staring down at her dying daughter. What she felt in that exact moment… it was something she had never felt before… it was a strange mixture of anger, sadness and… remorse. The witch found herself tightening her fists.

“Why… why did you throw away your life? What for?” Shadow Weaver murmured.

“For her.” Adora answered, a hardened expression taking the place of her previous smile.

“It wasn’t worth it… Catra wasn’t worth it…” The witch hissed through gritted teeth.

“I don’t expect you to understand. You’ve never truly loved anyone… not her… not me.”

“I… I… you…” Shadow Weaver stuttered.

The red witch became silent, then, after a few moments she turned around and quickly left the room.

“G-Glimmer?”

“Adora?” The young queen immediately sat down beside the blonde.

“Please… can you do me o-one last f-favor?”

“Anything!” Glimmer reached for Adora’s hand and held it tight between her own.

“All of you… stay… stay until I… I don’t want to be alone…” Adora’s voice trembled.

“Of course we’ll stay!” The young queen quickly replied.

“We won’t leave you.” Bow came closer.

“Don’t be afraid Adora, we’re here.” Perfuma whispered, as everyone came around the small bed.

They’re here…

They’re here… with me…

My family’s here…

Can I go now?

For The Honor Of Grayskull

"Please… can you do me o-one last f-favor?"

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They're here…

They're here… with me…

My family's here…

Can I go now?

…

…

…

No…

I… promised…

I promised her…

But… I'm so tired…

Adora's eyes started to close…

And it was right in that moment… that her bedroom's door swung open.

"My Queen!" A soldier cried, clearly in panic.

"What happened?!" Glimmer asked.

"The Horde is here!"

Everyone began to exchange panicked glances, but not Glimmer.

"Are the black ships back?" She asked.

"N-no, my Queen. The sentinels have reported several transport vehicles and a few dozens of tanks emerging from the Whispering Woods' borders! They're headed-" The guard explained frantically, but before he could finish, Glimmer raised a hand.

"She's here." The young queen murmured in amazement as she realized that the ones who were coming were not Prime's troops.

Somehow… Catra had managed to guide her people through the woods… but there was no time to think about how she had done it. Glimmer quickly knelt down next to Adora.

"Adora? Catra is coming… she's very near… I'm going to go and get her, okay?"

"Catra? What is she doing outside at this hour? S-she's way past the curfew… Shadow Weaver is going to get mad at her…" Adora whispered, her eyes half closed.

Glimmer's face paled at the blonde's words.

She was starting to slip away.

"We need to hurry." Glimmer declared as she stood up.

She followed the guard outside the bedroom and travelled through the palace's corridors as fast as she could. When they finally reached the castle's exit, the guard pointed in the direction of the woods. Glimmer's eyes widened. She hadn't expected so many to follow Catra.

The feline's intentions were good… but the Horde wasn't… or at least… that's what the young queen had always thought. Maybe it had always been the one leading them the only one who was truly evil. Maybe… maybe the Horde thought that what they were doing were right. Maybe… many more of them were just like Adora.

"A-as you see my Queen, they are heading towards-"

Glimmer didn't let the guard finish, she simply disappeared into a cloud of sparkles, leaving him speechless. When she reappeared, the young queen found herself around fifty feet away from the incoming army… and despite being alone… the ones who looked truly scared… were the Horde's soldiers.

"I-It's Bright Moon's queen!"

"T-the leader of the rebellion…"

"I heard she's a witch!"

"Don't try anything stupid! She'll vaporize us!"

Glimmer found herself chuckling at the last one.

That's when Catra emerged from the large group of people. She looked scared too… but Glimmer knew that it wasn't because of her. The feline quickly reached her, putting a hand on her waist, asking a silent question that Glimmer immediately understood.

"She's… she's still alive… but we have to hurry…" The young queen explained swiftly, the panic in her voice not going unnoticed.

"Okay…" Catra replied.

Before Glimmer could teleport them, she took a step towards the Horde's people.

"You have nothing to fear… the Rebellion welcomes you to Bright Moon. We'll provide anything you need, food, shelter… don't be afraid to ask. I know our history is not the best one… we were once enemies, but right now we're allies. You will be treated as such." The young queen spoke with strength and determination, before turning towards Catra and extending a hand towards her. "Let's go."

Catra turned for a moment towards the Whispering Woods, her gaze falling upon Lonnie.

"Start planting the tents, I'll… I'll come back as soon as I can." The feline told her, doing her best to sound secure.

"Don't worry, I got this… take all the time you need." Lonnie answered, giving the feline a small yet encouraging smile.

Catra turned around, took Glimmer's hand and disappeared into thin air alongside the young queen.

~

"We're here." Glimmer announced, as she led Catra into the room.

The cat girl couldn't refrain herself from letting out a ragged breath. Adora's face was colorless, her hair disheveled, and her eyes… her beautiful blue eyes… they looked as if they had lost that particular light that only Adora had.

"Can't someone… can't someone…" Catra tried to ask, her eyes roaming the people inside the chamber.

However, as the feline noticed how everyone's gazes were set on the floor… how some people were trying to bite back quiet sobs and others were doing their best to comfort them… she realized…

No one had managed to cure Adora…

No one would have been able to save her…

And that meant that…

That meant that…

"Didn't you hate her?"

The question made Catra's eyes widen.

"Mermista…" Glimmer's tone became warningly grave.

"What? First she leaves Adora to die in that temple, then she almost destroys Bright Moon, she kills your mom, she sends a shape shifter to tear us apart from the inside, destroys Sealineas and only now she cares? Now that Adora's dying, you cry?!" Mermista shouts angrily, surprising everyone in the room.

They had rarely seen the princess break her indifferent façade. Catra wiped a few tears she hadn't realized she had been crying.

"What do you want me to say, huh?! That I'm sorry?!" The feline yelled back.

"Oh you wish… you wish you could get off the hook so easily, don't you?! Oh, but wait! You already did! You brought us your little army, you care about Adora for five minutes and-"

Catra doesn't let Mermista finish. She quickly steps up to her and grabs her by the hem of her shirt.

"Don't you dare… don't you dare! You know nothing about me and Adora! You hear me?! Nothing!" She screams.

The way Catra talked… cried… how her voice dripped with anger, hate and desperation… the tears that started to pool in her eyes… that's what left Mermista speechless. The one she was talking to, could she really be the same Catra that smiled down on the destruction she brought upon Selineas?

"C-Catra?"

The feeble voice immediately caught the cat girl's attention. Catra looked over Mermista's shoulder and her expression immediately changed. All the anger vanished in an instant as her gaze fell upon Adora. The blonde was looking at her, a weak smile on her lips. Catra let go of the mermaid princess' shirt and quickly knelt down in front of Adora.

"I'm here Adora… I'm here…"

"Shadow Weaver is going to get mad… it's dark outside… we… need… to get back to the barracks…" Adora spoke in a hushed tone of voice.

Catra looked stunned for a moment.

"Adora? We're in Bright Moon, do you remember?"

"Remember… I… I remember…" Adora muttered.

And then… suddenly… the blonde's eyes widened…

"A-Adora?" Catra said, as she noticed the blonde's eyes starting to water.

"I left the Horde… I left you…" The blonde quietly sobbed.

"Shhh… it doesn't matter… it doesn't matter, okay?" Catra's voice started to crack.

"I'm so sorry Catra… I'm so sorry."

“Adora… I…” The feline muttered, unable to refrain her tears any longer.

Suddenly, Adora’s breathing became ragged… uneven…

“Adora? Adora?!” Catra called her, grasping her hand and holding it tightly.

“I’m so sorry… it took me so long… to see that the Horde was evil… despite what they’ve always been doing… to you…”

Catra felt the blonde’s hand go limp. Adora gave her one last smile… and then… her eyes closed.

“Adora? Adora?! Don’t you dare! You hear me?! Don’t you dare! Don’t you dare go away!” Catra yelled furiously…

But Adora’s eyes remained closed.

“Oh… Adora…” Glimmer sobbed, hugging Bow as tightly as she could.

“Adora… don’t leave me again… please… I… I need you…” Catra cried, pressing her forehead against Adora’s hand.

Everyone fell silent inside the small chamber… it was as if hope had just died alongside Adora… the hope for a better world… for a free world… completely dashed.

“Oh… Adora, deary…”

But it seemed like hope wouldn’t have perished that day.

Everyone turned around as they heard the new voice. Bow immediately recognized the person who had just spoken.

“Madame Razz? W-what are you doing here?” Bow asked her, wiping away a few tears.

“Madame Razz has come to help Adora, of course!” Razz explained as she walked towards the bed where Adora was lying.

“It’s too late… you can’t help her.” Catra growled at the old woman.

“Oh, Katrina… always so snappy! But don’t worry… Madame Razz isn’t late.”

Katrina…

Katrina…

Catra knew that name…

She had already heard it…

In her dreams…

The feline remained speechless as the old woman knelt down beside her. She motioned for Catra to let go of Adora’s hand and even if the feline didn’t want to… she found herself doing it. Madam Razz took it in her own ones and as she began to speak… a low light began to engulf the both of them.

“Tell me Adora… why do you fight? Do you fight for Etheria?”

As soon as the old woman spoke those words, Adora’s face started to gain color…

… and the blonde suddenly grunted.

Everyone gasped loudly.

“A-Adora?” Catra’s voice trembled.

“Adora!” Glimmer cried.

“Do you fight for its people?” Razz continued.

The blonde’s eyes started to open…

“Do you fight for the people you love? Will you fight for them?”

For Etheria…

For its people…

For the ones I love…

With or without the sword…

I'll always fight to protect them!

Adora felt her hand being raised in the air, cradled in Madam Razz's ones.

"Then call for the power to protect them Adora, it has always been inside of you."

"For the honor… of Grayskull!"

The light that came next… was so blinding that everyone had to cover their eyes. Catra could have sworn she had seen a sword appearing in Adora's hand… a sword that came out from nowhere… and when the light finally grew less bright and Catra was able to look at Adora… her eyes widened. The blonde's wound had completely healed, leaving behind nothing but a small, barely visible scar.

"Adora?" Catra called her name.

Adora however, did not respond. The sword in her hand had already vanished and her eyes were closed.

"W-what happened? Is she going to be all right?!" Glimmer asked, her voice laced with worry.

"She'll need to rest… but my dear Adora will be fine…" Razz said, gently running a hand through the blonde's hair.

"How… how could she… the sword…" Bow stuttered.

"She-Ra was never a sword, dear boy…" Razz smiled at the young archer.

She was about to turn around and leave the chamber when she felt a hand grasping the sleeve of her dress. When Madame Razz looked down, she found Catra staring back at her. The feline gulped and quickly wiped away her tears.

"T-thank you…" She muttered.

"Enjoy every moment you'll spend with her." Madame Razz spoke gently, and before Catra could add anything else, she turned around and reached for the chamber's door. Before leaving, she turned towards the feline one last time. "See you soon, Katrina!"

"W-wait! Who's…" Catra was going to ask, but as soon as she opened her mouth, the old woman was already gone.

And then… suddenly… Adora shifted slightly on her matress.

"Adora? Can you hear me?" The feline tightened her hold on the blonde's hand.

Noticing Catra's worried look, Glimmer took a step towards her.

"She's going to be alright Catra, Madam Razz said she'll only need to rest, right? So let's just go and-" The young queen began to speak, but stopped as soon as she felt Bow's hand touching her shoulder.

The young archer gave her a meaningful look before nodding towards Catra and Adora. Glimmer didn't understand immediately, but when she turned her gaze towards them and watched them silently for one moment, she finally did. The feline was drawing light circles on Adora's hand, and the blonde's expression seemed to be more and more relaxed. The look that Catra had in her eyes… the people inside the room knew that she would have never admitted it… but they knew what it meant.

"We should leave them alone." Bow suggested, a warm smile on his face.

"Yeah… yeah, I think you're right." Glimmer answered.

“Whatever…” Mermista muttered.

The small group of people slowly made their way out of the bedroom. The last one to go was Scorpia, but before the scorpion princess left, she turned one last time towards Catra.

“Are you going to be okay Wildcat?” Scorpia asked.

Catra turned her gaze towards her and nodded swiftly. The scorpion princess smiled at the feline before leaving the room. Finally, Adora and Catra were alone. The feline let her head rest on the pink mattress. It felt softer than anything she had ever slept on before, but the feeling didn’t really bother her. She felt exhausted, and despite that, her mind kept screaming at her. It kept telling her that Prime was still alive, that he would have come back, to take everything she cared about from her, that the Rebellion would have never been able to stop him… that happy endings didn’t exist in the real world…

It took one look at Adora’s sleeping face to make her mind shut up, before Catra drifted off… lulled into a nightmare less sleep by the blonde’s soft breathing.

Fixing Things

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Heat… almost unbearable… fire creeps closer… it's engulfing everything.

Someone stands over Catra… she wants to reach out but… she can't.

She can only cry.

"Queen Katrina…"

The voice is terrifying… and… familiar.

Too familiar…

"You don't know how much I have dreamt of this moment."

"Little people will always dream of little things."

"You always had a big mouth… it'll be my pleasure to shut it forever."

The one who stood protectively over her pounces on an ominous red figure.

Blow after blow… the two grow slow…

Until the red one falls.

"You're done for… this is for everything you've done to my people."

"Your people deserved everything I did to them… you're nothing but beasts! You don't deserve all that power! You don't deserve that crown!"

"And you do, isn't it? You're nothing… just a sad, old woman, craving for the most meaningless thing in the universe. Power is nothing if you're alone. I pity you."

"Spare me the sentimentalisms… do your worst, freak."

Catra can see a clawed hand raised in the air.

And then…

A loud explosion…

Her ears are ringing.

Her hearing is muffled.

Another figure approaches.

"Lord Hordak…"

"Finish her."

"With pleasure."

The red figure takes a sword from the ground.

Catra can see the blade shining under the moonlight.

When it comes down, a strangled scream resonates in the air.

"Let me kill her daughter too."

"No."

"What?!"

"Their last stand failed. They're all gone… but this one? This one will know what we'll tell her… her strength will be ours. Raise her."

"You can't ask me that. You can't!"

The tall, white faced figure steps closer to the red one.

"I… can't?"

…

…

…

"As you wish… my lord."

The red figure grows closer…

Clawed hands reach out for her…

Catra screams…

~

The feline woke up with a strangled scream. She looked around frantically, as if she was expecting the room to be still on fire. But she wasn't in that damned tent anymore… she didn't feel that terrifying, unbearable heat on her skin any longer. No, she just felt… warm… her hand felt especially warm. Catra looked down and found out that her hand was still intertwined with Adora's. The feline's breathing became less ragged, more stable as she let her gaze linger on the blonde's face.

It was then that she saw Adora open her eyes slightly.

"Catra?" Her voice was barely above a whisper.

The feline let out a sigh of relief she didn't know she had been holding.

She was fine…

Adora was fine…

"Y-yeah… I'm here." Catra stuttered, moving closer.

"I'm… cold…" The blonde muttered.

"I'll get you another blanket… tell me where-" The feline began to speak only to stop as she felt Adora's hold on her hand tighten.

The blonde's gaze was lowered… her cheeks slightly flushed…

"Can you stay? With… with me… please. Just for tonight… I don't want to be alone."

Adora's voice was so fragile… so vulnerable… Catra could have broken her heart right there and then.

…

…

...

The feline raised the thin sheet covering the blonde and slipped under it.

"What are you doing?! Leave her! You know she's gonna to break your heart all over again! She doesn't… she doesn't… care…"

The voice inside Catra's head screamed… but as it kept speaking… it became less secure… because the feline knew… Adora had almost died for her. How could she not care? And when Catra felt that long forgotten closeness… that comforting warmth… she realized how much she had missed that. How much she had missed Adora. The blonde tightened her grip around the feline's

hand once more. Catra looked at her face and saw a tear streaming down her cheek.

“Adora?” Catra’s tone was laced with worry.

She didn’t care about hiding it anymore.

“You’re enough… you’ve always been enough… I’m…” Adora muttered between quiet sobs before raising her gaze and bringing her free hand to rest upon Catra’s cheek. “I’m sorry I made you feel like you weren’t… I’m sorry… I’m so sorry…”

“I’m sorry too…”

The statement shocked Adora. She watched as Catra lowered her gaze in shame.

“You left because it was the right thing to do. The Horde was going to destroy many more lives… just like it probably did with the ones we should have had… and you decided to stand against it. I choose to stay… of course I choose that, I’m that weak-” Catra hissed between her teeth but stopped as she felt her chin being lifted up.

“That’s not true.” Adora shook her head.

“Yeah… yeah it is. I should have followed you, but instead of caring about the only person who ever gave a damn about me and following her… I chose to stay to be someone in the eyes of people who always treated me like trash…”

“It’s not your fault… if I had been treated like you all my life… I don’t think I would have had the strength to leave either… I’m sorry I couldn’t be there for you the way you needed me to. Truth is… truth is I’m the one who wasn’t enough.” Adora’s lip trembled.

“Shut up! Okay?!” Catra startled both Adora and herself with the strength of her voice. “You were everything to me, you got it?! Everything! The only reason I didn’t die in that hell was you… I just… I just wish that place hadn’t torn us apart…”

"It doesn't matter, okay? It doesn't matter now… we're… we're here now…" Adora gave the feline a teary smile.

"How… how can we go back? H-how can we fix it?" Catra's voice began to crack.

"We'll find a way… one day at a time. I… I know I shouldn't say it. I know you probably don't trust me… but I…"

Please don't…

Please don't say it…

I couldn't bear it if you broke another one…

"I promise you… we'll fix this." Adora's voice was so hopeful, and it carried a warmth in which Catra simply wanted to drown.

We won't be able to do it…

We can't fix it…

It's broken beyond repair…

"Okay…" Catra muttered.

Adora's teary laugh… it made the feline chuckle as well. The blonde grew closer and wrapped her arms around her. Catra stiffened. Adora must had felt it and began to shift away, muttering a barely audible 'sorry'. Before she could retract her arms, Catra locked her own behind her, keeping the blonde close.

"This is a mistake. You're going to regret it." The voice inside the feline's head muttered in a dark tone of voice.

Catra didn't listen, she focused on Adora's light breathing and listened to it until she fell asleep once again. This time, the nightmares didn't come back, and when she opened her eyes, the new day's light had already illuminated the chamber. When was the last time she hadn't woken up at 0500 sharp? It had always

been dark when she opened her eyes… but not now it wasn't… and if Catra had to be sincere… she loved it.

And even if she wasn't ready to admit it… she loved it when Adora opened her eyes and gave her a warm smile.

"Hey…"

"Good morning…" Catra answered, unable to keep a smile from forming on her lips.

Adora's grew even wider as the blonde noticed the feline's one. How much had she dreamt about living a moment like this with Catra again? As time went by, Adora had convinced herself that it wasn't a dream worth having, because it would have never turned into reality… but here she was…

Here they were…

"How are you feeling?" The feline asked.

"Much better, just a little tired." Adora answered before trying to sit up.

A hand immediately flew on her shoulder.

"Razz said to take it easy." Catra's voice became stern, but not unkind.

"So, she really was here… I don't remember very well… just fragments."

"She was here… she… I think she helped you… healed you… just a little bit but enough for you to… turn into She-Ra."

"I-I turned into She-Ra?!" Adora exclaimed in disbelief.

"Yeah… a sword appeared out of nowhere and woosh… you turned for a second… and your wound disappeared."

Adora felt a smile grow on her face. She-Ra… if she had turned without the sword… it really meant that the magic warrior wasn't a sword… she was so much more. Madame Razz was right. However, the blonde's smile vanished as she noticed Catra's face. She looked… ashamed.

"Catra?"

"It's my fault… isn't it? Your old sword…" Catra's gaze lowered in shame.

"I had to destroy it to stop the Heart, but Catra-" Adora tried to speak but the feline interrupted her.

"Yeah, like I said, it's my fault. If I hadn't pushed the Rebellion to use the Heart, you wouldn't have had to destroy your sword and… maybe you would have still had it when you faced Prime… you wouldn't have risked to die…"

Adora placed a hand on Catra's cheek and gently raised her face.

"With or without the sword, it doesn't change the fact that I would have gladly accepted my death, if it meant that you would have continued to live."

Catra let out a shaky breath.

"Always the hero, huh?" The feline chuckled after a brief pause, although, there was no malice in her words.

"Nah… just a girl who'd do anything for the person she loves the most…" Adora spoke softly.

The person she loves the most…

It took time for Adora to realize that. It took her time to understand that despite everything that happened, she would have never been able to hate Catra and finally… after what the feline had done for Glimmer… that she had never truly stopped loving her.

“Adora… I…” Catra muttered, an uneasy expression on her face.

“Hey, you don’t need to say anything, okay? I just wanted you to know that.”

“Thank you…” The feline whispered.

Maybe they could really fix this…

Adora slowly sat up. She didn’t feel dizzy, just a little bit tired.

“You know what we need right now?” The blonde asked, her tone dripping with enthusiasm.

“What?” Catra chuckled at Adora’s childlike excitement.

“A good breakfast. You won’t believe how good the Rebellion’s food is.”

“You sure? That old lady said you should rest.”

“But I’m sooo hungry…” Adora said dramatically as she fell back on the mattress.

She turned towards Catra and smiled brightly as she saw the feline smirk.

“Well, it can’t be worst than the Horde’s ration bars, so why not?”

~

“I’m telling you Glimmer, this is a great idea!” Perfuma insisted.

“A ball? Really?” Glimmer said, clearly unconvinced.

“Uhhh… did you like… see how the people down there are looking at us?” Mermista pointed at the large camp that had been built

just outside the palace's grounds, at the edge of the Whispering Woods.

"That's exactly why we should do it! We should show the Horde's people that we're not the monsters Hordak told them we are! We should show them how much happier they could be here!"

"That's… really nice Perfuma, but I doubt that a single party could make them change their mind." Glimmer gave the flowery princess a sad smile.

"Don't be like that Glimmer! Trust me! I bet that it's going to be great and-" Perfuma began to speak, but was suddenly interrupted.

"Hey, you!"

The new voice caught the three's attention. As the young queen and the two princesses turned around, they found themselves face to face with a small girl. She had to be around nine or ten. What took the princesses most by surprise was the stun baton she was holding in her right hand. A moment after, another girl appeared. She was older, one of Adora's old friends if Glimmer was not mistaken. She was called… Lonnie! That's what her name was. She rushed to the young girl's side and swiftly grabbed the baton away from the young girl's hand.

"Ivy! What are you doing?!" Lonnie hissed through gritted teeth.

"Give that back to me! I'm tired of you saying that I have to wait! I know they did something bad to her!" Ivy shouted back.

"Her?" Perfuma asked in confusion.

"Don't play dumb with me, princess!" Ivy addressed her with a mocking tone. "I know you took Catra and locked her up in your big, stupid castle!"

Glimmer snorted and chuckled slightly.

“Something’s funny?!”

“You’re cute, you’re just like an angry little cupcake.” The young queen mused, making Perfuma giggle and Mermista smirk.

“W-what?!” Ivy became as red as a tomato as she heard Glimmer’s words. “I’ll show you ‘cute’ rebel scum!”

But as soon as the young girl raised her fists into a fighting stance, her eyes fell on a figure near the castle’s gates.

“Catra!” Ivy yelled, rushing towards the feline.

Chapter End Notes

I'm so sorry guys! The next, big exam is coming and I completely forgot about the schedule! Sorry. I hope that it was still worth the wait! Enjoy this new chapter and tell me what you think about it in the comments. I hope you're enjoying this story as much as I enjoy writing it, see you soon!

Breakfast

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I'm telling you Glimmer, this is a great idea!" Perfuma insisted.

"A ball? Really?" Glimmer said, clearly unconvinced.

"Uhhh… did you like… see how the people down there are looking at us?" Mermista pointed at the large camp that had been built just outside the palace's grounds, at the edge of the Whispering Woods.

"That's exactly why we should do it! We should show the Horde's people that we're not the monsters Hordak told them we are! We should show them how much happier they could be here!"

"That's… really nice Perfuma, but I doubt that a single party could make them change their mind." Glimmer gave the flowery princess a sad smile.

"Don't be like that Glimmer! Trust me! I bet that it's going to be great and-" Perfuma began to speak, but was suddenly interrupted.

"Hey, you!"

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But as soon as the young girl raised her fists into a fighting stance, her eyes fell on a figure near the castle’s gates.

“Catra!” Ivy yelled, rushing towards the feline.

However, the young girl stopped dead in her tracks as she saw that Catra wasn’t alone. Ivy’s eyes widened in shock as she noticed the blonde walking beside her. She had already seen that face… many times if she had to tell the truth. There were cadets who told stories about a Horde soldier who went rogue and sided with the rebellion after receiving the powers of a princess… She-Ra… Adora. A few soldiers had even made sketches of her face and put them on their punching bags. That’s how she had recognized her.

“Watch out Catra!” Ivy shouted as she resumed her run towards the feline.

Catra's expression went from surprised to amused in a matter of seconds. She stood in front of Adora, shielding her, although not in a way that would make Ivy feel threatened.

"Hey pipsqueak, what's the problem?" Catra grinned down to the little girl, who had stopped right in front of her, her fists raised in a fighting stance.

"Wha- Catra! That's She-Ra! Run! I'll protect you!"

Catra burst out laughing.

"Don't laugh! She's dangerous! She's-" Ivy began to rant, but immediately stopped as the feline dropped to her knees.

Catra knelt down in front of the little girl and brought her into a tight hug as she kept laughing.

"I'm glad you're okay kid."

Ivy felt her anger vanish immediately as she heard those words. Her lower lip trembled slightly as she hugged Catra back.

"I was scared… I thought they hurt you." Ivy muttered.

"No, I'm fine, see? Better than ever." Catra said as she stood up, flexing dramatically, earning a chuckle from the little girl, although, her concerns came back pretty quickly.

"B-but… that's She-Ra!" Ivy pointed to a very confused Adora.

'Who's this kid?' The blonde thought.

"Yeah, and you wanna know something? She-Ra saved my life. If it wasn't for her, Prime would have killed me, and by saving me, she almost died herself." Catra said, giving Adora's hand a light squeeze.

Why did that make Adora's heart flutter?

"She… she did?" Ivy's tone went from angry to disbelieved.

“Yes… Ivy, meet Adora… my… my oldest friend. And Adora, meet Ivy, the bravest, toughest cadet you’ll ever know.” Catra introduced the two to one another.

Ivy looked at the blonde suspiciously for a couple of moments before she spoke once more.

“What’s with that dumb hair poof?” The young girl crossed her arms.

Adora looked surprised for a moment. She turned towards Catra and saw that the feline was trying her best not to burst out laughing. She returned her gaze to the little girl… strong… fierce… ready to fight She-Ra if she had to… all to protect Catra…

“I can see you already had a great influence on her Catra…” Adora joked.

“She’s a great kid.” The feline smirked proudly.

Adora smiled sincerely at the little girl before talking.

“I’m glad Catra has such a brave, young little girl looking out for her.” Adora put a hand next to her mouth and fake whispered, “She wouldn’t last a day without us.”

“Hey!” Catra pouted.

Before she could realize what she was doing, Ivy snickered. The young girl cheeks suddenly flushed of a deep red as she realized she had just laughed at a joke the supposed Horde’s nemesis told her. But before she could protest, a voice caught the attention of the small group.

“Adora! You’re awake!” Glimmer yelled happily as she rushed to hug the blonde.

Adora stumbled back as the young queen threw herself at her, laughing alongside her.

“Sorry! Sorry…” Glimmer apologized as she noticed the small grimace of pain on the blonde’s face.

“It’s okay.” Adora reassured her with a warm smile.

“How are you feeling?”

“Pretty good! Just… hungry… a lot actually.” Adora chuckled as she scratched the back of her neck.

“To the kitchen then!” Glimmer announced, pointing a finger dramatically towards the palace’s entrance.

“Soooo… what about the ball thing?” Mermista asked as she reached the group.

“A ball?” Adora asked, her tone a mixture of confusion and curiosity.

“Yeah, Perfuma had the idea, why don’t we talk while we have some pancakes?” Glimmer proposed.

“What’s a… pancake?” Catra asked, raising a brow.

“Oh! You’re going to love them! They’re really soft, and warm, and sweet!” Adora said, grasping her hand.

Catra smiled, not questioning the warm feeling that unfurled in her chest as the blonde’s hand made contact with her own. She had forgotten how much she liked seeing Adora blabber about whatever thing she found impressing. The blonde was so easily entertained.

“Sure, why not. But wait a moment.” Catra said as she let go of Adora’s hand and walked over to Ivy. “Hey, you wanna come?”

Ivy’s eyes lit up at the offer. Spending time with her hero? Who would refuse? Even if she would have had to be in the same room with a bunch of stupid princesses, she would have never passed up the opportunity.

“Someone has to make sure they don’t poison you.” Ivy cast a dirty look at the princesses near the palace’s entrance.

“See? An angry little cupcake.” Glimmer smirked as she elbowed Adora lightly, making the blonde snicker.

“I’m not a… a… whatever that thing is!” Ivy fumed.

The trip to the kitchen was pretty quiet, everyone looked happy though. The treat of Horde Prime was still present, but for a moment, it was just the princesses having breakfast together, it was just Adora and Catra, together just like the old times, it was just… them. Glimmer opened the kitchen doors only to be met with chaos. Dozens of cooks were running back and forth, with Frosta yelling orders as loudly as she could.

“You heard the Queen! We have to bake a wonderful breakfast for the Horde soldiers that got to Bright Moon! Quicker! You, be sure the pancakes don’t burn! You, you’re too slow!” The young princess conjured a ball of snow in her hand and threw it at the poor chef.

“I think… you’re overdoing this Frosta… just a little.” Glimmer chuckled.

“Nonsense! You should have seen them before I got here! They were slower than nails!” Frosta crossed her arms.

“Breakfast for all the Horde soldiers?” Catra grinned in amusement, looking at Glimmer.

“A-ah! Well…” The young queen’s cheeks flushed, “They just got here, they’re out there living in tents and they’re probably eating those… ugh… horrible ration bars Adora told us about. I wanted to do something nice for them, to show them… you know…”

“Yeah, I know.” Catra smiled.

“You think you can buy our loyalty with food? You rebels are even dumber than you look.” Ivy shook her head.

“Hey, grumpy pants! Be nice or you won’t get any!” Frosta yelled, pointing at the young girl.

“Uh, sorry?! How did you call me?! You wanna come here and say that to my face?!” Ivy growled.

“I think I have a better idea.” The ice princess grinned as she threw another snowball, this time aiming at the young Horde soldier.

The ball flew through the air and hit Ivy square in the face. It obviously didn’t hurt, even though the small cadet thought it would. Instead, the strange sphere revealed itself to be far softer than the training staffs Ivy got hit with during training. However, the shock of not having been actually hurt quickly vanished, replaced by anger and embarrassment.

“You’re going to pay for that!” Ivy yelled as she tried to rush towards the small princess, only to be stopped by Catra.

“Woah, come on Ivy, chill out.” Catra snickered, holding back the small cadet.

“Awwww… young love is by far the cutest thing in the world.” Perfuma cooed.

“WHAT?!” Both Ivy and Frosta yelled, turning as red as tomatoes.

Catra, Adora, Glimmer, Bow and even Mermista couldn’t help but laugh.

“Come on, the chefs are going to be done cooking in a few minutes. Let’s go to the dining room, I’m starving!” The young queen announced. “Frosta? Come on, I think you scared them enough.”

Frosta gave the kitchen staff one last glare before following the other princesses. When they reached the dining room, Scorpia was already sitting at the table waiting for them, chatting with

Spinerella and Netossa. As soon as the small group came into view, the scorpion princess turned her head and smiled brightly.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia waved a pincer at her.

“Hey Scorpia.” Catra smiled back.

As everyone sat down, the waiters came in, bringing a seemingly endless trail of different types of food on the table.

“Come on.” Catra patted the chair next to her, looking over at Ivy.

The young girl looked embarrassed. She shifted uncomfortably before nodding, sitting down next to the feline. Everything around her was so… colored… vibrant… everyone looked so happy and… kind… it was as if nothing of what the Horde had taught her was true. But it couldn’t be! It had to be a trick, to bring them to their side, to destroy the Horde! She wouldn’t fall for that.

But… despite not liking Catra’s plan, Ivy knew that they would have never been able to defeat Prime on their own. They needed all the help they could get. But as soon as they defeated the tyrant, they would have gone back fighting the Rebellion, fighting the princesses, bringing back order to-

Ivy’s train of thoughts got interrupted by the sound of chair shifting beside her. As she turned her head, she found herself face to face with the blue haired princess from before.

“Ugh… do you have to sit here?” Ivy muttered.

“Uh, do you see any other free chair?” Frosta crossed her arms.

“Whatever.” The young Horde soldier scoffed.

As if she cared… Ivy looked away. She could always talk with Catra. She turned around only to find the feline smirking.

“What?” Ivy asked in an annoyed ton of voice.

“Nothing.” Catra chuckled, stabbing the pile of pancakes with a fork and bringing a piece to her mouth.

She expected it to taste like ration bars, maybe a little bit different… but… she would have never expected it taste like… like this. The feline’s eyes grew as wide as dinner plates as she chewed on the soft, sweet food.

“Oh… my…”

“They’re so good, right?” Adora asked, smirking.

“S-shut up. It’s not that great.” Catra stuttered, blushing slightly.

“Sorry to tell you Wildcat, Horde’s food got nothing on this.” Scorpia said with her mouth full.

“As if…” Ivy rolled her eyes.

The young girl looked at what had been brought to them and chose to reach for a steaming mug. What was inside looked like a brown, dense liquid, with a tuft of something white on the top. She brought it to her lips but yelped as the liquid burnt her tongue.

“Ah! It’s a trap! I knew it!” The young Horde soldier exclaimed.

“Oh, for the First Ones’s sake!” Frosta exclaimed, taking the mug in her hands.

“Don’t drink it! It’s poison!” Ivy exclaimed, trying to reach for the cup before she could think about what she was doing.

However, the ice princess didn’t seem to want to drink the burning liquid. She simply held the mug between her hands, one eyebrow raised in curiosity at the cadet’s exclamation. After a few moments, she rolled her eyes and spoke again.

“It’s not poison dummy. It’s hot chocolate. It’s just hot.” The princess rolled her eyes.

“Wha… b-but then… why did you take it?”

“I’m cooling it down.” Frosta answered, tightening her hold on the steaming mug.

Oh…

But that’s… kind…

Princesses are not supposed to be like that…

Ivy remembered the words of her teacher…

“The princesses are mindless monsters and their powers make them capable of the most atrocious things.”

This was a princess but… she didn’t look like a monster… and she surely didn’t act like one…

“Thanks…” Ivy muttered as Frosta passed the mug back to her.

The ice princess hard façade cracked a little, surprised by the Horde’s cadet words. She gave her a small smile and nodded.

The “hot chocolate”, as Frosta had called it, revealed itself to be the most delicious thing Ivy had ever tasted in her entire life.

Chapter End Notes

> What's better than an angry little cupcake? Two angry little cupcakes! Don't where that Frosta/Ivy scene came from, but I found myself writing it nontheless. Hope you all liked the chapter! New one coming soon! Also, my final exam is growing closer, then after this one, I'll have a ton of free time, like... all rest of July, all August and the first twenty days of September... horray! See you soon!

Author's note: Woohooo I'm coming back!

Hi guys! Yes, it's me, I bet you thought I was dead. Well, I'm not! I completed all of my exams and I'll be completely free from now until September the 21th! So, as soon as I got the results of my last exam, I got back into the story and wrote three new chapters. I know, you thought it was going to be over in two chapters, but I found myself writing more than I expected and I won't certainly end this story before its time. So brace yourself for three new chapters! "Rebellion breakfast", "Standing up to the shadows" and "The ball" will be published on August the 5th, the 8th and the 11th. I hope you'll enjoy these new chapters, that you're all doing okay and right now I'm going to go to sleep, I'm really tired, but also really happy. See you soon!

Rebellion Breakfast

Chapter Summary

> Back with a new chapter! Remember to comment, like and subscribe! Ring the bell for... wait... actually, you can't do those things here. But you can still do one of those things! Leave a comment and let me know if you liked this chapter and the story so far! Enjoy!
>
> P.S. Next one comes out on August the 8th!

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“So, Sparkles, what about this ‘ball’ you were talking about earlier? I’d love to trash another one.” Catra smirked as she took another bite of her pancakes.

“Hey!” Adora elbowed her slightly, trying her best to look angry, but failing miserably as a little smile crept on her lips.

She had just missed Catra’s sassy attitude. She had missed… all of her if she had to be sincere.

“Try to do that and I’ll spray you with water.” Glimmer replied, grinning in satisfaction as she saw the feline’s mane stand up.

Catra quickly regained her composure and scoffed.

“Seriously though, what about this ball?” Adora asked.

Perfuma cleared her voice.

“I know that Prime is still out there doing who knows what, but I thought that maybe… we could show the Horde soldiers that the Rebellion isn’t what they think it is… that we princesses are not the monsters Hordak told them we are. Plus, I think that with everything that happened, we all deserve a night to simply have fun together.” The flower princess smiled sweetly.

“They’re never going to come Perfuma…” Mermista scoffed and shook her head.

“They will.”

Everyone at the table turned towards Catra.

“I mean… I’ll tell them that it probably won’t suck… it’ll be a nice occasion to relax and eat more of your food.” The feline explained.

“What else would they come for…” The mermaid princess grumbled under her breath.

“That would be great! I know they’ll trust you.” Adora placed a hand on her shoulder and smiled encouragingly.

“Uhm… yeah… no problem.” Catra mumbled.

Why was she feeling this flustered?

“Ooooh! I know it’ll be sooo much fun! Dancing and eating and talking and laughing and… well… maybe not the explosions part. So sorry for that Frosta!” Scorpia chuckled nervously.

“Let’s say that you’re forgiven… if you help me build the ice statues for this ball!” Frosta crossed her arms, smiling triumphantly as Scorpia nodded enthusiastically, her mouth full.

“Oh! That’s going to be so fun!”

Catra rolled her eyes at Scorpia's childish like enthusiasm, but… yeah… it was probably going to be fun.

~

"As if we'd ever fall for something this ridicule!" A Horde soldier yelled waving a stun baton in the air, making a few waiters step back.

"T-the Queen j-just wanted you t-to have a good breakfast." One of them muttered.

"Ha! We know you've poisoned this food! Look at all those weird colors! Your schemes won't work, rebel scum!"

"Chill out."

The Horde soldier turned towards the source of the voice, ready to give a piece of her mind to whoever dared to talk to her like that. Her scowl however turned into a frightened expression as her eyes landed on Catra.

"A-ah! Lord Catra!" The soldier stuttered.

The feline rolled her eyes at the title.

"Don't call me that, it's just Catra." She told her.

"Uhm… as you wish my l- Catra…" The Horde soldier seemed to have used all of her will power to call the feline by her name.

"See? That wasn't so hard." Catra chuckled before turning towards the massive camp, "Listen to me! These people have brought you food and drinks, enjoy them, there's plenty!"

"B-but what if it's pois-" The soldier stuttered in fear.

She yelped as Catra rolled her eyes and took a plate from the nearest waiter, using a fork to cut a piece cake and eating it, trying not show her delight as the sweetness of it came in contact with her tongue.

“See? It’s perfectly fine.”

A few soldiers exchanged looks of uncertainty between them before stepping closer to the Bright Moon’s waiters.

“Do you… have any tables where we could put down all of these plates?” A waitress asked shily to the soldier standing right next to Catra.

“I… we… ehm… yes, we do have tables, j-just follow me… I guess.” The soldier stuttered.

“What’s with all the noise?” Lonnie asked, her voice hoarse from sleep, emerging from one of the tents, rubbing her eyes as she reached Catra’s side.

“Look at who slept in…” The feline smirked.

“Watch it.” Lonnie warned her jokingly before the two shared a laugh. “I just… never liked all those loud noises in the Fright Zone. They’d always wake me up during the night…”

“Light sleeper?” Catra joked.

“Yeah, you could say that. But here? Nothing… just… silence. I woke up when that woman started yelling at the… how did you call that guy with the plates?”

“Waiter.” Catra told her, “By the way, they brought breakfast, you should eat everything you can get your hands on, it’ll blow your mind away.”

“Wow, that good?” Lonnie asked, smirking at Catra’s choice of words.

“Y-yeah, you know, it’s okay.” The feline stuttered.

“Yeah, okay, I’ll have some. See you later okay?” Lonnie waved at her and turned to reach for the center of the camp where a few tables had been prepared with every delicacy Bright Moon had to offer.

The Horde soldiers drew closer to the tables, tentatively at first. Only a few of them grabbed a plate at first, nibbling on the strange food. It didn’t take long for them to devour it, grabbing other kinds of food and bringing their comrades to try it. In less than an hour, all of the dishes brought to the camp were gone.

Lonnie was one of the last soldiers who left the tables. She patted her stomach and made her way back to Catra, who seemed to be involved in a rather interesting conversation with Kyle and Rogelio, or at least that’s what she thought as she noticed the excited expression on the blonde boy’s face.

“I think I’m in love with this place’s food.” Lonnie chuckled.

“Don’t tell anyone but… Scorpia’s kinda right… Horde’s food got nothing on this.” Catra smiled back.

“So, what were you smiling about?”

“Oh, Lonnie! Catra was telling us that about a party!” Kyle explained excitedly.

“A… party?” Lonnie asked, clearly confused.

What in the Horde’s name was a party?

“Yeah, tell her Catra!” Kyle told the feline, who chuckled and shook her head slightly at the blonde’s childish like excitement.

It was nice though…

It reminded her of Adora…

“There will be tons of food, music and you can like… talk, or dance, or whatever.” Catra explained nonchalantly.

“Dance?” Lonnie snickered as if the feline had just explained to her the most ridiculous thing in the world.

“Just some stupid thing those dumb rebels do instead of training.” The feline grinned smugly, crossing her arms.

“Suuure, I bet I won’t catch you dancing with Adora during the party then.” The horde soldier smirked.

“Wha-what?! Why would I?!” Catra stuttered, her cheeks slightly flushed, her smug demeanor suddenly crumbling apart.

“Oh, no reason, no reason at all.” Lonnie snickered alongside Kyle and Rogelio. “It would be nice though, I’ll spread the news and try to get a few people to come.”

“Yeah whatever, do what you want.” Catra replied casually.

The trio laughed knowingly before waving goodbye. The feline simply scoffed before turning around, heading for the palace. When she reached the gates, she found Adora waiting for her, a hesitant smile on her lips. As soon as Catra’s eyes fell on it, suddenly, her stomach began making those weird flips she felt as the two of them laid in each other’s arms a few hours before.

It wasn’t… unpleasant…

But Catra couldn’t understand what it meant… and that made her nervous…

“Hi…” Adora greeted her.

“H-hey…” She stuttered.

“Uhm… Glimmer is starting to plan the ball… I thought that maybe… maybe we could help her. Do you… do you want to?” The

blonde asked, showing a strange look that made her eyes look bigger.

"Y-yeah, let's do that." Catra quickly replied, grabbing Adora's hand and dragging her inside the castle.

She sincerely hoped the blonde wouldn't notice the blush on her cheeks.

Standing up to the shadows

"All I'm saying is that we have like… more important things to do than throw a party for the people we've been fighting our whole lives." Mermista scoffed, looking away from the other princesses.

"Mermista… their home has been destroyed, a space tyrant literally waltzed in and wanted to turn them into brainless puppets and right now they're living in tents… doing something nice for them is not going to kill us." Glimmer sighed in exhaustion.

They've been discussing the same thing for almost an hour.

"I mean, since your food is so great… I think that other stuff you do might be just as great? Maybe? And it would be nice to spend an evening dancing and eating instead of thinking about our impending doomsday." Scorpia chuckled nervously.

"Scorpia is right Mermista! Don't you want them to have a break?" Perfuma said, placing a hand on the scorpion princess' pincer.

"Of course Scorpia's right." Mermista cast a dirty look at the display of affection.

Perfuma followed the mermaid princess' look and pulled her hand away, both her and Scorpia blushing slightly.

"I-it's not like that, I'm serious about wanting them to finally experience something good, something nice."

"Why?! Why are you all acting like they deserve it?!"

Suddenly, the war room's doors opened. Adora and Catra walked in, hand in hand, laughing about something. They immediately fell

silent as their eyes fell on the princesses. Some looked conflicted, others simply sad… Mermista looked furious.

"Speak of the devil…" She muttered.

"If you got something to say you better raise your voice, otherwise I won't be able to hear you." Catra spat back.

"See?! She chooses to stay with the Horde, she destroys Selineas-"

"Hey!" Catra tried to stop her but Mermista kept talking.

"She kills your mom," Both Catra and Glimmer grimaced at that, "And then she gets to act like the brat she is only because, what? Now she's She-Ra's girlfriend so she can do whatever she wants?!" Mermista throws her hands in the air in exasperation.

"S-she's not… I-I mean w-we're not…" Adora stammered, red as a tomato.

Mermista suddenly walked up to Catra. Adora herself between the two but the mermaid princess simply shoved her aside.

"H-hey!" The blonde protested, stumbling back.

"You think you can fit in here after everything you've done? You think there are no consequences to your actions?!" Mermista yelled, grabbing the hem of Catra's uniform.

"Don't touch me." The feline growled.

Adora put a hand on the mermaid princess' shoulder.

"Let her go." She demanded.

Everything remained still for a few moments in which everyone held their breath… and then… Mermista let go.

"Simply forgetting what they did… what she did… you've all stooped low." She said, before shoving Catra aside and leaving the

war room.

No one spoke for the next minute. The princesses eventually began to talk again about the ball's preparations, but Adora couldn't help but notice how Catra remained silent the whole time, her head hanging low.

~

Stupid mermaid princess…

Stupid castle…

Stupid people judging her…

…

Judging her for all of the things she's done…

All of the things she's done…

Catra shakes her head as Mermista's words came back to her mind. 'You think there are no consequences to your actions?!'. Of course, Catra knew there would have been consequences to what she had done in the past. But in that past, she simply didn't care… she hadn't cared for a lot of things for a long time.

But now?

Catra was starting to realize her mistakes… how she had pushed away the people she loved in the pursuit of something she thought she wanted… something that would have made her great in the eyes of the people she so desperately wanted the approval of... bad people… people whom only now she was starting to realize she didn't need. She just wished she had understood that sooner.

As she was lost in thought, the feline didn't notice what was happening a few hundreds of meters away from her. She had chosen a spot outside the castle where she thought no one would have ever come to bug her. However, her train of thoughts was quickly interrupted by a shrill cry.

"Ouch! You hurt me!"

"You deserved it! You're a liar!"

Catra immediately recognized that voice…

It was Ivy's voice… and she sounded upset… really upset…

"What is happening here?"

Suddenly, the feline's blood turned to ice.

She recognized that voice too…

The voice that haunted her nightmares…

Who always belittled her…

Told her she was nothing…

"She hurt me!"

"Run along child… I'll deal with her… it seems that she needs to be taught some manners."

No…

No…

'I won't let you touch her…' Catra thought as she started to rush towards Ivy.

A greyish, clawed hand started to reach for the little girl's wrist… and then…

SMACK!

Suddenly, it was slapped away.

Catra stood between Ivy and Shadow Weaver. The red witch took a step forward, doing her best to tower menacingly over the feline. A good trick, Catra had to admit. A trick that had always worked in the past. Not anymore.

"Stand… aside… Catra." Shadow Weaver hissed between her teeth.

"Why? So that you can hurt her?" Catra didn't move an inch.

"She needs to be taught some manners. Or maybe you're going to tell me that she deserves a prize for what she's done?" The witch asked.

"You're not going to teach her anything with your methods." The feline replied.

"She'll understand… she'll be better thanks to my so called 'methods'."

"Of course she'll be better, your methods worked wonderfully on me and Adora, why shouldn't they work on other defenseless children?" Catra chuckled darkly.

"Don't you dare compare yourself to Adora… you were always weak." Shadow Weaver took another step forward, now standing inches away from the feline.

"No, you made me weak. You made me believe that the only thing one needs in their life is power, and it nearly destroyed me. But now? Now I know what it means to be strong… and right now I'm strong enough to tell you to back off." Catra snarled.

"I'm not going to ask you again Catra… stand asid-" Shadow Weaver muttered menacingly before stopping abruptly and letting out a strangled yelp.

Catra had just grabbed her by the hem of her tunic.

“You’re going a bit deaf, aren’t you? I said… back… off!” Catra snarled before she pushed the red witch away.

Shadow Weaver stumbled backward, her eyes wide as dinner plates.

“H-how dare you… you insufferable-”

Catra sheeted her claws and took a step forward.

“You remember how it ended last time, right?”

“You’re… you’re nothing more than a filthy animal…” Shadow Weaver’s voice trembled.

“Yeah, still better than a monster though, that’s what you’ve always been. Now go.” The feline remained still, not breaking her fighting stance, her eyes fixed on the old witch.

“This isn’t over…” She muttered, before turning around and walking away.

When the witch was finally gone out of sight, Catra relaxed, letting out a breath she didn’t know she was holding. Then, suddenly, a pair of small arms circled her waist. She turned around swiftly, and Ivy buried her face in her stomach.

“Thank you.” The little girl whispered. “She’s so scary…”

“I thought so too… but she’s only a red robe, a mask and a booming voice, nothing more.” Catra explained to the little girl, before sighing heavily and kneeling down in front of her. “Ivy… why did you hurt that boy?” The feline asked.

“He deserved it.” Ivy scowled.

“Ivy.” Catra’s tone was dead serious, she put her hands on the child’s shoulders, not gripping them harshly, but still firmly.

“H-he was a liar! He told me that we’re the bad guys! T-that Lord Hordak didn’t bring order to Etheria but that he’s destroying everything! That we are destroying everything! That’s not true!” Ivy said, her breathing getting erratic.

“Ivy…” Suddenly, Catra’s tone softened, and a sad look appeared in her eyes.

Ivy noticed it immediately.

“No… n-no… it’s not true… it’s not true!” Ivy yelled, pushing Catra away.

The feline looked at the little girl with a shocked expression.

“Kid… what’s w-” Catra tried to extend a hand towards her but the kid slapped it away.

“It’s not true! Because if it was… t-the Force Captain that found me told me that my parents were rebels! That they were planning to harm many people and that’s why they had to be killed!”

Oh…

Oh no…

“I-if Hordak lied to us t-then… then…” Ivy’s voice started to crack.

“Ivy… I’m so sorry…” Catra whispered in horror.

Another kid whom the Horde had taken everything from.

“No… no! You’re lying! You’re all liars!” The little girl screamed in tears as she launched herself towards the feline.

Ivy began to throw punch and kicks at her, growing more and more ferocious as Catra dodged every hit.

“Say that you’re lying! Say it!” She yelled.

But soon enough, the kid's hits grew slower, until she finally fell on her knees.

"S-say it…" Ivy raised her face, completely wet with tears, and looked Catra in the eyes, "Please Catra, please… t-tell me you're lying…"

Catra could see pure desperation in the little girl's eyes… but she couldn't lie to her… not again… not like the people who ruined her life. The feline dropped down to her knees and brough Ivy in a tight embrace, hugging her as close as she could.

They both cried.

They both cried because of what the Horde had taken from them.

Ivy cried because now she knew… she knew that she had hated her parents for as long as she could remember… only because of a lie…

Catra cried because for the bigger part of her life she had been a part of the people that stripped that incredible little girl of everyone who loved her… and because deep down… her dreams were starting to make understand… that maybe the same thing had happened to her as well…

"I'm sorry I tried to hit you… I'm sorry… please don't hate me… don't go… I have no one else." Ivy hid her face in the crook of Catra's neck.

Never…

She was never going to leave this girl alone…

"I'll never leave you, got it?" Catra said as she cupped the little girl's cheeks and raised her face so that she could look at her in the eyes.

"Promise?" Ivy sniffed.

Promise…

She knew how much it could hurt to break one of those…

She'd never do that.

"I promise." The feline spoke in a firm yet warm tone of voice.

The two hugged each other again, then, after a few minutes, Catra broke the silence.

"Hey, I saw a bunch of young cadets going to the training grounds near the castle. Queen Sparklehead has offered them so that we can train… if we want…"

"I… I think I'll go there… to think… and punch something too." Ivy managed to give the feline a little smile.

"Want me to come with you?" Catra asked.

"No, I'm good… I think… uhm…" Ivy hesitated, "We'll see each other later, okay?"

"Sure pipsqueak, I'll ask Glitter to add one plate to the dining table so we can have dinner together… sounds good?"

"Yeah… yeah, I think I'd like that." The little girl smiled.

"You sure? Won't you be embarrassed? I mean, Frosta will be there." Catra said coyly, snickering at Ivy's reddening cheeks.

"Geez! I don't care! Ugh, I'm gonna go now." Ivy huffed before turning around and heading for the training grounds.

Catra rose up from the ground and crossed her arms, a contended smile on her face as she watched Ivy walk away.

"You stood up for that kid."

The voice made her turn around swiftly.

Mermista was standing a few feet away from her.

“Yeah…” Catra replied, trying not to sound nervous.

“Shadow Weaver would have hurt her.”

“I’m not gonna let that happen.” The hatred in the feline’s voice was palpable.

It surprised the mermaid princess.

She remained silent for a few moments before finally speaking again.

“I don’t understand you…”

“No one still has managed to do that… I’m a mess.” Catra gave the princess a small smile.

“Obviously.” Mermista rolled her eyes, the corners of her mouth tightening as if she was trying to suppress a grin from forming.

The two remained silent, Catra looked at the ground and scratched her left arm nervously.

“Listen-” Mermista started to speak but was suddenly interrupted.

“I’m sorry.” Catra spoke abruptly.

“What?” The mermaid princess was stunned.

“I’m sorry about what I did to your kingdom. I know that apologizing won’t fix it, but I want you to know… that when all of this is over, if I’m still breathing… I’ll help. I’ll help rebuild, if… if you’ll let me.”

Mermista remained silent. A monster, that’s how she had always seen Catra as. But now? The same monster who had destroyed her kingdom had just not only saved a child and brought a smile back on her face… she had just apologized… and offered her help

to rebuilt what she had once destroyed. The mermaid princess' expression softened.

"Why did you do it? I mean… you're standing here saying that you're sorry… and I can see that you're sincere, that you understand that what you did was wrong… but then… why did you do it in the first place?"

"Shadow Weaver taught me and Adora everything we know… she taught us the power is what everyone should aim for… Adora was able to leave, to choose a better path, but I couldn't. I just… I just wanted people to look at me like I was something more than garbage… that's how she made me feel my whole life… so I tried to get as much power as I could… away from Adora's shadow. Turns out that was never what I wanted… I'm… I'm sorry it took me so long to realize that."

Mermista remained silent the whole time. Only when Catra had finished, she stepped forward and put her hands on the feline's shoulders.

"I… I can't imagine what it must have been to grow up like that. You still did what you did but… maybe sometimes people feel like they don't have a choice. But I can see that you want to change… you already did… and I guess that you could help me rebuild my kingdom once all of this is over." Mermista paused, sighed heavily and then spoke again. "I want you to know something, and I think it's something that'll make you understand a few things. It's gonna be hard for me, but I guess that it must be like… even harder for you to change who you are."

"What do you mean?" Catra's voice was reduced to a whisper.

"Catra… I… I forgive you."

I forgive you…

Mermista had forgiven her…

After everything that she had done…

She could still come back…

She could still be a better person.

The Ball

Chapter Notes

> Here you go! The Ball is finally here! Hope you'll like this chapter, the new ones won't take long to come out and I'll post an author's note a few days before they do! Enjoy and comment! Bye bye!

“Neeeeed any help with that?”

“Ack!” A waiter yelped as she spun around, managing not to drop the two trails of food she was taking to a nearby table.

In front of her stood the scorpion princess who had recently joined the Rebellion. Still, even if she knew that, the towering figure sent a chill down her spine.

“N-nono! I got this, don’t worry!” The young woman stuttered as she turned around and walked away.

“O-oh… o-okay! Call if you need anything…” Scorpia tried to speak with her usual cheerful tone of voice.

However, as soon as she saw the waiter had gone far enough, her shoulders dropped, and a heavy sigh left her lips.

“Oh man…” The scorpion princess scratched the back of her neck.

“Hey Scorpia!”

Suddenly, a cheerful voice called out her name. Scorpia turned around, a surprised expression on her face as she noticed Perfuma waving at her and sprinting towards her.

“H-hey Perfuma… is everything alright?” Scorpia asked.

The flower princess’ euphoric demeanor suddenly dropped. Scorpia immediately noticed it.

“What?! Did I upset her?! H-how did I… I’m such a screw up!” The scorpion princess yelled internally.

“I’m okay but… you don’t look like everything’s alright… did something happen?” Perfuma asked, stepping forwards.

“Oh… oh! N-no! Everything’s totally fine, peach perfect! A-okay!” Scorpia chuckled, finding it harder and harder to maintain her positive behavior under Perfuma’s concerned look.

“You don’t have to tell me what’s wrong Scorpia, but if there’s anything I can do, I’d like to help.” The flower princess spoke kindly.

“A-ah…” Scorpia suddenly felt her cheeks growing hot, “Well… you see… I…” Scorpia struggled.

“Yes?” Perfuma stepped even closer to her.

“I don’t think I really fit in here… I-I mean… I’ve been trying to help all day… I really care about this ball! I think it was a great idea!”

“Thank you.” Perfuma giggled at the compliment.

“B-but people seem… more scared of me than anything else.” Scorpia’s face fell.

However, the scorpion princess immediately raised it as she felt a pair of soft hands lightly grasping her pincers. She looked at Perfuma who was now smiling again, and her eyes held such kindness that Scorpia wondered if this was exactly what she had missed during her entire life.

“They’re afraid because they don’t know the real you, Scorpia. I know that you’re kind, brave, funny and you have the biggest heart in all of Etheria. I promise you that people will get to see that in time, but I want you to know that I already do.”

Okay, Scorpia was definitely blushing now.

“Thank you. N-no one ever said that to me before…” The scorpion princess muttered, unable to look away from the flower princess’ eyes.

“How about you help me with a few things? I think I grew some of the flower decorations inside the ball room a tad bigger than they should have been, have you ever done some gardening before?”

“N-no? B-but I can try! I mean, better put these two to work rather than letting them do nothing all day!” Scorpia grinned as she raised her pincers above her head.

“I’m certainly looking forward to it.” Perfuma giggled as she put a hand on the scorpion princess’ bicep, sliding it upwards until she reached her pincer.

The flower princess grabbed it and began to guide Scorpia towards the ball room.

“Oooooh boy.” The former force captain muttered under her breath.

~

“I’m telling you, you gotta try the blue one!” Bow spoke excitedly.

“I think the red one would fit her better.” Glimmer said, crossing her arms.

“Well I-” The archer began to argue.

“Thank you guys, I think I’ll try them on in my room. Alone. See you tonight!” Adora interrupted the two’s bickering.

“But Adora! We have to be there to give you some advice!”

“No no no, I got this. I want the dress I choose to be a surprise… aaaaand I want to chose it quickly so that I can take a nap before the ball. I’m still a little bit tired.”

“Okay…” Bow said, clearly disappointed.

“Come on Bow, why don’t you help me pick up a dress?” Glimmer tried to cheer him up.

“Yeah, yeah I think I’d like that, come on!”

“Okay, see you tonight Adora!” The young queen said as she suddenly grasped Bow’s hand, both of them disappearing in a cloud of sparkles.

Adora heaved a sigh of relief and entered her room.

“Hey, Adora.”

The voice made the blonde swirl around, but with a smile on her face.

“Hey, Catra.”

The feline’s eyes drifted to the set of dresses Adora was carrying under her arm.

“Let me guess, Sparkles and Arrow boy wanted to help you with all that ‘choosing the right outfit’ stuff?” Catra asked, smirking as she crossed her arms.

“Exactly.” Adora chuckled.

“Same here, Scorpia couldn’t stop blabbering about the ball and how I should have asked Glimmer if she had something for me to wear that looked like the tuxedo from princess prom.” The feline explained.

It was only then that Adora noticed the black pants and the crimson red shirt. The tuxedo’s jacket laid on her bed alongside a bow tie. Suddenly, the image of Catra during Princess Prom came back to her mind. The blonde didn’t even notice she was blushing until the feline called out to her.

“Everything alright princess?” She spoke in a teasing voice, obviously having noticed how Adora’s cheeks had reddened.

“Y-yeah, I just remember that you… uhm… you looked really nice in that tuxedo.”

Suddenly, Catra’s smug demeanor fell apart. She didn’t expect Adora to say something like that. And really, it shouldn’t have had that effect on her, it was just a compliment, but something about the way the blonde said it made the feline’s stomach feel weird. Still, she chose not to pay attention to the strange feeling and forcefully brought her smirk back on her face.

“I always look great, tuxedo or not.” Catra grinned devilishly.

“I-I didn’t mean that you don’t-” Adora waved her hands in front of her, panic written all over her face.

“Adora, relax, I’m just joking.”

The blonde sighed in relief and fell silent. She scratched the back of her neck awkwardly before speaking again.

“Would you help me choose one?” She asked tentatively.

“Uhm… y-yeah.” Catra replied, wondering what had just caused that slight tremble in her voice.

Adora stepped forward and placed down on her bed three dresses. A red one, the same she wore at Princess Prom if she Catra wasn't mistaken, a blue one, with… ugh… ruffles… and a white one. That's the one that caught the feline's attention. It was long, white dress, with a completely opened back while the front had a v shaped opening.

"Try this one on." Catra spoke before she could think, taking the dress in her hands and handing it to the blonde.

"T-this one?!" Adora asked, her tone a mixture of surprise and uncertainty.

"Yeah, this one, try it."

"Catra… I really don't know…" The blonde began fidgeting nervously.

"Adora, trust me… you'll look great in it." Catra reassured her.

Adora's eyes went wide. She had never heard the feline use that tone. It was… kind… warm… reassuring.

"O-okay… I'll try it on." Adora finally agreed.

"Good." Catra seemed satisfied.

Adora took a good look at the dress. Not a chance that she could wear it with her training top, or any other kind of top…

"Uhm… could you… turn around?" The blonde asked shily.

"Why? Nothing I haven't seen before in the showers after training." The feline cackled.

"C-Catra!" Adora shrieked, going completely red.

"Yeah yeah, okay, I was just joking." Catra kept snickering as she laid the dress on Adora's bed and turned around.

A few minutes went by, then…

“Okay, you can turn around.”

Catra did… and found out that even if she tried, she couldn’t breathe.

“Uhm… so… how is it?” Adora asked.

The feline just stared in silence.

“I-is it bad?”

“It’s all but bad…” Catra whispered. “Turn around, you gotta show me the whole thing.”

“Uhm… m-maybe I should change dress… don’t you think it’s too… too much?” Adora suddenly sounded worried, and that immediately broke Catra out of her trans.

“Adora? Is… is something wrong?”

“Nono! I just… I…” Adora stuttered, averting her eyes from Catra’s gaze.

Something inside the feline told her to step closer to the blonde… and so she did. Catra moved closer and took Adora’s hand in her own. The two stared at each other for a few moments before Adora turned her back to the feline. That’s when Catra noticed them… five, thin, white lines, going from the blonde’s shoulder blades to her lower back. Unconsciously, she brough her hand on the scars, gently tracing them with her fingers. Adora’s breath itched and her back arched slightly.

“Sorry…” Catra quickly retracted her hand.

Adora turned around and took the feline’s hands into her own.

“Catra it’s okay, they don’t hurt, they’re just sensible.” The blonde tried to reassure her.

“I’m sorry…” Catra whispered, avoiding Adora’s gaze.

“Don’t be, it was a long time ago.”

“They won’t go away… they’ll always be there… to remind both of us how awful I am…” The feline muttered as tears started to stream down her cheeks.

“What?! Oh my stars Catra, no no no, you’re not awful!” Adora brought her hands to Catra’s face and cupped her cheeks, “Listen to me, okay? Catra, I’m serious, I need you to listen to me.”

Catra simply raised her face and met the blonde’s gaze. Adora used her thumbs to wipe away her tears, as she kept looking at her with that same, hopeful, warm smile that had always made the feline feel weird.

“We hurt each other… a lot… we both did things we regret…”

“Yeah right… as if Etheria’s hero ever did something regretful…” Catra scoffed, slightly turning away.

“I regret leaving you every day of my life.” Adora spoke in a firm tone of voice, gently pushing the feline’s face upwards to meet her gaze.

Catra’s breath stopped.

Her eyes widened in surprise at the blonde’s words.

“A-Adora…”

“I left you… I promised I’d always be there for you and I left you… I wanted to do the right thing but I never considered how *you*’d feel… what would have happened to you when I left… I’ve been selfish… and I almost lost the person I love the most in the entire universe… I’m sorry…” Adora’s eyes began to water.

“You don’t need to apologize.” Catra shook her head.

“Yes… I do… and you did too… life put us in a situation where we made mistakes… but we still found each other again… we still

became better people and… I'm happy that we're here… I'm happy you're here… right now…" The blonde gave her a teary smile.

"I'm… I'm happy too."

Catra placed a hand on Adora's and looked at her straight in the eyes. It was as if time had stopped. The two couldn't breath as they both grew closer and closer…

TOCK TOCK!

"Guys! Are you ready?! People are already pouring in! Let's go!"

"Thanks Glitter…"

Adora laughed… and Catra found out it was the most beautiful sound in the world. The blonde pressed their foreheads together and closed her eyes.

"Ready for the ball?"

"Yeah… I'm ready… just a little something…" Catra said as she reached out behind Adora's head and took her ponytail out, letting her hair cascade down her shoulders.

"Power is the greatest thing in this world…" The feline remembered Shadow Weaver's voice, *"No, this is."* She thought, as she stared at Adora.

"Now we can go."

~

Music… bright lights… food… just everything the Fright Zone never had was there, for everyone to enjoy. It had been hard to convince the remnants of the Horde to join the party, but thanks

to the promise of more "Rebellion food", the princesses had finally managed to convince them.

The soldiers came in walking cautiously, as if they were expecting a trap, but as soon as they noticed that they had been lead by the palace's staff to a room full of food and music and nothing else, they began to calm down. The people of Bright Moon and many other kingdoms joined them alongside the princesses and despite a few, first awkward moments… all of them began to talk to each other, shily at first, but as time flew by, between music, food and drinks, the atmosphere grew less tense and more relaxed.

"Would you have believed it if someone back in the Fright Zone told us that one day the Horde and the Rebellion would dance and talk and laugh together?" Adora spoke as she looked around the ball room.

"Not in a million years." Catra chuckled.

"So… what do you want to do? Eat something? Are you thirsty? I could get us a few drinks if-"

"Do you wanna dance with me?" The feline suddenly asked.

Adora looked taken aback by the question, but she quickly shrugged the surprise off and smiled.

"Yeah, but do the almighty Lord Catra remember how to without stepping all over my feet?" Adora teased.

"Oh! I'm truly offended Lady Adora! A leader such as myself must excel in a great variety of activities. Dancing is one of them. Allow me to demonstrate." Catra extended a hand towards the blonde.

Adora giggled and took it. They began to dance around the room, alongside many other couples. They got a glimpse of Sea Hawk chanting a new love song to a very pissed looking Mermista, even though Adora could have sworn she had seen the ghost of a smile on the mermaid princess' face. Bow and Glimmer were dancing

around, seemingly lost in conversation and… into each other's eyes.

Spinerella and Netossa were standing right next to a column, the first rubbing the latter's back in a soothing manner, whispering something in her ear. Ivy stood in front of one of the tables, thinking of what food to try next before Frosta reached her side with two plates in her hands. The two smiled at each other as the frost princess offered one to the young cadet.

Scorpia was dancing too. Perfuma was holding her pincers and suddenly, the scorpion princess scooped her up and made her swirl around in the air as the flower princess laughed joyfully. When she put her down, the two stared at each other for a few moments. Perfuma bit her lower lip, stood up on her toes, and whispered something in the Scorpia's ear. To say her face had turned red would have been an understatement. The flower princess began to drag her away from the dance floor and Scorpia eagerly obliged.

"Have fun, Scorpia." Catra muttered under her breath as she chuckled.

"What?" Adora asked, not having heard her.

"Oh, I'm a little thirsty, I'll go fetch a drink, you want one?"

"Oh, no thank you, I'm good, I'll just wait for you."

Catra reached one of the tables and looked at the vast multitude of drinks that had been placed on it.

"What to choose… what to choose…" The feline wondered before someone reached her side.

"The red one is sooo sweet! And you have to consume it in these tiny little glasses, which makes it even more enjoyable for me!"

Catra turned around, having recognized immediately the voice.

“Entrapta…” She whispered, noticing how the scientist princess was pouring the red drink in two glasses.

“Hi Catra, are you enjoying the party?” She asked, not an ounce of resentment or anger in her voice.

“Uhm… yeah… yeah I am… what about you?”

“Oh! It would be a great opportunity to study the interactions between sides who had once been at war and now are cooperating towards a common goal… but I really can’t leave Hordak alone, and he wasn’t allowed to join the party.”

At the mention of the former Horde leader, a scowl appeared on the feline’s face, but it quickly went away as Entrapta took the two glasses in her hands and began to turn around.

“Welp, I gotta go, enjoy the rest of the night!”

“E-Entrapta wait!” Catra called out to her.

“Huh? What is it Catra?” Entrapta asked, slightly taken aback.

“I… w-why aren’t you angry at me?”

“Angry at you? Why should I be?” The scientist princess asked before the realization suddenly hit her. “Oooooh! Because you sent me to beast island, stole my work and used it to open a hole in the fabric of space and time?”

Catra grimaced at that.

“Yeah! Exactly! I mean, how can you not be?!”

“Were you hurt?” Entrapta suddenly asked.

“W-what?” Catra asked, clearly confused, where was Entrapta trying to go with this?

“Were you hurting in that moment?” The scientist princess pressed on.

Catra remained silent for a few moments before nodding.

"It's something that I understood as I studied all the people I came in contact with. People seem to… lash out sometimes when they're hurt… they do things that they wouldn't normally do… and most importantly, they regret those actions…" Entrapta explained.

"I'm sorry… about everything…" Catra said, her voice just above a whisper.

"Yeah, I know, but it's still nice to hear you say it. And obviously, I forgive you. That's what a good friend does." Entrapta said as she smiled and patted Catra's head with her pigtail. "Now I have to go, tell the others I said hi!"

"Sure…" Catra smiled at the scientist princess before she turned around and walked away.

She filled a glass with the same red drink and gulped it down.

It felt… nice…

To know that Adora had forgiven her…

To know that Mermista had forgiven her…

To know that even Entrapta had forgiven her…

When she walked back to Adora, a pair of drinks in her hands, the blonde immediately noticed the feline's smile. It wasn't devilish or euphoric, just… peacefull.

"Everything alright?" Adora asked.

And that just did it.

All the people around her were happy. Even Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio were chatting with a few soldiers from the Rebellion, smiles on their faces. The princesses were happy, the remnants of the Horde were happy and even though Prime was still out there…

it was as if for a single moment he had never even existed. And then… then there was Adora, looking at her with that dumb, warm, kind look that made her feel like every place in the universe could be her home if they were together.

Catra stepped forward and cupped Adora's cheeks before bringing their lips together.

Adora yelped in surprise, her mouth remaining still for a few moments. Then, as she realized what was happening, she closed her eyes, and kissed Catra back.

For a moment, everything was perfect.

The moment after…

Catra wasn't in the ball room anymore.

She looked around frantically, tried to call out for Adora, tried to move… but she found out that she couldn't do any of those things. She could simply stand still and look at her younger self tied to a table, Shadow Weaver towering over her.

"Let me go! I didn't do anything! Please!"

"You didn't do anything?! How dare you lie to me, ungrateful little brat!"

SLAP!

It stung even if the one who had been hit was her younger self.

"Adora told me what you did… do you think that I wouldn't have found out?"

"We didn't do anything wrong! We love each other!"

We love each other…

What… what was happening? Why did this feel so real?! Why didn't she remember any of this?!

"Adora could never love someone as pathetic as you. You're weak, you're just an animal I had to grow because of Lord Hordak's will, nothing more. You don't deserve someone like her, and she certainly doesn't deserve to be dragged down by someone as vile as you."

"You're the vile one! Let me go! Adora!"

"Adora can't hear you now. She's sleeping. I made her forget this… incident…"

"No… no… y-you wouldn't!"

"I wouldn't? I'd do even worse to ensure she'll reach her full potential. Having a side kick has done and will always do wonders to her, but a lover? You'll just be a distraction."

"You're sick."

SLAP!

"Oh, but don't worry. I'll make sure you won't distract her again. She already forgot… you'll do it too."

"No! No! Stop! St-"

Those gray hands grasped the sides of her younger self's head, and the pain she felt… Catra felt it ten times stronger.

Then…

She was finally back…

The music came back…

The chattering of the people around her came back…

Adora came back…

She stepped away from the blonde, who looked as shocked as she did.

“C-Catra…” Adora muttered, tears streaming down her cheeks.

Catra couldn’t bear to watch the blonde a moment longer. She turned around and ran away. Even when Adora called out to her, screamed her name, telling her to wait for her… she didn’t stop. There was someone she had to meet… and it wasn’t going to be a pleasant meeting.

It took Catra twenty minutes of running through endless corridors… but finally, she reached a door that lead her to a garden outside the castle. And there she was… Shadow Weaver… tending to her flowers. The red witch heard her coming. She raised her gaze and stared at Catra.

“Can’t you see that I’m busy? I don’t have time to-” Shadow Weaver spoke in a bored tone of voice, but became silent as the feline interrupted her.

“I’m going to kill you.” Catra hissed between her teeth, her voice dripping hatred and anger as she started to run towards the old witch.

“Have you gone mad?!” Shadow Weaver yelled.

She had just the time to stand up and dodge Catra’s claws, they shined under the moonlight as they came down from above her and missed her by a few inches.

“I saw it…” The feline truly sounded out of her mind.

She stepped forward and threw a kick the old witch, who conjured a magic shield which exploded into fragments of light as Catra’s hit landed on it.

“What do you think you saw?!” Shadow Weaver shouted in both anger and confusion, rays of darkness erupting from her hands, flying towards the enraged feline.

But even in this state, Catra didn’t do one single wrong move, and the red witch didn’t manage to hit her… not even once.

“I saw what you did to me and Adora! I saw you erasing our memories!” Catra screamed as she rushed towards her.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes widened… and in that exact moment the feline had no more doubts… what she saw was true.

“So, you know…” She said as she conjured a binding spell.

But before it could close around the feline, she jumped in the air. The old witch raised her hand towards Catra as she came down from the sky. The shadow ray missed her by nothing… but the feline didn’t miss her target this time. Her foot came in contact with the witch’s mask, and a loud cracking noise resonated through the air.

Shadow Weaver fell backwards, a long crack forming in the middle of her mask.

And as soon as she hit the ground, Catra was already on top of her, one hand around her neck, the other raised in the air above her face.

“We loved each other… we loved each other even before all of this! And you took that away!” Catra shouted in anger as tears started to stream down her cheeks.

“I did what I had to! To make sure Adora would reach her full potential! I couldn’t have let you drag her down! And I’d do it again if I had to!” Shadow Weaver yelled back.

“You won’t ruin any more lives.” The feline stated, raising her clawed hand, ready to strike.

The old witch gasped in horror as she saw the claws coming down upon her…

She tried to shield herself but…

The pain never came…

Instead, a scream was heard.

“Catra!”

The feline turned her head and saw Adora sprinting towards her. The blonde reached her side and kneeled down next to her.

“Don’t…” Adora pleaded.

“Do you know what she did?! What she has taken from us?!” Catra’s voice trembled.

Adora couldn’t bear to see her in this state, tears streaming down her cheeks, desperation clear on her face and in her voice. She cupped her cheeks and wiped away her cheeks.

“I know…” Adora muttered, trying to bite back a sob.

“W-what?” The feline replied, shocked.

“I’ve seen it too… w-when you kissed me…”

She had seen it… she had seen that terrible memory… then why didn’t she want to…

“But even after everything she did… she isn’t worth it… she isn’t worth a single moment of our time.” Adora spat, venom in her voice.

She stood up from the ground and offered Catra a hand…

A moment later…

Catra took it.

“A-Adora… my child…” Shadow Weaver muttered, extending a hand towards her.

“I’m not your child… I never was. I will never forgive you for what you’ve done to us, and if you even try to do something like that again… I’ll personally strike you down.”

The old witch couldn’t believe the blonde’s words.

“B-but Adora! E-everything I did, I did it for you!”

“You did it for yourself… I pity you… you’ll never know happiness, and I certainly won’t let you take ours. Let’s go, Catra.” Adora said as she gave the feline’s hand a light tug.

Catra remained silent as Adora guided her towards the castle.

None of the two turned around when they heard Shadow Weaver calling their names.

I Love You

Chapter Notes

> Hi guys! I know I know, I told you that the new chapters wouldn't have taken a lot to come out, and they won't! Still, I had this chapter between my hands and I ended up finishing it today. So I thought "Why don't I post it now and then I'll start to work on the last ones instead of publishing this one alongside the last chapters". So here you go! Enjoy the smutty chapter! It's finally here! I'll put a few "XXXXX" when the smut begins, so you can avoid it if you want. Have a good day!

The two reached Adora's bedroom, their hearts beating so fast they both thought they'd have a stroke. Adora closed the door behind them.

"Catra, are you ok-" Adora began to speak as she turned around but before she could finish, the feline pinned her against the bedroom's door.

Catra looked at her for a single moment, mismatched eyes full of nothing but hunger meeting blue ones, wide with surprise. The feline pushed against the blonde and brought their lips together.

"Catra… w-wai-" Adora tried to speak again but was silenced by another kiss.

This time though, it was different. Catra let the tip of her tongue trace the blonde's bottom lip. Adora gasped in surprise and as soon as her mouth opened, the feline pushed her tongue inside. Adora had read many romance novels during her stay in Bright Moon.

She knew what a kiss was, but she had never thought it would feel like this. Those stories always spoke of this strange feeling in one's stomach, like tiny butterflies moving around… but this… it

didn’t feel like butterflies at all. It was as if someone had just lit a fire inside of her… and it was traveling lower and lower as they continued their kiss.

XXX

Suddenly, Catra pulled back and tore away both her jacket and her shirt. She proceeded to look straight into Adora’s eyes as she slowly pulled off her top. The feline grinned in satisfaction as she saw the blonde’s face turn completely crimson. Her eyes were wide, her pupils dilatated.

Catra decided to take advantage of Adora’s momentary amazement and stepped forward. Before Adora could snap out of it, the feline slipped two fingers under the laces on her shoulders and sliced them. The white dress fell to the floor, leaving the blonde only in her underwear.

Adora’s eyes grew even wider, if that was even possible. She tried to cover herself with her hands but Catra was already on her, lips pressed firmly on hers, one hand tangled in her golden locks, the other on her back. Adora felt the tips of Catra’s claws on her back. It was… frightening… but in a good way, if that could even make sense. Then… the feline raked her nails down her spine, not hard enough to draw blood but definitely hard enough to leave marks… and Adora moaned loudly.

Without notice, Catra moved her hands from the blonde’s back to her thighs. She gripped them and hoisted Adora up. The blonde yelped in surprise. Catra pulled back from the kiss, letting her eyes linger on Adora’s both confused and dreaming gaze before latching her lips on her neck.

“C-Catra!” The blonde moaned, legs tightening around the feline’s waist, hands tangled in her mane.

Catra kept licking, sucking and biting the soft flesh as she brought Adora towards her bed. As soon as she reached it, she laid the blonde on it, immediately pouncing on her and resuming her work on her neck. After a few minutes, she rose up and kissed Adora again, deep and passionate, letting her rough tongue lick the blonde's and savor the taste of her mouth.

When she pulled back, a devilish, smug smile appeared on her face as she admired her work. Adora was a mess, a good one though. Her neck was full of marks, her lips a bit swollen, her cheeks completely red and her eyes half lidded.

"Etheria to Adora?" Catra chuckled.

"Wha… w-wha…" Adora tried to speak, finding it incredibly hard to do so.

"Take your time." The feline said, gently tracing the blonde's jaw with a claw.

"What was that?" The blonde asked as she kept gasping for air.

"I believe that is called a kiss, princess."

"I never thought kisses would feel so…" Adora struggled to find the words.

"So?" Catra snickered.

"So amazing…"

Catra faltered… there was only honesty, wonder and infinite warmth in Adora's voice… and it only made the feline want her more. She cupped the blonde's cheeks and pressed her lips to her, enjoying the little moans Adora emitted as her tongue intertwined with hers. When she pulled back, the feline licked the shell of her ear and nibbled her lobe before whispering.

"That was nothing… wanna go further?"

“F-further? W-what does t-that mean?” Adora muttered.

“Why don’t I show you?” Catra whispered on the blonde’s lips.

Adora didn’t know how to answer. She was… excited… more than she had ever been. She was also a little bit frightened. She had never felt like this before. It was new… she didn’t know what to do but Catra seemed to know. Adora trusted her… she… wanted her. That was what she was most conflicted about.

Adora had never allowed herself to want things. She always had a greater purpose in her life… to be force captain… to be She-Ra… there wasn’t the time for anything else. There wasn’t time for distractions… there wasn’t time for her wants. So the blonde had started to not to listen to them… to muffle them. But, here with Catra, with the person she cared about the most in the entire universe… those wants had come back.

And when Adora pushed herself upwards and kissed her? She knew she had given Catra her answer.

Show me…

Show me everything I had ever wanted…

I’m begging you…

Catra looked at her for a moment, eyes wide, filled with lust, and kissed her again. It was quick, as soon as it began, it ended. The feline licked her neck before nibbling the skin where she felt Adora’s pulse, she kissed her collarbone and went lower. She remained mesmerized for a moment when she finally reached the blonde’s breasts.

Full and perfect, they had grown a bit since the last time she had seen them under the showers in the Fright Zone. It didn’t matter, they were perfect then, they were perfect now. Without notice, the feline took one nipple in her mouth and sucked it as hard as she could. Adora arched her back, gripping her mane and pulling slightly, as she released a long, stuttering moan.

“D-don’t stop! It f-feels good!”

Catra switched breast and gave it a long lick, from the bottom to the tip of its nipple, before engulfing the hardened nub in her mouth and giving it a quick suck.

“It’ll feel a lot better in a few moments, I guarantee you.” Catra almost growled.

The feline kissed, licked and bit every inch of the blonde’s skin as she went lower and lower. She wanted to taste everything, everything that was Adora, the space between her breasts, her flat stomach, until she reached her thighs. That is when Catra looked up, as if to ask for permission.

Permission for what?

Adora had no idea, but she also had no intention to stop the feline now.

The blonde nodded.

Catra pushed her legs apart and kissed her inner thigh. She shifted her gaze and finally focused her attention on Adora’s core. She was completely soaked.

“You’re so beautiful.” Catra whispered in awe.

“C-Catra, w-what are you d-” Adora tried to ask.

Catra had to thank Perfuma’s idea. If there hadn’t been a party going on, the entire castle would have heard the blonde’s scream as the feline’s rough tongue came in contact with her wet folds. Adora’s hands flew to Catra’s mane. The feline grabbed her legs and put them on her shoulders. She could feel Adora arching into her, wanting her, screaming her name again, again and again. It only made her hungrier. She kept licking her core until, in a rush of boldness, she decided to push her tongue inside. Adora suddenly squeezed her head between her thigs for a moment before letting her go.

“S-sorry! D-did I hurt you?”

“Idiot. Always worrying, even in a moment like this.” Catra thought. “No, you didn’t hurt me.”

She kissed the blonde’s thigh as to reassure her and resumed her work. Catra kept going for a few minutes and Adora’s yells of pleasure getting louder and louder only fueled her to continue. After a while, she felt her breaths coming out ragged, heavy and uneven. She was close.

“C-Catra, s-something is… something is coming!” Adora stuttered loudly.

Catra had to refrain herself from laughing. Adora could be so clueless sometimes.

“Yeah, you.” The feline replied, before closing her lips around the blonde’s hard nub and giving it a long, hard suck.

Even with a party as loud as the one that was going on downstairs, Catra couldn’t believe that no one had heard Adora. As she came, she released such a loud, stuttering cry, that the feline believed the bedroom’s walls would have crumbled to the ground.

“There you go.” Catra whispered, giving the blonde a few more licks, before kissing her way up to her lips.

She planted a deep, firm kiss on Adora’s lips before nestling in the crook of her neck, enjoying the blonde’s gasps for air.

“That… that was… that was amazing…” Adora spoke breathlessly.

“Glad you liked it princess.” Catra chuckled.

“Y-you’re amazing.”

“Thanks, glad you finally figured it out.”

“I love you.”

…

…

…

“A-Adora…” Catra raised her face only for her cheeks to be cupped by the blonde, who brought her into a loving, gentle kiss.

Adora pulled back and pressed their foreheads together.

“I love you. I always have. I’m sorry it took me so long to realize it. But I’m tired of keeping inside me what I feel, what I want. I want you, I love you.” Seeing Catra’s eyes widen, Adora’s voice grew less secure. “Y-you don’t need to tell me if you don’t-”

Catra brought the blonde into another kiss before muttering on her lips.

“I love you too…”

That single sentence seemed to rekindle the fire inside Adora. The blonde suddenly flipped them and Catra found herself with her back on the mattress. Before she could protest, Adora bent down and kissed her, licking her bottom lip as if she was asking for permission to come in. The feline chuckled into the kiss and opened her mouth, letting the blonde’s tongue roam free inside. After a few minutes, Adora pulled back, flushed red but with a look of determination on her face.

“Your turn.”

Catra suddenly felt self-conscious… which didn’t really make sense to her. But as soon as Adora cupped her cheeks, she felt that strange feeling fade away.

“If you don’t want it, it’s okay, I want you to be happy Catra.”

She loved her.

Catra was one hundred percent sure she was in love with this stupid, caring, buff blonde.

"I… I want you to…" Catra muttered before hesitating and looking away.

Adora simply smiled mischievously and began to kiss and suck the skin of her neck.

"A-Adora…" The feline whispered in a stuttering voice.

But it wasn't enough. The blonde rose from Catra's neck and without a warning, she gave her ear a long, slow lick, from the base to the tip, which she bit for good measure. She didn't expect a big reaction but starts, she did get one. Catra's hands flew to her shoulders as she bit down on her bottom lip, trying to contain a low, almost animalistic moan. But still… it wasn't enough. And it wasn't enough for Adora even when she went lower and, taken by a sudden hunger, she took one Catra's hardened buds in her mouth, while she grasped the other soft globe of flesh and squeezed it gently. That's when the feline started purring. Adora rose up from her chest, giving her a smug look.

"D-don't look at me like t-that… you suck at this…" Catra mumbled as she looked away, her cheeks flushed red.

"Oh, you really think so?" Adora asked, that unlimited determination back in her voice.

The feline turned her head only to see the blonde kiss the skin between her breasts, her stomach, going lower and lower until she reached her center. Catra expected the blonde to be clueless, after all, she didn't even know what they were doing. She expected her to hesitate. But Adora had never been one to hesitate. The blonde simply grabbed her thighs, hooked the feline's legs around her shoulders and immediately dived in.

"A-Adora!" Catra screamed at the top her lungs.

Adora hadn't started slow. She licked her folds up and down, stopping only to take her nub into her mouth and sucking it hard, before going back to using her tongue.

"Say that you love me." Adora growled before continuing her work.

"I l-love you, I love y-you, I love you s-so much! Please don't stop!" Catra begged her.

"I'll never stop, you taste so good."

"A-ah! I'm… I'm coming!"

"Come for me kitty."

That's when Adora used her thumbs to part her folds and slid her tongue inside. Catra pulled the blonde's hair and shouted in ecstasy. Her vision became white for a moment, then, she collapsed on the bed. Adora gave her a few more licks before she rose up and laid down next to her. Catra immediately turned towards her and kissed her, before embracing her, resting her head in the crook of Adora's neck.

XXX

"You seemed… so clueless at the beginning. W-what happened?" Catra asked, still trying to catch her breath.

"Uhm… I… I did what you did… that's it. I didn't really know what I was doing. I don't… I don't even know what this is…" Adora's bold demeanor had suddenly faded away.

"It's something I got to witness as Second in Command. I could watch over basically every place inside the Fright Zone. There are

cameras even in places people wouldn't even think to find one. Aaaand let's just say that I saw a few Force Captains doing this."

"You… You ever did this with anyone else?"

"Jealous, princess?"

"N-no! I just… I just wanted to k-know if-"

Catra raised her head and cupped the blonde's cheeks.

"Adora? You were my first…"

"Y-you were m-mine too…"

"I think I had understood that… 'come for me kitty'? Ugh, really?"

"W-wha-! W-well, I didn't know what to say! I-it was the heat of the moment and I-" Adora stuttered, trying to justify herself, even though she fell silent as Catra placed a finger on her lips.

"Adora, I was jocking… you… it was amazing. You are amazing."

Adora gasped lightly in surprise. Catra never talked to her like this, of course, she knew the feline loved her, and she loved her too, but hearing her speak like this… it made her heart flutter. She closed the distance between the two of them and kissed her, slowly, trying to savor Catra for as long as she could. The two broke apart and Adora placed a hand on the feline's cheek.

"You're amazing too." She said, a happy, almost goofy smile on her face.

"Thanks for noticing." Catra chuckled.

They hugged each other, wanting to be as close as possible… and fell asleep…

One hour later…

A cry woke them up.

Author's note: FInal chapters coming!

I'm aliveeeee! And right before the start of my final year's lessons, I'm gonna bring you the last, four chapters of this story! The Trap, Family, Halfmoon and The Last Stand will be published respectively on September the 24th, the 25th, the 26th and the 27th. I hope you'll enjoy the ending of my story! Thank you for having being with me this whole time!

The Trap

Chapter Notes

Here we are with the first of the last four chapters of my story! Enjoy, and comment!

"Entrapta…" Hordak sounded… tired.

"Hordak! I just went down to the party! It's a great opportunity to study the social behavior of the people of Etheria!" Entrapta explained, her smile growing larger as she noticed a small grin appearing on the former Horde leader's face.

"Why didn't you stay there then?"

"I wouldn't leave a friend alone all night long." The scientist princess said, her usual cheerful tone replaced by quieter, warmer one.

Hordak seemed taken aback by Entrapta's words and… something that looked like guilt flashed through his eyes before it was replaced by a more curious look.

"What is that?" Hordak said, pointing at the plate that the princess was holding.

"Oh! It is called cake! It's a really sweet food! I thought you might have liked it!"

It was strange. Hordak had never felt this way in his entire life. He had been created to serve Horde Prime, to help his master in his endless conquest of the universe. An unbreakable faith in Prime, an unwavering determination and the most burning rage towards the enemies of his creators… those were the only things the

former Horde's leader had felt during his life. But now… this small princess had managed to make him feel something new…

Something he didn't dare to name…

But it was something that he desperately wanted to keep feeling…

So he inhaled, and let out a long sigh a few moments after…

"Why are you doing this?" Hordak whispered.

"You're my lab partner, my friend! This is what friends do!" Entrapta's cheerful demeanor came back only to vanish a few seconds later, when she heard Hordak's next words.

"Drop the barrier…"

"W-what?" The scientist princess asked, confusion clear in her voice.

"You convinced them to spare me… to let me stay here. They created this barrier… but their mages… their tricks are nothing compared to your intellect. You already know how do it right? How to break these walls." Hordak said, placing a hand on the magical barrier, ignoring the zap it gave him.

"H-Hordak… I can't…" Entrapta's voice wavered.

"Do you want to slide that plate inside this cage? As if I'm nothing more than an animal? I want to be able to share it with you. You've already saved me from myself Entrapta… from Prime… you've proven that I can call you a friend. Now let me prove to you that I'm yours."

A few, endless moments went by, uncertainty written all over the princess' face…

Then…

The girl stepped forward and placed a small, circular device near the magical barrier. Light erupted from it… and with a bright flash… the wall was gone.

“I trust you.” Entrapta said, smiling up at the dumbfounded clone.

Hordak shook off his surprise and stepped towards the princess, suddenly enveloping her in a tight hug. It was stiff. After all he had never done this with anyone else… ever. But the pigtailed princess simply sighed and circled his back with her arms.

“I’m sorry.”

Entrapta raised her head to meet his gaze.

Hordak pinched the side of her neck.

Everything went dark.

~

“D-did you hear that?!” Adora asked, getting up from bed.

“Yeah, it came from nearby…” Catra answered as she jumped off the mattress and quickly put her uniform back on.

“Catra… it sounded like…” The blonde murmured as she hastily dressed herself.

“Ivy…”

The two exchanged a worried look and immediately rushed towards the bedroom’s door. They ran through the corridors, only picking up the pace as another scream rang through the castle’s halls. Then… as they took one last turn… their gazes fell upon two figures. One, tall with white skin and bluish hair. The other one… little… with curly hair. It kept squirming and trashing around as

the tall one hoisted it up its shoulder. Adora and Catra got closer and finally… they saw them… Ivy and…

Hordak…

"Hordak!" Catra roared as she broke into a full sprint towards the former Horde's leader.

Hordak simply turned around and began to run.

"C-Catra! Catra help me!" Ivy screamed, extending her arms towards the feline.

Adora began to run only to stop in front of the room the clone had come out of. Her eyes widened at the sight of Entrapta lying on the ground, unconscious.

"Adora! We gotta move! He's gonna get away!" Catra yelled.

She was ready to chase Hordak, but as soon as she took a step in his direction, a hand grasped her arm.

"Adora?!" The feline turned around, her voice coming out harsher than she intended.

"I'll take care of him, you warn the others and get help for Entrapta." Adora pointed towards the pigtailed princess.

"Adora…" Catra sounded unsure.

The blonde quickly closed the distance between them and pressed a quick kiss to the feline's lips. She pulled back and raised her arm in the air.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

After a bright flash of light, Adora was gone, and She-Ra stood in front of her.

"He won't outrun Swifty. And he won't outrun She-Ra."

Catra found herself nodding. She trusted her. She trusted Adora.

“Go get him.” The feline declared.

Adora nodded and broke into a run. Catra turned the other way, and rushed through the palace’s corridors. It didn’t take long for her to reach the ball room. Everyone was still there. The feline’s eyes quickly scanned the room, trying to find Glimmer.

“Hey cat girl!” The young queen’s voice caught her off guard.

Catra swirled around and found herself into a tight embrace.

“Where have you been? Where’s Ador-” Glimmer began to talk but immediately fell silent as the feline pushed her away.

“Hordak’s escaped.”

The young queen’s face turned white.

“W-what?”

“He’s gone and he’s taken Ivy with him.” Catra explained quickly.

“Oh no…” Glimmer muttered in horror as she covered her mouth.

“Hey guys! Enjoying the… party?” Netossa’s tone turned from cheerful to worried as she noticed the looks on the two’s faces.

“Glimmer? Is something wrong?” Spinerella caught up to them, followed by Frosta and Bow.

“You two look super pale…” The archer mumbled.

“Yeah, and did any of you see Ivy? She said she was going to the bathroom, but I think she’s still wandering around the castle trying to find it all by herself…” The ice princess asked as she kept looking around.

“Hordak’s gone.” Glimmer stuttered, her voice shaky.

“What?!” Everyone shouted.

“Hey, not to interrupt or something… but you all look like… really freaked out… isn’t this supposed to be a party?” Mermista said as she reached the group, Sea Hawk standing by her side.

“Hordak escaped and he took Ivy with him! Adora is chasing them, but Entrapta is hurt so she told me to warn all of you! We gotta move, now!” Catra explained swiftly.

“W-what do we do?!” Glimmer asked, panic clear in her voice.

“Glimmer, you and Bow come with me, we can still catch up to Adora if we move quickly. The others can take care of Entrapta, she’s in Hordak’s holding room. We don’t know how he got out, someone who helped him could still be around, be careful.” The feline warned the group.

“Hey! If Hordak took Ivy, I’m gonna come with you! I’ll turn him into a popsicle when we’ll catch him!” Frosta declared as a pair of ice gloves covered her hands.

“Okay.” Catra’s expression turned from worried to mildly amused for a second before she spoke again. “Everyone’s ready?”

Everyone nodded. And then they were off. Catra, Glimmer, Bow and Frosta rushed for the palace’s exit, while Mermista, Sea Hawk, Netossa and Spinerella quickly reached the spare room in which Hordak had been imprisoned.

“There she is!” The feline exclaimed as she saw the typical golden aura of She-Ra by the edge of the Whispering Woods.

“Catra…” Glimmer grasped her shoulder.

The feline turned towards the young queen and noticed how her gaze wasn’t fixed on Adora, but on something above the woods. When she raised her head, her mouth fell open.

A Horde’s ship…

It was hovering above the Whispering Woods, not far away from where Adora was. They had to be quick. Whatever was happening… it couldn't be anything good. The small group rushed towards the forest. A few Horde soldiers came up to them, asking for an explanation, saying they had seen someone enter the woods, a screaming kid hoisted up on their shoulder, and that She-Ra had appeared short after. Catra didn't stop running. She turned her head and gave them a quick warning.

"Prime is here!"

The soldier's eyes widened, and they immediately went back to the camp and began to warn everyone. The feline must have heard Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio calling her name, but she didn't have time… she had to catch Hordark, she had to save Ivy and… she couldn't leave Adora alone.

She-Ra's aura grew brighter and brighter and it didn't take long for the group to reach her…

"A-Adora…" Catra muttered as she stopped running.

Then, her mismatched eyes shifted from the blonde to Hordak…

He was standing a few feet away from Adora. He had put Ivy down, keeping her by his side… a clawed hand closed around her neck.

"It'll take nothing to kill her." Hordak warned the group.

Catra snarled and took one step towards him.

"If you hurt her, I'll cut you into a million pieces…" The feline growled.

"You'll all stay where you are if you care about this child." The former Horde leader declared, his grip becoming tighter.

The young girl yelped in pain.

“Stop it! You’re hurting her!” Frosta cried.

“You should have all kneeled in front of the great Prime! He is the emperor of the entire universe and your feeble strength is nothing compared to his power!” Hordak shouted in anger.

“Why did you take Ivy?!” Adora asked, dismounting Swift Wind and slightly raising her sword.

“You are nothing but fools…” He suddenly chuckled. “I knew I couldn’t have gotten away if I tried to escape on my own… but now? Prime is here for me… and not only I managed to bring him She-Ra… I also managed to kill a few of his enemies…”

“We’re all still breathing Hordak!” Glimmer shouted as sparkles began to erupt from her fists.

“Not for long…” Hordak smiled devilishly and pointed a finger to the sky.

That was when they finally saw it. The black ship had reached them. A beam of green light came down from it and before anyone could do something… Hordak threw Ivy towards Adora. The blonde caught the kid but as she raised her gaze towards the former Horde leader, she saw that he had been already invested by the green light. Moments after, it faded… leaving nothing behind.

“H-he got away.” Bow muttered.

Everything became still for a second… until Ivy broke the deafening silence.

“Watch out!” The little girl cried as she pointed at the sky.

And when everyone turned their gazes towards the black ship… they saw it. A red light, growing larger and larger… a menacing sound growing louder and louder before a single, glowing projectile was shot towards them.

“Adora!” Swift Wind cried.

It all happened in a few moments.

Adora threw Ivy towards Catra and summoned her shield.

The feline caught the little girl between her arms and watched as Frosta raised her arms above her head.

Walls of ice surrounded them…

Then…

The explosion…

Then…

The darkness…

Halfmoon

Chapter Notes

> Still two chapters to go guys! I'm so excited that I've been able to bring you this story, and even though it's ending, I hope you've all enjoyed this little tale!

Fire was all around her…

She could see her red dress…

The one who took Katrina's life was carrying her…

She watched over her shoulder and stared as the village grow more and more distant…

They had reached a hill…

The fire was almost out of sight when her eyes focused on a figure…

A man in a silver armor…

His blue eyes met her mismatched ones…

He took a step towards her…

But then he hesitated…

He crouched to the ground…

The wails of an infant… her wails… resonated through the night air…

The man turned and ran away…

He left her… left her to cry…

The village burned…

Everything disappeared behind the hill…

Everything.

~

"Don't leave me!" Catra screamed as she woke up.

She found herself sitting on a soft blanket… her arm outstretched towards nothing. She was breathing hard and only after a few moments she realized that her cheeks were wet with tears. Catra grunted in anger as she quickly wiped them away with the palms of her hands.

"What is wrong with me… why am I seeing this…" The feline muttered.

"Katrina! You're awake!"

The feline yelped and jumped on her feet. A mistake she realized she had made a little bit too late. Everything hurt. But why did everything… Suddenly, Catra remembered. Hordak escaping Bright Moon, taking Ivy with him… the spaceship teleporting him away and attacking them soon after… Ivy! Adora! Glimmer, Bow and Frosta! Where-

"Are you alright deary?"

The voice suddenly pulled Catra out of her thoughts and the feline jumped away, yelping in pain as she fell ungracefully on the ground. Her mismatched finally focused on the one who had just spoke. It was an old lady, with long, white hair. She wore a pink dress and a pair of yellow glasses. She started to step closer to the feline who hissed and crawled back.

"S-stay away from me!" Catra growled, claws half drawn.

“Don’t you recognize me Katrina? It’s me! Madame Razz!” The old lady didn’t look scared by Catra’s warning.

Suddenly, the feline’s expression went from angered to confused.

“Where… where did you hear that name?” Catra asked, her voice turning shaky.

“That name?” Madame Razz tilted her head to the side before howling with laughter, “Silly Katrina! It is yours!”

Catra remained baffled for a moment before she snarled and stood up from the ground.

“You’re not making any sense, but I don’t care, I gotta find-”

“Your friends?” The old lady concluded her phrase.

The feline’s eyes widened.

“H-how do you-”

“They’re here!” Madame Razz stepped aside, showing Catra the rest of her home.

A few covers had been sprawled all over the ground, and a few figures were laying on them. The feline recognized them immediately. Glimmer, Bow, Frosta and Ivy. Even Adora’s dumb horse, what was his name again? Swifty?

“They were a little roughed up, but nothing that Madame Razz couldn’t fix! They have to rest… but after that, they’ll be good as new!”

Catra’s expression softened.

“You… healed them?” She asked.

“Of course! They’re Mara’s friends!”

Mara…

“Who’s friends?” Catra asked, once again confused by the old woman’s words.

“She-Ra!”

“You mean… Adora?” The feline asked, suddenly noticing the blonde’s absence.

“Adora… Adora… oh! Adora! Yes!” Madame Razz suddenly looked like she had just remembered something, “Katrina! You have to go and save her!”

“S-save her? Where is she?” Catra’s voice came out laced with panic.

“The ship took her! I wasn’t fast enough…”

“Adora…” Catra muttered, eyes wide, gaze set on the floor.

She couldn’t protect her… she couldn’t protect Adora. After everything that had happened between the two of them, after all the pain they had inflicted to each other… after everything they had been through… the universe still gave them the chance to be together. Catra loved Adora, she was tired of hiding it, of denying it. Adora loved her… she was sure of it. And Prime… Prime made the fatal mistake of standing between them. He wasn’t going to take Adora from her… Catra would have ripped her out of his cold, dead hands…

“I need to go… please watch over them while I’m gone.” The feline declared, before a hand grasped her wrist.

“But Katrina! How are you going to save Adora if you don’t have your crown?” Madame Razz asked.

Her… crown?

“Listen old lady, I don’t know who this Katrina is supposed to be or why do you think that I’m her, but my name is Catra, and I

don’t have any crown so-” Catra yelped as the old lady dragged her outside, interrupting her.

“Oh! Madame Razz knows where it is! You must have forgotten it at home, didn’t you?”

The feline groaned. What was Madame Razz talking about? Why did she know the name of the woman of her dreams? Why did she call her by her name? What was this crown she was blabbering about? And where was she taking her?!

“Listen lady, I need to- woah!” Catra yelped as she ducked under a branch.

She didn’t realize that they had begun to run, and pretty fast too. How was this old lady dragging her at such a speed?

“I need to go and save Adora!”

“You won’t save her if don’t have your crown! The runestones are powerful, but not enough to defeat the Great Shadow Above! Only She-Ra and her most powerful ally can hope to banish him!” Madame Razz tried to explain.

It made Catra even more confused.

“Her most powerful ally?! A-are you talking about me?!”

“Of course! The Queen of the Magicats have always been destined to bring peace to the universe alongside She-Ra! Or… have they already done it? Bah! Who knows!” The old lady giggled.

“Q-Queen of w-what?! Alright, that’s enough!” Catra declared as she untangled herself from Razz’s grip. “You’re not making any sense! I-I’m not a queen or a princess or anything like that! I grew up in the Horde!”

Madame Razz stared at her for a few moments before turning around and starting to wipe the forest’s ground with her broom.

“Wha… are you listening to me?!” The feline walked up to the old lady and gripped her shoulders, “Adora could be hurt right now! Prime could be doing who knows what to her and I…” Catra suddenly felt tears starting to stream down her cheeks, “I love her… and I need to be there for her… please…”

The old lady reached up and brushed the feline’s tears away with her thumbs.

“Oh… oh, dear Catra… I didn’t recognize you… but I see you now. You’ve been… seeing things, right? In your dreams…”

Catra’s eyes widened in surprise.

“H-how do you know?”

“I can’t tell you who you are, deary, but I can show you where you’ll be able to know… where you’ll be able to remember.” Madame Razz took a step backwards.

Suddenly, Catra’s eyes fell on the ground that Razz had just wiped with her broom. Where there was once dirt… now the feline could see a large, circular platform made of stone. It had strange symbols engraved in it and… tall, thin figures with long manes and… ears that looked exactly like hers.

The figures were all kneeling in front of a figure that stood in the center of the platform. It was just like them but… much, much larger. The figure stood on four legs and looked more bestial than the other ones. But what surprised Catra the most was her crown…

The same crown Katrina wore in her dreams…

It looked like…

Her mask…

“What… what is this?” Catra asked as she turned towards Madame Razz, who had begun to walk away.

The old lady turned her head and smiled.

"Your home. Face whatever awaits you down there deary… and you'll have the power to save the one you love."

And just like that, Madame Razz walked away. Catra tried to call out for her but she was already gone, too far into the woods to hear the feline calling. Catra gulped and turned towards the stone platform. It was strange but… it was almost as if she felt like all of her dreams had been trying to guide her here. Home… as Madame Razz called it. Catra didn't know what she was going to find wherever the old lady had brought her… but she had saved both her and her friends… and the feline decided to trust her.

Whatever was down there…

Whatever power Madame Razz was talking about…

It would have helped Catra save Adora…

That's all that mattered.

The feline took a deep breath and stepped over the platform. Everything seemed to go quiet for a moment… then… the platform began to vibrate… and to descend underground. Catra gulped as she was brought lower and lower into the ground, until the light above her completely disappeared.

She always hated darkness… it would remind her of Shadow Weaver… and the times she had locked her up into that old, malodourous storage room near the cadets' barracks. But right now… Catra felt a strange sense of ease pervading her. Her eyes adjusted to the darkness and suddenly, after what felt like an eternity… the platform stopped.

A dim light appeared in front of her, then another, then another one. A trail of small flames lit up a small pathway. Catra looked around and found out that the platform had brought her into a cave. The path in front of her seemed the only way out.

“For Adora…” Catra muttered, as she began to follow the trail of lights.

Step after step, the feline began to wonder if the path the lights were guiding her on would have ever come to an end. It was far too quiet around her, and Catra didn’t like it one bit. It made her thoughts unbearably loud, impossible not to listen to.

“If you were stronger, Adora would be here with you.”

“You’re walking this path alone.”

“Just like you’ve always done… just like you’ll always be.”

“You don’t even know who you are.”

The thoughts got louder and louder as time went by. Catra covered her ears, gritting her teeth as she kept walking the path in front of her. It was exactly when the feline thought there would be no end to the gallery she was stuck in… that finally she saw it. A brighter light coming from a small hole at the end of the rocky road.

She began to run towards it, the booming voice inside her head growing weaker as she got closer to the hole. Then, finally, she reached it. Catra had to crouch to slide through the gap, and when she emerged from the other side…

Her mouth fell open…

A cave larger than any other she had ever seen appeared in front of her. She looked right and left and found out that she couldn’t see the end of it. When she raised her gaze, her eyes grew wide as she noticed that the ceiling had to be at least six hundred feet above the ground. Behind her, Catra noticed how she had emerged from only one of the many holes that had been carved into the cave’s wall.

But what took Catra most by surprise… was what the cave contained.

A city… surrounded by a tall, sturdy-looking wall of stones.

The entrance resembled the head of the creature she had seen at the center of the platform, but with its mouth opened…

The same creature that wore Katrina's crown.

Catra gulped, and began to descend the road that would bring her to the entrance of the mysterious city. Her mind must have begun to play tricks on her, because as she grew closer to the gigantic entrance, her ears started to pick up small noises… pebbles being kicked… doors being shut… voices whispering. However, as soon as she took one step beyond the entrance, everything became quiet… even quieter than her journey through the gallery.

"Catra…"

The feline yelped. Someone had just said her name. Someone had just called her. It was the strangest thing, because even though Catra realized that the voice came from inside her head, it seemed to be guiding her somewhere… somewhere close…

She kept walking, eyes darting around quickly, trying to spot anything that could be waiting for her, anything that could have been ready to hurt her. But the streets of the city were completely empty, illuminated by small fires which were contained in some kind of glass chambers, held high above the ground by tall pillars of metal.

The street she was following was the largest one. At its sides, Catra could see dozens and dozens of houses, shops and smaller streets, going far beyond where she could see. She kept walking what looked like the main street of the mysterious city as the voice beckoned her, calling her name, begging her to come closer… to come home.

"Come home…"

Catra shook her head. This wasn't her home, the Horde was where she had grown up, that is the place she had always called

home…

But…

Was it?

Without even noticing, the feline had left behind her the city, and found herself in front of a large palace. It had to be as tall as the one in Bright Moon, and the point of its highest tower shined as a small ray of sun passed through a small gap in the cavern's ceiling, hitting it. The familiar voice called her again, this time more clearly. It sounded like… like she was begging Catra to reach her…

It was Katrina's voice… without a doubt.

"W-why do you want me to go in there…" Catra muttered to herself more than to the voice.

"Please…"

Catra gulped… and quickly passed through the castle's gates. It was so strange… a palace usually had guards defending it… Glimmer's was filled with tall women with shiny armors, spears and swords… but this one? It was as deserted as the city she had just walked through. But… she could still feel it… the smell of something… things… that were alive. She could still hear it… shushed whispers and quiet movements…

Was she going mad?

The voice inside her head only made Catra consider that hypothesis more and more.

But then…

Suddenly…

The voice stopped.

It was as if Catra could finally understand what was surrounding her. She raised her gaze and found herself in front of a large double door made of stone. Engraved in it, she could see two faces. One, looked exactly like Katrina's… the other… the other looked like the man she spoke to in her dreams… the man with blue eyes… the man who fled when…

Catra shook her head. She was tired of this nonsense. She was tired of these dreams… and she was tired of not having Adora between her arms. Whatever power Madame Razz spoke about… whatever truth she would find beyond those doors… she was ready to find out. She inhaled deeply, and pushed the doors open.

The room she found herself in, looked very much like Bright Moon palace's throne room. It was vast, well-lit by torches stuck to the walls, and by a large chandelier that hung from the ceiling. Catra's mismatched eyes traveled across the room and finally came to a stop when her gaze fell upon the two thrones at the far end of the room.

It wasn't the one on the right that made her breath stop… even though she had recognized Katrina's golden mask laying on it… it was the left one. And that simple looking stone throne had that particular effect on the feline because…

It wasn't empty.

Family

Chapter Notes

Let's play a game, spot the three movie references!

Catra stared at the figure sitting on the throne with her mouth agape. It was tall figure, completely encased in a silver armor, with a golden crown embedded in its helmet. For a single moment, the feline thought that whoever was sitting on the throne… had to be dead. But as she took a single step forward… the figure which once sat completely still, with its head bent over its crossed fingers… suddenly raised its face.

Mismatched eyes stared into two minuscule holes in the figure helmet's face plate… and whatever was behind that face made of silver… stared back.

A few, silent moments went by… then… the figure's shoulders began to shake, and soon, the sound of a deranged laughter filled the throne room. The sound sent chills down Catra's spine, but it was nothing compared to the dread she felt when the knight in silver armor began to speak.

"Are you seeing this, my dear Katrina?" The figure spoke as they extended a hand towards the other throne and lightly caressed the edge Katrina's golden mask.

Catra's breath hitched.

"First she comes into our village… she slaughters our people, burns their homes… then, she takes you from me…" The figure suddenly hesitated, their voice slightly cracking, "And then… she takes our daughter away…"

No…

It… it couldn’t be…

“Our little Catra…”

The feline let out a strangled noise. The dreams she had… they… they weren’t just dreams, they were memories. The village that burned… it wasn’t a simple village, it was her home. The infant that cried in that crib… the baby that witch took away, it wasn’t just any child… she was that child. And… Katrina and Mathias… they weren’t just two people caught in a war. Katrina and Mathias were…

Katrina and Mathias were her parents.

The figure that stood at the end of the throne room… was her father.

Suddenly, Catra’s train of thoughts was interrupted by the tall, armored man standing up.

“And now… she decides that that’s not enough. She decides to come here… and mock me with *her* image.” Mathias growled as he lifted his hand from the golden mask and brought it to the hilt of his sword.

Catra wanted to speak, she wanted to with all of her heart… but words didn’t come to her.

All of what was happening…

It was too much.

“What did you do to our Catra, Shadow Weaver?”

The feline’s eyes grew wide at the man’s words. Shadow Weaver… the witch that struck down her mother… that took her away from her village… it was Shadow Weaver. Catra clenched her eyes shut,

balled her fists and gritted her teeth as anger, hatred and sadness pervaded her all at once.

Matthias began to walk towards her, sword in hand.

“Did you torture her? Kill her?” The man’s voice came out shaky, “My Katrina was everything you could never be, strong, determined, respected, revered… beautiful… and our Catra would have grown up to be the same. And that is why you hated them so much, didn’t you? But now… now I’ll avenge both of them.”

The armored man raised his sword in the air and turned his head upwards.

“Are you watching us now, my loves?! Tonight these halls shall run crimson with the blood of the one that destroyed our family!”

“W-wait!”

Finally, finally something clicked inside Catra, and words came back to her. She extended a hand towards the tall man… towards Mathias… towards her father… but it was too late. He broke into a sprint towards her, sword held tight between his hands. Mathias jumped in the air and came down with such force, that when Catra dodged his sword, making it come in contact with the ground, the floor shattered.

“Stop!” Catra cried, but to no vail.

Another swipe of Mathias’ sword almost cut her neck, and blow after blow Catra realized that she would have never been able to make him stop… but… that would have meant that she’d need to fight back…

“Stop this! I’m not Shadow Weaver!” The feline shouted as she ducked under another swipe of the man’s sword.

“Silence!” Mathias replied, kicking her in the stomach as she avoided his blow, sending her to the ground. “You’re not going to ruin any more lives!”

Catra rolled to the side as her father's sword came down once again, edging itself in the throne room's floor.

"Now or never."

The feline jumped upwards and landed on Mathias' shoulders. She propelled herself in the air and came down, sending a powerful kick to the man's back. He cried out in pain and stumbled forward, managing to pull the sword's blade out of the stone floor.

"We don't need to fight, I'm-" Catra made the mistake of trying to speak once more, stepping closer to the man.

Mathias cried out as he turned around, throwing a blind hit. The edge of his blade cut through Catra's side. The feline stumbled backwards and fell to the ground, clutching the wound tightly as a few droplets of blood fell on the floor. It wasn't deep, but it would have definitely slowed her down.

"Look at me…" Mathias breathed heavily, towering above her. "This is for everything you've done to my family… to the magicats…"

"What you're doing now is killing the last bit of that family!" Catra shouted back.

Mathias was raising his sword above the feline's head, but as he heard those words, he hesitated… and Catra took the opportunity. She kicked the man's leg, who fell to his knees with a grunt. Mathias cried out in rage, trying to raise his sword once again, but the feline was quicker, and kicked him again in the stomach, making him fall to the ground. His sword slipped from his fingers, flying in the air above them. Catra jumped off the ground, grabbed its hilt, and landed on her feet. Mathias merely managed to push himself onto his knees when his own blade touched his neck. He raised his gaze and met Catra's.

"Go on… do it… at least I'll be able to see my family again."

Catra simply stared at him.

“Do it!” Mathias cried, gripping his helmet, lifting it and throwing it to ground.

The feline could finally see the man underneath the silver armor. He had short, white air, a well-kept, mid length beard and… and blue eyes… just like her right one. Catra let the sword fall to the ground. It clattered loudly as it hit the floor, as the feline took a step backwards. Her expression shifted, from anger to sadness.

“You’re looking at it right now…”

Silence…

Mathias opened his mouth to speak… but no sound came out.

“You… if you were Shadow Weaver… you’d have no reason to spare me…” He muttered, his eyes focused on the ground before he once again raised his gaze to met hers.

Blue eyes met mismatched ones.

“Catra…” Mathias whispered, his voice on the edge of breaking, as tears started to pool in his eyes.

He stepped forward, extending a hand towards her cheek, but the feline stepped back, avoiding his gaze.

“You left me…” The feline whispered.

Mathias let his hand fall to his side. He lowered his gaze in shame for a moment, before he raised it once again.

“I wanted to follow you… but I had no choice.”

Catra would have once believed what he had just told her… but now… now she knew.

“We always have a choice… you had a choice when you decided to run away.” The feline met his gaze, eyes glossy, resentment clear in her voice.

He had run away.

There was no denying it.

But he had already lost his daughter once, he wasn't going to lose her again.

Mathias hesitated for a moment before he spoke again.

"Your mother was dying."

Catra's lips twitched.

"You were nowhere to be seen…" Mathias spoke as his gaze seemed lost into nothingness. "I was afraid…"

Remembering that night… it hurt more than anything else in the world... but he owed his daughter an explanation.

"Your mother had sent me to escort a large group of magicats to Halfmoon, this underground city. She knew that the Horde was going to attack our village, so she sent me and her best warriors to bring our people to safety. I thought I would have had more time… but when I came back…"

A tear slipped from Mathias' left eye.

"I reached our home… but the Horde had already burned it. I reached Katrina's tent… and that's when I saw you. Shadow Weaver had taken you… Hordak was at her side… there were so many soldiers… but I would have faced each and every one of them… for you." Mathias took another step forward, feeling his heart clench at the sight of his own daughter stepping back. "But then… I heard her calling my name."

Catra gasped lightly.

"Katrina… she had crawled outside her tent. I knelt down and held her as she slipped away. But… before she died, she took my hand in hers and told me: 'If you go now… she'll lose both of us. Go

back, protect our people… protect Half Moon and… one day… when she'll come back… then you'll know you'll have the power to fight back…'."

The old man took another step towards her, and this time, Catra remained still.

"I wanted to save you, I wanted to destroy them all… for everything that they had done to us. But… I knew your mother was right. If I had tried to save you then… you would have lost your entire family. Still… there hasn't been a day I haven't felt regret for leaving you in their hands." The old man muttered in a shaking voice as he closed the distance between him and the feline.

"I did something terrible to you… I haven't been there for you. It's the worse thing a father could do. The magicats decided to follow Katrina's orders, to wait for your return… and I was too afraid to lead them to their demise to encourage them to fight back immediately." Mathias sighed heavily, "I'm not asking for your forgiveness… I just want you to know to understand…"

Catra watched Mathias straight into his eyes. He wasn't lying… and even though what he did hurt her… how could she deprive this man of the only family he had left? He could have come for her… but the fear to lose his people, to let down the one he had loved… to lose his daughter forever… it made him stay in the dark.

Something she was very familiar with.

"I've… I've done terrible things too…" Catra muttered.

Mathias raised a hand towards her, and this time, she didn't back away. She let him cradle her cheek as he spoke once again, his expression turning so loving and desperate at the same time, Catra felt a pang to her heart.

"I want you to know that in all these years I never stopped waiting for you… I never stopped loving you…"

Catra let out a stuttering sigh. She covered her father's hand with her own and hesitated for a few moments before doing something Mathias wasn't expecting… she smiled at him and said something he had been waiting for a long time to hear.

"I forgive you."

"Catra…" Mathias whispered, his eyes wide, before he stepped forwards and enveloped the feline in a tight hug.

The doors of the throne room suddenly burst open.

"My king!"

Catra lightly pushed Mathias away and watched as a creature very much like her rushed towards them. The soldier wore a leather armor and had a long, light grey mane. The short fur that covered her skin was white and her eyes shone of a bright emerald green as the torches of the throne room illuminated them. However, the warrior came to a halt as Mathias raised his hand.

"It's all right, Anthea… it's… it's her…" The old king stood aside, letting the magicat see Catra.

Anthea gasped, her mouth agape and her green eyes as wide as dinner plates.

"Could… could it be?" The warrior fell to her knees, her head low. "My Queen…"

"W-what is she talking about?" Catra turned to her father and asked.

"Katrina was the magicats queen, Catra. From the moment she left us… you've been the new Queen of the magicats… and they have been waiting for you ever since our village was destroyed by the Horde." Mathias explained as he gestured with his hand towards the throne room's gates.

As Catra turned towards the entrance, she finally noticed them. Her eyes went wide at the sight of such a large group of people that looked like her. Countless 'magicats', as her father called them, had grouped outside the throne room. Their eyes shone with astonishment and wonder, and slowly, quiet whispers began to erupt from the large crowd.

"It's her!"

"It can't be!"

"Look at her left eye!"

"Golden like her mother's…"

"No other magicats but our queens are born with that eye color! It must be her!"

Catra felt overwhelmed. It took only a moment for Mathias to notice. He turned towards Anthea and placed a hand on her shoulder.

"Please Anthea, could you lead our people back to their homes? And… call the council, tell them to wait for us in the war room. We'll go there too, just… give us a moment."

"My king." Anthea nodded and reached for the large crowd.

Reluctantly, the group began to follow the warrior, and soon enough, they all disappeared. When Catra turned around towards her father, she saw he had reached the empty throne at the end of the room. She joined him at his side and noticed he was staring at Katrina's… at her mother's mask.

"This… has belonged to you for a very long time Catra… it is time for you to finally have it." Mathias took the golden mask into his hands and gave it to her.

With hesitant, slightly trembling fingers, the feline took it from her father's hands, and put it on.

And for a moment…

Everything went dark…

~

Catra gasped as the darkness surrounding her vanished. She wasn't in her father's castle anymore. As she looked around, all she could see was a vast Greenland. The sky above her was dark, strewn with stars. Where was she? How could it be already nighttime? Had she fallen asleep? Had she fainted?

But the feline's thoughts were suddenly silenced by a low growl coming from behind her. As she turned around, she noticed a single, large tree a few feet away from her. Laying on its branches, she could see ten creatures that looked exactly like the one on the center of the platform that brought her to Half Moon. They were all staring at her, golden eyes shining in the night.

One in particular, its mane and pelt completely black, suddenly jumped down from the tree, keeping its eyes on Catra. The feline took a few steps backwards as the beast approached her, but grew still as the creature began to change. It stood on its hind legs and grew smaller, until… someone very much like Catra appeared in front of her.

Catra had already seen her… in her dreams…

"Katrina…" The feline whispered.

The woman smiled, and her smile, so warm and kind… for Catra it was like feeling the sun on her skin for the first time.

"Oh… my sweet Catra… you've grown so much." Katrina said, her eyes full of nothing but love.

That is when Catra felt a pull she couldn't ignore. She quickly closed the distance between her and her mother and enveloped her in a tight hug. Katrina let out a small yelp of surprise, but quickly wrapped her arms around the younger feline, kissing her between her ears as she nestled her head in the crook of the taller woman's neck.

"M-mom…" Catra muttered.

The word should have sounded so weird to her, not having used it once in her whole life, never having called Shadow Weaver like that… but right now, in the arms of Katrina… it felt so, so right.

"Catra… I always knew that one day, you would have come back home…" Katrina whispered, running her fingers through the cat girl's mane.

"H-how do you know?" Catra asked.

"Walk with me dear…" The tall magicat gestured to follow her.

Catra did, and mother and daughter turned away from the tall tree, leaving it behind them as they started to walk.

"This is the place where every magicat queen comes to rest after they die…" Katrina explained.

The younger feline's eyes widened, and turned her head slightly, glancing at the other nine creatures laying on tree's branches… the other magicat queens…

"But I sense life in you… that must mean you found Half Moon and… my mask."

"There's… there's so much I want to ask you…" Catra said, turning towards her and grasping the magicat's hand.

"And there is so much I want to ask you too… so many questions come to my mind but… there's only one that matters, I guess. How are you?" Katrina asked, cradling Catra's cheek.

“I’m fine mom… I… after a long time… I’m finally happy…” Catra leaned into her mother’s touch, a tear streaming down her cheek.

“That is all that matters to me, my dear child.”

To know that Catra was alright… that she was happy… it must have truly been the only thing that mattered to Katrina. But the younger feline couldn’t refrain herself from asking what truly, she had been wondering for all of her life.

“Mom I… who am I? I spent so much time pretending that I didn’t care about who I was… but I do.” The younger feline spoke as she grasped her mother’s hands, a pleading look in her eyes.

Katrina simply smiled back.

“You are the daughter of the latest queen of the magicats, an ancient race that has been living on Etheria for a long, long time. We were the first to discover what the Horde truly was… who Hordak truly was… many didn’t want to believe us, to help us… we paid the price of our courage in the end.”

“It’s not your fault… they should have all listened to you. If they did… maybe… maybe now…” Catra had to bite her lip to stop her tears from falling.

“Do not blame them for not wanting a war Catra. People desire peace and are not ready to face the truth sometimes. In the end, they suffered just as much as we did, if not more.”

“I’m going to stop the Horde… they won’t hurt anyone anymore. No one else will have to go through what happened to us.” Catra spoke with such fierce determination.

“I know you will, and I know that you won’t be alone when you’ll stand against them.” Katrina said, giving the feline’s hands an encouraging squeeze.

They remained silent for a few minutes after that, holding hands and walking through the seemingly endless Greenland. Catra was

the one who broke the silence, her voice barely above a whisper.

“I… I think that Mat… I think that dad really misses you…”

Katrina’s eyes widened, and her expression turned distant for one moment before softening once more.

“How is your father?” She asked.

“I just met him but… he seemed fine… he didn’t think it was really me we saw each other.” Catra explained.

“I can’t really blame him… I left him alone to grieve… in one day he lost both his wife and daughter.” Katrina’s expression turned remorseful for a moment.

“It wasn’t your fault… it was Shadow Weaver… and Hordak’s… but they’re going to pay for this.” The younger magicat growled.

“I don’t want revenge Catra.” Katrina spoke without a hint of anger in her voice.

“W-what?! B-but they killed you! They kidnapped me, they ruined our family! You’d… you’d still be alive if it wasn’t for them…” Catra exclaimed, clearly shocked by her mother’s words.

“And killing them would bring that back?”

Catra looked away, but Katrina cupped her cheeks, gently raising her face to meet her gaze.

“I lived a long, happy life. I fell in love with your father and the year we spent together with you had been the most wonderful of my whole life. Do not ever pity the dead Catra, pity the living… especially those who live without love.”

“I… I would have loved to grow up with you and dad…” Catra sniffed slightly.

“And yet, something tells me that you still managed to find happiness in your life… to find someone who loves you with all of their heart… and you love them too.”

“I… I did… I did find someone… but mom, they’re in danger.”

Katrina’s expression turned serious.

“The leader of the Horde, it was never Hordak. He was just a pawn. Their true leader… Horde Prime, he found us. He found Etheria and… he kidnapped Adora. How… mom, how can I save her? Madame Razz told me that I would have found the power to save her if I got back home… w-what did she mean?”

Katrina smiled at the mention of the old witch’s name.

“Always talking in riddles… she hasn’t changed.” Katrina chuckled, “The magicats have remained hidden for a long time, waiting for their queen. Now, Catra, it’s time for you to be their guide. Bring them into the sunlight, take one last stand at their side, at your father’s side… lower the mask on your eyes and… save the one you love.”

Wind started to blow, breaking the silence that surrounded them.

“W-what is happening?” Catra asked.

“You need to go… our time is almost up…” Katrina looked around herself.

“I don’t want to leave you! W-we just met!”

Katrina tried her best to hide the pain on her face as she brought Catra into a tight hug.

“When you’ll need my help… I’ll always be here… I’ll always be with you.”

“M-mom… I don’t… I don’t know what to do…” Catra whispered.

“Yes, you do. You’re so strong, Catra. Be their guide, wear my mask, unite the princesses and the magicats once more… and you’ll have the power to save Adora.”

“Mom…”

“I would have loved to see you grow up… to see her… to see the both of you together. But this… this already is a gift. I love you, Catra.” Katrina whispered, kissing her daughter’s forehead.

“I love you too.” Catra replied.

Darkness began to surround her once more. Katrina let go of her and turned around, her form shifting once again. She returned to the tall tree, tail dangling from the thick branch as she kept her eyes locked on Catra. The feline did the same, smiling at her mother as darkness enveloped her.

Everything went quiet for a moment…

Then…

Her father’s voice brought her back…

Now she knew what she had to do.

The Last Stand

Chapter Notes

> So here we are, after almost a year, with the final chapter of my fanfiction. I really hope you've all enjoyed it, I sure did enjoy writing it. Thank you all for all of your kind comments, for all the bookmarks and kudos, it meant and it still means a lot to me that people have enjoyed something I wrote. I leave you with this words "do what you like, people will like it too, you'll like yourself more and more each day you do that."

The Horde's ships had converged above the Fright Zone. Dozens of black shapes covered the sky, plunging the land into eternal darkness. But it wasn't something that would have stopped the people of Etheria from fighting back. The armies of every kingdom stood by the Whispering Woods' edge. Even Huntara stood with them, the people of the Crimson Waste right behind her, and the part of the Horde that had remained loyal to Catra stood with them too.

In the front lines, the princesses were discussing what strategy to use.

"I think we can like… scratch the 'surprise attack' option. They obviously know that we're here." Mermista said as she pointed her finger towards the black ships which were hovering above the Fright Zone.

All of the ships were pointing towards them, positioned in what looked like an attack formation.

“Would a frontal attack work? We won’t stand a chance if they start bombing us like they did to you while you were in the woods.” Netossa wondered, recalling what Glimmer had told her and the others once they came back from the forest.

“Again, I’m soooo sorry I wasn’t there to help…” Scorpia apologized, blushing slightly as she recalled the reason she hadn’t been there with the others at the moment.

“Y-yeah… me too…” Perfuma looked away in embarrassment, scratching her arm.

The princesses exchanged a look before starting to talk again.

“A frontal attack is our only hope. We won’t be able to surprise them.” Spinerella intervened.

“Honey, if their blast took out She-Ra, we won’t stand a-” Netossa shook her head as she spoke, before someone stepped in and interrupted her.

“We do stand a chance.” Castaspella spoke determinately. “I’ll stay behind with all of Mystacor’s mages and erect a barrier that’ll cover us.”

“You’ll create a barrier to cover the entire Fright Zone? Aunt Casta, it’s too dangerous! It could drain you and the other mages completely!” Glimmer exclaimed in a worried tone.

“Y-yeah! You could cover just the field between us and the Fright Zone, once in we’ll have no need to-” Bow tried to talk the sorceress out of her idea, only for Micah to step in and interrupt him.

“Prime won’t hesitate to obliterate his own soldiers to take us out… if he’s anything like Hordak… he’s that kind of leader. Creating such an imposing barrier will take a lot out of Mystacor’s mages… that’s why I’ll stand with them.” Micah declared.

“Dad…” Glimmer turned towards her father and grasped his hands, a worried look on her face.

“We’ll hold the barrier up until the attack is over. It’ll be hard… but knowing that I’ll be protecting you… it’ll give me so much strength. Believe me, baby girl.” The old king said as he ran his fingers through the young queen’s hair.

“Madame Razz said that the ship that took Adora was the first one to reach the Fright Zone, and that its teleport was activated right above it.” Bow explained to the group.

“Mmmh… it might mean that our friend is being held captive in there!” Sea Hawk exclaimed, snapping his fingers.

“It’s a risk we’ll have to take. I’ll teleport us into the Fright Zone, while our armies will take care of Prime’s clones and the mages will protect everyone from his ships.” Glimmer turned towards the Fright Zone’s buildings, a determined look on her face. “We’ll take our friend back, and we’ll kick Prime off our planet.”

“H-hey!”

Someone else joined the group.

“Ivy?” Frosta stepped towards the young cadet.

“What about Catra?! That old lady said she’d join us! We have to wait for her!”

Lonnie reached the girl’s side, panting heavily.

“Damn it, Ivy! This is no place for a kid! You should have stayed in that old lady’s house!” The ex-Horde’s soldier scolded the kid before turning towards the princesses, “I’m sorry, I don’t know how she managed to sneak past us.”

“Hey! I have the right to be here! I’m a soldier! I can fight!” Ivy protested.

“You’re a kid! You shouldn’t go to a fricking war!” Glimmer spoke, a hint of exasperation in her voice.

“Frosta’s a kid too! Why is she here then?” The young cadet crossed her arms.

“Well… sheeeee’s a… princess.” Bow tried to explain.

“Ivy, what they mean is-” Frosta began to talk as she placed a hand on the girl’s shoulder only for it to be slapped away.

“What? That you’ve got powers so you can be actually useful?”

“No! These powers make me stronger than a normal etherian, it’s safer for me to fight, and I can help a lot!”

“I don’t care if I’m weaker than you! I want to fight for my home too!” Ivy shouted back.

Everyone remained silent for a moment, before Glimmer stepped towards the young girl. Ivy held her ground as the young queen stood before her. They both stared into each other’s eyes until a smile appeared on Glimmer’s face.

“You’re stubborn… and brave. You want to fight for those you love, and for your home. You will. We’ll all fight together against Prime.” Glimmer declared, placing a hand on Ivy’s shoulder.

The girl looked at her with an astonished expression before nodding. The young queen lifted her hand from the young cadet’s shoulder and turned towards the armies that had gathered along the Whispering Woods’ border.

What were the odds they could actually pull this off? Saving Adora… beating Horde Prime. He had ruled the known universe for hundreds of years… maybe even more… and who were they? Princesses, people who once she hated, bandits, soldiers who had no idea of what was expecting them… but… there was something more to them. Glimmer took a good look at all the faces that were staring at her. Suddenly, she understood.

They were there.

They had not run away.

They were standing one beside the other.

Glimmer took a deep breath and started to talk.

"People of Etheria! Today I don't see armies of different kingdoms. I don't see rebels, Horde soldiers or bandits, today I see the free people of a world that has been violated by a great evil. Prime stands between us and our long-awaited peace. He speaks of order and balance in the universe, but the only order that'll come if today he'll win… is oblivion, for us, and for everyone we love. There was once a day when we wouldn't even dare to think to stand side by side, when we were enemies. But today? Today I only see the people of a world whose desire is to be free! To hold their loved ones and live happily until the end of our days! So, let's fight for them! For the ones we love, for Etheria, for each other!"

A roar rose from the armies gathered in front of the queen, one of determination, courage and hope. The young queen turned towards the princesses.

"I'll teleport us inside the Fright Zone. We'll save Adora and stop Prime once and for all. His army will be too busy fighting ours to help him. Today, we free Etheria." Glimmer spoke without an inch of doubt or fear in her voice.

"But what about Catra?" Ivy asked again.

"Yeah… I mean… the old lady was pretty clear about the whole 'you'll need all the princesses to beat the evil that came from the stars and free Etheria' and yada, yada, yada." Mermista recalled the words of Madame Razz.

"I can't even imagine what kind of power the princesses will posses once they reunite. It must be something the universe has never seen before if it'll be great enough to beat Prime! Ohhh,

this will be so exciting!" Entrapta giggled excitedly, bouncing up and down.

"Whatever power Razz was talking about, we need to act now. Look," Glimmer intervened, pointing at the sky, "The ships are already moving towards us. They know we're here… he knows we came for Adora. If we don't act now…"

A dreadful silence fell upon the small group.

If Madame Razz was right, then they would have needed Catra in order to defeat Prime.

However… the feline was nowhere to be seen.

And if the ships had started moving towards them, it meant that Prime knew the free people of Etheria had arrived.

"We can't wait for Catra. Razz said that she would come, and I trust her… I trust Catra too. But we can't wait any longer." The young queen said.

"But she'll join us, right?" Ivy asked.

"Of course she will… I mean… she's Catra. Both the Rebellion and the Horde had never managed to beat her so… she'll join us." Frosta intervened, putting a hand on the young cadet's shoulder.

"Okay… but I'm coming with you!"

"What?! No way! We're not gonna face some random bandit! We're gonna fight Horde Prime!" Bow shrilled.

"Well, they're gonna face a few thousands of Hordaks, so? You'd prefer I stuck with them?" Ivy crossed her arms, raising an eyebrow.

"Absolutely not!" Frosta exclaimed.

Every princess turned towards her, Ivy did too. The ice princess blushed slightly and began to fidget with her fingers.

"I-I mean, it'll be safer if she's with us, we're princesses! And when Catra will reach us, s-she'll already be there!" She tried to explain herself.

Ivy snickered. The other princesses did too, except for Spinerella and Netossa, who simply cooed at the two young girls, making the Horde cadet blush too.

"S-shut up! It's as she said, just the most logical choice." Ivy stammered.

"Yeah, of course." Glimmer said, a knowing smirk plastered on her face, before she extended a hand towards the others. "Ready?"

The others nodded and placed their hands above the queen's, while Swift Wind placed his snout on top of theirs.

"Let's go save Adora!" The steed declared encouragingly.

"Onwards to our greatest adventure yet!" Sea Hawk yelled gleefully.

"For Etheria. For our friends. For Adora." Glimmer said, smiling at Bow.

The young archer nodded, smiling back, before the small group vanished into a cloud of sparkles.

~

"They're coming for me… and it'll be the end for you."

A clawed hand slapped Adora, drawing blood from her bottom lip.

“Today, your pathetic little friends will meet their doom. And so will your so called ‘Rebellion’.” Horde Prime grinned viciously.

Adora threw her head backwards in a roaring laugh, almost hitting the lab table Horde Prime had strapped her to.

“Is the end of your loved ones so… entertaining to you?” Prime raised a brow.

“No… you are.” Adora spat back.

Horde Prime expression turned from curious to enraged. He surged forward and took the blonde’s face in his hand, tightening his grip around her cheeks.

“I am?” Prime growled.

“You’re so little.” Adora laughed again.

Horde Prime screamed in rage and smashed her head against the lab table.

“I’ll posses a weapon so powerful that the entire Universe will bow to me.” The tyrant closed his hand in front of the blonde’s eyes.

“The sword is broken, it was the only link between She-Ra and the Heart of Etheria. You’ll never manage to activate it.” Adora replied.

“Oh, but my dear child. The sword is not broken any longer.”

Those words… they sent chills running down Adora’s spine. It was impossible. She did it herself. She took that damned sword, the sword the First Ones had created to control her, to control She-Ra, to make her a weapon… and smashed it into a million pieces. It was gone… it was-

And then she saw it.

A clone came into Hordak's old laboratory, his head bowed… and the sword of protection held between his hands.

Adora's eyes went wide in horror.

The sword's blade had lost its light blue color, and so did the gem embed in its hilt. Instead… both of them had turned green… a vibrant… somehow malevolent green. Horde Prime reached for it and took it from the clone's hands, before he walked up to Adora once more.

"No… it's a trick!" The blonde shouted in both anger and desperation as she started to pull on the straps that held her in place.

"I admit… for an old piece of Eternian tech it has proven to be quite complicated. But after a while, I understood its primitive mechanisms… and put it back together. Why don't you try it? So you'll see for yourself that it is far from a trick." Horde Prime grinned maliciously as he reached the blonde's side and took hold of her hand.

"No! You don't understand! The Heart is unstable! It'll destroy all of us if you activate it!" Adora screamed and trashed around, but to no vail.

Horde Prime simply cackled loudly.

"Despite the potential of their machine, once again the Eternians' work proved to be… sloppy. But do not worry… thanks to my modifications… the Heart will conjure just enough energy to destroy their little planet... and you, my dear little child, will be the executioner of your own family."

Adora's face turned white.

"N-no… no! I won't help you! Let me go!"

"You will… or maybe I should say that… she will." Prime laughed.

The tyrant pried open the blonde's hand and closed it around the sword's handle. He kept it closed as he leaned in and whispered a few… terrifying words in Adora's ear.

"For the honor of Horde Prime."

BOOM!

Suddenly, Hordak throne room's door burst open.

"Adora!" Glimmer cried.

"Adora! Where are you?!" Bow rushed inside, looking around frantically.

The other princesses quickly joined the archer and the queen, alongside Ivy, Sea Hawk and Swift Wind.

"Oh… she is right… here." Horde Prime cackled maliciously.

Everyone gasped as the tyrant emerged from the shadows of Hordak's lab, his hand resting on Adora's shoulder. But the one the princesses' gazes were fixed on wasn't Adora anymore. In her place, stood a distorted version of She-Ra. A tall, lean figure engulfed in a vibrant green glow, with its clawed hands closed around… the sword of protection.

"It can't be…" Glimmer muttered.

"B-but Adora destroyed the sword! I saw the fragments!" Bow shouted, pointing at the green blade.

"I'd love to stay and chat, but I have an old enemy to annihilate, and you… and old friend to fight. Goodbye, children." Horde Prime said, as he bowed mockingly to the small group.

A green beam came down from above Hordak's sanctum and broke its ceiling. Bow shoot an arrow in the tyrant's direction but it only hit the wall behind him. The green beam disappeared. Horde Prime had left them… left them with Adora.

She-Ra stood still, looking straight at the princesses in front of her, before releasing a powerful, distorted screech and jumping in the air towards them, sword held high above her head. Everyone dodged the powerful blow, gasping as She-Ra's sword sunk deep into the throne room's floor.

"Adora! It's us!" Glimmer shouted, but to no vail.

"Watch out!" Spinerella shouted as she pushed the young queen aside.

She-Ra's powerful kick sent the purple haired princess flying towards one of Hordak's clone chambers, smashing it. Spinerella fell to the ground with a loud thud.

"Spinny!" Netossa cried, before conjuring a net and throwing it at the green, screeching figure.

The luminous net engulfed She-Ra, before starting to get smaller and smaller, preventing her from moving. Sadly, it only worked for a few moments, and before anyone could land a blow, the net shattered. The green figure surged forwards, Netossa conjured another net in front of her but She-Ra's clawed hand simply smashed through it, grabbing the princess by the hem of her jacket and throwing her against a wall at full force. Netossa let out a strangled yelp as she collided with the hard surface before she fell to the ground, unconscious.

"We need to wake her up!" Bow yelled as he ducked under an energy wave sent by the green blade.

"I'll do it! Adora! I know you're in there! Listen to my chanty! Ohhhhh-" Sea Hawk began to sing.

Unfortunately, chanties didn't seem to work as She-Ra simply titled her head to the side before she rushed towards the pirate. Yelping, Sea Hawk raised his sword only to see it being cut in half by the green figure's sword. A clawed hand caught him by his neck and raised him in the air.

“Hey! Let him go!” Mermista shouted in anger as she raised her hands.

Hordak sanctum’s pipes began to tremble and a moment after water began to erupt from them. Mermista rotated her arms in the air and formed a giant sphere of water. She threw it at She-Ra, who simply held her sword in front of her, a wall of green energy materializing between her and the mermaid princess’ attack. The globe of water crashed against the barrier, and a moment after, the green figure dropped it and threw the pirate at the blue haired princess, making both of them crash to the ground.

That’s when She-Ra grunted, stumbling slightly. She turned around only to be hit another time by a flying kick to the stomach. This time, the green figure didn’t even move an inch. She-Ra’s white eyes focused on the small girl that stood in front of her. Ivy had managed to catch her off guard. However, the small girl’s confidence wavered as she saw the tall figure raise its sword above her.

“Ivy!” Frosta cried, jumping in front of her and raising a wall of ice between the two of them and She-ra.

When the green blade collided with the icy barrier, the latter shattered into a million pieces, one of them flying in the young princess’ direction and slicing through her jacket. Frosta cried as she closed a hand around her bleeding shoulder, stumbling back.

“Frosta!” Ivy held her, trying to support the princess’ weight as she leaned against her.

She-Ra raised her sword once again, ready to finish the two younglings, but before she could, a few seeds were thrown at her feet, and several thick vines grew in a matter of seconds around her, immobilizing her. A moment after, a surge of red, electric energy traveled through She-Ra’s body. The green figure screeched loudly and trashed around.

“We need to do something! I can’t hold her for much longer!” Perfuma cried, beads of sweat forming on her forehead as she tried to tighten the vines around the green figure’s body.

“Oh boy, I think we’re just making her angrier!” Scorpia shouted over She-Ra’s screams.

“M-maybe if I c-could get closer to her sword I-I could try to find a way to-” Entrapta blabbered before Swift Wind interrupted her.

“Don’t worry! I’ll use our bond to bring Adora back!” The steed announced before rushing towards the immobilized figure. “Adora! It’s me! Swift Wind! Listen to me! Listen to our magical bond! Come back! Come-”

The steed fell silent as he realized that his and Adora’s bond was still there… but it wasn’t working as he expected. The green glow around She-Ra grew brighter and brighter, until the vines around her burst into flames.

“Ack! Retreat!” Swift Wind cried as he turned around.

But before he could run away, a clawed hand closed itself around his tail. Swift Wind yelped as he felt himself being lifted in the air.

“Oh, you’ve got to be kidding!” Scorpia shouted in exasperation as she saw She-Ra rotating the screaming horse above her head.

An instant later, the distorted, green figure threw the steed at the princesses, effectively knocking Scorpia, Perfuma and Entrapta to the ground. She-Ra turned towards the only two remaining opponents. Glimmer’s fists were engulfed in a bright, purplish glow while Bow stood by her side, an arrow already nocked and ready to be shot.

“Adora, please! It’s us! Bow and Glimmer! Please!” Bow shouted, raising his bow towards her.

“Please! You can’t forget about us! The Adora we know is far too stubborn to do that!” Glimmer shouted, the ghost of smile

appearing on her face as she spoke that last sentence.

And that's when the figure hesitated, bright blue eyes replacing soulless white mirrors for a single moment. She-Ra doubled over and cried loudly as she held her own head with a hand, while the other, still closed around the sword of protection's handle, trembled slightly. Glimmer and Bow looked at each other, hope appearing on their faces. She was still there, Adora was still there. They just had to continue, to keep reminding her of who she was, but… could they do that alone? She had already taken out all the others…

And as soon as that doubt crossed their minds… a powerful roar came from behind She-Ra.

The green figure turned around swiftly only to be pushed to the ground, her arms pinned to the floor by two massive paws. She-Ra screamed an tried to break free, but her efforts ceased immediately as her white eyes focused on the mismatched ones of the beast above her. Cedar brown mane… light orange pelt…

Familiar…

Familiar…

Familiar…

"Could… could that be?" Bow whispered to Glimmer, who simply stood by his side, observing the scene, mouth agape.

The beast let a low rumble escape its mouth as it slowly lift a paw to its face, raising a golden mask above its eyes. The creature began to shrink, its form growing littler… until…

"Adora…"

A hand cupped She-Ra's cheek and a pair of soft lips touched hers.

Catra…

And Adora came back. Her blue eyes replaced Horde Prime horrifying creation's ones and a stuttering breath came out from her lips.

"C-Catra…" She mumbled.

"Yeah… yeah, it's me…" Catra chuckled as she bent down and kissed her again.

She-Ra stood up, helping the feline stand up as well, and turned towards Glimmer and Bow. The other princesses, Ivy, Sea Hawk and Swift Wind reached them, limping and groaning slightly. They were a little roughed up, but all of them would have survived.

"Catra!" Ivy yelled before she broke into a full sprint.

The young girl threw herself at the feline, who caught her between her arms and hugged her tightly.

"I was so scared… when I woke up and you weren't there… for a moment I thought I had lost you…" Ivy mumbled.

"It's okay… I was scared too... but I had to get this." Catra said, pointing at her golden mask.

"Wow! What's that?" Ivy asked, eyes fixed on the shiny object.

"My mother's crown, basically I'm the new queen of the magicats."

"WHAT?!" Everyone shouted loudly in disbelief.

"Madame Razz simply told us that you would have come carrying the power we needed to defeat Prime but… this… this is incredible!" Glimmer said, shocked.

"Oh wildcat! I always knew you were special!" Scorpia cried, engulfing the feline in a tight hug.

Catra simply chuckled and hugged the scorpion princess back before being put down.

"Y-you found your home?" Adora asked in a trembling voice.

Catra turned towards her and took her hands into her own.

"You're my home… but I found my parent's kingdom and… my dad…"

"Your dad is still alive?" Glimmer put a hand on the feline's shoulder before she smiled. "I'm so happy for you. My dad… my dad told us about your mom and… and mine. About how Bright Moon didn't believe Katrina and wasn't there when the magicats needed help. I'm sorry… if my dad and my mom had listened to her… maybe now…"

"It's not your fault Glimmer, and it's in the past now. I was still lucky enough to see my father again… and I got to see my mom too, in here." Catra pointed at the golden crown.

Glimmer and the other princesses shared a confused look but decided to remain silent.

"My dad guided the magicat army through the woods. The clones are done for. I saw it before I came here."

"M-my dad… is he…" The young queen's grasp tightened on Catra's shoulder.

"Yeah, he's fine. He and the mages managed to keep that barrier up until every ship was taken down. The clones were so many… but… you had the Horde's and the Crimson Waste's people on your side… the magicats too. Prime's done for."

"Uhm… he… he escaped. And there's another problem… Adora…" Bow chose to point at her instead of using his words.

Adora was still transformed, her appearance hadn't changed. She was still surrounded by that bright, green glow, only her eyes

were different.

“Try to change back!” Entrapta encouraged her.

Adora closed her eyes and began to concentrate. She tried to shift back, a task that usually she could accomplish in mere seconds… but found out that she couldn’t…

“I… I can’t… I can’t…” Adora breathed hard, falling to her knees.

“Adora!” Catra gasped, rushing to her side. “What’s wrong?!”

“I can hear him… I can’t… I can’t control myself!”

Suddenly, Adora stood up, the green glow around her growing brighter. The other princesses began to glow too.

“No, no, no! Not again!” Glimmer cried as the familiar burning sensation she felt when the Heart was activated for the first time pervaded her body.

All the princesses cried out in pain as their glow became more intense.

“What do we do?!” Bow asked, trying to think of a plan.

“H-he wants me to destroy Eternia! It’s my parents’ planet! I-I can’t stop it!” Adora shouted as she felt her arm lift the sword high above her head, pointed towards a planet far, far away, as if it had a mind of its own.

“Adora!” Catra surged forward and closed her hands around the one Adora used to hold her sword. “Don’t do it! I know you can resist him! I know how strong you are!”

And the sword moved… just an inch to the right.

“A-Adora!” Glimmer muttered as she reached the princess of power.

The young queen lifted her hand and closed it around Catra’s.

“I know you can break free! I never met someone as strong as you! As determined as you!”

“We believe in you Adora! Just keep fighting! For Etheria! For each other!” Bow placed his hand on top of Glimmer’s.

“Come on! Prime can’t beat you! Not if we’re all with you!” Scorpia said, closing her pincer around the sword’s blade, pushing it away from the spot in the sky Adora had originally pointed it too.

“Horde Prime can’t win! He doesn’t have what we have! Our friendship is stronger than his control over you!” Perfuma placed her hand above the scorpion princess’ pincer.

The sword moved again.

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“Enjoy your last moments Eternia… for your end has come…” Prime muttered, crossing his fingers as he stared at the screens behind his throne.

Half of them displayed Etheria, giving him a perfect visual of the First One’s mightiest weapon, the other half of the screens displayed a distant planet… one of the few that managed to fend off the intergalactic tyrant in the past. But against the Heart of Etheria? It wouldn’t have stood a chance.

“Rejoice! For Prime’s light will be the last thing-” The tyrant shouted, raising his arms in the air, before a clone dared to interrupt him.

“My Lord!”

“How dare you interrupt me?!” Prime turned towards the clone, however, his anger vanished as he noticed the terrified expression

he wore on his face.

“M-my Lord… the targeting system of the sword is changing its objective!”

Horde Prime is speechless for a few moments, something that hadn’t happened to him in hundreds of years.

“What… do… you… mean…”

“Eternia isn’t the target anymore! W-we are!” The clone stuttered, terrified.

“It’s impossible! The sword has been created to control She-Ra! I control her! I own her! Show me my little brother’s sanctum!” Prime turned towards the screens.

One of them stopped displaying Etheria and began to show the tyrant the inside of Hordak’s throne room… that’s when Prime’s eyes widened. Not only She-Ra wasn’t fighting the princesses, she was resisting his orders, she was resisting his programming.

“No! It’s impossible! How are they doing that?!”

~

“He thinks he can just waltz in and take our home from us?! Show him who’s the boss Adora!” Netossa spoke determinately as her hands joined the ones of the other princesses.

“Don’t let him rob us of the ones we love Adora!” Spinerella shouted over the princess of power’s screams, placing her hand above her wife’s.

“Prime thinks he can beat us? Ha! Countless chanties will be sung about his idiocy!” Sea Hawk joined them too, alongside Mermista.

“Let’s show him what Etherians can do!” The mermaid princess yelled encouragingly.

“Keep pushing! We can’t give up now!” Frosta reached the group, hoisted up on Ivy’s shoulders so that she could reach the height of She-Ra’s sword handle.

“Come on guys! It would seem the odds are against us! But somehow I know we can do this!” Entrapta raised her pigtails and wrapped them around everyone’s hands.

“Don’t give up Adora! We’re all here! We’re all together!” Swift Wind pressed the side of his head against the conjoined hands and pushed alongside everyone else.

And indeed, they were all there.

They were all together.

In the end, Horde Prime made one fatal mistake.

He fought against people who had love in their lives, the most powerful magic of all.

The sword moved again, one last time and then…

A blinding light erupted from it.

The gargantuan beam of light traveled through the sky of Etheria, up and up until it reached its target.

~

“It is going to destroy us!” The clone cried.

Prime slapped him, seething in anger.

“Move the ship! We have more than enough time!” The tyrant shouted.

The clone nodded, but before he could turn around, something hit him in the back of the neck. The clone fell to the ground, revealing another one standing behind him.

Prime recognized him immediately…

Hordak…

“Little brother… what… are… you… doing?” Prime hissed between his teeth, clenching his fists.

“What I should have done a long time ago… stopping you.” Hordak replied.

“Stopping me?! You can’t stop me! I’m your master! Your creator! You are the one that came back to me that night!”

A mocking grin appeared on Hordak’s face, and Prime’s blood turned to ice.

“Begging you to let me come back, showing you how eager I was to be at your side again, pretending that I would have left everything and everyone behind just to be your pawn again… I knew it would have blinded you. You’re that pathetic.”

“How dare you!” Prime lunged forward, trying to grab the clone, only for him to dodge his clawed hand.

“This will be your end. I disabled the engines. Nothing can save you.” Hordak declared.

“You’re a fool! You’ll die too!” Prime screamed.

The tyrant turned towards the screens behind his throne. His eyes went wide as he saw his little brother’s sanctum engulfed in a bright, white light, while the screens displaying Etheria showed a gigantic beam moving towards them.

“Damn you!” He shouted in pure anger and hatred as he lunged again at Hordak.

The clone dodged again, before jumping towards Prime.

His punch collided with the tyrant’s face as the white light engulfed the giant space ship.

Hordak closed his eyes, his last thoughts going to Entrapta… and to the fact that he had managed to hit God.

The magic of Etheria pulverized the ship alongside everyone inside it… including a small, terrified cloud of black smoke, that in front of what only then it understood what true light was... could only evaporate into nothingness.

~

“A-Adora?”

That voice… it was muffled, but it sounded so, so familiar.

“Adora?! Please, wake up!”

Catra…

Adora finally opened her eyes.

“Adora!” The feline cried happily, tears streaming down her cheeks as she bent down and embraced the blonde tightly.

“Catra…” Adora murmured, hugging her back.

Catra pulled back slightly only to cup the blonde’s face and bring their lips together in a deep, passionate kiss.

“Ewwww!” Ivy mimicked a gag, while Frosta snickered and elbowed her side slightly.

“Did… did we do it?” Adora asked, pulling back slightly from the kiss.

“Yes dummy, look up in the sky.” Catra answered, resting her head in the crook of the blonde’s neck.

Adora raised her head and her eyes widened as she saw that Horde Prime’s ship was gone.

“We… we really did it… he’s gone.” Adora couldn’t believe her own eyes.

“We did it!” Glimmer exclaimed, launching herself towards the two.

“Yeah!” Bow followed her right after.

“Oh my gosh! I can’t believe it! W-we’re all okay!” Scorpia laughed incredulously, before turning towards Perfuma and hugging her tightly.

Perfuma squealed joyfully as the scorpion princess raised her from the ground and began to twirl around.

“This war made lovers out of everyone didn’t it?” Spinerella whispered to Netossa, who simply smiled brightly at her before dipping her and kissing her deeply.

“This victory requires a song! Ohhhh-” Sea Hawk began to sing, only to be silenced by Mermista, who groaned deeply before grabbing the hem of his jacket and pulling him into a kiss.

“Will that shut you up?” Mermista asked, pulling back.

Sea Hawk simply nodded.

“Yuck! I hope I won’t have to see this every time they win!” Ivy said, crossing her arms.

“You probably will.” Frosta snickered, before she gave the young cadet’s cheek a quick peck.

Ivy turned towards the ice princess, eyes wide, cheeks red as a tomato.

“I-I… y-you… I m-mean… I-” Ivy stuttered, embarrassed beyond limit.

Frosta simply chuckled.

Glimmer and Bow helped Adora and Catra up, before their gazes fell upon the sword of protection. It laid on the ground in pieces, its green blade shattered.

“Good riddance.” Adora muttered.

Suddenly, everyone’s attention was caught by the sound of a familiar voice. The small group turned towards Entrapta, who was holding a small tablet, her hands slightly shaking.

“That voice…” Catra growled lowly.

“Hordak.” Adora stated.

The group came in close, surrounding the scientist princess as they kept listening to Hordak’s voice coming from the device.

“If you’re seeing this… it means that I have perished. Only now I realize the pain that I have caused to this planet… to these people. There is no way that I can atone for my sins, but I can do one good thing. I am sorry. I am sorry if the last time we’ll see each other we’ll look at each other with only anger, hatred and disgust in our eyes, but only by doing that Prime won’t suspect a thing. I will sabotage his ship… and when the time will come… I know that you’ll do the right thing, and he won’t be able to escape. The only regret I have is that I lived most of my life

without knowing about the most precious thing of all. Thank you Entrapta… thank you for having made me learn what love is."

The tablet's screen turned black. The message was over. Entrapta simply stood still, tears streaming down her face, shoulders shaking. She turned her head to the side, surprised by a hand touching her shoulder.

"He… he was good… in the end he was good… we couldn't have done this without him." Catra smiled at Entrapta.

The scientist princess sniffed before hugging the feline. Catra was taken slightly aback, but quickly reciprocated. The other princesses joined them too, each and every one of them letting Entrapta know that they were there for her.

"We should go and meet the others… see how they're doing." Entrapta muttered.

"Okay." Adora smiled weakly.

The group left Hordak's Sanctum behind, walking through the Fright Zone's corridors one last time.

~

Both clones and Etherians laid still on the ground. Glimmer covered her mouth, trying to muffle a sob. Bow took her between her arms, holding her tight.

"No such thing as a good war, huh…" Catra whispered, her ears low on her head.

The feline smiled weakly as she felt Adora put a hand on her shoulder, squeezing it lightly.

"Catra!"

Suddenly, a voice called her from afar. A man in silver armor rushed towards the feline. Adora made a move to summon her sword, however, Catra stopped her. A moment later, the feline was engulfed in a bone crushing hug. Hesitantly, she hugged the man back. It was a little stiff, rigid, but Catra wanted to believe that now she had time to get to know her father… to bond with him… to know what it feels to have a loving parent.

"Are you hurt?" Mathias asked, out of breath as he removed his helmet, revealing his light blue eyes to the small group in front of him.

"No, I'm fine." Catra answered, smiling meekly at the man.

"Catra…" Adora called her, curiosity clear in her voice.

"Adora, guys, this is Mathias… my… my dad." The feline explained almost sheepishly.

Everyone gasped.

"Catra, you have a dad?!" Bow asked, his voice growing shrill.

"Since when?!" Glimmer threw her hands in the air in disbelief.

"It's a long story…" Catra shook her head, smiling a little more broadly.

"One that'll have to wait."

Suddenly, Micah appeared behind the man in silver armor.

"Dad!" Glimmer cried before launching herself at the old king.

"Glimmer…" Micah whispered, kissing the top of the young queen's head and holding her for a few moments.

"Dad? What's wrong?" Glimmer asked, noticing her father's worried look.

“A portion of our army stayed in Bright Moon to prevent any kind of surprise attack from the enemy…” The king hesitated for a moment before continuing, “They were fine before the battle, no clones had been spotted… but…”

“Now they’re not responding anymore?” Adora asked.

“No…” Micah shook his head.

“What could have happened?” Glimmer asked, the joy from the victory slowly fading away, replaced by a crippling fear.

“Where’s Shadow Weaver…”

Catra’s question sounded more like a demand. The feline hadn’t seen the red witch anywhere, not on the battlefield, not inside the Fright Zone. A terrifying doubt crossed her mind.

“She was nowhere to be found when we left for the battle.” Micah answered, before his eyes widened in realization.

Everyone looked at each other.

“We have to get back, now.” Adora said, her tone grave.

Glimmer nodded before conjuring a teleportation spell, ‘the one Shadow Weaver had taught her’ Glimmer realized with a grimace on her face, and the group disappeared into thin air.

~

Everything looked… darker inside the castle. Not just as if someone had turned off the lights, but like if someone had poured… more shadows inside the already dark hallways of the now silent palace.

“What… happened here?” Adora asked in a low voice.

“I don’t know… but I don’t like it…” Catra muttered.

The blonde extended a hand and grasped Catra’s into her own. The feline turned her head towards her and smiled weakly.

Nothing really bad can happen as long as we stick together.

“Is it me or… it’s getting colder and darker?” Glimmer asked, rubbing her arms as she trembled slightly.

Bow immediately reached her and gently hugged her side.

“Thanks…” The young queen muttered, a light blush adorning her cheeks.

“You’re not wrong, the closer we get to the exit… the colder it gets.” Bow said, eyes darting around, trying to spot any danger.

“You okay?” Frosta asked, putting a hand on Ivy’s shoulder.

“Y-yeah…” The young cadet answered.

“It’s okay to be afraid you know? I’m a little nervous too.” The ice princess explained, a kind smile on her face.

“Pfff… who says I’m scared?” Ivy pouted. A moment after, she spoke again. “But I wouldn’t… completely disagree if you… held my hand… just, you know… for precaution.”

Frosta snickered before taking the girl’s hand into her own.

“Something wrong?” Scorpia asked, turning towards Perfuma.

“There’s… a really negative energy vibrating through this whole place…” The flower princess explained, shivering.

“Whatever it is… I think it’s coming from there…” Mermista said, pointing at the palace’s exit.

“This is bad… I’ve never seen readings like these ones… there’s an enormous amount of magical energy coming from nearby but…

it’s not similar to She-Ra’s… it’s more like… the opposite…” Entrapta muttered worryingly as she kept looking at her tablet.

“Whatever it is, we can take it. Together!” Sea Hawk said, trying to sound cheerful.

“Towards the big cluster of evil magic we go…” Swift Wind whispered, his voice shaky, as the group walked through the palace’s exit.

That’s when they saw it.

The moonstone…

“It’s… it’s…” Glimmer’s eyes went wide in terror.

“It’s completely black…” Catra growled.

The group broke into a sprint towards the magical stone. But as soon as they reached the bridge leading to it, the ground began to shake.

“What’s happening?!” Spinerella cried as she leaned onto Netossa.

“I don’t know! Hold on!” The net throwing princess replied.

“Welcome…”

The voice resonated through the air. Everyone recognized it immediately.

“Shadow Weaver…” Adora muttered in a grave tone of voice.

Slowly but steadily, shadows began to pour from the black stone.

“What is-” Glimmer began to ask, but as soon as she opened her mouth…

A loud scream resonated through the air, and an explosion of darkness erupted from the stone, obscuring everything around the group, turning everything black. When Catra opened her eyes,

there was no one around her, everyone was gone except for Adora, who laid on the ground, her eyes closed.

"Adora!" Catra cried, kneeling down and taking Adora's head into her lap. "Adora? Adora wake up!"

"She won't…"

"Shut up! Show yourself! I'm not afraid!" The feline shouted back angrily.

"You should…"

And then she appeared. Shadow Weaver came out from the dark. Her bust emerged from the ground, as tall as the Moonstone's tower, the black stone now adorning the once empty slot on the red witch's mask.

"I must say… I thought that I would have encountered much more resistance from you all… I guess I have to thank Horde Prime for that…"

"He's dead, and you're gonna follow him." Catra spat angrily.

"Even in front of certain death you still are a disrespectful brat. You've always been the one who resisted me the most. I thought that getting rid of you would have been easier… but somehow you've managed to come out alive from each of my traps…"

"W-what… are you talking about?" The feline asked.

"Micah discovering about you did to his wife… the magic field that imprisoned you in Bright Moon suddenly disappearing… the voices inside your head… did you think that those things happened for no reason at all?"

Suddenly, Catra realized. It had always been Shadow Weaver.

"You wanted me to crumble under my own guilt… and when you saw that I was actually strong enough to overcome it… you hoped

that Micah or Prime could do the job…" The feline talked through gritted teeth, as tears threatened to fall from her eyes.

"Always so smart… and yet, here we are…"

"Yeah… here we are." Catra sniffed slightly, gazing into the white, glowing cracks of Shadow Weaver's mask.

"It is a pity, that Adora will have to die alongside you… but it's a sacrifice I'm willing to do in order to maintain this power."

"Of course you're willing to do it." Catra chuckled darkly. "Well? What are you waiting for?"

"You're not going to beg for mercy?"

"You're voice is even more annoying than before, can you just make it quick? So that I'm not gonna have to listen to you anymore?" The feline smirked smugly, not even an ounce of fear on her face.

The slits on Shadow Weaver's mask grew thinner.

"I am going to enjoy smiting you."

The enormous black figure raised her hand above the couple.

"I think that even if we're together… this time it won't matter Adora." Catra whispered, tucking a strand of the blonde's hair behind her ear, smiling down at her before kissing her lips softly. "I love you."

The black hand came down.

Catra closed her eyes.

A loud bang resonated through the darkness surrounding them.

A distorted scream rang through the air.

The feline opened her eyes.

Shadow Weaver was holding her own hand, as white cracks began to form on its surface. Catra looked down and saw that both Adora and herself were glowing. A bright, golden aura had surrounded them. And then, just as the feline laid eyes on the blonde she was holding between her arms, Adora opened her eyes.

"Hey Catra…"

"Hey…" Catra answered with a teary chuckle.

The feline helped the blonde stand up, and as Shadow Weaver raised her hand again, the two simply held each other's hand, the golden glow around them growing brighter and brighter.

The black hand came down again, this time shattering completely as it came in contact with the pair. The old witch screamed in pain as she held her now mutilated limb.

"This is impossible! You can't be this strong! My power is far greater!"

"You're wrong!"

Glimmer's voice rang through the darkness, and suddenly, the young queen emerged at Adora and Catra's side, hand in hand with Bow.

"You can't defeat us, because you don't have what makes someone strong in the real way!" Scorpia joined the group, Perfuma's hand clutched around her pincer.

"Despite every odd we encounter, we always come out on top, because we have each other!" Sea Hawk appears from the shadows, holding hands with a slightly blushing Mermista.

"Because we're there for each other!" Entrapta yelled cheerfully as she reached the group on top of Swift Wind.

“Because we’ll never leave each other alone!” Ivy shouted at the giant, shadowy figure, as she joined the others, hand in hand with Frosta.

“Because we love each other…” Netossa spoke, emerging from the darkness alongside Spinerella, gazing dreamily into her wife’s eyes.

Each and every one of them stepped into the golden glow, making it grow bigger and brighter, until the Great Shadow couldn’t hide anymore.

“No! No! It burns! Make it stop! Make it stop!”

The gargantuan black figure cried, her voice growing smaller and smaller as light began to pierce her veil of darkness, as colors came back to the world, as Bright Moon began to emerge from her darkness once again. Shadow Weaver grew smaller and smaller, her mask falling into pieces, the Moon Stone gaining its color back. In the end nothing but a semi transparent shadow remained in front of the group. It looked at each and every one of them with such fear in its eyes.

Then, a cloud that was obscuring the sun moved away.

A ray of light engulfed the shadow…

And the old witch vanished without a sound.

“It’s… it’s over?” Glimmer asked, her hand still holding Bow’s as tight as she could.

“Yeah… she’s gone…” Adora muttered, turning her head towards Catra.

“Good riddance…” Catra spoke in a hard tone of voice, before turning towards the blonde, her expression softening.

The two embraced each other for a few moments before pulling back. Adora cupped the feline’s cheeks and brought her into a

kiss, her cheeks becoming red as she heard whistles and joyful hollers all around them.

"I love you." Adora whispered against Catra's lips.

"I love you too, dummy." The feline answered.

The following days were spent celebrating. Even though Etheria would have needed a lot of work in order to be completely restored, the princesses felt like they have earned their rest. Even Adora managed to relax… after a lot of convincing.

An incredible party had been organized for the day after the Rebellion's victory, and during the festivity, Micah called Catra away from the dance room. The feline expected the old king to tell her that she shouldn't have gotten so comfortable, that some kind of trial was expecting her, but surprisingly enough, Micah simply wanted to thank her. If it hadn't been for her and Adora, he would have probably lost his daughter too. The past was in past, he said, and it was time to finally move forward.

Glimmer spent the next few weeks after the battle helping build new homes for the Horde members that had followed Catra, alongside Bow and Entrapta.

Mermista departed alongside Sea Hawk the day after the party, wanting to start immediately to rebuild her kingdom. Catra asked to join her. Mermista accepted. Adora went with her obviously.

Scorpia went back to the Fright Zone. Glimmer explained that before Hordak, that place had been the scorpion princess family's kingdom, and now the war was finally over, it should have gone back to its rightful ruler. Having zero experience in being a princess with a kingdom, Perfuma decided to follow Scorpia and help her.

Ivy didn't have a home, not anymore, Scorpia offered her to come back to the Fright Zone but the young girl said that she would have never gone back to that place. That is when Frosta shily offered one of the many rooms of her castle to her, saying that

until she found another place, she could have stayed there. Ivy simply giggled, took the ice princess' hand and followed her. In the years to come, she would have never left the icy castle… or Frosta.

The few clones that had survived the war ran away. Without their guide they set a course through the infinity of space. No one ever saw them again, and slowly, in each and every part of the known universe, Horde Prime was finally forgotten.

"They're beautiful, aren't they?" Adora asks, leaning her head on Catra's shoulder, eyes exploring the multitude of stars above them.

"Yeah, but I prefer the one right next to me." The feline replies, kissing the top of the blonde's head.

They decided to watch the stars for a few more minutes. Another day of work was ahead of them. Selineas was far from rebuilt, but they would have managed to repair everything that had been broken, together.

And as the two of them kept watching the stars in the sky, unbeknown to them, on a distant planet, a young man with blonde hair was doing the same. The legend of She-Ra, and the tale of Horde Prime's fall had traveled far, far enough to reach him… and to make him realize that the sister he had lost long ago… could finally be found again.

End Notes

Hi guys, so this is my first fanfiction. I really enjoyed season four, the best one yet in my opinion and I just couldn't stop myself from continuing it from where it left off. I know season five won't take long to come out, but still, even if it'll be four or five months, it's still too long, so I decided to write some kind of continuation to the season four's finale. Hope you enjoyed this chapter and if you'd like to see more, just let me know in the comments!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!